Kingdom of Dreams

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38119888.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F, F/M, M/M, Other

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit

Additional Tags:
Blood and Gore, Violence, Explicit Sexual Content

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Tapestry of Time

Stats:
Published: 2022-04-02 Completed: 2022-11-17 Words: 107,923 Chapters: 18/18

Kingdom of Dreams

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38119888.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F, F/M, M/M, Other

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit

Additional Tags:
Blood and Gore, Violence, Explicit Sexual Content

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Tapestry of Time

Stats:
Published: 2022-04-02 Completed: 2022-11-17 Words: 107,923
Chapters: 18/18

Kingdom of Dreams

by Faded_Glory

Summary

Struggling to find balance, Adora leaves to find her answers about She-Ra, about Mara, about who she is now that the War is over. While Catra returns to Mystacor to learn how to wield her magic. Seeking to uncover the mysteries of the ancient past that lay within the Elemental Basilica and the secrets to the Nameless One, that only Light Spinner had known.

Notes

Ok, I have not finished writing this one. But I have it planned it out more or less. I figure you guys might be eager to keep going with this story. If you hadn't figured it out yet. I love writing the day by day. As the character's struggle with moving forward into the future. As always, leave a comment or a kudo's . It the fuel that keeps us writer's going.

Broken Bonds

(Free…?) Twin voices echoing, in his mind. Kyle scrunched his eyebrows in confusion, as he lay prone on the ground. He could feel the heat of a fire nearby, it made him uneasy but he lacked the strength to move. He could feel Lonnie's hand resting on his cheek and Rogelio holding his hand. It settled his fears as it always did, knowing that his most precious friends were near.

(Yin…hurts..) A gentle pleading moan.

(Yang…weak..) A rumbling groan…then silence.

(Master…)

Kyle groaned and rolled his head to the side, as the soft voice whispered plaintively against the back of his mind.

(You are still alive?) The other voice inquired bluntly.

Kyle took a deep breath, smiling faintly as the deeper voice resonated after the softer one. The two voices in his head seemed to start and finish each other's sentences, as if they were of one mind. It had been disconcerting at first but he was getting used to it. He didn't know if perhaps he had gone mad, or if this was magic…but he swore that the two orbs had started talking to him back when he was trapped in that inferno. Somehow he had survived…Flashes of Adora carrying him out, the gentle, soothing balm of healing magic covering his body…then darkness.

Kyle merely nodded, not having enough energy to speak. His whole body hurt, every muscle and nerve throbbing with a bone deep ache. The exhaustion of being brought back from the brink of death, hung over his awareness like a heavy shroud. Leaving

him barely able to move against the invisible weight pinning him down, his mind floating in a strange half aware state, as consciousness came and went. Then he felt them, pressing against his side. Like two lost and frightened animals, they nuzzled against his hip seeking comfort and warmth.

"What the hell!" Lonnie exclaimed, jumping to her feet as the two orbs lurched forward and rolled sluggishly away from Max. Who had been tinkering with the smashed control chips that were now dangling off of them. The metal faces bent and twisted free as the Orbs rolled over the chips. Leaving the wires and fine components to crunch against the ground as they moved.

Max tucked the small picks he had been using to pry open the chips, back into a tiny pocket of his utility belt under his woolen poncho. Observing the two orbs with mild trepidation as they butted insistently against Kyle's hip. Kyle groaned and flopped his free hand over the two orbs protectively, stilling their movements.

Rogelio growled nervously, glancing up at Adora for answers. Adora, who was sitting nearby, merely shrugged, not knowing what to do. They didn't seem aggressive anymore. Kyle had beaten them and in return the orbs had submitted to him. They didn't seem to pose any kind of threat.

The late afternoon sun was falling behind the steep, rugged cliffs. That surrounded the scorched remains of the Red Squad's memorial. The wind howling off the rocky shoreline below, was cool. Rushing over the desolate bluffs and barren, upper crags of Scorpion Hills. Flattening what was left of the dying, scrub grass. That had survived the onslaught of energy fire and magic. The outcropping would be scarred by their battle for many seasons. But in time it too would heal and the marks of their combat would disappear.

As soon as Catra saw the gentle light of She-Ra’s healing magic, engulf Kyle. She could wait no longer and had set out to the higher cliffs to find Melog. Her anxiety and worry was nearing their breaking point. Never expecting that a few of her squad mates would accompany her, but thankful for them. If she ran into trouble up there with that Eternian she could definitely use the back up.

Now Catra was in the lead, unwilling to take the long way up along the barely used goat trails that wound lazily up the hillside to the upper heath. She had sprang upon the wall of hard packed clay and sand stone ascending upward behind the memorial’s outcropping. Taking to the rocky ledges and barely visible foot holds along the sheer face of the cliff. With Otis, Atila and Levi climbing in her wake. Alert to every sound and movement around them, the boys had their boot knives gripped tight in their teeth and a stun baton was dangling from it’s leather harness on Levi's wrist. As battle hardened soldiers, their faces wore a mask of unshakeable focus and cold determination.

It had taken most of the day for Adora to heal Kyle enough. That he was no longer on death's door. But he was still far from being able to travel. So they had set up camp around the burnt remains of their circle of stones. Setting up the tents and starting a fire to keep Kyle warm. Adora had remained behind, needing to keep Kyle stable with her magic. Sitting calmly before the fire next to him. As he slept on a blanket beside her. She kept a steadying hand on his shoulder, as he was curled up on his side cradling the two orbs against his stomach. Sore and exhausted, she wrapped herself up in her cloak, hood pulled up tight. Watching Rogelio, stack a decent pile of dried wood he had gathered from the small clusters of trees. That grew upon the rising bluffs that surrounded them. The hardy oaks were one of the few trees that could survive the intense winds and salt spray from the Serpentine Strait. Lonnie was busy with Max just beyond the campfire, setting up their tents.

Adora sighed with exhaustion, the healing aura surrounding her bracing hand was barely visible. The magic she was transferring into his body was barely a trickle now. His mortal wounds were healed, but the broken ribs and shattered spine were taking longer to mend. This kind of healing was slower, more methodical then as She-Ra. Using Sheana's power through the bracer and not being transformed into She-Ra. Was less taxing, at least physically. She was still drained of energy, though. Mentally exhausted from the strain of having to repair Kyle's body piece by piece. But far too stubborn to rest. Her thoughts were scattered, flitting from one worry to another. Falling upon Catra's whereabouts and Melog's well being. She kept glancing over her shoulder from time to time to the towering cliffs. Where Catra and her strike team had set off to find Melog. Hoping to exact some much needed retribution. On the Eternian that caused so much pain and blood shed to one of their own.

No one talked as they crawled over the side of the cliff, glaring warily around the barren heath that spread out ahead of them. They had ascended straight up to the higher bluffs, now a rocky field of wild grass and standing stones lay before them. With even greater cliffs looming at the furthest recesses of the heath. The upper crags and barrier rocks cast long shadows over the barren ground, as the sun sank below the highest peaks of Scorpion Hills.

They had walked only a few yards, before long ruts of energy fire and scorched earth surrounded them. What was left of the field was desolate, ravaged by fire and magic. The scars of the battle that had raged above them, was unmistakable. Catra took a steadying breath, barely containing the urge to scream for Melog. Her heart leaped into her throat as cold, terror gripped her chest. She picked up her pace, glancing frantically around the wide heath for any sign of Melog.

Atila, Otis and Levi quickly fanned out to cover more ground. As Catra sought to control her rising panic. Spinning in a circle

cataloging every scuff, every gouge, every scotch mark upon the battlefield. Replaying the swift yet brutal fight in her mind's eye… as her expression contorted from grim clarity to utter dismay…as she found herself before a large circular patch of burnt grass on the far side of the cliff. The rocky beach stretched down below, the raging water of the strait lashing against the stones that hugged the base of the cliff.

“Melog!” Catra snapped her head up and screamed in terror. She couldn’t feel them! Melog’s comforting presence deep inside of her, was no longer there. Back was that lonely void she had felt. When they had been separated by her trip to space without them.

The light of two greater full moons overhead, cast strange shadows over the crisp white snow. The freezing wind was blowing hard, snapping Tri-clop’s heavy wool cloak violently. The hardened warrior stood upon the deck of an old War Sled, the curved front hood was dented and slightly rusted from surviving many battles. He gripped the handles of the sled's controls with his left hand. As his right arm was melted beyond recognition from his wrist to his elbow. The wires and gears fused and seized from a massive flare of wild magic. His hand was no longer functioning, the metal arm hanging limp at his side. The servo’s in his left arm were still usable, but shorted. Sparking and buzzing, in protest. Creating an annoying hum that issued from under his cloak.

His leather hood was pulled up. To shield his face from the freezing wind. Tendrils of smoke escaped along the hem, quickly blown away by the fierce wind created by the hovercraft's speed. Two of his robotic, enhanced eyes were destroyed, the other damaged but still functional. The red eye flickered and buzzed, within the shadows of his hood. Faintly lighting the tundra ahead in an eerie crimson glow. He had won, but not without sustaining major damage to his cybernetic frame. He would be in repair for

weeks, before he could set out to continue his surveillance of his current obsession.

In all his years, traveling the universe doing Lord Skeletor's bidding. He had never come across such a fascinating mystery. A First One, who could summon the Universal Magic without the aid of a portable rune stone. It was unheard of!

Modulok's communication had been brief, a sparse report of an ancient Master of the Universe, that had not been seen for over a thousand years. Had been sighted in the Forests of Etheria. A planet that had just reappeared after a thousand years of absence from the Tri-solar system.

Modulok was an unscrupulous, morally bankrupt mutant. With an ego and ambition for power that rivaled Skeletor's. The scientist had been playing both sides of Eternia's power struggle for years. Siding with which ever side would fund his unorthodox experiments. He had been getting sloppy at covering up his less than humane research recently, while working for King Randor. Overreaching with the last massive shipment of stasis containers. That he was now hoarding in a warehouse on the outskirts of Eternos. His traitorous ways had finally caught up to him. The portal tech's he had on his payroll at the Eternos ground base had turned on him. Unwilling to go down for Modoluk's crimes, they had called in the Royal Guards as soon as he started shipping container's through the portal. He had used Lord Skeletor's Husks to harvest this planet, intending to sell some of his specimens on the black market and keep others for his research. King Randor's, Man at Arms and a contingent of Royal guards had been waiting for him to return through the portal at Eternos's Ground Base. He was quickly taken into custody to be put on trial for treason against the crown.

Lord Skeletor had sent several small combat teams to Etheria months ago, during Primes occupation. Feigning allegiance to the Emperor of the Universe, to help his clone forces secure the rebels. In reality their mission was to hunt down several relics that

were lost when the planet disappeared. One was the Sword of Protection, the other was the Shard of Kaydak.

When Modulok's visuals of this this strange Master of the Universe was transmitted over the com's, Tri-clop's interest was peaked. It had been pure luck to run into her at the old Horde fortress he had stumbled upon during his survey of the planet. The energy reading's he got when she was transformed were unbelievable. She was at least twice as powerful as He-Man and her magic was completely unrestrained. But she had no portable Rune Stone so how was she channeling the magic without completely vaporizing her own body? Summoning the Source, without a reservoir to hold it, restrain and channel it safely was unheard of.

At that point he had become obsessed with getting answers. Jitsu's interrogation had been a waste of time and when he commanded the drone to kill him. That crazy Etherian wizard had smashed his drone. He had not been able to gain any more information about the whereabouts of the Shard of Kaydak or this Master of the Universe until today. The woman was a miraculous puzzle...that should not exist? She had transformed only once...her power had been unbelievable. Yet today he finds her channeling the magic through…portable rune stones in her bracer's. What happened? But the reading he got from the drone made no sense the bracer's were organic…not tech. He needed answers!

Huntara squinted into the blizzard that now blinded her. Staring out of the back of a large metal sled. As it flew over the barren, frozen tundra. Her head was ringing, barely able to remember the brief, but humbling fight she had had with this Eternian Cyborg. Her confidence in her fighting prowess was now shaken. She had been so easily overpowered by his tech, tossing her around like a helpless child. Her speed, physical strength and horde combat tactics, that she once had full confidence in. Had not given her any kind of advantage. Over the speed and superior strength of his robotic arms and legs. Or his visor's ability to shoot energy

fire, while also being able to see in every direction at once. She had been disarmed and overwhelmed in minutes. If it had not been for Catra's companion's interruption to their battle. She might have been dead and not just beaten into submission and captured instead.

Now she was lying prone on the deck of this alien sled, with her hands bound behind her in chunky metal cuffs. Curled up on her side, facing out the back. Taken prisoner and hauled off to Etheria knows where…

It had been days since Swift Wind had felt Adora transform, let alone use enough of She-ra's magic to even be felt through their bond. But he was determined to use that brief flash of magic he felt that afternoon, to track down his errant princess! Over the years since, the magic transformed him. Swift Wind had rediscovered who he was. Life had been simple when he had been just a normal horse in Thaymor. He never begrudged Adora for accidentally turning him into an Alicorn. He had always felt honored that he was given a greater purpose, a destiny far beyond his humble pasture. He had been given a gift, to be more, to be able to form complex thoughts and choose his own destiny. To fight for freedom and protect the people he had come to love. In return he had been loyal and steadfast to Adora, always heeding the call of her magic. When She-Ra needed him, he would always be there. But since the Sword of Protection had been destroyed, that magic had changed. At the beginning of Primes occupation that magic had been desturbingly silent. He had never been more scared or felt more lost than when Adora's magic had disappeared, after the shattering of the Sword. He had never wanted to experience that complete lack of magic ever again.

Then later it had surged within him like a newborn star, when Adora finally got her magic back. It had rushed through him, like a mighty, crashing wave. Giving him the power to save his friends at Elboron.

He had thought that after Adora freed the magic within the heart, her magic would have been amplified even more. But after the war…that mighty power receded into something more gentle. Always there…woven into the fabric of Etheria itself. It became more like a whispered song that he could barely hear. A constant hum that surrounded him all the time. He found it comforting, like a security blanket he could always rely on.

As her connection to Catra strengthened, during Primes Occupation. He felt that their bond began to weaken. He was his own horse and never felt he had to be with her all the time. He had his own life to lead, a place in the Alliance he had carved out for himself. It was rather startling how she stopped confiding in him, seeking out Catra instead. It took some getting used to, but he had come to accept that perhaps his connection to Adora was not as strong as it once was.

Then a few days ago…he had gone dark! A flash of crimson light had overtook him, as he played with Finn on the Cloud Beach. His hide had turned black, his mane began to glow a deep blood red along with his eyes. His rainbow wings had darkened to a deep indigo. The once glorious feathers, he was so proud of. Molted to the ground leaving only leathery wings behind. The sudden rage and urge to exact retribution upon his enemies overwhelmed him. He had bucked, then reared, kicking his front hooves as he whinnied and snarled. Scaring poor Finn, who had run for his life. It had been several days now since he had seen the young Thaymorian. He knew that Finn was still on the island, as he could still smell the little boy but he was just avoiding him.

Swift Wind had died that afternoon and he was still mourning the loss. When the darkness faded, he was forever changed. Becoming less majestic, but far more wise and stalwart in both his appearance and personality. He no longer had a voice, but 'Thank Etheria', he never lost his intelligence.

Several days ago, the urge to stay close to Adora had been so much stronger than before. So he had set off from Mystacor to find her. No longer able to fly, he had trotted to the edge of the

floating island. Where the smaller grassy steps of floating earth would lead him back down to the main continent. Then he had galloped straight for the Whispering Woods, trusting that the forest would take him towards the southern grassland of Scorpania. As Swift Wind in the months leading up to this. He had flown over this new Etheria, mapping it inside his mind with his own magic. Even as just a horse, he would never become lost. His hooves would be as stalwart as his wings once were carrying him where he was needed most.

Following his magical intuition, like an arrow to his target. He navigated through the forest, the plains of Thaymor. Running across the now lush fields and valleys of Scorpania, heading unerringly towards Scorpion Hills.

He had tried and failed over the course of this week, to come to terms with Adora not confiding in him. When the magic they shared had begun to change, resulting in his current form. He was angry and frustrated with her. They used to have such a close connection…a sacred bond. But ever since she had gotten close to Catra again. Intentional or not, she had pulled away…which made him feel like he wasn't needed anymore. He felt cast aside and forgotten…replaced…abandoned…

It hurt and he couldn't help but feel jealous and afraid that he was losing her to that magicat. A person he still didn't trust fully. A person who was once an enemy, who had hurt Adora repeatedly over the last three years. But he had been patient and understanding, as their friendship mended itself. When it had turned into something more, after the Heart and they had disappeared together for many weeks. He had accepted it, his loyalty and trust in Adora had always been unquestioned.

Now…now he couldn't help but question…

He stood before the ocean now, stamping his hooves anxiously on the stoney beach. The last rays of the sun were burning upon the horizon, painting the heavy clouds in a vibrant array of color. The sky high above was already darkening into the deep blues of

twilight. The largest of the Greater Moon's was rising behind him, over the cliffs. Casting it's silver's gleam upon the upper heaths and crags of Scorpion Hills.

Staring dismissively, at his fractured reflection. Upon the dark, rolling water, foaming and lapping around his hooves. He was getting used to his new form again. It was comforting to revert back to what he once was. Yet disappointing all the same, as he could still remember his life as Swift Wind. His hide that had once been a dark brown when he had just been a simple horse, had turned a silvery-white. His mane was now orange, just like it once was when he had been an Alicorn. He no longer had a horn or wings. His bright blue eyes that twinkled with magic had returned to a soft, soulful brown just like he had as a horse. He had been scared when he lost his ability to speak, that he would lose his ability to think as well. But thankfully, the intelligence he had gained when first transformed by the magic remained. He shook his head sharply, tossing his mane as he closed his eyes and focused upon that invisible thread that always pulled him towards Adora. The high bluffs and wild heaths of Scorpion Hills rose up on his right. He tried not to wallow in the grief of what he had lost. He was no longer Swift Wind…but merely the 'Spirit' of that once majestic Alicorn.

It was the soft, plaintive sound that drew Spirit towards a cluster of larger boulders near the base of the cliff. Investigating the faint rustle, sensing the distress of a fatally wounded creature. He hesitantly trotted around the cluster of massive boulders, their surface smoothed and glistened a jet black from the constant polishing of the sea spray. Unsure if what lay behind would approve of his presence or attack him for intruding upon its last breaths. Leaning down with his muzzle, to nudge the narrow gap between two tall stones. His nostrils flared nervously, as Spirit took a good sniff of the strange, yet familiar scent the lay hidden within. That was wafting up from between the cracks of those stones. Along with the cool mist now brushing up against the smooth velvet tip of his nose. He instantly recognized that mix of scent and sensation.

(Melog?) He whinnied, urgently stamping his front hooves. The fine stones that made up the shoreline of the Serpentine Straight crunching and grinding excitedly under his hooves. Finding the alien in a poor, badly beaten state was startling and panic thrummed inside Spirit's chest. Melog was no longer able to keep their cat-like form, reduced to a weak, flickering iridescent blob. That was now cowering and shivering near death between these two stones.

This was bad…this was really bad…

(Wait here…I will bring help!) Spirit knickered and huffed. Nudging the blob compassionately with their nose for a moment before dashing off down the beach. Adora was just above him, on the towering bluffs that overlooked the water. He just needed to find a way up there.

Sorrow filled Catra's eyes, as she reentered camp. Unable to pull her gaze from the ground, so distraught with worry. She never noticed Adora closing in, her blue eyes shimmering with sympathy. The feline flinched, when she felt arms encircling her and pulled her in.

"I've got you..." Adora whispered soothingly into Catras ear as she held her close. It was then Catra finally allowed herself to cave into the sadness. She had been barely keeping it together all the way back to camp. As soon as she felt the security of Adora's arms and the comfort of her scent she was unable to hold it in any longer. With a soft whimper she pressed her face against Adora's chest, hiding her tears from the others. As she clutched Adora's shoulder blades and wept silently.

"Melog's….gone…" She moaned faintly, a grim finality in her breathless declaration.

The fear and misery in Catra's voice had Adora instantly on the verge of tears herself. Taking a brief shuddering breath, she

quickly regained her composure. Knowing that Catra did not need her breaking down as well. But she was scared too, these Eternian's were powerful. This Tri-clops guy could have very well killed them. But she wasn't going to give into those kinds of tragic thoughts, she was going to have hope. Until Melog's body was found she wasn't going to give into the worst case scenario.

"We'll find them…I promise…" Adora assured her, holding her close and rubbing her back in long, calming strokes.

Atila, Otis and Levi filed past them somberly. Seating themselves upon the driftwood logs, that had been scavenged from the beach below and pulled up around the fire.

"There was no sign of them…or that Tri-clops fella. Just a lot of destruction, same as here." Levi grumbled, snapping a twig off the side of a log and poking its tip into the fire. Sending glowing sparks skyward, into the gray twilight that was now descending over Scorpion Hills.

"How's Kyle?" Atila asked, quietly. Nodding towards the trio, who were huddled together on the ground on a blanket. Leaning against a large, fat log near the fire. Kyle was sitting up, pressed between Rogelio and Lonnie, with the two orbs in his lap. He looked exhausted and utterly worn out. His soft blue eyes were unfocused, lips moving slightly as if he was having a silent conversation. While Lonnie fussed with another wool blanket draped over his legs. Rogelio chirped a short growl, thumping his chest over his heart with a fist. Having grown up with a non verbal Rogelio, they had all learned to decipher his visual language to a degree. Levi nodded at the lizardkin, so he knew she understood what he was saying. Kyle had a strong heart and he was going to get through this.

"He's recovering, thanks to She-Ra's healing magic…." Lonnie breathed out in awe, staring gratefully up at Adora offering her a ghost of a smile. Still very worried about Kyle. "But he is going to need a few days rest before we can head back to Scorpania." Lonnie stated. Adora had explained to her that even though Kyle

was healed. He would still need a few days to get his vitality back. That the magic he stole and the magic she used to heal him had taken a toll on his body.

"Otis and I have to head out at dawn, as I said we have a boat to catch." Atila restated.

"Are you heading up to the old Horde naval base or down to Cuttie's Cove?" Max inquired lightly, leaning over his knees as he got comfortable on the log.

"We are heading further south." Otis grumbled back, not giving anymore details.

"Let the man have his secrets, Max!" Levi shook her head, elbowing Max in the ribs harshly as she sat down beside her partner on the log.

"I was just asking…" Max muttered, not understanding the reason for secrecy.

"They are part of the crew of a Pirate ship…Max." Levi leaned in close and growled low, near Max's ear. Making the pale blonde's eyes widen and his eyebrows shoot up into his hairline. He had never figured that out.

"Our Captain was nice enough to drop us off near Sea Worthy. But he aint' going to wait for us if we don't show up at the rendezvous point." Atila started to explain, his voice trailing off. As his eyes narrowed, catching sight of something just beyond the firelight. His hand moved low, over the handle of his boot knife. Otis noticed and quickly rose to his feet off the log they were sharing. His amputated tentacles snapping aggressively.

It was the shine of an animal's eyes that first appeared from the gloom beyond the firelight. Adora sensed the animal's presence and quickly ushered a barely composed Catra behind her. Catra hiccuped, quickly clearing the moisture from her eyes with her

wrists. Always prepared to hide her misery and defend herself, at a moment's notice.

With a knicker and a shake of his sleek head, Spirit appeared from the darkness. His pale hide glowing like the healing light of She-Ra in the firelight, his mane blazing like the golden hue of her power.

“A horse?” Lonnie cried in disbelief, slowly rising to her feet. Making Kyle slump towards Rogelio’s shoulder as he had fallen asleep again.

Adora was stunned at first, unable to take her eyes off the regal beauty of this horse. As it so bravely entered their camp. Its warm, gentle eyes were so familiar? The elegance to its movements, the strength in its stride. As it cantered without fear towards them.

The horse came up short before Adora, shaking its fiery withers sharply. Before nudging her in the chest with it’s muzzle. Then turned, presenting it’s rear in invitation.

Adora swallowed hard, glancing nervously back at Catra. Who stood behind her, her lips thinned to a hard line to maintain her composure. A perplexed distrust shadowed her eyes as she lightly sniffed the air.

“Horsey…” Adora returned her gaze back to the horse. Muttering softly in fearful disbelief. As she finally released who this horse reminded her of. Suddenly she couldn’t breath, as the heavy weight of grief and horror settled over her.

Catra took her hand then, her ears flicking nervously. She could hear Adora’s heart rate suddenly picking up, her breath becoming more shallow.

“Adora what’s going on?” She asked Adora gently.

Adora was quick to gather her turbulent emotions and stuff them down deep inside herself. Needing to stay focused and in control,

she refused to allow herself to speculate anymore about who this horse was. Until she had solid proof that it was Swift Wind.

“I don’t know but this horse wants us to come with them.” She turned to regard Catra firmly. Her eyes now steeled with determination to plunge once again into that abyss of the unknown. Trusting that the universe would lead her where she is needed most. Catra merely nodded, because she would never have to jump alone. They climbed onto the back of the strange horse without another word.

“Where are you guys going?” Levi jumped to her feet in alarm, as they mounted the horse.

“I have no idea…but we’ll be back. I’m certain of it.” Adora promised, before leaning over the Horse's neck, threading her fingers through his wither’s and grasping his mane tight. As the horse leaped forward into a full gallop back along the narrow trail that would lead them down to the shore.

The greater moon’s were high overhead, hiding amid the clouds. Hovering over the strait like eternal sentinels always on watch. Their gentle light focused solely upon the rolling waves, making them shimmer as if created from molten silver. The sky was dark, the stars hidden behind thick clouds. A storm was brewing out over the sea, yet to hit the mainland. But it threatened on the far side of the Strait, over Meadowlands, like an omen.

The horse was sure footed along the narrow trail. That wove downward from the steep cliffs and desolate bluffs towards the rocky shoreline.

Adora’s tumultuous thoughts were roaring in her head. Guilt and dread tumbling and clashing inside of her, regarding this strange horse's sudden appearance. Her link to Swift Wind had gone silent, days ago. But she had not taken it too seriously. The Alicorn was fiercely independent and if he flew too far away it was

natural for their link to fade. When she had been in space, they had spent months without feeling one another.

She was left to ponder yet again…if this Horse really was Swift Wind. She had not taken into account how sealing her magic might affect her trusty steed. When she broke the sword…there was very little impact upon Swift Wind beside no longer feeling her magic. Perhaps she was just jumping to dire conclusions, perhaps this horse was just that…a random horse.

That had an uncanny resemblance to Swift Wind.

That moved with the same confident grace like Swift Wind.

The little snorts and huffs he made while carrying them down to the moonlit beach, was typical of Swift Wind when he was upset with her.

Adora swallowed hard, blinking rapidly to clear away the tears of remorse that wanted to fall. It was with a broken, shaky breath that she leaned over the horse's ear and whispered.

“Swifty…what happened to you?”

The horses whinnied with joy, at how quickly she recognized him. Then nodded sharply, affirming that she guessed correctly.

Adora moaned, wrapping her arms around his neck and squeezed, pressing her face into his neck.

“I’m sorry….She-Ra’s magic has been sealed away inside the bracers on my wrists. I guess it affected you too?” She sighed in dismay.

“Adora…” Catra’s voice was soft, tender. As she rubbed a hand soothingly in small circles on Adora’s back. Sensing her grief and guilt. She had been able to piece together the identity of this horse as well. Swift Wind may have changed in appearance, but he still smelled the same.

Silence reigned for a long time, as Adora came to terms with how her choices had inadvertently affected one of her most treasured friends. Wondering bleakly, if Swift Wind was not speaking to her because he was mad or if he could no longer communicate verbally? Finally after staring at the moonlit water for a very long time. Listening to the horses' hooves crunching upon the small pebbles that dominated the sand along the coast. She found her courage to speak once more.

"Can you still speak?" Adora asked, giving the horse a gentle pat on his cheek to get his attention.

The horse made a rude, huffing sound. Flapping his lips against his front teeth in frustration.

"That's ok…we'll figure out how to communicate. We got this! Our sacred bond will never break." Adora affirmed with a resolute nod.

The horse stopped suddenly, jerking it's riders violently. Adora was bumped forward over his wither's, while Catra yelped in fright as she was flung forward suddenly. Losing her balance and being dislodged from the horse's back, slipping sideways to the beach. Hitting the pebbles and small stones on the ground with an indignant grunt.

"What the hell!" Catra lay sprawled on her side for a moment. Mentally gathering the tattered remains of her dignity. Then scrambled back up to her feet. Claws out and tail bristled, ready to fight. Not expecting the sudden stop and assuming they were under attack again. Adora quickly righted herself and slipped down off the side of the horse. Her boots crunching softly against the stones as she dismounted.

The horse whinnied and trotted ahead, shaking his head low. Disgruntled and fuming over what Adora had said.

Adora sighed, then nodded. Accepting that Swift Wind was mad at her because of what happened to him and he had every right to

be angry. For however long he needed to be, but she was adamant that she would make amends. A simple apology was not good enough. She willed the disappointed tears to dry as she began to formulate a new approach.

"I never thought you would be affected…it must have been so scary when you lost your transformation and went back to being just a horse." Adora walked after him. Seeking to get him to understand that she didn't do this on purpose.

The horse glared accusingly over his shoulder at her. Stopping her in her tracks. The familiar hurt burning in their eyes was enough to make Catra suck in a startled breath. She understood far too well the pain she saw reflected in the horse's eyes.

Abandonment…Betrayal…heartbreak…

Reaching out, Catra lightly grasped Adora's wrist. Silently restraining her from further approaching the horse. He was angry and might lash out and hurt Adora.

Which would result in regret and self -loathing for losing control. Catra understood that vicious cycle, and had lived it for three years.

"Give him some space, right now. Ok." Catra offered, moving to stand in front of Adora. Blocking her view of the brooding stallion stamping in the sand a few yards ahead of them.

Adora nodded, bowing her head in somber reflection upon the moonlit beach. She wouldn't push. She would give this version of Swift Wind space…this was just one more friendship she had to mend.

The horse whinnied more urgently and shook his muzzle towards Catra. Beckoning the feline to him. Catra was stunned at first, then reluctantly left Adora's side.

The horse led her onward, further down the beach. Leaving Adora to stand alone and forlorn upon the rocky shore. Glowering down

at the toes of her leather boots, as the dark water lapped against them.

He led Catra to a small cluster of weather worn boulder's that huddled around the base of a towering cliff. She looked upward, scanning the looming earthen wall. Realizing with dread, that the heath Melog had been fighting on that afternoon was above her. A ball of ice formed painfully in her gut. As she paid the horse a resolute nod. When he came to stand directly behind her blocking her from exiting the sheltered ring of stones.

She was hesitant to walk into the complete darkness that lay behind the towering boulder's. But the horse would not allow her to even get her bearings. Now, pushing her forward with a guiding pressure of his muzzle against the small of her back.

"I'm going…I'm going…" She complained, indignantly. As the horse impatiently pushed her forward.

With the moons covered by thick clouds from the overcast sky. Catra was quickly swallowed by the pitch black. Her ears folded back anxiously, as this forced march into the dark resurrected rather brutal memories from her childhood.

Shadow Weaver had used the darkness as a 'teaching tool'. A way to cage her, force her to cool her temper and reflect. But it only made her more resentful, more angry. That Adora only got a few firm words and disappointed looks. While she was locked in that cursed storage room deep in the bowels of the Forge. The walls were so thick it prevented any sounds from leaving. So her punishments would remain hidden and undisturbed. As Shadow Weaver, tolled out lashes with a wicker rod or her bare hands. Tormented with her with shadows of her Squad mates. That would spit half truths and reticule her inadequacies. As if their opinions ever mattered to her. Perhaps if the vile witch had used a vision of Adora as Prime had, Catra's spirit might have broken as a child. Making her more malleable and obedient. But thankfully Shadow Weaver had never crossed that line. Other times she would bind her with the electric bolts of magic. Leaving her

writhing in pain, in the throes of the black garnets power. Or simply leave her in the darkness for hours. Trapped in the silent void of nothingness. To curl up in the corner of the room, forced to sit and contemplate her choices, her weakness, her tireless faults that always landed her here.

But she had also been trapped in the Light as well…unable to think, or act of her own free will. Her true self caged inside her own body, left to scream and rail against her bonds. As Prime paraded her about like a puppet, forced to speak and act against her will.

Forced to hurt the woman she loved…

She had always been tenacious. Her spirit was wild and free, always pushing against whatever cage tried to contain her. Unable to adhere to any of the dogma the Horde fed to them growing up. Such as duty, discipline and sacrifice. Her life was her own and she would always live it her way. So she had chosen to walk that line between light and dark…to exist in that morally ambiguous world of gray. In whichever good or bad her choices were, they would be her own and she would bear the consequences.

In the furthest corner of the small circle of stones, there was a faint, incandescent glow. Wedged tight within a crevasse between two boulder's. Cowering in the protection of the stones, like a frightened, wounded animal. Then a flicker of magic, sparked in the core of the faceless blob. Reaching outwards, it floated towards her like the pale thread of a spider web. As she reached out to touch the ghostly wisp, it wrapped around her wrist and flared a bright orange. Mimicking the fiery color of her Sun Stone. Just like before…just like on Krytis…the magic that gave Melog life, sought to bond with the magic that lived inside her own soul. There was a flash of light and suddenly a new connection was formed.

Catra swallowed, seeking to hold back the panic that suddenly wanted to escape her throat. As the starling revelation took hold. The faint shapeless creature that lay upon the pebbles, hidden in

the crack between two tall boulders. The weak, vulnerable blob of energy. Was all that was left of her precious Melog.

"Melog!" She finally shouted, rushing into action. As she raced to the blobs side, sliding on her knees to pick it up and cradle it tenderly to her breast. Sobbing and snarling, as she just didn't know how to react. As she was both relieved, enraged and drowning in despair.

"What happened to you…" She whispered, as the blob hummed in response to her myriad of turbulent emotions. It's formless body begins to absorb her magic, as the sustenance was offered freely. Warming into a pale orange glow, as a new lifeline was formed between them and it's master.

Melog could no longer speak, but it's emotions mirrored that of her own. Then faintly their own feelings, trickled through their link. They were sorry for worrying her. Their arrogance had been their downfall. Believing that they were still as strong as they once were on Krytis. When they had fought with the full magnitude of Krytis's wild magic and forced Prime and his armies off of their planet. They have not been thinking clearly of late. They had given into their rage and fear at the prospect of losing Catra. To their oldest enemy. Making them take risks, use up the last of their Krytian Magic in some crazy kamikaze attack in the hopes that it would kill Tri-clops.

Melog began to cast into her mind the final images of their valiant battle to subdue Tri-clops. The fight had been intense and was over far too quickly. This Eternian was powerful and cunning. With an arsenal of tech that was much more than just Seeker Drones at his disposal. Melog was angry and frustrated that they had been defeated. Humiliated and humbled by how effortlessly the Eternian had beaten them. They had seen themselves as something powerful. An ancient tool, capable of unbelievable magic. The fact that they had been mighty enough once to drive Prime's forces off their planet. Had emboldened them, to seek retribution for their people, their planet. All on their own. But that power, what was left of it, had faded inside them unknowingly

over the last thousand years. They had gambled and used up the last of their Krytian Magic in the hopes of defeating the cyborg. Only to be cast over the cliff, weakened and near death.

Left in a defenseless, near incorporeal state. Thankful that the silly horse had sensed their meager traces of magic and found them and brought help. Now they were nestled in the safety of their master’s arms. Surrounded by her magic, soothed and sustained by it. Melog settled into her arms, purring softly as they finally found sanctuary again. Resting for the first time in a thousand years in the peace and comfort of her magical aura.

Change

Once again, it was just the five of them sitting before a low burning campfire deep into the night. Rogelio had gathered up some more blankets, hours ago. Now Lonnie was huddled, beneath the woolen protection with Kyle resting against her chest in the circle of her arms. While Rogelio tended to the coals. Keeping the fire alive with small logs, from a moderate pile of wood he had gathered earlier. From the sparse clusters of young trees growing on the hillsides behind them.

Adora sat upon their sleeping bag, with Catra. Having wrapped her maroon cloak around both of them. The feline was leaning her head against the blonde's shoulder, absently adjusting a blanket with one hand, that was tucked up over their laps. While holding what was left of Melog against her stomach as she sat cross legged before the fire. Her orange runic glow thrummed around her body, pulsing like a heartbeat in the very core of the now molten blob in her lap.

"Melog will be alright…" Kyle's small voice broke the heavy silence.

Catra glanced up at him, her eyes were red rimmed from crying. A lost, forlorn shimmer still shrouding them. Her expression is devoid of any emotion. The stress and exhaustion of the last few weeks were starting to take its toll on her mental and physical health.

Adora unconsciously wrapped a comforting arm around Catra's shoulder keeping her close. As she kept a close eye on the horse, who had been standing guard all night. He had never approached the fire, always hovering at the edge of the outlook. Staring towards the storm upon the strait. As the dark clouds continued to gather upon the horizon, sluggishly rolling towards the mainland. The sun would be up in an hour or two and then the squad would be going their separate ways once again.

“Yin…says be at peace…your Golem is weak. As it has been drained of all it’s magic. Allow it to rest for as long as it needs and one day. All will be as it once was.” Kyle slurred, as his exhausted voice filtered out once more.

Catra stared at him in quiet confusion. Melog rarely talked about themselves or their past. To find out they were called a golem, was startling but not unexpected. She had been putting the pieces together for a couple seasons about who or what Melog might be. She had no idea what a Golem was, but at least now she had another piece to the puzzle that was Melog.

Kyle offered her a small smile, slapping his hands over each of the orbs nestled against his hips.

“This is Yin.” He patted the white one, on his left hip.

“This is Yang.” He patted the black one, on his right hip.

“They are Combat Golem’s.....An Arial Assault model...” He explained, struggling to stay conscious. His eyes were heavy and kept closing. But he refused to fall asleep again, he needed to tell Catra all that he had learned from his new friends.

“What kind of Golem is Melog?” Catra asked, her expression hopeful.

Kyle merely shrugged at first, as her weak, yearning smile faded into disappointment.

“Your…Melog…is a very ancient, very powerful Golem… it may be the last of their kind.” Kyle finished with a long sigh. “Melog needs your magic…to sustain itself…as long as they have a connection to your power they can never die.” Kyle’s voice faded, as his chin slumped against his chest, unable to stay awake.

Catra nodded, holding Melog protectively against her stomach seeking to pour even more magic into them.

The pale half light of the gray pre-dawn covered the sky. The heavy clouds hovering in the distance were ominous, with lightning flashing deep in their depths. Which only increased Spirits' anxious state of hyper awareness. The pale white horse stood vigilant upon the cliff's edge, the anxious pull to protect Adora from some unseen foe. Was still nagging at him. He felt he was missing something? Some clue or smell to track down why he still felt he needed to stay alert? His instincts were humming that this wide open bluff was not safe.

“Calm down, Dearie.” An old croaky voice called up to him. “You are strung too tight, I fear you might snap!”

Spirit nickered happily and bowed his head. To greet the wise old lady, who lived in the Woods near Bright Moon. After he had been transformed into Swift Wind, he had been terrified and confused. Nearly crashing through the roof of Madame Razz’s hut during his first frenzied flight with his new wings. The old lady had helped him down from the huge willow tree that he got hung up on. Soothed his fears as she hummed a soft tune, tending diligently to his many cuts. That he had received from the sharp spindly branches. Rubbing noxious smelling herbs into the cuts around his legs. Since then he had gone to her hut at least once a week to check on her. Sometimes she would be there, sometimes he wouldn’t find her home for many weeks. As the war escalated and then Primes invasion, pulled him further and further away from Bright Moon. He was unable to check on her, but he never stopped thinking about her. Wondering how she was fairing with all the chaos and upheaval happening all over Etheria.

This was the first time he had seen her in nearly a year. It was a bit unnerving though, how she seemed to just appear out of thin air. He had never heard her approach or even smelled her until she was standing before him. He didn’t dwell upon the mystery, far too happy to see the old woman.

(Razz! It’s so good to see you.) Spirit huffed and stamped his front hooves eagerly.

“It is good to see you too.” She offered, reaching up and patting his cheek affectionately.

Spirit had sensed that Razz was a magical being the same as them, years ago. So he merely grinned cheerfully down at her. Thrilled that she was able to read his thoughts and respond in kind.

(I would ask why you are out here, so far from your hut. But I figure that may be prying and none of my business.) Spirit tossed his mane, returning to stare out over the gray pre-dawn sea.

“I go where I am needed.” Razz answered. Brushing her wrinkled hands down her weathered, worn out skirts of her dress absently. As she slowly scanned the shoreline that stretched out beyond the outlook. With a curt nod, she raised a single wrinkled finger and pointed it towards what seemed to be an empty part of the overcast sky.

“Razzle…Dazzle.” She muttered, sending a spark of magic from her boney fingertip. That shot towards the sky like a firecracker, snapping and fizzing in the air. Dusting what lay below.

“This is what’s got you all worked up, dearie.” Razz snapped her fingers. As the magic dust flashed across the metal facade of a Death Seeker Drone. That had been hovering just beyond the outlook, spying on them. Her powerful magic, forcing the Eternian Tech to reveal itself.

[Warning! Cloak is offline. Warning!] A klaxon sounded, as a robotic voice boomed out shattering the silent morning.

“Oh, hush now. You will wake everyone up!” Razz tutted, snapping her fingers again silencing the drone. Then reached out her hand, drawing the floating head of the bird of prey into her long, slender fingers. Holding it firmly before tucking it under her armpit as if it was a small, badly behaved pet in need of restraint.

Spirit just stood there in awe and surprise at how effortlessly the old woman had dealt with the drone. It slowly settled in how

unbelievably powerful Razz was, it was also rather disconcerting that she kept it hidden. Pretending to be a simple, doddering old lady. Spirit flicked his ears nervously, he was kinda freaked out.

“What’s going on?” A groggy sounding Adora moaned from behind them.

Spirit snapped his head towards her, as she shuffled towards them. Rubbing at her eyes and yawning. She had barely just fallen asleep, when suddenly her steed’s anxious emotions startled her awake.

“Aw, well that is to be expected I guess.” Razz huffed as she glanced at both Spirit and then Adora. Slamming the now offline Seeker Drone onto the ground and promptly sitting down upon it. It was far too round and large for her short legs. Forcing the old woman to straddle its wide dome. Razz tutted and began adjusting her skirts modestly, hiding the drone away so Adora would not see it.

“Sit, sit, Adora. We have much to discuss.” Razz offered Adora to sit upon the ground before her. The old woman raised her wrinkled arms in the air, her chunky multi-colored bracelets clinking in the quiet gray dawn. As several large motes of light flared in the air around them. Hovering like fireflies, illuminating the small area of the cliff they were sitting upon. Into a soft, warm atmosphere that was as calm and soothing as Razz’s old hut in the woods.

Adora sat before the old woman dutifully. Taking in the storm clouds briefly that rumbled and rolled threateningly behind Razz.

Spirit remained standing, ever vigilant to their surroundings. Even though the culprit for his uneasy feelings had been found, he was still on edge. He snorted, wondering why Razz was hiding the Drone away from Adora.

“I see the magic found a way to restrain themselves.” Razz chuckled and shook her head ruefully, tapping one of Adora’s

bracer's.

"They told me that you would begin my training and then when I'm ready, the Whispering Woods would call me and lead me to Addie to complete my training." Adora stated, getting right to the point. Not wanting to waste any time with pleasantries or light conversation. That might distract Razz and have her rambling about things that served no purpose. Wanting to use whatever time she had with the strange old woman effectively.

"Ah, yes…I did agree to that. Didn't I." Razz chuckled.

Adora merely nodded with a hopeful smile. Her eyes flaring in surprise, when Razz conjured a huge bundle of willow shoots, each of different tan colors and various sizes and lengths.

"I guess there is no time like the present to start your first lesson in weaving." Razz grinned, conjuring her broom into her hand once more.

Adora just blinked, completely dumbfounded.

Razz leaned over her knees, poking the sticks with the handle of her broom.

"Sort those out for me, dearie." She instructed.

"How?" Adora asked, lightly picking up a thick pale colored rod. "Do you want them by color, length or thickness?"

Razz merely smiled gently. "You choose."

Adora nodded hesitantly, not liking that Razz couldn't just tell her exactly how to do it. She liked to be told how to do things. Having to guess and hope she was right, sent her anxiety skyrocketing. Several minutes later she had decided to sort them by thickness. Strangely enough it seemed each color bundled together perfectly based on that, so she was proud.

“Etheria is old, Adora.” Razz began. “But magic is far older, then even the universe.”

“Do you mean Sheana and Despara?” Adora inquired, her voice barely a whisper. Still overwhelmed by the prospect of wielding such an ancient, primordial power.

“Yes…and No, Dearie. They are merely some of the guiding threads to the tapestry.” Razz sighed.

Adora nodded solemnly. Patiently waiting for more of an explanation.

“Touch the ground.” Razz ordered.

Adora pressed her palms to the earth.

“Magic surrounds us, binds us to the weave. Mara came to understand this and so too must you.”

Adora expected she should feel the magic coursing through the earth, but all she felt was dirt and grass.

“What do you feel?” Razz inquired.

“Dirt.” Adora shrugged in disappointment. .

Razz sighed and nodded. “Perhaps, a more familiar magic? Spirit, come here.” the old woman beckoned. As the Horse had wandered off a little ways to nibble on a patch of grass that had miraculously survived the fire.

“Spirit?” Adora muttered, perplexed.

“Aye, He calls himself Spirit now.” Razz responded, sweetly.

Adora’s heart lurched painfully with grief, realizing bleakly that Swift Wind’s change was more than just a transformation this time. That the Alicorn…might very well be dead and replaced by this new version of himself.

Spirit plodded over to Razz, head hanging low in confusion.

“Can Adora touch you?” Razz asked simply. As Adora slowly raised her hand, nervous that Spirit was going to reject her. If he did, she might not be able to hold back the despair that had been compounding inside of her all night. She could very well see herself breaking down and bawling like a baby.

Spirit vibrated his thick lips against his top teeth and nudged his muzzle into Adora’s palm. Adora smiled gratefully and released a held breath of relief.

“What do you feel?” Razz asked.

“Warmth, soft fur…hot breath…” Adora answered, sadly.

“Close your eye’s dearie.” Razz chuckled, realizing that her thoughts and emotions were scattered. Distracting her from the more subtle components of the magic, she needed to shut out some of the stimuli to focus.

Adora slowly closed her eyes, breathing deeply as she sought to clear her mind.Going through the same centering techniques she had to use to summon She-Ra after the Failsafe. She understood that Razz wanted her to feel the magic and it was disconcerting that she was unable to sense it, even with a familiar bond to Swift….Spirit…

The guilt and sense of failure at not being able to protect him flooded through her. That whole train of thought hurt so unbearably. Adora grit her teeth refusing to cry. In a few moments Spirit merely pulled away, resuming his breakfast a few yards away.

Razz hummed thoughtfully, as she watched the painful emotions pass over Adora’s face. Then merely nodded, she would need to help the girl work through the emotional blocks she had erected.

Before she would be able tap into the weave of Etheria's magic freely.

Adora sighed and offered Razz a bleak grimace, feeling like a failure.
"Perhaps before the lesson, we should speak about the changes to your magic?"

Razz offered, her tone was patient, tender and kind.

It settled Adora's anxiety, over not instantly feeling the magic. She glanced at her bracers, her expression was a mixture of frustration and disappointment.

"If I had known, by restraining their power's in this way. Would result in losing Swift Wind. I would have never agreed to it."

Spirit's ear's flickered, giving away that he was eavesdropping on their conversation.

Razz leaned forward, grasping one of Adora's hands. Her expression was firm, her dark eyes intense.

"I see, So you believe Swift Wind is gone and you blame yourself for it."

"This magic has been as much a blessing for me and a bane, Razz. I want to learn, I want to become stronger and protect everyone. I want to be a force of good in the universe. But every time I move forward in any way, there is always a cost." Adora groaned, scrubbing a hand down her face in frustration. Finding the sword and becoming She-Ra had cost her Catra. She had been entrusted to save Etheria. But she proved to be less than worthy of that trust. She had failed to stop Catra from pulling the lever and Queen Angella paid the price. Because it was her sword that was powering the portal. Then she wasn't smart enough to figure out a way to stop Light Hope from setting off the weapon. Forced to destroy the hologram and shatter the Sword. Breaking the Sword had cost her She-Ra, when the Rebellion had needed her most. Now by binding She-Ra to the bracer's Swift Wind had

been lost. She always felt so inept, never being able to foresee the consequences of her decisions in regards to this magic.

"I have no problems taking on the risks of this magic…but why do the people I love have to constantly be the collateral damage?" She snarled, pounding a fist into the ground. Barely restraining her rage, the silver bracer fibrated at her emotional explosion. Her past choices were riddled with guilt, in regards to Catra, Glimmer and now Swift Wind.

Razz darted her eyes towards the bracer, in owlish surprise. As Adora's anger surged through the dark side of the magic, wild and out of control. She was so out of balance, so full of rage and pain…she had to move past it…she had to let go…

"Calm down, child. You must seek balance…you have to learn to let go." Razz sighed.

"You sound like Light Hope." Adora growled bitterly. "She wanted me to let go of my attachments..my friends…but my love and commitment to my friends has always made me stronger."

Razz nodded and chuckled. A fond nostalgic smile pulled upon her thin lips. It took Light Hope forever to change. She had always been so logical, unable to move past the strict tenets of the Eternian's programming. To see the individual for who they were and adapt the training regime to suit them. To be capable of nurturing the innate gifts of the current vessel. So that the weave could be as strong and singularly beautiful as the rune bearer itself. Those stiff, uncompromising ideal's had affected Mara's training. Made it incomplete and the poor woman had suffered because of it. Without the Portable Rune Stone to absorb and filter the magic, protect her…her mind and body was laid bare before the full might of Etheria's itself. She had died, because her tapestry was weak and could not withstand the onslaught of the Hearts magic. She did not understand how to channel the threads of magic through her own body and could not stop it from devouring her whole. Her body had been absorbed into the weave

of Etheria, before her ship crashed…never reaching Serenia in time to save herself.

The old woman shook her head and then cleared her throat. Needing to stay on track. She refused to dwell on timelines she could not change. Mara's death was necessary to begin the chain of destiny. So that Adora could take on the mantle of She-ra a thousand years later. So that she could release Catra from her tomb and the thirteen threads of magic that were once lost and bound. Could once again be woven together to protect the universe.

"Change is a part of living…it is not always welcomed. But it is necessary to move forward, towards greater things." The old woman offered Adora a warm, encouraging smile before turning her gaze upon Spirit. Silently communicating with the horse for a moment. Before turning back to the brooding young woman sitting before her.

"If you had not been able to change how the Horde conditioned you to think as a child, you would have never been able to embrace the magic. Leave the Horde and accept your destiny to become She-Ra. If Angella had not been inspired by your selfless bravery to always face your fears head on. She might not have cast off her cowardly ways and accepted her own destiny. If Hordak had not been able to find the strength of will to rebel against his creator, he might have lost what he cherished most. If Catra did not have a change of heart upon the Velvet Glove, then she would have never saved Glimmer. She would not have begun her journey back to you. Then she would not have been by your side when you needed her most and Etheria could have been lost forever." Razz began. Adora never questioned how the old woman knew all of that. A normal person would have no idea what had happened on the Velvet Glove during the months of Glimmer and Catra's captivity. Or what happened to Queen Angella in that unstable reality. Or what transpired between Hordak and Prime, when Entrapta had been kidnapped. But Razz was not a normal person, she was magic and Adora had long since realized that. Entrapta never talked about that battle...honestly she never

shared anything personal unless asked direct questions about it. Adora was in awe at how fiercely loyal Hordak was to those he deemed worthy.

"Years ago, a simple horse accepted his own change and willingly became your trusted steed. He was able to accomplish great things for his own species and those of this planet, alongside the Princess Alliance. Once again, this horse was unprepared for the next change. But he accepted it and heeded the call of your magic. Loyal and steadfast he returned to your side. Change can be difficult, painful even but never a bad thing. " Razz finished pointedly toward Spirit.

Who pretended not to hear her, stubbornly staring off towards the distant storm once more.

"We are going to start off simple. Weaving only three threads of magic…or willow rods…" Razz started with an impish laugh at her joke. Tapping the tip of her broom's wooden handle on the bundles.

Adora focused on the comforting task of following directions.

Using her boot knife to trim the pieces she wanted to use. Gently twisting a thicker rod into a hoop and then adding to it with a thinner rod to make it more sturdy. Once the frame was created, she was instructed to begin using thicker rods again. Placing them vertically as weaving guides and then hatching them with other thinner rods horizontally and vertically to form a pattern. Weaving them through each other, until a small round platter was created.

When she was done, she showed Razz her work. Her fingertips bleeding lightly, from many small scratches from the sharp ends of the willow branches.

"Good,that is a fine start." Razz nodded approvingly. As she flipped the simple woven platter back and forth between her hands.

Adora tempered her smile, even though her blue eyes were gleaming with triumph at the modest praise. Razz handed the platter back. Adora took it, as Catra's sleepy voice beaconed to her from the fire.

"Adora?" The magicat called again more strongly, when she did not receive a response. Adora could hear the anxious tremble in her tone. She was still upset and needed the comfort of having her nearby. Waking up to find her gone was unsettling.

"Go, now. We will meet again for another lesson." Razz chuckled, waving impatiently for her to go.

Adora nodded and rushed to her feet, jogging back to the fire. The balls of light that hovered around Razz, slowly faded as she left. As soon as Adora had gotten far enough away not to overhear. Razz turned to Spirit, as the somber gray atmosphere that existed before Adora's arrival returned. Emphasized by the seriousness of the old woman's frown.

"These metal spies are everywhere, watch for them and destroy them. They are circling Adora now like carrion birds. It seems the Sorceress of Grayskull's ploy to tamper with the weave of destiny is beginning to unravel. If Keldor does not know of Adora yet, it will only be a matter of time now." Razz stood up with a loud, plaintive groan. Her old bones hated the cool season, despised the cold season even more. But she could not affect what season she entered, the currents of time carried her where she was needed most. With a huff she turned, to confront the drone. Sweeping the slender birch and willow twigs woven into her broom's brush at the base of the Drone. As if trying to merely clean it up. It shimmered and faded away.

(Why were you keeping this a secret from her?) Spirit asked.

Razz sighed, "Adora does not need anymore distractions, right now. We must help her stay the course. She is scattered and unbalanced. Her thoughts and emotions are in turmoil. She needs guidance and time to focus on a single task…her training..if she

can not reclaim her balance all may be lost. She needs to weave a strong and resilient tapestry before summoning She-Ra again."

The old woman's eyes bored into Spirit as she spoke. Spirit merely nodded, tossing his mane. Understanding the seriousness of the mission Razz was setting him on.

"Take care of her, until we meet again. Honorable steed." She hopped upon her broom and with an explosion of silver dust she rocketed up into the sky and disappeared over the water. Heading without fear, straight into that threatening storm brewing on the horizon.

Catra was barely coherent, curled up under Adora's cloak, with Melog nestled against her stomach. Rubbing at her eyes with a loosely fisted hand, as if she was still a wee kitten. As she struggled to wake up. Her short hair was ruffled from sleep, sticking up wildly at every angle around the crown of her head.

Adora sighed, admiring her love with a fond, amused smile. Catra's sweet, innocent gestures were totally unintentional. But Adora had to admit that her girlfriend was absolutely the cutest sometimes.

"Hey, there Sleepy Head. I'm here." Adora offered, sitting down beside Catra. Stroking her hand down the back of the feline's head, lightly scratching behind her ears. Catra's purr instantly thrummed to life at Adora's gentle voice and soothing touch. The comforting sound slowly faded away as the magicat fell back asleep.

The morning was rather cool, being so close to the water. So Adora rekindled the campfire while she waited for the other's to wake up. Soon she had a nice flame, dancing within the circle of

stones. The wood Rogelio had gathered yesterday was old and well cured, so setting it alight was easy. The lizard kin was fast asleep, curled around Kyle. Who was snuggled between him and Lonnie. They were all resting partly propped up against a fat log set on other side of the fire. Adora was sitting on the ground near Catra, poking the coals with a stick lost in her thoughts. When Levi joined her upon the ground, sitting on the other side of the fire. Her dower face cast in orange flickering light as she stared pointedly at her. Silently seeking her full attention with her penetrating brown eyes.

Adora sighed and squirmed slightly, under the woman's intense stare.

"Look, just spit it out! I'm tired of being glared at like I'm something disgusting at the bottom of your boot." Adora grumbled.

"Did you ever think about the soldier's you were tossing around, while in your She-Ra form? Or were you more interested in just showing off for your new friends?" Levi spat, pulling up her knees and leaning her crossed arms over them. An unconscious action to shield herself. Her cold accusing glare became more heated, as her eyes shimmered with hurt and unshed tears.

"I…" Adora snapped her eyes up in alarm and sudden clarity at how callous she had been. Her startled expression crumpled into guilt and regret. Her apology stuck in her throat, like a lump of very hard bread that refused to be swallowed.

"I was in full combat armor, helmet and all that. You would have never known it was me. But we fought at a Horde munitions compound on the border between Bright Moon and Plumeria. She-Ra, some Archer and a Sparkly Princesses came charging in. You were unstoppable, like a force of nature. Charging through our ranks like we were nothing. You hit me so hard with the flat side of your sword. I was airborne and flying over the outer perimeter wall. If it wasn't for that Sparkly Princess, I'd be dead. She teleported me to the ground safely. Otherwise I would have

fallen several hundred feet out of the sky and into a dusty, dried out ravine. Doubt I would have survived that fall. ” Levi shrugged bitterly.

Adora was aghast for a few moments absorbing Levi’s near fatal story. Shallowing hard, as she choked on her guilt, absorbing all the blame for nearly killing one of her childhood friends. As she quickly began to review her past battles during the war. Seeking to rationalize her actions. She-Ra’s power had been so hard to control at the beginning and perhaps she had also been a bit overzealous. She felt she had to prove herself to Queen Angella, to the people of Etheria. That she was not Horde Scum, but a force for good. Someone they could depend on to save them. Knowing that she might have accidentally killed her own bunk mate while in battle. It was sobering to say the least.

The Horde had trained her. To see the enemy as merely targets. Faceless, soulless figures that just needed to be dealt with, subdued and taken out if necessary to achieve the mission. So she had fallen back into her training, knowing that she would never be able to do what she needed to do otherwise. Refusing to acknowledge the Horde soldier’s she fought against, as people while in battle. Levi’s had forced her for the first time to admit that she also had blood on her hands.

Adora suddenly felt very cold as her hands started to tremor. As the heavy weight of regret fell over her. Her blue eyes darkened into a turbulent, stormy gray.

“Honestly, I tried not to think about who I was fighting. I kept focused on the mission, concentrating on my goals. Win each battle, push the Horde back. Save Etheria…be the best She-Ra I could be.” Adora admitted in a flat, emotionless tone.

“Our well being never crossed your mind at all?” Levi laughed incredulously. As it wasn’t hard to believe. Adora had always been able to stuff down all her emotions. She never questioned her orders, her duty or her destiny. She became a machine, a powerful, perfect Soldier. Who could or would do anything,

everything that was needed to win. That's what set her above the rest of them and what also made her so very scary.

"No, not really. You guys were no longer my responsibility." Adora answered her question with a slight shrug. Poking the fire more aggressively with her stick. Sending sparks and ash into the air. Her stomach burned with the turbulent emotions she was holding down. She wanted to lash out, scream and punch something. She had been such a self righteous idiot!

Levi threw her head back and released a loud, harsh laugh. That sudden abrasive sound had Lonnie jerking awake with a cry of alarm. The calm and always collected Rogelio merely opened one eye briefly, ascertaining if he needed to wake up. Finding that it was just squad drama he promptly went back to sleep.

Catra merely snarled and unfurled from beneath Adora's cloak. Giving Levi a disgruntled look, before crawling to her feet and storming off with Melog in her arms. Dawn was approaching and she would need to sing her greeting anyway.

"For what it's worth. I am sorry for leaving you behind." Adora rubbed the back of her neck, bowing her head with the weight of her guilt. "I should have tried to…" Adora's further apology was rudely interrupted by Lonnie.

"Nope! " The dark skinned woman exclaimed, throwing a rock at Levi and striking her squarely in the shoulder just beneath her white and red training shirt. It was a chastising strike and Levi knew it. Her and Lonnie had gotten into an argument over Adora days ago, before the blonde showed up at their camp. She knew where Lonnie stood in regards to Adora being a traitor and guilt tripping their old Squad Leader would not be tolerated.

"Owww." Levi whined, casting Lonnie a disgruntled pout.

"Adora. You got nothing to apologize for!" Lonnie shook a chastising finger at Levi. "I admit. I was really angry with you just after you left us. Remember when we fought in the prison. When

you broke in with your new friends, to save that Archer..guy. I could have killed you and not thought twice about it then. I felt abandoned, betrayed. You hurt us, Adora…all of us.” Lonnie confronted her, her hazel eyes wet with sorrow and heartache. Adora swallowed and averted her eyes to the smoldering flame of the fire.

'It took me years, but I realized you were right to leave, the Horde was evil. I came to realize that I was in charge of my own life and didn’t owe the Horde or Catra anything! Levi could have left, just like you did. Just like I did with Kyle and Rogelio. The fact that she stayed, even though she hated being a soldier for the Horde. That’s on her!”

“Where was I supposed to go!” Levi shouted back, picking up a rock and throwing it at Lonnie. Her aim was off and it was headed right for Kyle’s chest. Lonnie swung her arm in front to protect him, the rock bounced off her forearm.

“We went to the Crimson Waste! Just like we had planned years ago when we were Senior cadets.” Lonnie spat back.

“None of you guys gave a shit about us! ” Levi shouted back, her voice rising as her anger reached its boiling point.

“We were all split up then! Catra got promoted to Commander and we all got broken up into different battalions. How the hell was I supposed to track you guys down on the spur of the moment. During the final push, we got fed up with taking Catra’s orders. Honestly, by that point she had lost her goddamn mind! “ Lonnie shot Adora a sharp look. There was blame, burning in her eyes that she valiantly tried to hide as she quickly looked away.

Adora swallowed, it was hard to hear how much pain Catra had been in then, because of her. She tried not to loathe herself for abandoning her. Knowing from many long talks with the magicat. That it wasn’t her fault, that there were so many other contributing factors that had slowly broken their relationship. That

had also completely shattered Catra's heart, turning her cold and spiteful over those years.

"We stole a cargo hauler and took off in the middle of the night! We had no time to hunt down you or Max…were you even in the Fortress at the time? " Lonnie exploded, jumping to her feet.

"Max and I found out real quick that we could only count on each other! You all are just a bunch of selfish assholes!" Levi jumped to her own feet.

"Hey…Hey…!" Adora scrambled to her feet, trying to get in between the two women. Who were now circling one another just beyond the fire, ready to throw down.

"Adarion…Adarion…" Catra's voice rose up, just as the first rays of the sun burned upon the watery horizon.

"Do you hear me!" She crooned, as the sky began to burn. The glaring glow of dawn, reflecting off the water, setting the strait on fire.

"Do you see me!" She shouted, out to the warming sky. Standing on the crest of the outlook, with the cool breeze dancing threw her short dark mane. Holding Melog close as she offered herself to Adarion. She left nothing hidden, opening her heart and soul to her magic without worry or reservation. Trusting in it fully for the first time, that it would heed her call. Melog needed her magic and she wanted it to be pure and untainted. So she offered all of herself to Adarion, so that it may strengthen her and her dearest friend.

"Adarion…Adarion." She pleaded, "Give me the power I need to make them whole again." She held Melog, pressing the glowing orange blob against her breast as tenderly as a mother would a newborn kitten.

Road to Recovery

Adora was stuck in the middle, holding both Levi and Lonnie back with her hands pressed flat to their collar bones.

“How can you just forgive her!” Levi shouted, bouncing on her feet and swinging her left arm in a hooking punch. Attempting to hit Lonnie in the temple with everything she had.

“Because she’s family!” Lonnie shouted back, leaning away. As Adora was forced to duck. Levi’s wildly swinging fist nearly boxing her in the ear. Adora crouched low and spun on the balls of her feet to avoid getting tangled in the melee. Quickly regaining her balance, she stood back up and lunged back into the fray. Grappling with Lonnie and pulling her off Levi. As the stouter, dark skinned woman had gotten the brunette on the ground, on her stomach. She was attempting to lock Levi into a submission hold, called the triangle choke. By wrapping her arms around Levi's head and neck, while leaning her full weight upon Levi's back. Adora was now desperately seeking to disentangle them from engaging in full on combat.

She managed to pull Lonnie off enough for Levi to squirm out of her loosened arm lock and then regain her feet.

“She stopped being family three years ago, when she sided with the Princess’s and started treating us like the enemy!” Levi exploded, panting and heaving for breath. As she began to weave around Adora who was already blocking her from getting to Lonnie. Who was glaring and snarling behind her, the battle rage roaring inside of her. They were trained to kill, trained to win… Lonnie was not going to just give up and calm down. She was a soldier and she would finish what she started.

“We were on the wrong side! Adora was right to leave! I wish I would have realized quicker…been less of a coward and left earlier.” Lonnie shouted back, pushing Adora’s blocking arm away. As she sought to snag Levi into a headlock.

“She’s a traitor…she betrayed our trust…fought against us…hurt us…she was supposed to protect us…be our Force Captain…We were going to fight the Princesses together…we were supposed to stay together!” Levi was snarling and shouting. Confessing all the pain and heartache she had kept bottled up for years. With her face flushed with anger and tears rolling unchecked down her cheeks. Leaving trails of moisture down her face as they washed away the dirt. Somehow she had stopped trying to fight Lonnie and was now grappling with Adora. With her hands gripped tight on Adora’s shoulder’s. She hooked the blonde's leg and pushed her down on the ground. Adora fell backward, grunting in pain as her back struck the hard ground. With Levi now straddling her waist, hands locked together as they both struggled for domination. In seconds they had released each other’s hands. Reduced to rolling around on the ground, as they wrestled, each trying to pin the other.

“I’m sorry for leaving!” Adora bawled loudly, tears streaming down her flushed cheeks. Levi finally had her semi-pinned down, as Adora was trapped in an awkward sitting position. Her bulky, strong arms were locked around Adora’s middle, head ducked into the taller woman’s hard abs. As Adora curled upward, pushing against Levi’s shoulder as she sought to push her off. Struggling to her knees and then standing up. Grunting and sobbing as she struggled to dislodge Levi from her waist. As the shorter girl’s arms refused to be dislodged, latched around her waist like a vice. Adora had a sudden flash of fear, at Levi’s lower center of gravity against her abdomen. She was in a bad position, the woman could easily pick her up and slam her head first into the ground. She needed to reverse her hold…or perhaps take this fight back to the ground?

“I’m sorry for not coming back and taking you all with me!” Adora pleaded, blinking rapidly, trying to see through the tears. As her hands gripped Levi's shirt at the shoulders. Twisting the fabric around her fists, as she hooked her leg around Levi’s ankles and used her weight to push the girl off balance. The shorter, stockier brunette cried out in alarm. As Adora finally pinned her flat on her back.

“It's your fault…Everything that happened to me was your fault! I hate you!” Levi screamed, writhing and bucking under Adora. As the taller, stronger blonde now straddled the shorter woman, struggling to grapple her wrists. As Levi evaded her clutching hands, twisting and yanking her arms away over her head. Adora’s desperate, tortured expression had hardened into an impassive mask. Except for the painful furrow of her brow and distress in her eyes.

“You lied to me…I thought you cared about me…I can never forgive you!” Levi raised a hand, striking Adora hard across the cheek with an open palm. Adora’s head snapped to the side, as she made no effort to defend against the hit. The strike echoed like a thunder clap across the gray, quiet morning.

Lonnie had moved away and was watching their exchange with her arms folded across her chest. Fury was burning in her hazel eyes as a grim, contemplative frown shadowed her features. She had disengaged to allow them to sort things out, but now she was left fuming and distraught about retreating and allowing Levi to just go off on Adora without further consequence.

“Levi!” Max shouted, racing up to them.

As Lonnie finally interceded. She grabbed Levi’s wrists and pulled them down to the ground above her head. Hovering over the short, dark haired woman's face, panting and out of breath. Her braids had been pulled free from her ponytail and now hung over her face.

“Stop fighting!” Lonnie declared, angry, painful tears running down her cheeks.

“Traitor!” Levi sobbed, brokenly. Squeezing her eyes shut, refusing to see the devastating shame in Adora’s shimmering blue eyes. As fresh tears overflowed and streamed down her own cheeks.

“I leave you guys for ten minutes and all hell breaks loose.” Catra’s snarky tone shattered their confrontation. When her greeting song ended, the tell tale cries and grunts of hand to hand combat could be heard. She had run back to camp from the outcropping immediately. With Melog glowing bright red in her arms. Finding Adora stradling Levi’s torso, her blue eyes smoldering with hurt and fury down at her.

Adora sniffed and stood up, drying her tears as she nodded. If this was how Levi felt, she would accept it. She deserved to be hated for what she did. If there was no way to repent for her mistakes, or repair the fractures to their relationship. She wasn’t going to keep trying.

Spirit trotted up beside her, nudging her shoulder blades with his broad nose. Silently asking if she was physically hurt. He wasn’t oblivious to the emotional pain now raging through her. He had known her for years, knew how she coped. She was closing herself off, hiding her feelings behind a stone facade. Their link was so strong now, he could feel every powerful emotion that was lashing against her forced calm.

Disappointment…frustration…loathing…shame…regret…

Adora avidly ignored him, balling her hands into fists at her sides. As she took long strides to get away from everyone.

“I wanted you guys to talk…get everything out in the open. I hoped she would be able to get past it, forgive you. “ Max pleaded, as Adora swept him aside with one arm as he sought to get in her way. She moved past him without an acknowledging glance. He was not wearing his poncho, looking disheveled and distraught. In just his long sleeve white shirt and black pants, not even wearing socks or boots.

“It doesn’t matter. What’s done is done…there is no going back. She hates me, if I can’t fix that. Then I’ve got to accept it.” Adora offered as she stopped a few feet past him. Then she paid him a

weak, bitter smile over her shoulder. Before bowing her head and continuing on.

Catra darted to Adora's side, not even paying Levi a parting glance. A silent reminder to everyone where her loyalties lay. Levi could keep her stubborn grudge as long as she wanted. But Catra was over dwelling on all that hatred and resentment. The war was over...it was time to move on..try and find a little piece of happiness to call your own. To be thankful that you lived…you survived those terrible years. To finally be free and live your own life on your own terms.

It took less than an hour for the departing members of the squad to pull down their tents and prepare to leave. A light drizzle had already started to mist in the air, the low rumble of thunder threatening several miles off. The sky had darkened into a murky, slate gray. The perfect accent to the violent tension that still hovered in the air. Otis and Atila had bid them all a curt farewell, heading out on foot along the trail that would lead them down to the shoreline. Adora remained on the edge of the cliff watching them go, arms folded and glowering at the storm slowly rolling in. Spirit remained nearby, nibbling absently on the grass. Keeping a close eye on Adora.

As soon as the two hybrids had walked out of sight down the hill. Lonnie had retreated into her tent. She was fuming and needed some space to calm down. Kyle had been tucked away inside the tent at the first signs of the rain and soon Rogelio sought refuge inside as well. As the coming storm began to roll in.

Leaving Max and Levi to finish packing up their gear. Levi had no intention of saying goodbye to any of them. As far as she was concerned they were all dead to her. She shouldered her pack and headed off down the trail they had used to ascend up to this bluff. Heading north, back the way they had come.

The constant tension in the air had put Catra's fight or flight instincts on high alert all morning. Her stomach was flipping and crawling with noxious, uncomfortable feelings ever since the fight. Needing to find relief from being hyper vigilant to threats and desperate to find a sense of relative safety. She had retreated out of camp. Climbing up the largest boulder that she could find. That was huddled against the base of a towering cliff. She was still in earshot and had clear visuals on Adora and the last remaining tent. Wanting to be close by in case her partner needed her. But when Adora got this upset it was useless to engage with her. She always sought solitude, when her emotions were beyond her ability to conceal. Unwilling to shatter that impenetrable facade of the perfect, unflinching persona. She had cultivated around her old squad mates. She was not comfortable being too vulnerable around them. It wasn't natural for her to show weakness. If Catra was to attempt to comfort her, now. Adora would merely rebuff any physical touch or verbally deflect any enquiry about her well being. It was better to wait it out and let her simmer down. When she was ready, she would find Catra and as always they would find solace in each other. This was how they did things back in the Horde. Creating new coping patterns was hard and she wasn't going to force it. She had spent enough time talking with Perfuma to know healing was a slow, steady grind and it needed to happen naturally.

"Catra…" Max's voice floated up to her, nervous and wary.

Catra sighed with irritation and looked down from her perch on top of the boulder. To find Max now wearing what was left of his tan poncho. That no longer had its hood, the neck was cut low and had become ill fitting. Hanging loosely off one shoulder.

He tossed her up a balled up wad of woolen cloth. She caught it and unfurled a covered pouch with cloth straps she could tie around herself. She offered him a confused frown.

"It's for Melog, a safe place for them to hang out. So you don't have to carry them all the time." Max pointed to the bag. "I'm an apprentice to a tailor, in Theria, a village just north of Bright

Moon. Levi and I have a place there. If you and Adora are ever in the area, look us up. " With that he jogged away to catch up to Levi, tossing Catra a wave over his shoulder as he went.

"Thanks!" Catra called out, a gracious smile pulling on her lips. This would be very useful. She had felt somewhat disarmed at having to hold Melog not be able to use her claws. Now she would have her primary weapon's back and be able to protect them and Adora. She quickly set Melog down in her lap and adjusted the length as she tied up the straps over her left shoulder. So the pouch hung off her right hip, then she gently tucked Melog inside and folded the cover over top. Concealing the molten blob, warm and safe inside.

"You ready?" Adora's clipped voice pulled her from obsessively adjusting the pouch. Catra once again glanced down from her perch, now finding Adora sitting bare back. Astride the white horse at the base of the boulder. Their packs were strapped across the steed's shoulders by a rope, hanging loosely over the horse's powerful biceps.

"Are we leaving?" Catra answered, dropping off the boulder to land lightly on the horse's back. The Horse nickered and pranced away from the boulder, casting Catra a dirty look. Not appreciating the pricking sensation of her toe claws on his hide.

"Sorry, horsey." Catra apologized, getting a loud, agitated huff in response.

"He calls himself Spirit now." Adora answered as the horse plodded forward down the same rough, uneven footpath as Levi and Max. Heading the way they had come, back towards the valley.

"Where are we headed now?" Catra inquired lightly, hours later. Adora hadn't said a word the entire time and Catra hadn't really tried to start up a conversation either. She was still feeling the

disgusting after effects of the tension back at camp. Her instincts were still on high alert and she was getting frustrated at not being able to calm down. Adora was still brooding, the emotional wounds from this morning. Still fresh and hadn't scabbed over enough to talk about it yet. So Catra had merely offered the comfort of her presence, allowing the silence to reign. But now the feline was growing restless. Her superior balance allowed her to lounge on the back of the steed. With her back pressed up against Adora's and her legs stretched out and crossed over Spirit's hind quarters. She swayed her lithe body in unison to the horse's lazy gait to maintain her balance.

As she kept vigilant upon the open fields that stretched out towards the horizon. The river cut through the tall grass a few yards away, the clean, sparkling water shimmering under the clear sky. The mid- day sun beat down on them yet again, making her feel rather hot and clammy. They were close to the border of the Crimson Waste. She swore if she squinted her eyes she could just make out the outline of the arid desert. It was wishful thinking, she knew that. But the yearning to see what had become of Serenia had been growing for weeks. With a disgruntled sigh, she pulled her gaze away. Returning to eyeing the cold water of the river, even though she hated being wet. Being sticky and overheated was far worse. Cooling down for a bit in the stream was becoming more alluring.

"We are headed back to Mystacor." Adora answered, her steel blue eyes scanning the way ahead. "You have to start your magic training with Casta."

"What about you?" Catra sighed knowing she was leaving things unsaid. As Melog squirmed in their pouch. Drawing her attention away from her surroundings. As she flipped open the bag, to find them glowing a soft, cornflower yellow. Reflecting her anxiety, like a living mood ring. They were resting, tethered to her latent fire magic and absorbing as much they could. Catra had come to understand that she didn't need to worry, if they were not in physical contact all the time. As long as they were glowing, they were still absorbing her magic.

“I’m going to drop you off and then head to the Crystal Castle.” Adora answered again, her voice was modulated. Knowing that this decision to separate would not go over well and wary about voicing it.

Catra was quiet for a long time, before finally speaking again.

“For how long?” Catra responded, her voice sharp and clipped as she sought to control her rising anger. Her stomach was burning and her chest ached. Adora’s statement was enough to overflow the tense emotional cocktail that had been brewing all morning inside of her. She focused on her hands in her lap, watching as her claws flexed and retracted as she sought to control herself.

“I don’t know, for however long it takes for me to learn about the She-Ra’s of the past. I have to do this, Catra. We are running out of time. We need She-Ra at her full strength. ” Adora sighed heavily. Keeping to herself how her research would be focused mostly on Mara and what had really happened on Etheria a thousand years ago. Why was Mara trying to reach Serenia? Why did the First Ones activate the Heart, when they knew that it wasn’t balanced and would end up destroying the planet?

“I guess it’s too much to expect Queen Sparkles to blink you back and forth everyday.” Catra chuckled bitterly, as her throat went dry and her chest clenched in dread. She had been preparing for this day for the last month, when they would have to part ways again. Yet it still hit so hard and hurt just as much as before.

“Not everyday…she’s got magic training and ruler stuff too, I do not want to be a burden. But whenever she gets back to Mystacor from Scorpania, I’m sure she can bring me back once and while.” Adora advised in an upbeat tone.

“Sure.” Catra agreed half heartedly, her voice was barely a whisper. Then she abruptly leaped off of Spirits back. She needed some space, she felt disgusting!

She needed to cleanse away the unwanted feelings of abandonment and betrayal. That always reared their ugly head when Adora needed to leave her side.

“Catra!” Adora cried in alarm, giving Spirit’s wither’s a quick yank to let him know to stop.

Spirit whinnied sharply, shaking his head vigorously to soothe the sting. Vowing that he needed to train Adora how to ride bareback properly. She was instinctively rather aggressive with her non-verbal commands and he did not like having his mane so rudely pulled.

“Catra…don’t be mad!” Adora pleaded, she was struggling to remain calm. As she dashed after Catra. Who was storming off towards the stream.

“Not mad!” Catra shouted back, as she pulled off her bag and set it down gently on a flat rock. That was nestled into the tall grass along the bank of the river. Avidly, ignoring the swirling aura of dark tangerine, now emanating from inside the pouch. As Melog shifted from reds to yellows as he navigated through her turbulent emotions.

Proceeding to slip out of her leather jacket and set it down next to her bag. Draping it over the pouch slightly so that Melog’s glow was hidden. She didn’t need him broadcasting to Adora how she truly felt. Not that the blonde needed any hints. She knew Catra very well and could read her without Melog’s help.

“Yes you are!” Adora huffed, rolling her eyes in frustration. As she finally caught up to her. She stood before the now half clothed feline with her arms crossed and an irritated arch to her eyebrows. Silently bidding for Catra to come clean.

“I’m hot and uncomfortable and I want to go for a swim.” Catra shrugged, tossing her white t-shirt onto the rock and then pulling off her black leggings.

“Yep, not mad?” Adora snapped back sarcastically, unhooking her cloak by the wing pin and adding it to the pile of clothes on the flat stone.

“Nope…not at all!” Catra spat back, ripping off her black, fingerless gloves rather violently. Before pulling off her breast wrap.

“Ok…we are getting totally naked now.” Adora nodded, biting her lower lip as she tried not to let on how much she was enjoying it. Watching her gorgeous magicat girlfriend disrobing in front of her. Even if it wasn’t in a sexy way, but in an angry, violent huff kind of way.

In seconds, Catra’s supple, slender body was on full display. Her tawny tan fur had a golden hue under the midday sun. The rusty red stripes on her arms and on her back looked like tongues of fire. She promptly turned on her heel, her dark tail snapping behind her. As she sprinted down the grassy bank. Her toned, well muscled legs flexing and stretching. Leaping into the air effortlessly, as she dove off the spongy clay lip of the bank. With her arms outstretched over her head, she cut into the water and slipped below. Gracefully disappearing beneath the surface.

Adora was instantly awe struck, as Catra broke the surface of the water further out on the river. She had swam beneath the water until she reached the middle of the sparkling clear stream. The elegant curves of her upper body breaking the tranquility of the water. The water glistened on the tan, velvet soft fur on her arms and softly curving torso. Thousands of tiny droplets of water beading and rolling over her firm, pert breasts. That bounced gently, as they crested the surface of the water. Rosy nipples, stiff from the cold temperature, stood at attention. As her cute cat ears flicked off the moisture, then she shook her short dark mane. Casting even more droplets into the air. That showered down behind her creating a twinkling rainbow that quickly faded into the sweltering heat of the day.

With a languid sigh of satisfaction. Catra settled down into the water. Wading out even further along the river, before turning to confront Adora with a teasing grin.

“What are you waiting for, dummy? Come and get me!” She taunted, slapping the water and sending a spray in Adora’s direction.

This sudden shift in emotion wasn’t uncommon for Catra. The feline had always been a little contrary, swinging from one intense emotion to another. She would bury her anger and sadness behind a mask of indifference, or like now. Act as if everything was alright and she just wanted to have some fun. This emotional rollercoaster was a ride Adora knew well. She had gotten whiplash from it more than once. So she learned to just roll with it, this was just how Catra coped.

Catra’s mischievous smile and teasing banter was all the incentive Adora needed. To finish stripping down to nothing. She tiptoed hesitantly into the cold water. Yelping and gasping as she slowly got used to the frigid tempature. Once she was submerged up to her neck, she made a quick scan of the river. Tracking down where her cunning girlfriend might have swam to. Finding her nearby, submerged to her nose with just her eye’s above the water. Watching her with a playful, yet calculating gleam in her eyes. Catra slowly stood up when Adora caught sight of her. Her stalking attempts to pounce on Adora and dunk her under the water, disappointingly thwarted. Catra licked her bottom lip to clean away some of the water. As she shivered, wrapping her arms around herself to keep warm.

“Rethinking the punishment?” Adora jested with a smug smirk.

“What?” Catra gasped, her eyes narrowing in confusion and then slowly widening as she became appalled at Adora’s assessment of the situation.

“Yesterday was scary, with what happened to Kyle and then Melog. We nearly lost two people we cared about. This morning

was intense, thanks to me getting into a fight with Levi. You retreated out of camp and up high on that rock. So I know you were 'upset'." Adora paused, searching for Catra to admit the truth. With all the stress and anxiety they had been dealing with lately. That she was scared and worried about the future. So much so, all her old toxic coping methods were resurfacing. Catra remained stubbornly silent, avoiding eye contact. Focusing upon the ripples in the water between them, struggling to mask her emotions.

"You have been silent all day, so you've been brooding about all of it. So have I…" Adora sighed, figuring she would be the one to admit weakness this time. "I'm scared…Catra. I'm scared we are running out of time. Omega Prime is out there! Somewhere and I need to find it, contain it…or heal it….or kill it! " She was nearly shouting, heaving for breath as she purged all her fears.

Catra waded closer, preparing to wrap her up into a tight hug before she completely unraveled.

"I need to regain the upper hand here. Catra. Things are spiraling out of control. The only way I know how to do that. Is to go to the Crystal Castle and uncover all the secrets Light Hope refused to tell me. I need to know what really happened on Etheria a thousand years ago. What pushed the First Ones to fire the heart, when they knew it would rip the planet apart? Why did Mara rebel against her own people? I need to know why the Eternian want that Crystal. I have to find where Critia is hiding. She's the leader of the Mutants and she wants Omega Prime. That monster can never leave Etheria, Catra….it could destroy the universe. The First Ones turned Etheria into a weapon…and I need to know how to disarm it…permanently! " Adora ground out, seething over how helpless and terrified she felt by all this pressure.

"Why, Mara, was headed to Serenia?" Catra whispered, her tone was more accusatory and bitter as she finally confronted Adora about her secret. Adora bravely met the hurt in her eyes. Shame flooding her eyes, the blue pools filling with unshed tears. It was

too much for Catra to bear, so she quickly averted her gaze back to the water.

Adora gasped, her shoulder's slumping, weighed down by guilt.

"I…" she stuttered, unable to formulate a good excuse as to why she hadn't told Catra the truth.

"Did you intend for me to overhear you talking to Glimmer about her on the Command deck?" Catra finally looked up, disappointed tears shimmering in her eyes.

"Yes…no…Maybe….I don't know…I'm sorry…back on the skiff… when we were talking. It didn't seem like the right time. Then everything else happened and I never got around to talking to you about it. So I guess…yes…I knew you might overhear and I could get it off my chest without actually telling you face to face." Adora rambled out, her focus drawing inward as she sought to understand her own intentions. She had been so nervous and scared about telling her back on the skiff. Worried Catra's drive to uncover the truth of her past at the time. Would be more important than staying by her side, that she would leave her in the middle of the night like before. How she went about finally admitting the truth to her had been rather cowardly.

Catra merely nodded, holding herself tighter.

"So then, my home was somewhere in the Crimson Waste."

"Yes…I promise we'll go…as soon as I get back from the Crystal Castle. " Adora pleaded, wading closer to her. Silently seeking forgiveness for stalling and unintentionally hurting her.

Catra heaved a long, suffering sigh and smirked up at her.

"I guess, I've been waiting over a thousand years to see my home again. I guess I'll wait a little longer." She teased.

"Well, clearly. Me and the universe have pissed you off, real good. Landing us in this river freezing our collective asses off." Adora

smirked, looking around absently as she waded the last few meters to stand in front of her in the shoulder high water.

"I was hot…" Catra bemoaned warily, as she reviewed her own true intentions behind jumping into the water. She had been feeling yucky and off balance all day, ever since the fight. She had just wanted to clean herself, clear her head and hopefully wash away the filth….and perhaps cleanse those bad feelings as well.

"You hate getting wet…hate being cold…so why?" Adora put her hands on Catra's shoulders, maintaining eye contact. Beseeching her silently to realize what she was doing. Unconsciously or not, Catra was still trapped in that cycle of pain and punishment. That Shadow Weaver had instilled in both of them growing up. When things went wrong, it was their fault. Correction needed to be given to insure that those mistakes did not repeat. She had felt wrong and wanted to replace those feelings with physical pain to distract herself.

Catra locked eyes with Adora for a moment, her mismatched eyes wet with sudden clarity. She had been feeling guilty that she was not there to protect Melog, that she wasn't around to have Adora's back when Levi attacked her. Then Adora told her she was leaving and all those anxieties of being abandoned, because she wasn't good enough. Came roaring back. She had wanted to punish herself for being weak and useless. Had been obsessing over jumping in the river for hours, seeking that physical pain like a moth to the flame.

Catra threw her head back and laughed. It was a loud, boisterous sound of self recrimination and raw acceptance of the truth. As she was forced to admit that Adora was right. This was a toxic habit of hers…carrying on with her punishments when she felt like a failure. A habit that she would now endeavor to break.

Adora was startled at first and then she took advantage of it. Leaning in, she began to lovingly mouth Catra's neck. Pressing her lips just below Catra's sensitive ear, her breath warming the

feline's neck, alluringly. Wanting to alleviate any guilt or remorse Catra might be having about dragging her into the river.

"Well I for one, intend on making the best of this situation." Adora whispered seductively, licking sideways to just below Catra's chin. Tasting the cool, fresh water mixed with the salty tang of Catra's sweat. Making the short fur on the back of Catra's neck stand up in arousal.

Catra moaned with pleasure, locking her arms around Adora's neck to help hold herself up as her legs suddenly weakened.

"I love you…I will always love you…" Adora whispered against the shell of her other ear. When Catra finally pulled back, she found Adora staring up at her with a lustful gleam in her eyes.

"Don't leave me…" Catra pleaded, her voice weak and fragile. Her eyes were haunted, filled with a loneliness and pain that Adora could not fathom. So she reassured Catra in the only way she knew. Wrapping her arms around the bottom of Catra's butt and standing up to her full height. Lifting Catra out of the water. Adora's powerful legs held her weight easily, her feet were steadfast upon the uneven ground beneath the water. As she began walking forward, carrying Catra out of the river. The ripcord muscles of her strong arms flexed under Catra's modest weight.

"I am never going to leave you…Catra." Adora promised, her eyes warm and ardent as she stared up at her. Finally reaching the bank of the river, Adora's balance never faltered as she ascended the modest incline.

Catra nodded, folding herself against Adora's shoulder's. Seeking the shelter beneath her chin where her scent was the strongest. Needing to feel the comfort of her warm skin and hear the steady beat of her heart echoing in tune with hers. Adora set her down on the grass, her arms circling her waist and holding her close.

"We may be apart for a little while, but I am coming back….no matter what I will always return to you." Adora pressed her

forehead against Catra's, cupping her cheeks tenderly in her hands.

Catra whimpered, "I know…I just don't like to be without you." Her mind was spinning catastrophe as it always did, that Adora might not come back. That something bad might happen. Her bitter, negative mantra echoed inside her head. 'Nothing good ever lasted.'

Catra pulled away, her gaze was searching. Needing some reassurance that Adora would keep her word. Laughing jadedly to herself. They both had such bad trust issues!

"I will be back." Adora slid a hand behind her neck and guided her face upward. Into a forceful, passionate kiss that took her breath away.

Catra responded eagerly, her fangs sharp and her tongue demanding as she ravaged Adora's mouth. Adora moaned and gasped in rising arousal as the kiss intensified. As they both collapsed upon the soft grass of the river bank, arms and legs intertwined.

Then Adora rolled on top of Catra, pinning her beneath her own body. Pressing her tenderly into the thick, soft grass. Catra hooked one leg around Adora's hips, holding her firmly against her groin. As they began to rock against each other, seeking that blissful explosion deep inside. Eager to engage in their new love play, that is so much more fulfilling than sparing.

Catra nipped at her lover's plump lower lip, then slid her tongue deeper. Tasting every inch of Adora's mouth. Adora whimpered with need, grinding herself harder against Catra. Her insides began to quiver with anticipation for that euphoria that awaited her. Her breasts tingled as Catra's stiff nipples brushed alluringly against her own, in a steady if frantic rhythm. They shifted and rocked against one another. Soft blissful sounds escaped them both in a symphony of pleasure. Adora's groin throbbed and ached, tightening unbearably. Then suddenly pleasure jolted

through her. Her eyes snapped open in surprise, when Catra's hand slid downward from the arch of her back to the bare curve of her behind. Gripping her ass, her fingers tightened against her skin. Squeezing her butt hard for a moment and then releasing. Kneading the soft flesh as she purred with satisfaction.

Adora shivered, as she felt the sharp pricking of Catra's claw tips against the highly sensitive skin between her legs. Then finally they broke apart, panting and sucking in mouthfuls of air. Adora's chest was burning from the prolonged kiss.

Relaxed and barely lucid after having such a sudden and powerful release. Adora was basking in the afterglow, as she rolled off Catra.

Catra lay on her side, a contented purr thrumming in the air between them. As Adora's hands stroked up and down Catra's bareback. Gazing lovingly into her eyes. The mismatched hues now warm and vibrant, simmering with pleasure.

"Wow…" Adora breathed, eyes wide and full of blissful excitement. Eager to engage in a verbal assessment of her love play with Catra. Hopeful for tips on how to do better, or perhaps praise at how amazing it had been?

Catra giggled, reaching up and cupping her cheek tenderly.

"Hush, Don't ruin it…" She responded in a charming, breathless whisper.

"Ok…" Adora smirked, caressing her hand down Catra's arms and giving her hands a quick squeeze. Before rushing off to the rock to retrieve her cloak.

Catra's eyes flared wide in both surprise and mortification. As she saw four small claw marks. Scratched a light pink across the bottom of Adora's right butt cheek. Thankfully she hadn't broken the skin, if she had made Adora bleed during their love making she would feel even worse.

Adora quickly spread her cloak out on the mossy bank of the river nearby and then stretched out upon it. Beckoning Catra to join her. She knew laying out in the sun would be the best, most relaxed way for her feline girl to warm up and dry off.

Catra was quick to join her, a pleased smile glowing upon her face. Once she was settled on her side, curling ever so slightly into Adora's taller frame.

"I'll miss you, don't be gone too long." She sighed, her index finger lightly tracing the failsafe scar on Adora's chest.

"I promise" Adora breathed, lightly caressing the blunt tip of her index finger up and down Catra's arm. Tracing her stripes one by one, in a soothing rhythm. It didn't take long for the heat to lull them both into a tranquil half awake state. Soon they were both dosing lightly, snuggling contentedly in each other's arms.

The tell-tale chime of the air splitting and the dusting of sparkles falling around them. Announced the sudden appearance of Glimmer. Both women craned their heads up to find the Queen standing a few yards away. Her face was already burning at finding them naked and snuggling upon the banks of the river.

"Sorry…guess I interrupted something." She laughed nervously, quickly averting her eyes to the ground.

"You always do." Catra answered back a teasing lilt to her raspy voice. As she rolled away from Adora and rose to her feet. Heading back to the rock to gather up her clothes.

"What's up Glimmer?" Adora asked, following Catra to their clothes to get dressed.

"I need Catra to talk some sense into Scorpia before I strangle her!" Glimmer snarled, mimicking throttling the taller princess with her hands.

“Trouble in Paradise?” Catra smirked, having finished dressing and pulling on her jacket.

“Sweet Bee is still in a cell! Scorpia is being stubborn and totally unreasonable!” Glimmer huffed. Bracing her hands on her hips and tapping her foot impatiently.

“Ok, ok. ok.” Catra placaded, coming to terms with the impending teleport she would have to endure.

“I’m going to continue on. To the Crystal Castle then.” Adora advised softly, heading toward Spirit who was grazing nearby. Catra dashed after her, reaching her side. As she was untying Catra’s pack from the rope hanging over Spirits neck. Adora handed Catra her pack with a small, tender smile. Catra shouldered her pack, avoiding Adora’s gaze. Desperately trying not to break down and cry.

“I’m going to miss you.” Adora whispered softly, brushing her finger’s lightly down Catra’s cheek. Catra merely nodded, taking a step back turning to leave. Then spun back around and grasped Adora’s hands. “Call me on the communicator tonight.” She demanded, her eyes firm.

“I will.” Adora promised, leaning down and kissing her tenderly before heading back to Spirit. Who had moved off a little ways to graze on more succulent grass closer to the river.

“New horse?” Glimmer asked.

“Old horse, new look.” Catra sighed, picking up her bag from the flat rock and slinging it back around her shoulder.

“Where’s Melog?” Glimmer asked, still trying to work out Catra’s cryptic answer to her first question.

Catra merely flipped the cloth flap, revealing the somber blue blob nestled inside.

“Alright, what the hell happened!” Glimmer shouted in alarm.

“More Eternia Troubles, Sparkles. Let's get this over with.” Catra grasped her hand squeezing her eyes shut tight. As the ground faded, replaced by that sudden void of nothingness and then solid ground again.

To thine own self be true...

Horror Hall's gloomy crypt-like atmosphere was as silent and oppressive as always. Catra found herself unconsciously moving as quietly as possible, using only her toes to creep forward. Ear's up and alert, listening for any strange sounds as if it was even a possibility to be attacked here.

She quickly tried to settle her frayed nerves, by taking slow, calming breaths. She was being irrational. Yes, there had been a report of an intruder days ago. But since then the patrols had been increased and security bots activated. There was no way anything was going to freely roam through the base or these caves without being detected. She had nothing to worry about.

She was just starting to ease her heart rate down to a reasonable level, when she suddenly felt a light tap on her shoulder. The ear piercing scream of pure, unadulterated terror that ripped from her throat. Was unexpected and highly embarrassing. As it echoed down the dark, vacant corridor. Catra leaped into the air, hackles raised, tail bristled and sticking straight up!

"Sorry….sorry…I didn't mean to frighten you!" Perfuma apologized sweetly.

Catra turned and regarded the Flower Princess with a less than thrilled glower. Humiliation hot upon her cheeks and fear still shimmering in her eyes. Her badass persona was now officially obliterated by Perfuma's soft spoken and annoyingly stealthy appearance.

"What the hell! Flower Girl!" Catra railed, "I swear. I just lost at least seven of my nine lives." the feline grumbled, clutching her chest in a valiant attempt to calm down her pounding heart.

Perfuma sighed and pinched her nose with her finger's, seeking calm. She hated that obvious nickname, ever since Huntara gave it to her in the Crimson Waste. The fact that Catra would shout it

out in a bout of panic, only frustrated her more. But that conversation was for another time.

"I sent Glimmer to fetch you, since I can not seem to get through to her." Perfuma decided to just let it go, getting right to the point. "Scorpia wants to talk to you. She's this way…come." She turned on her heel and disappeared back into the total darkness of the tunnel she had been hovering in the mouth off. When Catra had passed. Her slippered feet whispered on the ground as she walked. Irritating Catra even more that she had so easily been surprised by the Plumerian Princess.

Catra sighed and gave the glowing red lump in her pouch a comforting pat, seeking to calm Melog down. Then obediently followed Perfuma into the bowels of Horror Hall.

"Seriously, Scorpia needs to redecorate a little here." Catra groused. "A few more torches could go a long way to making this place more tolerable. "

"Scorpia see's this place as a family tomb, she isn't going to touch it." Perfuma responded.

"What happened to her people?" Catra asked. "Besides her mother's, Grandfather and Grandmother. There is no record of what happened to them after Hordak's fleet crashed into her kingdom decades ago."

"She didn't know either, no one here on the Mainland knew exactly what happened to the Scorpioni. We had thought Hordak killed them all. But thanks to Sweet Bee and her bad habit of being brutally honest. Even when she is not being asked to share." Perfuma seethed quietly. " Scorpia knows. That her Grandfather, the King and her people. Abandoned her and the rest of the Royal Family for Meadow Lands. Leaving them to be slaughtered by Hordak. Yet Hordak let Scorpia live? Why…" Perfuma was confused and appalled, shaking her head as if trying to free herself from the ill feelings all this created inside her heart.

“Hordak didn’t kill kids.” Catra responded, “Perhaps he wanted to be able to use her as a weapon against the Princess Alliance in the future.”

“Well, thank the stars the Black Garnet didn’t connect with her until she was on our side.” Perfuma giggled, nervously. “Because with that kind of power, Hordak could have conquered Etheria much more quickly.”

“Yeah…” Catra breathed, her mind churning with more questions. Why did the Black Garnet refuse to link with Scorpia? Did that have something to do with Shadow Weaver’s tampering with the Rune Stone? She had been holding back the Horde behind the scenes, while in command for nearly a decade or more. The Horde never gained any more ground until Catra took over? Perhaps, dening Scorpia her birthright had been a part of her strategy to keep Hordak’s conquest in check. She was using her parasitic dark magic to siphon the Black Garnets power. To keep herself alive, to make herself more powerful.

Trying to decipher the true purpose of the old witch's many schemes made her brain hurt. Every attempt she made at doing something good to protect Etheria. Had been twisted and tainted by the Nameless Ones corruption.

Perfuma led her to the original Black Garnet Chamber that lay just behind the throne room in Horror Hall. The place was as grim and cavernous as the rest of the place. The circular walls were roughly hewn from the granite rock the same as the corridor’s and Great hall. With ancient murals painted within alcoves, faded and flaking from time. The domed roof ascended out of sight towards an open round skylight. That was cut in the direct center of the room, the looming monolith of the Black Garnet stood just below the skylight. It’s once ominous crimson glow now absent, leaving the Rune Stone dull and lifeless instead. Runes were etched into the stone floor around the Black Garnet. But Catra didn’t stop to read them, swiftly keeping on Perfuma’s heels. Catra had always

found Horror Hall creepy. She never knew why until recently. That Scorpia's parents and grandmother had been murdered here as well. It explained the mournful, haunting atmosphere she always sensed. Which brought into focus Angella's words. That her magic was tied to the deep magic of Death. Allowing her to invoke the Soul Pyre spell back at the camp with her Squadmates.

A massive ribcage came into view as they crossed to the far side of the chamber. Red lightning sparked and crackled along the inside of the curving bones. A dark silhouette was hunched over the hilt of a sword within the chest cavity of the ancient skeleton. The spine protruding from the back was curled out of view into the gloom of the back wall, the neck and massive skull of the ancient serpent rested upon the floor. Hundreds of nodules that once held spines in life, covered it's wide forehead and large ridges of its cheekbones. The soulless black orbs of its eye sockets bored into her. The thin shroud of it's magic, still clung to it's bones. Causing the very depths of them to still hum with a residual power.

Catra was instantly put on edge by the phantom magic, she felt still immenateing from the skeleton. Wondering now if she was to find Oroborous's remains. If his bones would still hold the essence of his magic as well?

"Scorpia…" Perfuma called gently as she approached a massive rib bone. Weaving delicately between the pale white bones, as if they might be brittle and not wanting to destroy them.

Catra followed her example and slipped sideways between two ribs, brushing up against the dry bones as gently as possible. To find Scorpia, sitting on the ground. Hunched over the cross guard of Jitsu's old sword. Her pincher's folded over the pommel and forehead resting in brooding repose against them. Crimson lightning was exploding from the red gem beneath her pinchers. Crackling and crawling up her overly muscled arms and snapping violently against the pointy carapace on her bent shoulders. Scorpia seemed to be immune from the warding spell that had once hurt Catra, during her battle with Jitsu.

The scorpion hybrid made a rather ominously dangerous visage. With her once soft, gentle features cast in deep shadow. Her expression hardened into a grim, contemplative scowl. Her blue eyes now dimmed with disappointment and a fathomless sadness. Wallowing in the harsh truths of her own people's cowardice. Her Grandfather… the King's…betrayal. Leaving the female Royal family to be slaughtered…The motto of honor…of loyalty she had once sought to emulate. Was false, her Grandfather wasn't a hero…as she had envisioned. But a feckless coward. All the stories Shadow Weaver had told her about her people, about her family had been a lie. King Scorpio hadn't fought Hordak to the death for killing her grandmother, her mother's. But offered them up as a sacrifice to ensure that he could escape with his people to Meadow Lands. That her own life might have been forfeit if it wasn't for Hordak's mercy. Refusing to allow his men to kill the defenseless little cadet they had found in the rubble of the Black Garnet Chamber.

King Scorpio had never cut a deal with Hordak before his death. Offering the secrets of the Black Garnet in order for the Space Tyrant to spare his granddaughter's life. It was just another story, Shadow Weaver had woven to placate her desires to know about her own family. There was no family honor, no loyal creed to speak of. The very foundation of who she believed she was…was based on lies. Manipulations and fallacies to control her, mold her into the loyal, unquestioning Soldier she had been for Shadow Weaver.

Her grandfather was alive and well, living peacefully in Meadow Lands.

All while her mother's and grandmother's bodies had rotted and turned to dust where they fell. Fighting Hordak's forces here in the Black Garnet chamber. Mr. Pointy as well, had defended the Black Garnet until his dying breath. Became nothing but bones, his rage still haunting this chamber like a roaring echo from the afterlife.

While his own grandchild had been torn from her grand-mother’s corpse. To be raised in a dreary, loveless world. In which she would know only the endless days of training and conditioning to become a soldier. To strive to perform her duties to the best of her abilities, to be loyal and live each day in the service of the Horde.

She had spent her life looking for the positives, affirming her own worth in the absence of praise. Hoping that one day she would honestly believe in herself. Trying to find the best in the people that surrounded her. Finding purpose in fighting for the Horde. That she could find her place here in the ranks of this usurper’s military. Since the Princesses did not want her in their ranks. None of the other kingdoms had ever tried to save her from the Horde, so she believed Shadow Weaver. That she just would not fit in with the other Princesses. She wasn’t a true Princess anyway, the Black Garnet had denied her her birthright. So she would find her purpose as a Force Captain. Remaining loyal to the Hordes cause. To control the Chaos the Princesses Magic created on Etheria and force them to bow to Hordak’s will.

But thanks to Catra and her rebellious nature, her refusal to just blindly follow orders. Having to witness her numerous unfair punishments at the hands of their superior’s when she failed. Or the petty retaliations against her by the other Force Captains, when she succeeded. Catra always thought for herself first and strived, tooth and nail for her own personal power within this twisted hierarchy. She inspired Scorpia to finally be able to break free of the chains of duty and blind loyalty that always tied her down. Finding the courage to begin to think for herself and make her own decisions and fight for what she believed in. To defy her upbringing and finally have the courage to do what was right. She couldn’t help Catra, she had tried for years but the feline just didn’t want to be happy. But she still had a chance to save Entrapta. So she left, hoping to fix her past cowardice. She would change, she would be better…and seek to repair the damage she had caused to her friendships, to Etheria.

But after Sweet Bee’s revelations, of her Grandfather's betrayal. Scorpia had been overwhelmed by rage and grief. Unable to

handle the ferocity of those negative emotions and worried that she might take it out on others. She had retreated up to Horror Hall to try and work it all out. In the end, she had crawled into the bones of Mr. Pointy to brood and wallow in her rage and pain.

Refusing to talk to Glimmer or Perfuma…they would never understand. Finally demanding to talk to the only person she knew. Who could empathize with the emotional torment she was going through. She wanted to talk to Catra, hoping that perhaps her best friend. Who had already traversed and conquered this gauntlet of grief, rage and heartache could help her navigate to the other side of it. She needed Catra to help pull her out of this darkness she was trapped in.

Catra settled down on the other side of the rib cage. Crouching in a ready position to spring away. Her tail curling over her feet, ears and eyes alert to the surroundings. Her instincts were already humming with the subtle threat Scorpia was giving off. She cleared her throat nervously and pulled her satchel off her shoulder, setting Melog down behind her.

“Hey, there big gal?” She greeted Scorpia gently.

Scorpia growled as her tail quivered.

Perfuma moaned in fear, keeping a very close eye on the Scorpion's stinger. “She’s been like this for days. She won’t talk to me anymore, she’s completely closed herself off and no one can reach her. Is this a Scorpia thing….or a Hybrid thing?”

Catra rolled her eyes and sighed. Human ignorance when it came to her kind was rather annoying. Perfuma wasn’t trying to be insensitive, she was just really scared.

“It’s a bit of both Flower girl.” Catra advised, “We have a tail, so it’s just part of how we Emote. If you want to be friends with a Hybrid you gotta learn how we communicate beyond words.”

Perfuma merely nodded, slowly taking in every nuisance of Scorpia’s posture and her tail’s violent quivering. “She’s

angry….and sad….” Perfuma paused for a beat then added, nervously. “ but she won’t hurt me? ”

Catra started to nod, then chuckled and shrugged. “She might still hurt you, but it won’t be intentional and she will feel bad about it.”

Perfuma paled and swallowed hard.

“I hurt Adora tons growing up…still do at times.” Catra sighed, flicking out her claws and flashing her fangs for emphasis. “But she’s come to see the charm in it I guess. Cause she’s never made me feel guilty or complained about the pain, I cause with my claws or my fangs. If you want a relationship with a Hybrid you gotta accept our animal side.”

Perfuma gave her a resolute nod, but the fear in her eyes remained.

“Go away…” Scorpia’s eyes flicked up to regard Perfuma. The icy blue in the depths of her gaze was cold and impassive. Her tone was flat, firm and devoid of emotion.

“But…I want to help?” Perfuma pleaded, curling her hands together in a beseeching gesture.

“YOU CAN’T HELP ME!...” Scorpia bellowed, her eyes burning into Perfuma with barely restrained fury.

Perfuma squeaked and jumped in fright, hands splayed over her chest as she instinctively called upon her magic to protect herself. Roots burst from the cracks in the granite floor, curling and knotting around her.

Catra had hissed at the sudden outburst, her hackles raised along the back of her neck. Eyes wide, pupils dilated as her fight or flight instincts roared to the surface.

“Please, leave me alone…” Scorpia snarled, she had been holding back her wrath for days. Not wanting to scare Perfuma any more

than she already had. But her defensive walls were crumbling and she was straining to remain calm.

"I don't want you here…I need you gone…" She was panting and heaving for breath, as she struggled to restrain the howling rage that sought to rip through her. Lightning crackled up her large muscular arms, illuminating the shadows briefly in a deathly crimson aura.

Perfuma whimpered, biting down on her lower lip as she swallowed hard. Quelling the tears of rejection, as Scorpia dismissed her efforts to comfort her once again.

Catra had been quiet observing their interaction, with familiar shame. So many times while they were growing up. Adora had reached out to her, when she was hurting. And she had pushed her away, rejected her efforts to comfort her. Until finally, she had hit rock bottom and was forced to confront her own toxic behaviors.

It had been Perfuma who had peeled the scales of denial from her eyes. Made her face that fact that she had closed herself off to others…to Adora. Out of fear of rejection…

The only way she was ever going to find happiness. Was face her fears, open her heart and allow herself to be vulnerable. That vulnerability was not weakness, but an act of bravery. To be honest and true to your feelings and share them with those you loved, trust that your heart would be safe in their care. It was the most terrifying and most rewarding thing she had ever done.
"Fine…" Perfuma grumbled, brushing her hands down her skirts as she stood up. Her movements were crisp and sharp as she dusted off her clothes. As if she was mentally collecting herself. Packing away her concern, her disappointment and yearning for Scorpia to need her in a tidy little mental box. Then promptly turned on her heel and retreated from the cage of bones.

Catra watched her go, guilt sitting heavy in her chest. Perfuma had wanted to be the one Scorpia turned to. She understood the

hurt and disappointment at not being wanted. Having lived that painful existence of never measuring up, feeling unwanted and unworthy of being loved.

“Alright, spill.” Catra turned back to Scorpia, her tone sharp and demanding.

“He left us…He left me!” Scorpia exclaimed, the crimson lightning flaring and sparking with new vigor up her arms. Catra was suddenly unsure if all that power was coming from the rune in the sword or Scorpia herself.

Scorpia’s eyes were smoldering with wrath and pain, as she glared at her. The lightning engulfing her whole body, crawling up the rib bones behind her. The Scorpion’s level of threat increased ten fold as she began to release her rage.

“Your grandfather…” Catra clarified, hesitantly. Her claws were tingling, at the overwhelming aura of violence now coming off of Scorpia.

“He didn’t want me….didn’t love me…He abandoned me…” Scorpia threw her head back and laughed, long and loud. The sound was harsh and abrasive, echoing off the cavernous walls like a gunshot. A bolt of lightning exploded from her crossed pincers on the pommel of the sword. Arcing across the room, threw the rib bones on either side. Cutting into the hard granite of the walls and leaving rough, blackened scars upon the rock.

Catra snapped her eyes down to Scorpia’s pincher’s when she heard the sharp cracking of the swords hilt being slowly crushed. “I will show him. That I don’t need him either…I’ve done just fine without him…I’ll build my kingdom all by myself…and it will be stronger and more powerful than ever before! No one will dare to oppose Scorpania… I will protect my people…my home will never be destroyed again” She snarled, then with a rending snap the hilt broke in two.

Catra’s ears folded back against her head in fear at Scorpia’s declaration. This vengeful need to prove herself as a mighty ruler. Put her kingdom’s armament build up in a new and very disturbing light. Scorpia’s intentions were not just to protect Etheria. She wanted to resurrect the power and intimidating might of Hordak’s army. In some vain attempt to show her Grandfather that she was strong and that she didn’t need him. She was going to weaponize her people, create a kingdom forged from war.

Another military regime, under a new banner…

A new and improved version of the Etherian Horde…

And it was utterly terrifying…

“Scorpia…” Catra’s heart was now pounding inside her chest in both fear and concern. Suddenly feeling like she was trapped in a cage of bones with a ferocious animal. Her best friend was spiraling down a very dark and violent path, she needed to reign her in. Pull her back from that spiteful cliff, of seeking retribution against her grandfather and falling into that casm of pain and rage like she had.

Scorpia cut her eyes up from the broken sword, now littered at her feet. Her blue eyes were burning with a cold fury. That froze Catra in place and made her gasp in fright. Her muscles felt electrified in the same, overwhelming fear and surprise as when she first laid eyes on Scorpia in the Fright Zone. As she stalked into sight for the first time, her eyes blank and glowing green under Primes control. The terrifying power of the Black Garnets magic sparking violently along her torso and arms. The sudden alarming concussive blast that had struck her and sent her flying towards the smoke stacks beyond the forge.

“Ok…you need to calm down…” Catra raised a placating hand, seeking to get Scorpia to back down. “I get that you're angry…and upset…but let's talk ok…that’s what you wanted right?” She pleaded, her toe claws digging into the stone floor as she

adjusted her crouching stance. Reading herself to spring away, in a moment notice if Scorpia lunged.

Scorpia was heaving for breath, pushing the air out through clenched teeth as she valiantly tried to reign in her rage. It took several minutes of her maintaining eye contact with Catra to finally calm down enough to speak.

"Yeah…your right…Wild Cat…I needed to talk to you." Scorpia slowly closed her eyes as all the fight drained out of her. She slumped against the rib bones behind her, her arms dropping to her side limp and lifeless. As the focus of her eyes drew far away. Wallowing once more in her despair, finally able to show how vulnerable and weary she truly was with the only person she trusted.

Catra took a deep breath, as the imminent threat she had sensed began to dissipate. She still wasn't ready to get comfortable, remaining in a crouch as Scorpia began opening up.

"I was a baby, when Hordak's fleet of starships crashed in my kingdom. It fell to Hordak's forces, within days." Scorpia began. "I don't even know if my people fought, or just surrendered outright. Because he had superior weapons to ours at the time. Anyway's, my grandfather still ruled our kingdom…but I guess he was more a puppet ruler for Hordak. Perhaps to keep the Scorpioni from rebelling? I don't' know. I lived here in Horror Hall with my grandparents and mother's. When I was old enough to be sent to the barracks, I had to leave my home. I only got to see my family once a week. I was only in the barracks for a season before Hordak killed my family. Then I had no one…but my bunkmates. "

Catra kept silent, listening to Scorpia weave her bleak tale of being raised in the Horde. Never really fitting in with her bunkmates, always being so much bigger and clumsier then they were. Accidentally hurting them during combat training and breaking or bending quarter staves on a regular basis with her pinchers. It took her a very long time to learn how much pressure she could use to grip those metal staves. In the years between

she became touch starved, as no one would come near her. Causing her to become scared of her own body as she closed herself off to others. As she grew older she came to accept her body and began to try and prove to others that she would not hurt them. Hence her demanding hugs, upon first meeting someone. As a way to prove that she would not harm them. That she could be soft and caring, despite her hard shell.

That Shadow Weaver had taken an interest in her at first, seeking to mentor her. Mold her into a perfect weapon to use against the Princesses. But as she got older, the Black Garnet still refused to accept her. Shadow Weaver's plans to use and control the Rune Stones magic, though her, was scrapped. She sought to figure out a way to tap into the Rune herself. With Scorpia of no further use to her, she was forgotten. Growing up alone and abandoned once more.

Then Adora appeared and took her place as Shadow Weaver's protege. Which only made Scorpia feel more worthless and ashamed of her failure of not connecting with her Rune Stone. She would never admit it, but she hated Adora.

"I guess. I blamed Adora for taking away the only adult who had ever shown any interest in my well being." Scorpia sighed, scratching the tip of a pincher nervously against the stone floor. Worried Catra might be mad about how she felt.

"Do you still hate her?" Catra asked quietly.

"Naw…not really. Honestly I am rather indifferent about her." Scorpia advised with a smirk. "She's a great person…strong and brave and selfless. I mean she saved the World…well you helped… but she destroyed Prime…I could never have done that. " Scorpia began to sing her praises with a forced smile that didn't reach her sad eyes.

Catra laughed and nodded, accepting Scorpia's affirmation of her girlfriend at face value. Time would tell what her true feelings were towards Adora.

"Ok, enough…She's amazing. I get it. I just hope you keep all that to yourself. She doesn't need to get a bigger head than she already got." Catra joked.

Scorpia laughed, "Yeah…her forehead is kinda huge isn't it…the hair poof just draws more attention to it."

Catra rolled her eyes and threw a stone at Scorpia. It bounced off her carapice on her shoulder.
"Hey! I am the only one allowed to make fun of her giant head." She chastised playfully.

Scorpia's eyes flared in worry as she clamped her mouth shut. Swallowing her further witty remarks.

The tension was broken and Catra did not want it coming back. So she crawled forward, grasping the tips of Scorpia's pincers and holding them tenderly.

"I was just joking around, don't clam up on me now." She pleaded, searching Scorpia's stricken face and wet eyes for understanding.

Scorpia offered her a weak smile and nodded, taking a few moments to gather herself before continuing.

"I know you never meant what you said about me way back when….you were angry and sorta sleep deprived at the time. But honestly you were not the only one who ever told me. That I was useless…" Scorpia, sighed heavily. Stretching out her legs as she got comfortable.

Catra's heart sank at the mention of how terrible she had treated her. Scorpia was good and kind and her heart was pure. She never deserved any of the cruelty Catra had inflicted upon her over those dark years.

"Shadow Weaver said it plenty of times to me, while I grew up." Scorpia chuckled. "I guess that's something we have in common,

huh. Neither of us could gain her approval no matter how hard we tried."

"So she raised you too…at least for a little while?" Catra was surprised, this revelation struck a very painful cord. A strange kind of solidarity formed between them with this shared trauma.

"Not really…she was my Superior Officer, nothing more. I had asked once when I was really little if she was my new mom…Oh boy did that piss her off." Scorpia chuckled. "She put me in my place right quick…yelled at me for a good ten minutes. That I didn't have a mother anymore, that I was a soldier. That I needed to stop being a weak, useless cry baby. That the only way I was going to survive here in the Horde was to become stronger and prove my worth to Hordak."

"Heard that, got the t-shirt…" Catra started, "Then I burned it!" She finished with a cackle. That woman's constant 'pep talks' had been a thorn in Catra's side growing up. She could never measure up, no matter how hard she had tried, not like Adora and it had hurt.

"More like you blew it up!" Scorpia added, nodding absently towards the base.

"Yeah, well the Fright Zone was a Hell Hole, it should have been wiped off the map long ago. I did everyone a favor." Catra reiterated with a cocky smirk. She was getting more comfortable, as they bantered back and forth. Adjusting herself to sit beside Scorpia, stretching out against the rib bones with her arms crossed behind her head.

"So your plan is to become the new Hordak, then?" Catra quipped a few minutes later, giving Scorpia a meaningful look out of the corner of her eye.

"No…maybe…but not on purpose. Oh…boy…never thought I would end up like this. I had planned to be a more caring and supportive ruler for my people and little less a "GET OUT!" kinda,

Shut in…” Scorpia began, her cheeks burning with humiliation. She glanced up and looked mournfully at the shadowed entrance of the Black Garnet chamber. Finding it empty.

“Off to a great start then. ” Catra stated sarcastically then chuckled as she inclined the rib cage they were hiding in. “ You are already holed up in your own Sanctum, here Scorp. ” She finished with a sharp click of her tongue.

Scorpia’s mouth dropped open at that, her eyes searching the floor as she absorbed the seriousness of that statement. Scorpia sighed heavily as she looked around meekly. “Ah…yeah…I guess you're right.” She rubbed the back of her neck with embarrassment.

“Are you hiding up here, because you can’t deal with what Sweet Bee told you about your grandfather?” Catra offered, paying the taller hybrid a brief look of concern.

“I am just so angry…Wild Cat.” Scorpia snarled, the red lightening flaring over her body once more. As the very depths of her blue eyes began to glow with power.

Catra’s ears pinned back and she sucked in a startled breath.

As quickly as the magic surged over Scorpia it disappeared.

“Why didn’t he want me? Why didn’t he protect me?” Scorpia moaned, then heaved another great sigh. As she bowed her head and brushed her pinchers over her short platinum blonde hair in frustration. Pushing it off her forehead and flat to the back of her head. It stayed in place for all of two seconds when she lifted her pincers, falling back into its position over her eyes.

“How did you let go?” Scorpia asked, softly, refusing to look up. Staring despondently at her pinchers, as they hung limply between her now raised legs. As she now lounged against the bones next to Catra.

"I didn't for a long time. I fed off my anger and pain. I was bitter, resentful and mean. I pushed everyone away because I couldn't deal with getting hurt again. I caused nothing but suffering for everyone around me." Catra admitted, falling silent for a moment to gather the rest of her thoughts. As Scorpia absorbed what she was saying. Glancing back towards the entrance again.

"Perfuma's helped me figure out how to heal, Scorp. How to be happy. Don't push her away." Catra placed a comforting hand on her scorpion's bicep.

"I am terrified of hurting her." Scorpia whispered, cutting her eyes to Catra for a moment.

Catra took a deep breath before delving into the harsh truths of her weaknesses. Her yearning for redemption. Weaving her tragic tale of poor choices for Scorpia to learn from.

"I wanted power, cause I thought it would make me feel safe. I wanted to win, to prove to everyone who didn't believe in me. That I was better than them, stronger than them, smarter. That I didn't need them…in the end everything I had strived for, worked for, it meant nothing. Achieving my goals at the cost of others, only made me more miserable. I came to realize all of that, while on the Velvet Glove. Glimmer helped, that sparkly little menace was far wiser than I gave her credit for. " Catra laughed softly, her eyes warm. Shimmering with a jaded nostalgia over her memories of Glimmer during their shared incarceration. "We talked…like a-lot and she always called me on my bullshit. Sparkles ever let me delude myself that I could just keep surviving, keep reaching for power as if that was what was going to save me. That I needed more than that, that I needed to finally come to terms with my mistakes and the consequences of them. That I needed to be better….do better…do that one good thing in my life…I needed to change." Catra took in another shuddering breath, valiantly trying to hold back the painful tears. Speaking about her time being captured by Prime was hard. The trauma that she kept locked up tight in the back of her mind, resurfacing to torment her anew.

"I never let go…at least not all at once. I had nothing left to lose and I didn't matter to anyone. So I decided to get Glimmer off the ship, believing that Prime would kill me for my betrayal. I welcomed death at that point." Catra finished quietly, eyes downcast in shame.

"Oh…WildCat…" Scorpia moaned with sympathy, her bowed head illustrating that she took on some of the blame. For Catra being all alone and feeling like death was her only option to free herself of all that pain.
Catra pushed on, ignoring Scorpia's silent anguish at the suffering she had caused by abandoning her. "I was able to find the courage to apologize to Adora. To warn her and tell her to stay away, for her own good. Cause Prime was ready for her and I did not want her to sacrifice herself for me. I wasn't worth it. But the heroic fool came for me anyway." Catra laughed with relief, casting Scorpia a knowing smile.

"Yeah, Adora's just like that. Isn't she." Scorpia remarked, wrapping an arm around Catra and pulling her in close for a comforting hug. "I sure am glad she did, though. Cause you never stopped mattering to me, Wildcat. Accepting the fact that I couldn't save you from yourself. Leaving you. It was the hardest thing I had ever done. I never stopped thinking about you, worrying about you."

Catra sniffled and curled into Scorpia's side. Willingly accepting her comfort and seeking more. This softer version of Catra would have never been possible. If Scorpia hadn't left her, if Double Trouble hadn't given her that brutally honest description of her character. Shattering the vengeful persona she had wrapped around herself for three years, like so much glass. The months that followed had her start to pick up the pieces of her life and put them back together the right way…this time.

"It took a long time for me to finally open up my heart and let Adora in again. It was the hardest, most terrifying thing I had ever done. Confessing to her at the Heart. " Catra finished softly. They remained quiet for a little while, as Catra gathered her

composure. Scorpia had silent tears rolling down her face, her thoughts churning over the harrowing path to redemption Catra had traveled.

"You can't heal if you refuse to move forward, Scorp. Do not repeat my mistakes. You gotta face your fears head on. Being vulnerable isn't a weakness…it's being brave." Catra gave Scorpia's chest over her heart a brief slap and pulled away.

"I need to go to Meadow Lands…confront him. I need to know the truth." Scorpia finally accepted what she had to do. It would be the scariest confrontation of her life but she needed to do it. It was the only way she would be able to move forward.

"Then I'm going with you!" Perfuma declared from the entrance arch of the chamber. She may have retreated but she hadn't left.

Catra chuckled ruefully, realizing that the Plumerian Princess had been eavesdropping on their entire conversation.

Scorpia crawled out of the bones and offered her a wide, eager smile.

"I would like that." She declared, happily.

Battle of the Bugs

After Catra and Hordak's little disagreement, that blew up most of the Fright Zone. The remains of the fortress had been left to rot. As the leaderless Horde began to disperse over the continent. Attempting to find new homes and a new purpose. That proved to be rather futile since the rest of Etheria did not want them. The once subjugated masses of Etherian's became the aggressors. Pushing the ex-horde Soldier's back into the desolate, inhospitable wasteland they had created. By destroying the land to feed their ever expanding war machine for the last few decades.

Then Prime came, chipping those who remained within the Fortress. Once struggling to survive, had been re-purposed to expand his light. They fought under his banner, subjecting the outlying villages on the border's of the Fright Zone and the Whispering Woods. Helping his clones build spires throughout Etheria and his great magic siphoning machine. That he would use it to drain the magic from the Heart and claim the last great well of power in the Universe. That he had lost a thousand years ago, when Mara stranded the planet in Despondos.

Now the siphon sat silent and unmoving, a ghostly monolith looming far in the distance from the Fortress. Out upon the lush fields that spread over what is now known as the Kingdom of Scorpania.

Imp sat upon a rusted metal cross beam of an electrical tower, high above the Fortress. The heavy cross arm groaned and swayed slightly as the wind buffeted its worn out metal frame. The ground wires that had once been connected to the top of the tower, were curled on the broken cement below. No longer connected to power they lay like giant black snakes around the tower's base. The factories in this quadrant had been without power for seasons. The cavernous buildings inside were dark. Laying abandoned and mostly gutted for resources and building materials. With broken circular windows and crumbling cement foundations, this area of the Fortress would be the perfect place

for an intruder to hide. Imp's beady black eyes scan the narrow allies that lay far below. He had been tracking a strange scent for days. Sculking through the dried out gutters of twisting allies, searching behind greasy dumpster's and through piles of industrial debris. Crawling through the ducts and narrow, putrid tunnels of chemical waste. That sprawled below the munitions factory sector of the Fortress. Ignoring the tiny little surveillance drones that were skittering about all over the place. Avoiding the hulking metal monstrosities of the newly programmed bot's, that were now patrolling the streets. As guardian's instructed to protect instead of to kill. Their single glowing red sensor array, scanning the broken pavement and cluttered streets filled with busted machinery and chunks of mortar. Blasting away the debris that littered their paths so their three long legs could navigate through. Scanning the destroyed buildings and debris in great, arching swaths for their sensor sweeps. As they patrolled the sector relentlessly.

Imp had seen several strike teams, fully armored, with stun batons on their utility belts and energy bolt rifles strapped to their backs. Moving in unison with the bots. It reminded him of old times,when his master was still in power.

When the Fortress was alive with soldiers moving about like thousands of tiny minions through the streets. Tending to the daily running of the Fright Zones, great war machine. It was the same yet, it was also different. The insignia that now adorned their chests was a Scorpion's stinger. The war machine was coming alive again, but under a different banner.

Imp didn't know if he liked that? The trio had taken care of him in Hordak's absence. They had retreated to the Hot land, while Prime waged his war against the Princess's. They made a home in a small coastal village, on the Red Shore. The Trio had gotten work at the docks, renting a small room in the village's local tavern. Those few months, sitting on the plush cushions of the window seat in their room. Keeping watch and absorbing as much information as he could of his surroundings. As he knew nothing

else, denied to leave the room. Because of what he was. A defunct Horde Clone.

So he spent his days. Memorizing every detail of the street below. The thousands of tiny cracks in the stone mortar of the tavern's base and that of the shops across the street. Admiring the various hues of the peeling paint upon the ornate signs hanging from metal hooks above the doors. The colorful plumage of the types of birds who nested in the eaves up and down the street. The change in ambiance when the lamps would go out at dawn and then come alive as darkness fell. Watching the quaint villager's and more interesting array of travelers that would pass by the tavern. Going in and out of the shops. Finally having the courage to sneak down to the bar below, hiding in the thick wooden beams on the open roof. Eavesdropping on the merchants bringing back stories of Primes occupation of Bright Moon then Mystacor and finally the Fright Zone. Observing and listening to them, reporting the day's gossip to the Trio when they got back in the evening. The reports of steady encroachment of Primes forces upon the Northern parts of the Crimson Waste. It had been strange but a welcome change from the constant noise of the Fright Zone. The calm, peaceful days are filled with trivial things and small joys. Enjoying the evenings in front of the fire, playing dice games with the trio in their room. All while listening to the bards, singing and playing their instruments in the bar below. Then the infection of chipped ones began to infiltrate the village. They made their escape into the desert in the middle of the night. Just as Primes forces took over the village. Joining the resistance soon after.

Imp went back to spying, flying far and wide to gather intel and locations of the Clone troops and reporting to his new commander…Lonnie. The war waged and he fell into the old ways, of being hyper alert and always on guard. Missing those lazy, peaceful days in which he didn't have to worry about being killed on the front lines.

Then the war was over and they returned to the Fortress.When the Horde Princess…Scorpia had tracked them down months ago

in the Waste. Urging them to come back and help her rebuild her Kingdom. He had found comfort in returning to the Fortress, able to hide and snoop just as he did before. Revisiting all his comfortable little hiding spots, nested with stolen treasures he had taken over the years. Spying now for his new master…Queen Scorpia. Yet seeing the Horde come alive again, filled him with dread. His old Master had found purpose in conquest and Imp was worried his new master would as well. His first master had been kind enough to give him free will and the Trio had shown him what freedom was. That he could choose his own path, so here he sat high above the factories. Helping the patrols track down the current intruder, debating his loyalty to this new regime?

Dusk was settling over the tall stacks and bulky factories of this quadrant. The green chemical mist that always hovered in the air, was settling low over the allies and streets like a toxic fog. When the Imps keen black eyes caught movement. Deep in the shadowy recesses of a long, narrow alley between two storage warehouses just the northwest of his position. He narrowed his eyes to bring the shadowy alley into sharper focus, his eyes glinting with night vision as the light faded from the sky.

His slender, pointed ears twitched as he picked up a soft clicking emanating from just behind a large metal dumpster. That was overflowing with building material scraps and other rubbish from the plastic factories that surrounded the alley.

Unfurling his small wings, he leaped from the beam. Gliding silently into the shadows within the alley, his bare feet touching down on the metal lip of the lid of the dumpster without a sound. Hunching over his knees, he peered into the cluttered mess behind. Listening, barely breathing so that he would remain hidden as he surveyed the degree of threat that lay within the darkness.

The clicking was barely a whisper, easily misinterpreted as the dripping of water or creaking of metal. Imp though, he had spent years listening to the subtle sounds the Fortress made. He might

be the only one capable of picking out the subtle nuances of that sound, that was alien to this environment. It made sense now why the soldier's and surveillance bots would be unable to find the intruder's for the last few days.

Imp was known for his infinite patience and ability to remain still for hours. His hearing was phenomenal so he picked up on two or more different tones of clicks. There was more than one intruder. Now he had a dilemma, he was no fighter, at least not a very good one. He could take one full sized person and hold his own for a little while, just enough time for the real soldier's to arrive and take care of things.

But taking on more than one opponent was not good odds. For him to be able to get out of the fight unscathed. He didn't like pain and tried to avoid it. Opting to run away if the odds were not in his favor to win.

So Imp decided to make a hasty retreat, with his info. Wanting to leave the fighting for the trained soldiers. He knew, were patrolling nearby.

Stretching his wings, he turned to leap off the lip of the dumpster. When with a screech of pain, he felt a sharp sting strike his shin. Then suddenly he was dizzy and disorientated. With a weak moan, he crumpled forward into the darkness behind the bin. Followed by the soft sound of his small body striking the pavement .

The clicking became louder for a moment. Then silence fell heavy upon the alley, as three small creatures emerged from behind the metal bin. The tallest carrying Imp's body over its shoulder. They looked to be no larger than Imp himself, with dusty red carapaces covering their shoulders and backs like a suit of armor. Each one wore a pair of baggy military style pants with large pockets sewn down the sides. Buttoned closed with huge black snaps. Small bulbous tails jutted out of the back of their pants, curling up at the end, sporting a small but deadly stinger. Their torso's were uncovered, showing a very humanoid chest covered in rough

chiten. Their heads were not human in appearance, far from it. Blunt and arrow shaped, like ants. With large black almond shaped eyes. Their compound lens refracted the dim light. Shimmering like wild animals as night descended. Two, long,segmented antennae, vibrated and waved from their angular foreheads. Tasting the air, sensing the slightest of movements of the debris that surrounded them. As the trio slowly made their way towards the mouth of the alley.

The lead ant creature held two long sticks in each hand, the pointed tips glowing an eerie yellow. The tallest, most powerful of them walked behind. Carrying Imp over his broad shoulders, with the last and shortest ant trailing behind. Sporting a heavy, well packed utility belt made for much larger people. Draped across his small chest and buckled at his hip. He held a tiny hand held pad, tapping and swiping upon the screen with a slender finger.

{We should leave the mutant clone, he will only slow us down} The smallest ant-man clicked with its mandibles..

{I poisoned him, he will die if we leave him without aid} The tallest ant clicked back sharply.

{We don’t have time to be kind, our window to rescue Sweet Bee has long since closed. I refuse to leave this insufferable maze of an industrial wasteland without her!} The lead ant swung around and confronted both of his men with frustrated loud clicks.

{Thorne, it will be ok. People will find him, they are nearby, just leave it out in the open.} The shortest Ant offered, reaching up with a reassuring hand. To squeeze the big Ant’s bicep as he stared up at him.

{Fine!} The tallest ant-man promptly dropped Imp at the mouth of the alley. Stomping off down the street, uncaring that he was in plain sight. As his troop leader and scout scrambled after him.

Sweet Bee was tall for her race, but compared to Scorpia's towering frame. She resembled a scrawny prepubescent child. Her body was lean, almost willowy. Her small breasts and nearly straight hips gave her an almost boyish frame. With shoulder length strawberry blonde hair. That hung in curly waves down to her shoulder blades. Her bangs pinned back by a bright red head scarf. Knotted at the back of her head. The twin tails of fabric trailing down to the arch of her back. Her two, long, elegant antennae. Curled upward from the edge of her bandana, at the peek of her forehead. Bouncing every time she moved her head. Her skin was pale and unblemished like porcelain. Her round cheeks were flaming with rage, as her bright green eyes glared death up a Scorpia. She would have possessed a cute, endearing appearance that could have held the charm and dignity of royalty. If it wasn't for how scrunched up her pert little nose got when enraged. Or how she was seething hatefully, showing off her teeth like a caged animal. Her gossamer wings were vibrating against her back, humming with pent up wrath. As she stood indignantly before the Scorpion Queen inside her barren cell. Dressed in dark brown leather breeches, the sides are held closed by a criss-crossing piece of hide cord that runs down the length of her thigh. The pants narrowed under the knee and were tucked into the wide, folded cuffs of long black leather boots. With a billowing cream colored button up shirt, with the cuffs pushed up to her elbows. The wide collar hung low, as the shirt was only buttoned a couple times in the middle, gaping open. As she leaned forward to poke Scorpia in the chest. Her breasts were covered modestly in a black wrap. Her toned, well muscled stomach peeked out between the billowing folds.

Catra had to admit, Sweet Bee had a dangerous, sexy aura that might have been rather alluring. If she wasn't currently screaming like a spoiled, petulant child. About being detained for no reason for days. Scolding Scorpia for her mistreatment. Demanding to be set free and then threatening Scorpia all in the same breath. Followed by the ultimatum. That she was a princess and her Uncle, the King of Meadow Lands would hear of this injustice. War would break out between their kingdoms. Because she was such a

beloved and cherished Princess, her people would defend her honor and seek recompense for her pain and suffering by this unlawful imprisonment.

So on and so on...

While Scorpia stood stoically, taking her fuming tirade without showing any emotion. Standing rigidly before the raging Princess, with her arms crossed behind her back. Her training and high level of discipline as a Horde Soldier is very obvious. Accustomed to being yelled at, in point blank range. Letting Sweet Bee tire herself out, silently taking her verbal abuse.

Catra leaned against the far wall of the cell, arms folded over her chest. Staring at Sweet Bee with an indifferent, unimpressed expression upon her face. Scorpia had let her into the prison this time. But Glimmer was still not allowed inside, left fuming and screaming at the entrance. Perfuma had stayed behind to attempt to calm down the raging Queen of Bright Moon.

But Catra figured Scorpia intended to deal with the Queen of Bright Moon on her own terms, later. She prided Scorpia's tactics, she did not want Glimmer involved at all. Knowing that the Queen's louder, stronger personality would just undermine her own power. She was in charge here and she was setting a precedent with Glimmer. That the princesses had no say in how she ran her own kingdom.

"Are you quite done?" Catra arched an eyebrow, yawning for emphasis as they were both over her royal tantrum.

Sweet Bee's mouth gaped in shock at how her complaints were being disregarded so blatantly.

"Insufferable Horde Scum." She snarled, glaring down at her hands that were cuffed in front of her. The glowing chains trailing to the floor and over to the wall behind her.

"Nope, the Horde is gone, your majesty. You are dealing with the Queen of Scorpania." Scorpia stated matter of factly.

Sweet Bees lips thinned in distaste, as she chuckled. “Scorpio’s Granddaughter, the would be Queen.” She crooned, her tone thick with ire and disrespect.

“Return to boast and blather on about how I am a traitor to your new crony?” She tossed Scorpia a snide wave, before turning her back on her. “The apple certainly does not fall too far from the tree.” She finished with an arrogant flip of her hair. “Your grandfather is nothing but a pompous blowhard as well.” She huffed.

Catra arched an eyebrow, the princess of Meadow Lands certainly was cocky.

Scorpia smirked, leaning back against the wall with her pincers crossed over her chest. Attempting to look cool and unaffected by the Princesses obvious disdain towards her and her family.

“Well, aren’t we a charmer?” Catra observed sarcastically.

Sweet Bee gave her a nasty side eyed glare, for just a moment. Before quickly composing herself, behind a mask of indifference.

“My Soldier’s had to ‘escort’ her majesty into this cell to cool down. Cause she was…gosh… a real handful, when she first got here. Biting and kicking like a rabid animal. Getting those cuffs on her was a chore, she sent two guards to the infirmary, before I could sting her. Then she was out cold for a day. So it wasn’t worth talking to her. Until she woke up.” Scorpia shrugged, her pointed comment towards Sweet Bee, not going unnoticed. As the Princess narrowed her eyes in contempt.

“We had such a lovely chat then, didn’t we? We talked for such a long time, then. I laughed, you cried, I thought we really connected. “ Sweet Bee taunted, in a boasting sing song.

Scorpia cleared her throat and rubbed the back of her neck, pacing towards the cell’s forcefield to claim some distance.

Embarrassment and fury igniting inside her like a bomb ready to explode. If she didn't move away from the Bee-hybrid she was going to punch her. Knock that arrogant, pompous smirk right off her face.

Catra took note of how easily Sweet Bee was pushing Scorpia's buttons. The Princess had a sharp tongue and an even sharper intellect. Catra would have to watch how she engaged if she wanted to keep the upper hand.

Scorpia quickly paced right back to Sweet Bee, not allowing her to win and shake her resolve. Silently giving herself a pep talk, as she reengaged.

(Don't let her win, this time. Scorpia…You're strong, smart and capable! You can handle this!)

"We did, didn't we. " Scorpia smiled, the arch of her lips was taunting. The lilt in her voice was overly polite. Thick with sarcasm and bitterness.

"You wanted to hurt me? Make me feel insecure about who I was? The poor, ignorant Scorpion Princess. Who was raised by her people's enemy. Who knew nothing about being a Scorpioni? Abandoned and left behind to rot with her Mother's and Grandmother. While my Grandfather ran away to hide in your kingdom with what remained of my people."

Sweet Bee's smile was tight and just as fake, as she stood her ground. Craning her neck up, to glare Scorpia in the eye as the taller girl invaded her personal space.

"I'm over it!" Scorpia leaned over her and snarled in her face, crimson lightning cracking threateningly over her carapace. "The Horde may have destroyed my kingdom, stolen my Birthright and driven my people away. But being raised by them made me who I am today! I'm a soldier! I am strong and brave. I have fought and survived the war with Prime. I've become a Queen, I shall rebuild Scorpania and I will crush anyone who tries to harm me, my

friends or my people!” Scorpia shouted in Sweet Bee’s face. Forcing the bee hybrid to cringe and squint her eye’s to protect herself from being spat upon.

Catra observed the heated, staring contest they engaged in following Scorpia’s wrathful epitaph. The slow simmer of dual hatred for each other, seethed in the air between them. Neither was backing down. Scorpia was trained never to show weakness. Sweet Bee was too stubborn, her pride refusing to allow her to bow before Scorpia. A known Horde Force Captain. The enemy, an oppressor, a war criminal in her eyes.

“You gunned down my airship! My home!” Finally Sweet Bee snapped and screamed back, lunging at Scorpia. The chains attached to the back wall, yanked her back before she managed only a few feet. Leaving her sprawled on the floor, panting and heaving for air. As she struggled to contain her righteous fury.

Scorpia’s rage cooled instantly, at Sweet Bee’s honest grief.

“I am truly sorry, I never thought it was your home. “ Scorpia crouched down, her eyes tender and full of sympathy. “ Scorpinia engineer's are currently assessing the damage. We will haul your ship back to your own Kingdom for repairs, since we have no idea how to fix a Meadow Land airship. “

“Good luck with that.” Sweet Bee rolled her eyes, “You’re better off just using it for kindling. There is no way you are getting past the Border’s Patrols stationed along the sea wall.”

Scorpia raised an inquiring eyebrow, wanting more information.

“Meadow Lands has closed its borders to mainlanders for over a thousand years. We have built a giant barrier wall around the island. There are barracks and fortifications all along the coast. Our soldiers are on constant patrol on the perimeter of the wall. They are not going to let your people in and hauling a busted up airship like a peace offering is not going to work either.”

Sweet Bee’s anger cooled, as she crawled over to the wall.

“I will be accompanying the transport team back to Meadow Lands.” Scorpia added, her expression was firm. An air of unyielding authority in her tone and demeanor. She was not going to take no as an answer.

Sweet Bee sighed, offering Scorpia a knowing smirk.

“Wanting to track down your Grandfather I assume.”

“We have a-lot to talk about, yes. But he is not my sole purpose in going. My mission would be purely diplomatic. To repair relations between Meadow Lands and the Mainland. ” Scorpia nodded.

“Ah, Well after you have done all that and fixed my ship, you can haul it all right back to the Mainland. I will not be joining you, if you were hoping for a guide.”

Sweet Bee remarked, with a firm shake of her head.

“So your big words about complaining to your Uncle about how poorly you were treated and starting a war with Scorpania was all just a bluff?” Catra snarked.

Sweet Bee merely shrugged again in a vague non committal sort of way.

“My uncle doesn’t like me much. Since I started a civil war and tried to reclaim my father’s throne a couple years back. I lost, got me and my crew banished instead. I can’t go back, not without facing death for my crimes against the crown.”

Scorpia and Catra turned to each other with surprised expressions. It seemed Meadow Lands had its own problems right now.

Catra's cunning mind was already hatching plans to use that information. If Sweet Bee couldn’t be coaxed to tell them what they wanted to know about Peekablue, then perhaps she could be bought?

“My crew?” Sweet Bee asked softly, the fight ebbing out of her like a slowly dying flame.

“Most fled into the Whispering Woods, my soldier’s only managed to take you and the lizard-kin protecting you into custody.” Scorpia answered.

“We have intel that you picked up Prince Peekablue and a little magicat at the summit of Mount Mystacor. We need to know where they were headed. They have a very ancient and perhaps dangerous crystal shard in their possession.” Catra cut to the chase.

Sweet Bee laughed snidely. “It’s in better hands with them then you.”

Catra’s bland expression twisted into fury instantly.

“Seriously…don’t be such a stubborn brat! We got some really dangerous people on Etheria hunting for that shard. They will kill to get their hands on it, are you willing to put their lives on the line because of your stupid pride?” Catra verbally retaliated.

Sweet Bee’s large green eyes grew even bigger, as she processed the danger her boyfriend was in. Peekablue had never told her that he was being hunted by anyone. Getting blown out of the sky by a Scorpion Cruiser had been a total surprise. Her fear quickly cooled into a look Catra knew well. It was strong yet tender, illustrating her complete trust in the abilities of the person she loved.

“I trust Blue, he knows what he’s doing. That little kitten is perfectly safe in his care.” She affirmed stubbornly under her breath.

“We can help, if you let us. If you tell us where they are, what his plans are for the shard. I have the manpower and resources to keep them safe and aid them in their mission. ” Scorpia offered, “As long as his plan for the Crystal isn’t going to make things worse.” She added pointedly.

“You scratch our back, we scratch yours if you catch my meaning.” Catra nodded towards Scorpia. Who looked slightly confused.

Sweet Bee’s eyes narrowed with scrutiny.

“We also have the manpower and weapon’s to help you reclaim your throne.” Catra added, crossing her arms over her chest. This was merely a power play, if they could get Sweet Bee back in charge of her own kingdom. Then they would have leverage to gain Meadow Lands allegiance in the future. Sweet Bee would have a debt to repay to Scorpania, for getting her throne back. It was a solid gambit that could thwart any future threat Meadow Lands might pose to the Mainland.

“Ah…WildCat?” Scorpia suddenly went pale, all her fake bravado deflating as Catra smoothly usurped her authority.

Catra cut her eyes to Scorpia, her look was hard, fierce. Silently demanding that Scorpia back down and not discredit her offer. It wasn’t part of the plan, but they were running out of options. Scorpia only had one trump card, the fact that she held the only standing army left on Etheria. She had power. She needed to learn how to use it.

Scorpia swallowed nervously, confronted once more by the indomitable power in Catra’s glare. Swarmed by self doubt and waning confidence in her own personal power. Scorpia slowly bowed her head, allowing Catra dominion over her once again.

Sweet Bee laughed long and loud, as if Catra’s offer was the funniest joke she had ever heard.

“I don’t care about my throne anymore.” She spat out between bouts of wild laughter. “That backstabbing son of a bitch can have it and all the bullshit of ruling an ungrateful kingdom that goes with it.”

That bitter statement had Catra and Scorpia sharing a look once again. Sweet Bee’s past seemed to be more sordid and complicated at every turn.

Catra filed away that new info as well, shrugging as her offer was denied.

“Fine, then. We need to know where Peekablue is. So what do you want?” Scorpia offered, her pincher’s flying into the air in exasperation.

Sweet Bee merely stared at her, blankly for a long time.

“Getting captured was never part of the plan.” Sweet Bee ducked her head and snarled. She was stalling, or had no information to give them about Peekablue’s whereabouts.

Either way, the pressure Catra had been feeling for weeks finally shattered her patience. The world was ending yet again and she has less control now then when Prime was around. The mysteries about the Shard of Kaydak, the Nameless One, Omega-Prime, Tri-Clops, Skeletor, the Mutants…all these other worldly threats piling up. Slowly chipping away at the security she had managed to build, from being with Adora and people who honestly cared about her. Melog getting hurt had been the final push to send her over. She had been teetering on that knife's edge, of regressing back into that ruthless person she once was. To reclaim that sense of safety and security, through the means she understood best.

Power, rage, spite and revenge.

“Things never go as planned, ever!” Catra snapped back, taking the opportunity of the Princess being off guard. To dash up to her and grab her by the collar and haul her up off her feet and slam her into the wall.

“WildCat!” Scorpia shouted in alarm, never dreaming that Catra would use her old violent intimidation tactics again.

“Tell us where they are headed!” Catra growled inches from Sweet Bee’s face. The little blob in her satchel was glowing such a fierce red that its color was staining through the fabric.

Sweet Bee's eyes darted down to Catra's bag in fear, believing she might have a weapon. Not taking into account that Catra had claws and teeth much closer to hurting her.

"I don't know! Peekablue never tells me anything!" She ranted. Her voice high pitched with long held irritation. " I dropped them off in the Whispering Woods and tried to fly away…but you shot us down!" Sweet Bee shouted heatedly, tears shimmering in her eyes. All the pompous posturing she had been doing, crumpling under Catra's predatory glare. She was trembling now, wide eyed and terrified. As she felt Catra's claws tearing through the thin fabric of her shirt and digging into the tender flesh of her neck.

"Put her down…Catra." Scorpia placed a pincher on Catra's shoulder. Urging her to comply.

The use of her real name sobered Catra up immediately. She may have gone a little overboard. Clearing her throat she released Sweet Bee and stalked to the back of the room. Seeking to control her temper and calm down, brushing her claws through her short mane. She had been worrying about that little magicat ever since Huntara had mentioned them earlier. They might be the only other magicat on Etheria. The how or why wasn't important just yet. She didn't know who they were, just that they were just a kitten. Wrapped up in some dangerous plot hatched by some Alien Tyrant. Who was seeking an ancient power on Etheria, to resurrect something called the Nameless One. A darkness she had allowed to devour her within the Portal. A dark, malevolent power that Shadow Weaver had absorbed and that had ultimately killed her. Would Peekablue be able to keep them safe? Did that Prince even have enough magic power to protect them from powerful warrior's like Jitsu or Tri-clops or even any of those crazy Mutant's they fought on Beast Island.

Everyone and everything was coming at them fast and Catra was having a hard time dealing with it all now. The stress of the unknown that had been gnawing at her for weeks was wearing her down. Making her act irrational and slightly unhinged at times. She needed to calm down…think it all through so the worst case

scenarios that have been running rampant in her brain didn't come true.

"We have no idea then, where they're headed. Huntara mentioned that Peekblue liked to hide in the Dark Edge, those canyons are not that far from here?" Catra was reaching and she knew it.

"Already thought of that, Wild Cat. I sent a strike team to search the Canyon days ago. We have been getting daily reports, but they've found nothing but weird rocks and vegetation." Scorpia shrugged.

"Idiots! Get your people out of there!" Sweet Bee exclaimed. "No one goes into the Dark Edge without Peekablue… you need Far Sight to navigate in there. If they go too deep, they will become lost in the shifting canyons!" Sweet Bee warned.

"That's why Huntara never wanted to go in there." Catra breathed, her eyes wide with sudden fear. The dark edge was magic, just like the Whispering Woods. Able to change suddenly and lead invaders astray, or clueless blondes to their Destiny.

"I'm on it!" Scorpia swiftly exited the cell, pulling down the forcefield with a tap of her claw tip on the sensor pad. Leaving Catra and Sweet Bee standing on either side of the cell glowering at each other.

After about twenty minutes of waiting for Scorpia to return. Catra was about to leave the cell to go track her down. Since sitting and having a staring contest with Sweet Bee was getting boring.

She was about to stand up and leave. When a soft clicking noise whispered from just beyond the cell. Not wanting to draw attention to the fact she had heard the intruder's. Catra turned to Sweet Bee, heaving a deep sigh. Pretending that she was getting annoyed at waiting.

"How long does it take to contact a strike team and give them new order's." Catra groused, raising up her knees and crossing her arms over them. Glancing down at Melog, tucked safely in her

satchel. Finding their red tint fading into a dull yellow, showing her moderate unease about the clicking noise and the ruse she was attempting.

Sweet Bee’s antenna vibrated, her eyes darting to the force field briefly before regarding Catra with an irritated huff. Adjusting her position as well, tucking her legs up and clutching her arms around her shins.

Catra knew she had heard them as well, she was already taking stock of all the Princesses' more obvious tells. She was preparing to leap to her feet at a moment's notice, same as Catra.

“That little magicat, Blue is with is the sweetest thing. So thoughtful and kind, but sad, you know.” Sweet Bee offered softly.

Catra snapped her eyes up instantly, narrowing them slightly as she sought to ascertain Sweet Bee’s intentions. Finding that all the vitriol and malice she once had towards her and Scorpia was gone. Replaced with a calm, tender, serenity.

“They sing all the time, have the most angelic voice I’ve ever heard. It’s obvious that they have Sunna blood in them, same as you.” Sweet Bee nodded towards Catra.

“How do you know about the Sunna?” Catra was shocked, she believed such knowledge had been lost.

“A thousand years ago, Meadow Lands closed its borders and its people retreated underground. Taking with them a vast array of treasures from all over Etheria, ancient texts from every kingdom and many First Ones relics. I know all about the ancient hybrids of Etheria, about the lost kingdoms of the Magicats. We kept all the knowledge and relics safely hidden within our subterranean hives. While your historians, toil in caves and ancient ruins. Struggling to piece together the ancient past. My people never left that past. We are the same as we were a thousand years ago. I know more

about Etheria’s ancient past than her present, I am afraid.” Sweet Bee laughed bitterly.

Catra blinked in awe. There was a trove of knowledge about her people, locked away in Meadow Lands. It was such amazing luck! She could learn about the Serena Savannah, about Ouroboros… her fire magic…all of it!

“You're worried about them, because they are one of your own. I get that, I worry about my people too. Even though I can't be there to protect them. But I trust the ones I left behind, to take care of each other.” Sweet Bee offered her a warm, genuine smile.

“We might be the last two Magicats on the planet.” Catra sighed, rubbing the back of her neck nervously. Suddenly feeling off balance and vulnerable stating that to Sweet Bee.

“Nope, just the Sunna are gone. But the other half of your people, your cousins, I guess. The Lunari. They went into hiding within Half Moon. The same time as my people. I don’t know where that is, but legend says they will return upon the next Great Conjunction.” Sweet Bee answered, her tone was honest and steady.

Catra eyes flared wide in surprise, she was desperate to keep Sweet Bee talking. She wanted to know more! The first question was…what the hell was a conjunction?

“Great Conjunction?” Catra muttered.

“Lots of magic is based upon the stars and the moon’s. The sorcerer’s in Mystacor perform powerful magic when certain Moons align.” Sweet Bee shrugged. “A Great Conjunction happens only once every thousand years, when all of Etheria’s moon’s line up.”

Catra nodded, now more eager to get back to Mystacor and learn as much as she could about magic.

“Have you ever been to the Elemental Basilica?” Catra asked.

Sweet Bee offered her a gentle, nostalgic smile.

“Of course, a long time ago. When I was just a hatchling. My father and mother took me on a pilgrimage. To visit all the ancient hybrid ruins here on the Mainland and the Basilica was our last stop before returning to the Royal Court. It was the last time I would see my parents so happy and carefree.” Sweet Bee began to reminisce about her family, her heritage and the history of her people. Finding comfort in speaking about her most treasured memories to someone else.

“You know family is so important. You take it for granted that they are just always going to be there. You know.” Sweet Bee’s had a ghost of a smile, her eyes nearly overflowing with tears. But she kept talking, through her grief and pain. Regaling Catra with the most beautiful and bitter sweet tales of her youth. Catra listened avidly, drawn into Sweet Bee’s tales of childish adventures. As she explored the Whispering Woods and Mystacor with her Parents. Getting in and out of mischief. Meeting new and interesting people from all over Etheria. All with the patience and commitment of two loving parents who were always looking out for her.

In time Catra forgot about the world around her, as Sweet Bee’s voice lulled her into a languid state. Her imagination compelled to overwhelm her rational mind. She was blissfully enraptured by her stories, as time seemed to have no meaning. Her thoughts dwelled upon the time she spent with her parents and her own people deep in the past. That heartfelt yearning to have grown up with them. Knowing she had missed out on so much. Never knowing their love, their kindness, never experiencing any of the small tender moments between parent and child. The ancient teachings of the Sunna Pride, she was born into. All lost to her, because they had locked her away in a statis pod. But somewhere out there was a distant branch of Magicats…She could find them? She could learn all the ancient secrets of her people from them. She could learn how to use her magic from the source…the Lunari…

Then suddenly the spell Sweet Bee had woven with her tales vanished. As she suspiciously fell silent. Sweet Bee pretended to stand and stretch. “Man, these cells are small. I have been getting all stiff just laying around in here.”

Catra blinked and sluggishly came back into awareness. Cursing herself, she had been so caught up in Sweet Bee’s revelations, that she had stopped listening for the clicks. With a frustrated growl, Catra jumped to her feet. Catching Sweet Bee’s smug smirk, just as the roof of the cell exploded over her head.

Catra had just enough time to swing her bag under her and shield her head with her arms. As she leaped aside, avoiding getting crushed by the four foot thick chunks of cement that rained down upon the center of the cell.

“Leif, Needle, Thorne. “ Sweet Bee dashed beneath the hole in the ceiling grinning up at her tiny rescuers. “About time you showed up!” She shouted indignantly. The three ant-men clicked their mandibles happily. As the smallest of them jumped down. His small, muscular legs rebound off a chunk of loose mortar. As he lands on the floor of the cell just before Sweet Bee, with a soft clang. Dashing to Sweet Bee’s side, already digging into a pouch on the utility belt draped across his chest for lockpicks. So that he could free his Princess from her cuffs.

Catra groaned, rolling over. The concussive blast had left her body trembling and her ears ringing. She finally had gathered enough of her wits to stand back up as the dust settled. Finding the cell empty.

“Damit !…” She snarled, slamming her palm against the door sensor. Canceling the force field and then storming out of the cell.

She was furious and embarrassed that Sweet Bee had turned the tables on her. Dropping the information that there might be magicats in hiding here in Etheria, so casually. Like it was common knowledge, but I guess in Meadow Lands it was. But to

Catra it had shaken her, filled her with hope. That she could reclaim some of the heritage and history she had lost. Suddenly she didn't feel so alone in the world. It was the perfect distraction and she hated that she fell for it! Like some sentimental sap! Shaking her head ruefully as she exited the cell, berating herself for going soft.

Sweet Bee had escaped onto the level above. Catra rushed to the open walkway, craning her head upward. To scan the curving walkway above, her keen hearing picked up the sharp clang of their feet echoing above. With a growl she leaped off the edge, as she heard the low hum of the elevator platform ascending, towards her level of the prison. She jumped into the void without fear. Landing in a crouch, her toes claws digging into the metal of the platform as she rode it upward. One of the guards on a higher level must have called the platform as it wasn't slowing as she reached the floor above.

"You are not getting away." Catra vowed, as she jogged to the edge of the platform and jumped just as it cleared the walkway above. Catra's pride was bruised at being distracted by Sweet Bee so easily. She was not going to let her get away!

The Return of Tung Lasor

Catra was running on all fours across the open balcony, of the upper most level of the prison. The intruder alarm was blaring, forcing her to flatten her ears against her head. Red light flashed across the floor from the sensor lights strobing to the rhythm of the alarm. The sinister red glow, illuminating the determined rage twisting Catra's features. Fueling her to run faster, leap and bound forward with all the power and speed her hybrid body could provide. As several fully armored guards were racing behind her, stun batons sparking in their hands.

Catra didn't wait for them, she sprinted down the cell block. Veering sharply for the open pit, when she heard the hum of another platform approaching. Leaping over the abyss, trusting that the platform would catch her. She landed with another loud clang, ascending upward without the backup of the guards.

She had lost track of her prey, but she knew where they were going.

The only way out of here was at the top of the pit. Where a thin metal awning spanned the open stadium like structure. The awning could split in half and be retracted into the edges of the pit. So that flying prison transports, like the Scorpion Cruiser could land inside.

The prison was over twenty stories high and towered over the mountains of metal scrap. That was scattered over the expansive junkyard that surrounded the prison. Evening was falling over the ruins of the Fright Zone. The first of the Greater Moon's peeking its silver crown over the industrial towers in the distance. Catra slowly crept upward, using her claws to maintain her precarious grip on the smooth metal of the awning. She could see the dark silhouette of four people standing at the peak. The soft clicking of those ant-men echoed in the dim gray light.

She kept low, stalking upward along the dome on all fours, her tail high and lashing. Her movements are slow and stealthy. Keeping hidden in the long shadows cast by the towers in the distance that crept over the apex of the awning. She suddenly stopped, pressing her stomach flat against the metal roof, as a new sound thrummed in the distance. Casting her keen gaze to the south, she caught sight of a skiff flying upward in an arc to align with the top of the dome. A red scaled lizard kin was manning the rutter. He must be Sweet Bee's second in command that got captured trying to protect her. Looks like the Ant-men had broken him out first and sent him to find them an escape vehicle.

She had run out of time, there was no reason to stay hidden. With a snarl she lunged forward. Her back claws dug into the metal as she raced towards the four figures standing on the top of the roof. With the crimson glow of sunset gleaming behind them.

Sweet Bee spun in fright, as Catra roared in fury, closing in fast. The tallest Ant moved to stand in front of her. His stubby segmented tail, snapping with threat.

Catra understood that signal, thanks to Scorpia. That ant had a poisonous tail, she skidded and veered to the right. Just in time to avoid getting stung.

Agitated clicks issued from the smallest ant, who was now digging into the large pockets of his utility belt.

"Forget it, Leif…just get to the skiff. Thorne! Let's go!" Sweet Bee shouted at the largest Ant, while grabbing the two smaller ants and holding them against her chest. As she leapt into the air. Her wings fluttered, quickly picking up speed until they were a blur on her back. As she hovered, slowly ascending into the open air, heading for the skiff.

Catra hissed and leaped upward, intending on swatting the bug out of the sky.

When suddenly she heard a loud snap, followed by a sharp pain around her ankle then a hard tug. That sent her violently downward. She landed deftly back on all fours, glaring at her ankle that was hooked by a long red scaly tail. It unfurled and snapped away in an instant.

“Looks like it's my lucky, lucky day!” A deep, gravelly voice mocked from just out of sight along the curve of the dome. Silhouetted by the setting sun, a large imposing figure strode arrogantly into view. He didn’t look much different then the last time she had tangled with him. Just older and sporting a new outfit. Still preferring to wear an open vest with shredded arms. Proudly displaying his burly tan chest and abs. He was now wearing green combat pants, with large pockets. Tucked into heavy, black boots. His claws were still wrapped in cloth to protect them when he fought. He hadn’t lost any of that unearned confidence. He was still a brute, still a brawler. The smug, arrogance still stained his toothy grin.

“You're still alive!” Catra gasped, a part of her was relieved. She had felt guilty for years about his fate. Since she had so callously left him in a sand pit to die.

“No, thanks to you!” Tung snarled back, powerful arms raised, claws extended to shred Catra on the spot. His yellow eyes narrowed in loathing, as he caught sight of the leather jacket she wore. That sported the symbol of his long disbanded gang. Mocking him for all that he had lost, all that she had taken from him. He vowed to take his jacket back, off her cold, dead corpse.

Catra stood up and adjusted her stance, widening her legs and raising up her own claws. She would not attack…at least not yet.

“I crawled out of that death trap on my own! Made a promise to myself, that if I ever ran across you again…I would kill you!” Tung Lashor snarled, coming at her hard and fast. In seconds, they were engaged in a fierce back and forth of hand to hand combat. Blocking and striking at blinding speeds, each one vying for first blood with their claws.

“You took everything from me!” He bellowed accusingly. Catra had remained on the defensive, blocking his attacks and refusing to retaliate.

“I was the laughing stock of the Waste. I couldn’t get work as a thug or even a raider for rival gangs. Trying to get a drink at the “Oasis” was near impossible. I was always having to fend off some young punk trying to make a name for themselves, thinking I was an easy mark!” He complained, the fury burning in his eyes was painful to see. Catra could relate to needing to prove oneself, after being humiliated. His attacks became less strategic and more desperate. Than a low clicking announced the largest Ant hadn’t retreated like Sweet Bee had commanded. Catra snapped her head to the side, finding the Ant flanking her on her left. She was now pinned between two adversaries.

Which was fine…she could handle two on one odds.

“Hey, there little buddy.” Tung nodded towards the ant. “Looks like you're outnumbered, Kitty cat.” he taunted, swinging his claws at her stomach.

Catra easily avoided the slash, by shifting her body to the side.

Catra shrugged, “Doesn’t matter, I can take you both on. You’ve already proven to be less than a threat. Tung Lashor!” She taunted back with a snide cackle. Falling back on one of her best weapons when in an unfair fight. Her smart ass mouth, that could enrage an opponent and make them sloppy.

Tung hadn’t gotten any better at combat. He’s strikes were still easy to forecast. His attacks were blunt, sweeping slashes of his claws or tail. He never deviated from his simple brawling tactics that he had used back in the Waste. He was not very fast, or agile. Depending on his superior strength to subdue his opponent. Catra had picked up on that fast enough during their first fight. She had too much pride to just let him win. He had years to train, if he had wanted to take this rematch seriously. But he seemed like he had just just gotten comfortable again, as part of Sweet

Bee's crew. The lizard man growled and then lunged, swiping the claws of his left hand at Catra's throat.

Catra's mocking laughter echoed over the dome. As she easily leaps into the air. Curling into a forward flip and rebounding off his shoulder blades like a professional acrobat. Her weight and the momentum of her kick, slamming the lizard-kin onto the dome on his stomach. Pissing people off was a natural talent she had cultivated growing up. One she used to give herself an advantage when fighting a hot headed foe.

"Boring…" Catra yawned. "I was honestly hoping you would be more of a challenge this time." She placed her hands on her hips, cocking them sassily. As she offered him a dismissive shrug.

Tung Lashor snapped his tail, attempting to use it as a whip like he did before to wrap her ankle. He had caught her off guard before, but never again. She jumped, but just high enough not to get caught by his tail. But unfortunately, she jumped too close to the advancing Ant-man. Who snapped out his stubby tail in retaliation. She narrowly avoided getting stung, bouncing backward on her toes, as soon as she landed and twisting away. Landing on all fours, glancing in a panic down at her pouch. As it swung wildly back and forth across her hips, worried she might have tossed Melog out.

Releasing a relieved breath when she found him, glowing bright red within. His ball-like shape had changed slightly in the last few minutes. Now he had two pointed cat ears and tiny paws jutting out of his blob like body. With needle sharp, tiny claws, latched into the cloth in a death grip.

(Mew?) Melog inquired, nervously in Catra's mind. As he craned his large round head upward, when he noticed the flap being pulled aside. Showing Catra his rudimentary cat like face, with two bright blue button shaped eyes and a flat nose and short snout with long whiskers. That were now vibrating in agitation at being jostled around so violently.

“Hang on tight, ok.” Catra ordered, flipping the flap closed again to focus on her fight. She dashed in low to the Ant-man, spinning on the balls of her feet and swiping her leg at his ankles. The Ant squealed in alarm, but was not fast enough to evade and was quickly sent off his feet. He crashed to the dome. Unable to gather his balance, he slid away down the decline.

“Thorne!” Tung cried, disengaging from the fight to chase after his little comrade. Who was now slipping down the dome with frantic clicks, heading out of control for the edge and a very long drop to his death.

“Well, that was easy.” Catra chuckled, jogging to the edge of the curve. Her proud smile faltered, when she caught sight of the skiff parked just below.

“Well, that's just perfect.” She growled, watching in disgust as Tung Lashor had managed to grab the Ant-man and tuck him against his side. As they both now slid down to the Skiff and leaped on.

Sweet Bee was at the helm and the other two Ant-Men were at the bow keeping an eye on the prison’s outer yard below. Pointing and clicking in panic.

As several soldier’s burst out of the main doors to the open tarmac that bordered the scrapyard. They unlatched their energy rifles from their back and let loose a barrage of fire upon the skiff.

Catra was unwilling to jump into the crossfire of that barrage, so she stood stiffly upon the apex of the dome. Watching Sweet Bee ignite the engines and swing the Skiff at a sharp angle. So the side of the boat caught the onslaught of energy bolts and not the engines, that the soldier’s had been aiming at. She gunned the skiff, just as the nose swung away. Rocketing away towards the North-west and quickly disappearing beyond the slender smoke stacks of the refinery on the far side of the fortress. Catra stood in awe, that Andreenid was an expert pilot! She knew exactly

what the soldiers were aiming at. She had adjusted the skiff's position, mid-flight to protect the more vulnerable part then shot off at top speed. Able to maneuver through the dense maze of buildings and towers of the Fortress that surrounded the prison. All while gaining altitude until she was free of any obstacles.

With an exasperated huff, Catra deflated upon the top of the dome and just quietly sat and watched the sunset. Resting her arms on her raised knees, leaning forward with her head hanging low in exhaustion. Aldarion was sinking into the barren canyon's of the Dark Edge, far beyond the Fortress. Setting the lower clouds crowding around the horizon on fire. Catra knew it was time to sing her farewell, but she just didn't have it in her tonight.

(mew?) A soft cry floated into her brain, along with a question.

"I'm fine, Melog. Just tired." She responded, dipping a hand into the pouch to give her companion an affectionate scratch behind his new little ears.

The vibrant chime of Glimmer's teleport announced her arrival atop the dome.

"Where did she go!" She shouted, glowering down at Catra as she hovered over her. Then snapping her head back and forth, hoping to catch sight of the Bee Hybrid.

"Let her go, Sparkles. She doesn't know anything anyway." Catra released a long suffering sigh.

"Wait…what…?" Glimmer sputtered, her twisting and turning coming to a halt. As she gave up trying to spot Sweet Bee in the distance.

"She earned it, just let her go." Catra pulled her knees up even more and pressed them against her chest. Squinting her eyes

towards the fiery glare of the sun, as it dipped behind the metal towers in the distance.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes in confusion, then simply sat down beside her. Taking Catra's subtle cues that she needed a friend right now. They had spent a long time on the Velvet Glove getting to know each other. Catra had come and sat in front of her cell many times, hugging her knees. It was a sign she needed companionship but was too proud to admit it.

"Alright , Horde Scum. Spill." Glimmer got right to the point, keeping her gaze firmly on the sunset. So Catra didn't feel pressured to answer right away.

It took a few minutes of heavy silence before the hybrid spoke.

"You guys have made me soft." She complained, her tone bitter.

Glimmer merely laughed, adjusting her position to get more comfortable as the conversation was going to take awhile. Pulling up one knee and wrapping her arms around her ankle. Resting her cheek on her raised knee, she regarded Catra with a warm, caring smile.

"That's a bad thing?" She giggled, fondly.

Catra scoffed and cast Glimmer a dirty glare, before stubbornly returning her gaze upon the sunset.

"Sweet Bee tricked me, got me to let my guard down…somehow. Told me a story about another Pride of Magicats…The Lunari…who went into hiding in a place called Half Moon." Catra began.

Glimmer listened patiently, her mother had spun tales of Half Moon to her as a tiny child at bedtime. She merely nodded, it had been a long time since those stories and she had forgotten about them until now.

"She got me daydreaming about finding them, becoming a part of their….aw….whatever." Catra growled, as tears of longing pooled

in her eyes. Sneaking a sideways glance at Glimmer as her cheeks flared with humiliation. Finding the Queen was wearing a sweet, endearing smile.

“Family?” She quipped.

“Let it go, Sparkles. I’m done talking about it.” Catra snarled back, she wasn’t going to get her hopes up. It would only hurt more later when her hopes never panned out. Yearning for something that might never happen was stupid.

“It has been a really, really, really long time since I thought about the Lunari. My mom told me stories about them…they had settled around Sky Dancer Mountain and built a majestic Kingdom. Their last Queen, C'yra. Ruled Bright Moon and led her people into hiding in a mysterious place known as Half Moon. The lake that surrounds Bright Moon Castle is called Half Moon Lake. The Lunari disappeared over a thousand years ago. During Mara’s time, they were a peaceful people and refused to fight the First Ones. My mom took up the crown as Queen of Bright Moon in their absence. “ Glimmer began, as Catra listened with rapt attention. As she began to retell her some of the heroic tales she had been told as a child. Aldarion abandoned the sky, as Glimmer spun wondrous stories of mystical lore, full of the honor, love and strength of perseverance. All centered around the powerful, magical Queen of the Lunari…C'yra. Catra was quickly enraptured by this mysterious, whimsical, yet indomitable figure from the past. The Greater Moons slowly began to ascend. As the upper reaches of the sky began to darken and the star’s began to shine.

In time Glimmer’s stories faded into a companionable silence. They sat next to each other, unconsciously pressing their backs against one another. Watching the sky as it filled with stars. The simple metal poles, with hanging lamps that lined the streets and the courtyard below came alive. As the guard shifts changed yet again. A battalion of over twenty soldier’s entered the prison, marching in formation. A few minutes later, soldier’s began to trickle out in small groups. They were now off duty and were far

less serious. Laughing and joking with one another as they made plans, or discussed going back to their tents to relax.

Catra lazily dragged her eyes from the night sky. Observing the soft lights blinking on the tower's in the distance and the glow of the many small windows that speckled the walls of the warehouses within the scrapyard below. They could hear the dull roar of engines, as cargo hauler's and runner's made their rounds through the streets. This atmosphere of hushed productivity and armed patrols along the streets was a strange comfort for her.

Scorpania was quickly becoming a kingdom once again. Some aspects of the Fortress were already back in working order. Such as a few factories, the foundry and the refinery. The Forge had taken the brunt of the destruction and was taking some time to get rebuilt. Scorpia's focus had changed in the last few weeks as well. Her resources were now divided between producing and manufacturing materials for the rebuilding effort. To repair their armaments and restocking their military weaponry. Scorpia had brought the survivors of the Etherian Horde back together and gave them purpose. They were becoming a powerful force that could change the course of Etheria. It was as awe inspiring as it was terrifying.

"Turns out Tung Lashor was Sweet Bee's second in command. I could have fought him harder, I could have made sure Sweet Bee didn't get away. But my heart just wasn't in it." Catra confessed with a shrug, finally breaking the silence.

"He was that gang leader you told me about?" Glimmer inquired softly.

"Yeah, I left him for dead out in the Crimson Waste. I'm glad he's still alive, that's one less regret." Catra smirked, laying back against the awning and crossing her arms under her head. To admire the infinite blanket of stars, twinkling in the dark backdrop of the sky high above.

Glimmer craned her head up and watched the night set in. Allowing the heavy silence to remain between them, enjoying the moment of gentle contemplations passing between them. It wasn't awkward or nerve wracking being around Catra anymore, like it was in the beginning. Glimmer now felt calm, relaxed and comforted in her presence. Their banter had changed from the mean and hurtful words they flung at each other before the Velvet Glove. To smart ass remarks and truthful jabs at their less than stellar past at being decent people. Neither of them allowed the other to wallow in their own bullshit. They called each other out, made one another accountable. When they were being petty, spiteful or simply just stubborn. Or like now, not allowing the other to sink into self loathing.

"Still beating yourself up over every little mistake?" Glimmer commented dryly.

"Always." Catra smirked.

"Good, keeps you out of trouble." Glimmer turned and gave her a smart ass grin over her shoulder. Before flopping down beside her.

Catra rolled her eyes, but smiled softly.

"Keeping up to your dastardly plan's during the war was absolutely exhausting." Glimmer moaned, "So glad you're on our side now."

Catra smiled and nodded. Accepting Glimmer's teasing compliment.
"Well, it wasn't hard to out smart you guys. You three seemed to share a single brain cell most of the time." Catra sassed back, unfolding her arms from behind her head and resting them back down near her hips.

"Thanks." Glimmer grumbled. "But as I recall, you got your ass handed to you on a regular basis, thanks to She-Ra." Glimmer smirked. "I got you pretty good a few times as well." Glimmer

surveyed her fingernails, with a pompous, self satisfied gleam in her eyes.

“Yeah, well fighting a eight-foot tall sword lady with overpowered magic was never a fair fight. The rest was just blind luck. You guys, go to. Was to annoyingly. Get in my way and wing it!” Catra laughed. “I was surprised you guys survived most of the time.”

“Yeah, planning was not our strong suit.” Glimmer admitted. “But you have to admit it worked in our favor most of the time.”

“Up for debate.” Catra countered.

“Are we seriously going to hash out every battle to see who had more wins?” Glimmer laughed.

“Maybe later, for right now. I just want to appreciate the fact that we are both still breathing.” Catra sighed heavily.

“Yeah, we’ve had too many close calls recently.” Glimmer admitted quietly.

“Likely many more ahead of us.” Catra groused.

“Don’t want to think about that.” Glimmer’s moaned.

Catra’s eyes widened in surprise as she felt Glimmer slip her hand in hers, threading their fingers together.

“You can count on me, to always have your back. You know that right? ” She promised.

“Yeah, I got you too. Sparkles.” Catra rolled her head to the side and smiled fondly at Glimmer. Who returned her smile with one of her own. As Catra started to purr softly.

“Like I told Adora years ago. Bad things are going to happen. That’s life. You can let it paralyze you…or you can roll with it. Figure out the things you can…and trust that your friends have

your back for the rest.” Glimmer stated, her voice clear and determined.

Catra couldn’t help but sniff, struggling to hold back her tears. Suddenly overwhelmed by Glimmer’s support and gentle affection.

“Yep…I’ve gotten soft.” Catra muttered, giving Glimmer’s hand a squeeze.

“That is not a bad thing.” Glimmer professed ardently.

By the time the Greater Moon’s were ascending over the towers They had given Scorpia the bad news that Sweet Bee got away. She didn’t seem upset about it. She had her own plans for moving forward, with her kingdom and with herself. At this point she was fine with it. As Sweet Bee had no intention of interfering in her mission to Meadow Lands. It seemed the wayward Princess of the Anteenid’s had no plans of ever setting foot in her Kingdom ever again.

They had left Bow with Darla, in the Fortress with Brojee and his crew. They were still not done scavenging parts. The amount of junk in the cargo hold had grown tenfold in the last couple of days. Bow and Brojee had been holed up in the Engineering labs of the ship. As Brojee was currently teaching him about current Horde tech and helping him develop a new type of bow to shoot energy bolt's instead of arrows. So he was happily on a mission of his own. Glimmer and Catra had their own mission to attend to… learning how to use their magic back at Mystacor.

So now Catra was laying in the giant four poster bed back in her quarter’s at the apprentice dorms of the Elemental Basilica. Groaning and holding her stomach, as it twisted and rolled after another very unpleasant teleport. Glimmer had rushed off to the kitchen to fetch her something to settle her stomach.

She needed to call Adora, frowning at her pack leaning against the fireplace she opted to wait till later. If she moved right now, she knew she was going to throw up. With a queasy moan she rolled onto her back, flopping an arm over her eyes seeking to block out the world. Wanting only to wallow in her misery. Until a soft, inquiring meow invaded her thoughts.

(mew?) Melog chirped, as a sweet enquiry to her well being entered her mind. A pleased smile pulled on her lips as she felt a warm, soft, fuzzy, blob press up against her side. Melog had used his stubby paws to crawl out of his pouch. That she sat at the corner of the bed and was now snuggling contentedly against her hip.

"Mom!" Finn's exuberant voice exploded into the room just as the door slammed open.

Catra bolted upright, startled by the loud noise as much as Finn's exclamation of her new title. This was the first time he had called her mother and her heart warmed at the sound of it, yet her rational mind was screaming that perhaps being this kid's mom was beyond her abilities. She could easily screw him up even more with all her own issues. Her own mother figure had left some pretty deep emotional scars that she was still healing from.

"I missed you!" Finn bounded across the room, his hooves clicking against the stone floor. Then he flung himself across the bed and wrapped her up in the warmest, most loving hug she had ever experienced.

"Woah…there kid…ok, we're good. We're good…" Catra laughed, sounding happy yet nervous at the same time. As she hugged him with one arm, the other tucking Melog in closer to her side. To protect the blob from Finn's pressing body.

Finn pulled away, his cheeks flushed with glee. His smile slowly faded as he noticed the orange glowing orb staring back up at him with beady electric blue eyes.

“Who’s that?” Finn asked, innocently.

“It’s Melog.” Catra answered.

Melog opened his rudimentary feline mouth. Showing Finn a set of sharp little teeth and long fangs. Then sneezed, licked a stubby paw and started to groom himself behind a pointy ear.

Finn giggled.

“He got hurt and he is healing right now, He should be back to normal eventually.” Catra assured him.

“He’s sooooo cute!” Finn cooed, then slapped his hands over his mouth. Eyes wide in horror and guilt as if he had just swore.

He glanced timidly at Catra wondering if he was in trouble.

“It’s ok, kid. I think he’s cute too.” She ruffled his hair, affectionately.

“Did you have any supper?” Finn slid his butt onto the bed in the back corner not wanting to crowd the little blob now that he knew they were there.

“Not yet, Sparkles is bringing me back something from the kitchen to settle my stomach.” Catra adjusted her pillow and Adora’s behind her. Relaxing against the headboard in a semi reclined position.

“K…” Finn was fidgeting with his finger’s as if he was trying to work out the courage to confess something. His eyes kept darting around the room no doubt looking for Adora.

“Adora’s fine. She is just going to be gone for a little while longer, if that’s what you're worrying about asking.” Catra added, the tell tale anxiety about losing someone he cared about, was very apparent in Finn’s behavior.

Finn nodded, releasing a held breath.

“I am sure Sparkles will bring her back for a visit in a few days.” Catra added, which finally returned the smile on Finn’s face.

The little boy nodded then slipped off the bed. Heading over to his bedroll in the corner and retrieving his book. Then he hauled the giant book to the chair by the fireplace and proceeded to start reading and sketching with a thin piece of charcoal. That Catra had figured he had taken from the now cold, fire box.

“Worried she might be dead?” Catra inquired softly when the silence had hung between them for too long.

“Kinda…lost my mom and dad pretty suddenly during the war. So, yeah…I don’t like it when people I am expecting to return home….don’t.” He responded, still avoiding looking at her. Focusing on his drawing instead.

Catra’s eyebrows raised upward in confusion. Last time she had spoken to Finn about his parents back in the field after she had blown up the First Ones Ruins. He had mentioned he had two moms…?

When he finally looked up to give her a small smile, Catra masked her emotions behind a warm smile of her own. She had noticed little inconsistencies with Finn, ever since the crisis of Mystacor nearly falling out of the sky. At first she had just chalked it up to him dealing with the trauma of the event. Now she wasn’t quite sure. He never called her Grumpy Cat anymore…it was now Mom. Which was endearing yet strange. He was always writing and doodling in that book. Unwilling to share what he was working on, professing that it held secrets. He was working on some secret surprise, that was all she knew. She hadn’t heard him sing, which was something he used to do regularly even if it was just humming to himself. Now his story about his parents was different? What was going on?

Let there be Light

Sunset was nothing more than a glowing ember upon the distant hills. By the time they reached the valley once again. Spirit was slowly making his way down the face of the valley, his gait steadily heading towards the stream. That ran through the central forest at the valley's center. Adora sat stiffly upon his back, rolling her shoulders and arching her back. She was sore from riding all day, but refused to ask Spirit to stop. Anxious to get to the Crystal Castle and uncover all of She-Ra's secrets. That Light Hope had kept hidden from her. The hologram's manipulation and half truths about Mara, lingered like a bitter after taste upon her heart. Even though she had redeemed herself in the end, fighting the First Ones programming and sacrificing herself to save Etheria. Adora was left wrestling with the grueling, yet confusing emotions of both despising her and feeling grateful at the same time. Shadow Weaver's sacrifice for her and Catra, burned the same in her heart. With a groaning sigh, she rolled her shoulders again seeking to brush off the tangled thoughts. Unwilling to try and unknot her feelings towards Light Hope and Shadow Weaver while traveling. There would be time enough to deal with all that when she got the Crystal Castle.

As the last of the light faded behind the hills. Adora watched the stars slowly appear within the darkest portions of the sky, high above. As the new growth of trees slowly began to surround them as they entered the fringe of the massive forest. The saplings soon replaced by older growth. Soon a vast canopy of branches and lush leaves, was spider webbing above their heads. Fragmenting the starscape, as they moved into the deeper shadows of the sprawling woods.

Spirit grunted and huffed indignantly, as they reached the stream. The banks here were now marshy from a recent rain. His hooves began squelching disturbingly as he trudged through the soft ground. As they sank into the mud, every now and then one hoof would stick tight and he would have to use all his strength to pull his leg out. His legs were soon covered in thick, black mud all the

way up to his knees. He stubbornly struggled forward along the bank, refusing to climb higher into the obviously drier, upper reaches of the forest. Where the trees were far older and even more crowded, narrowing this foot path to almost nothing but worn animal trails. He would be forced to step over twisted roots and loose leaf litter, as he climbed up into the forest above the river. Which was far more treacherous, as he could stumble and twist an ankle in the half light of evening. He had a route in mind, to navigate more smoothly across the valley. He had no plans to deviate from it. Heading towards the Grand Willow a few miles away, that was the perfect place for Adora to set up camp. The tree roots had kept the river at bay, creating a wide bank of dry, rocky ground that was higher than the rest of the area. The small, flat meadow just above the creek, receded into the young trees that surrounded the Willow. It was secluded and protected and had a wonderful view of an amazing waterfall that cascaded down from the upper reaches of the forest.

"Spirit, maybe we can find another way through the valley?" Adora inquired, glancing down at the bloated stream rushing past them. It was moving a lot faster now then when she had passed through the valley with her Squad Mates days earlier. The rain, swelling the river and turning the banks into this boggy mess. Either way, she did not want Spirit to keep fighting with the mud and exhaust himself.

It took the horse several more minutes of fighting to go forward before finally conceding.

Spirit nickered in agreement, turning and trudging up the rocky hillside to higher ground. He was disheartened and kept his head low in defeat. Keeping a close eye on where he placed his hooves. Slowly ascending deeper into the forest, following a narrow trail created by small animals. Weaving through the thick overgrowth of berry bushes, that crowded around the trees. Climbing over the top of a small rise, Adora glanced back over her shoulder. Her eyes instantly spotted the regal, lavender crown of the massive Willow Tree amid a blanket of verdant green forest. A tendril of smoke snaked its way through the bowing branches. She instantly

realized that Levi and Max were already camped in their old spot. Her chest suddenly felt heavy, her heart aching with grief. She sighed heavily and forced herself to look forward once more. It would do no good to dwell upon things she could not change.

The heat of the day had cooled as night fell. Adora quickly wrapped her marron cloak tightly around herself. Spirit didn't seem to be stopping, moving through the labyrinth forest as if guided by an invisible thread. He knew where he was going, even if she had become totally lost in the dark.

After a time the ground began rising more sharply, becoming more barren as the tree's thinned back into the sparse groves of saplings. They had reached the edge of the valley and were soon ascending towards the rolling fields beyond. The Greater and Lesser moon's held court above their heads as the night drew on. The fathomless expanse of space, shimmered in the open sky. Adora was drawn to the stars. Casting her head back, losing herself to the starlight. It was so beautiful, yet so humbling as well. Her people's language came from the stars, it was the only touchstone she had to the First Ones. She had come from somewhere in that endless cosmos…She wondered if perhaps one of those twinkling lights might be Eternia?

The lonely hours beyond midnight set in. As Adora huddled upon Spirit's back, lost to her tangled thoughts. So many conflicting desires were swirling inside of her. Another conflict seemed to be hovering in the future. Either with these Mutants and Omega Prime. Or with this Lord Skeletor and his plans with the Crystal of Kaydak. Or perhaps other planets whose ancient agenda still lay upon Etheria's soil. Etheria had been a part of this Universe for countless eon's before Mara stranded them in Despondos. It was all so overwhelming to think about. Yet this time she found, she wasn't as driven by purpose as she was before. She just wanted time to breathe, to enjoy peace and to be with Catra. She found herself fantasizing more and more about running away with her. Seeking to hide in some safe secret place in which they could

spend their day's simply loving each other. It was selfish and totally unrealistic, she knew she would never run from her duties as She-Ra. But it comforted her nonetheless.

So many worries, doubts and fears plagued her. About her magic, its origin and her place in the universe's grand design. Sheana and Despara…primordial beings of pure magic…who had chosen her body…her soul, as their host. She had earned their trust and their power. She was the rightful heir to She-Ra's magic. Not just because she had First Ones blood, like she had been led to believe. That didn't matter. But because she had proven to them that she had a good heart. She was honorable, strong and brave. She had earned their trust and proven again and again that she could wield the power of She-Ra for the greater good of all.

Yet now she was unbalanced, she could no longer summon She-Ra as she once did. Her sense of purpose is muddied by selfish desires and resentments. A rage she never knew she kindled, had burned inside of her heart for years. Had finally surge forth in the bowels of Beast Island. Summoning only the dark side of her magic. So a compromise had been made, the powers had divided and restrained themselves upon her wrists. The war had taken its toll on her spirit and her body. She was tired, both physically and mentally. She needed time to rest, to train, to learn the truths about her powers that she had never been told.

Yet the universe and the sins of the past would not wait for her to be whole again. They were running out of time. Two many threats to deal with, too many unknowns to worry about, too many secrets, just too much of everything…she felt scattered and unfocused and scared. She couldn't be any of those things....cause Etheria needed She-Ra, not Adora…they could not get through this without the Princess of Power. Once again, Adora was lacking, failing in her duties to protect her friends…this planet. She needed to find her answers and a way forward that didn't put her friends in danger. She needed to fix herself, she was broken and until she managed to balance herself. She-Ra could not be summoned.

She needed to get to the Crystal Castle, learn all that she could from what was left of the data banks there. Train and become stronger, find that balance she had lost and reclaim her full powers before Etheria was embroiled into yet another galactic war.

Perhaps Spirit had sensed the urgency, churning within her and that was why he was plodding steadfast through the night. Following the Wailing River's course northward. Heading unerringly towards the Whispering Woods far in the distance.

Primes communication spire ascended towards the dark sky. A violent, silver monolith cutting upward like a mighty spear. The sharp prongs at its base piercing the ground and fanning outward like the pommel of a sword. Disrupting the flat landscape of Scorpania's wide fields with its ominous presence. Once dull and lifeless after the war. The strange alien metal of the towering structure was now gleaming in the pale moonlight. A faint lavender glow accenting the smooth, sharp angles showing that the spire was once again activated.

It instantly caught Adora's attention, she gripped Spirits wither's and pressed her heels into his side to get him to stop. The horse knickered softly, prancing in place as he too took note of the powered spire that lay just ahead of them.

Adora silently dismounted, pulling her pack off his back and slipping it on.

"Let's check this out " She whispered, patting him reassuringly on the cheek as she passed. There wasn't much in the way of cover, here on the bald, flat prairie. So she hunched down as best as she could, moving slow and cautious towards the Spire.

As they closed in, two clones could be seen hovering around the steel, double doors of the entrance. They were dressed as commoner's with cloth pants, leather shoes and simple button up

shirts. The most telling piece of clothing was the white shoulder capes and hoods, that still bore the black horde symbol. That was the last remnant of their robes as acolytes of Prime. They had their hoods pulled up, which was pretty much a universal symbol. That they were up to no good. One clone was guarding the door. Standing vigilant with an old Etherian Horde mace in his hand. While the second clone was splicing the wires of the main control panel behind them. That was mounted in the alcove beside the door.

"Odd…" Adora muttered. One clone was armed, which set off red flags. Two, the spire had power and they didn't have security access to get inside. Which meant they were not working for Entrapta. Which now had a warning klaxon sounding in her head. As the front doors hummed to life and pulled aside. Adora stood upright in alarm. When the clones slipped inside. She lunged forward, calling for Despara's sword. Her silver wrist bracer flashed and faded away. A long, broad sword appeared before her reaching hand. The heavy blade glowing with power, illuminating the field before her as she ran.

Spirit snapped his teeth onto the tail of her cloak, as it fluttered upward. In her sudden jolt forward to run. Adora cried out in alarm as she was jerked backward. Losing her concentration, the sword faded away reappearing on her wrist as the silver bracer. As she landed hard on her butt, amid the tall wild grass.

"Spirit, let me go!" She chastised, glaring back at her horse indignantly.

Spirit snorted, tossing his muzzle sharply towards the Spire.

Adora turned abruptly, as the angry shouts of a mob broke the silence of the night. Her eyes widening in both alarm and concern. As several commoner's converged upon the spire, with pitchforks and torches.

"Those clones are not a part of Entrapta's collection…" Adora scowled and paused, that was a poor choice of words. After

everything the clones had endured under Prime for a millenia. They deserved to be seen as individuals and not as mindless objects, owned by another person.

"Entrapta seemed to have gotten the Spires powered up again. So she could enhance..expand…the Watchtower sensor's." Adora muttered. "I need to know what those two are up to?" She nodded, staring at the Spire with grim determination.

Spirit snorted and tossed his head towards the raging crowd.

Silently reminding Adora that she had a whole crowd of angry Etherians to deal with before she even reached the front doors.

"Looks like I am going to need a distraction." She gave Spirit a sly smile.

Spirit huffed and rolled his eyes.

Adora was known for her crazy plans, but this…this was way beyond crazy, this was insane!

It had taken a little time to gather the necessary materials from the fields and riverbank. Stacking, weaving and knotting. Branches from nearby trees, cat tail stocks from the river, flowers from the fields and whatever else she managed to find. Draping her cloak now blanketed with all the debris, over Spirit's back. Flipping the hood over his ears and creating a piecemeal bog monster that could only be believable in the dark of night.

"Perfect!" Adora braced her hands on her hips and grinned proudly at her monstrous creation. Dressed in only her white long sleeve shirt and gray pants with her knee length travel boots. She had her Bright Moon, wing pin now secured to the top of her shoulder strap for her quarter staff.

Spirit flapped his lips against his teeth. Unsure if this was going to work. Slowly lowering his head so the debris hid most of his horse body. It was a valiant attempt but his rear and tail were still visible.

As he walked slowly towards the spire, he blended into the landscape like a moving mound of earth. In the darkness of the night he had become almost invisible.

Adora watched him approach the shouting crowd, crossing her fingers. Hoping that he scared them off easily. At first they had just stood there, staring as Spirit crept closer. Adora struggled to remain optimistic, when the crowd became curious and not frightened. The war had definitely changed the common Etherian. They had been fighting for far too long and were no longer spooked by things that seemed strange or unnatural. Moving to surround Spirit, poking the debris with the prongs of their pitchforks instead. Their torches got way too close to the debris as they leaned down to investigate.

"No…crap…" Adora muttered, charging down the open field. She never took the torches into account. Terrible visions of the torches, setting fire to poor Spirit. Running rampant through her mind. She had made it only a few meter's closer to the Spire, when that exact thing happened.

A young man, barely out of his teens, had crouched low, near Spirits backend. His torch ignited the cotton of a cattail bulb, sticking out further than the rest upon the hem of her cloak. Which quickly spread to all the rest of the stalks, fanning out over Spirits hindquarters. The soft, easily combustible cotton, flared and then exploded like a massive fireball. Raining flames down upon the now frightened crowd and poor Spirit. The Etherian's cried out and ran off into the night, as Spirit whinnied in terror, kicking the remains of the flaming cloak off and racing towards the river to put out his singed backend.

Adora's plan as always had gone sideways, but still to her advantage. She was able to creep past the fleeing crowd, using

the darkness as a cover. Reaching the front doors of the Spire without being stopped. She paid Spirit a concerned glance, finding the horse submerged in the river up to his neck. Blowing bubbles of irritation at her, her cloak smoldering into ash on the edge of the riverbank. Adora cringed in remorse, hoping Spirit wasn't too badly hurt. She would heal him up soon.

She quickly fiddled with the wires in the control panel to activate the doors and slipped inside. The long twisting corridor's reminded her of the halls within the Velvet Glove. They were enormous, with vaulted intersections and grand archways. The tiny spot lights embedded high up along the walls, glowing faintly. Creating a creepy, sterile, tomb-like atmosphere. Her boot steps echoed, eerily as she wandered the lonely, empty corridors.

Adora swallowed, calling Despara's sword into her hand for protection. Her eyes darted into every nook and open room she passed. Nervous that the robotic sentinels that usually patrolled around and within these spires during the war might still be active.

It was the harsh, frustrated voices that drew her into a massive room. She quickly took stock of her surroundings, finding that she had entered a factory of some sort. Dominated by a wide, conveyor belt, flanked by hundreds of automated robotic arms that were attached to the walls. Each arm had three long finger claws. They were frantically pulling robot components and parts from the large bins located beside the belt. Several Sentinels stood upon the belt, each one was partially assembled and completely different in design. As if the creator had gotten bored halfway through the construction and restarted a new bot behind it. The two clones were arguing at a control console at the end of the belt on the far side of the room.

"That was an absolutely terrible idea Brother." One clone complained, pushing the other away from the console. Typing swiftly upon the keypad to instruct the robot arms with new directives.

“No, Brother it is you who had the terrible idea.” The Second clone spat vehemently, shoving his twin away from the console.

“I am the only reason you got out of there alive, those unreasonably angry Etherian’s would have surely killed you.” The other clone antagonized. Folding his arms over his chest and frowned with disapproval at his twin.

“You are the reason we went to that farm in the first place!” The second clone, exclaimed. Folding his arms over his chest and frowning with disapproval at his twin.

Adora listened to them argue for a bit as she approached. Figuring out quickly that they were both so busy fighting with one another. Neither was paying any attention to the conveyor belt, currently clogged with half built Sentinel’s, let alone a sole intruder in their midst.

“The flaw was in its design..” The first clone tapped his chin pondering the dilemma.

“The flaw was in its primary algorithm.” The Second corrected, returning to the programming console. Only to get shoulder bumped out of the way by the First Clone. Which instantly degraded into both of them slapping frantically at one another, like two furious children.

“Hello.” Adora interrupted them. Standing just behind them, she tapped one of them on the shoulder with the tip of her sword.

They instantly stopped fighting and turned. Recognition dawned upon both of them at the same time, as they're glowing green eyes flew wide in terror.

“ She-Ra….Destroyer of Prime!” They both screamed and jumped away from the console. Now bawling and clutching at one another. Terrified, they were about to be skewered upon Adora’s sword.

Adora was instantly regretful at how aggressively she had introduced herself. Recalling the sword, it shimmered away and returned to her left wrist as a silver bracer.

“Whoa…now. It’s ok I am not going to hurt you?” Adora stated, taking a step back and holding up her bare hands in a placating manner. Seeking to give them space and calm them down. They were now kneeling on the floor, holding each other and wailing hestically. Adora could only make out a few garbled words, like ‘forgive, unworthy and defective.’ Adora hoped they would stop once she gave them space and showed them that she meant them no harm.

Minutes passed as she stood dumbfounded, watching them bawl inconsolably in each other's arms. Taking a deep breath, she waited patiently. Several more minutes passed and their crying turned into fearful whimpers and sniffles. It was then Adora felt she could speak up again.

“What are you guys doing in here?” She folded her arms over her chest, glowering down at them with accusation.

“Nothing.” They both responded timidly. Sounding more like small children, then fully grown clones.

Adora sighed, “Looks like you were trying to build more Sentinel bots?”

“No.” They shouted back, with more force.

“We meant no harm!” The first clone shouted, cowering and cringing on the floor.

“The Spire does not have the resources necessary to build new bots. We were merely repurposing the parts that were already made.” The second Clone answered.

“Ok, that sorta answers my question. But why were those people trying to linch you?’ She cut to the point, feeling this interrogation could go on and on with these two.

“We sold them a Sentinel bot. But there was a glitch. In its programming.” The first clone admitted, casting his eyes downward in shame.

“The bots' self preservation protocols were set off somehow. They started to attack the farm’s engineer that was attempting to command it. It went berserk..” The second clone finished.

“We are not trying to re-start the war.” The First jabbered fearfully.

“We are but humble merchants, with bots to sell.” The Second offers Adora a small smile that was closer to a grimace. Unused to showing emotion, his facial expression looked forced and awkward.

“Oookaaay.” Adora drawled, “But do you have permission to be here…”

“Horde Prime is dead.” The first cocked his head sideways in confusion.

“Yes, but Entrapta sealed off the Spires. Only Clones with passcodes, given by her can enter? ” Adora explained.

The clone merely blinked in silent confusion.

“Entrapta…do you work for her?” Adora tried again. The first clone stared at her, his brows furrowing deeper into confusion.

“Our older brother…Hordak’s…friend? ” The second clone elbowed his partner sharply.

“Ah…well…no.” The first admitted reluctantly. “At least we do not work for her exclusively.” He shrugged.

“You don’t have clearance to be in here, do you.” Adora accused, her tone heated yet firm.

“Ah…well…no.” The Second clone echoed. “We have helped our brothers. Who have joined her collective to harvest the tech from the Spires along the Fright Zones border’s.

“For a price.” The First nodded.

“Yes, we are entrepreneurs. When our brothers returned to rebuild the Spires, communication arrays. We sorta commandeered this spire for ourselves.” The Second finished.

Adora made a clipped, popping sound of frustration. By smacking her lips and then huffing a long suffering groan while rolling her eyes.
“To build bots?” She instantly summoned her sword and swung it towards the belt. “For what purpose?”

“For profit, of course.” The First Clone nodded, suddenly very aware of Adora’s rising threat.

“For the benefit of all Etherians, of course.” The Second clone responded, taking another step further from the console.

“We had reprogramed a Sentinel bot to do manual labor.” The First amended, taking a step back .

“We sold it to a nearby farmer just to the north of the Wailing River.” The Second added, also backing further away from the console.

Adora stormed up to the console, scanning the code scrolling across the screen. Her expression was focused, but she had no clue what the coding said. She couldn’t let on how clueless she was. She needed to maintain her superiority over the situation, lest these two shady clones saw weakness and tried to subdue her.

“But things went wrong?” She snapped, turning sharply from the screen to glower accusingly at each of them in turn. They were now backing even further away, hands up in supplication, bowing and cringing in fear and shame.

“Yes…all wrong.” The First stated.

“Yes…very wrong.” The Second added.

“The bot was defective.” The First nodded.

“Very disappointing.” The Second agreed.

“What happened!” She shouted, her heart now thundering in her chest. Sentinel Bots had incredible fire power and were more agile and deadly than anything Hordak had built. Leaving nothing but death and destruction in their wake. Capable of burning a village to the ground and decimating the rebellion’s forces in minutes. She had barely survived many encounters with them during the war. Watched in terror from the balcony of her bedroom. As the Bright Moon’s elite guards stood valiantly upon the bridge. As the sleek, heavily armed Sentinel bots advanced towards the castle. Only to be vaporized by an endless onslaught of energy fire from their arm cannons. Thousands of Sentinels had marched upon Bright Moon Castle that fateful day. A deadly Harold of Primes invasion and the misery and bloodshed yet to come. Without She-Ra or Glimmer’s magic. The rebellion didn’t stand a chance and had to retreat. That battle had been so frustratingly one sided and the bleak memories filled her with shame. These death machines were better off never coming online ever again!

“It was fine at first…helpful…even.” The First began to babble.

“Then something set off its threat alarm.” The second groaned.

“The auto self preservation protocol was activated.” The first moaned.

“It became violent.” The second sighed regretfully.

“It attacked the Engineer and the people nearby.” The first admitted, with a cringe.
“With the pitch fork it had been using to clean out the stalls in the barn.” The second cringed.

“Are the people alright?” Adora gasped in fright.
“Don’t know, we ran out of the barn.” The Second clone ducked his head and shrank back even further as if expecting to be hit.

“The bot’s alarm was sounding and it scared the horse. That was still in the stall. The animal kicked the bot through a window.” The First explained.

Adora groaned and recalled the sword back onto her wrist. Rubbing her temples as a headache was coming on. This sordid story was just getting worse and worse.

“Is the bot destroyed?” She asked through clenched teeth.

“Don’t know, we got chased away before we could find out.” The Second admitted.

“The farm hands outside the barn, they tried to kill us with pitchforks and torches.” The First clone exclaimed indignantly.

“It wasn’t our fault.” The Second whimpered.

“It wasn’t our intention to cause harm.” The First nodded to his brother.

“We just want to help our new brethren.” The Second nodded back at his brother.
“For a price.” Adora ground out, shoving past both of them. When she reached the doorway, she thought better of just leaving them.

“You two are coming with me. We need to disable that bot before it kills someone!” She raised her hand above her head, as the clones began to blubber apologies and excuses. She ignored their pleas, her blue runestone flashed on her golden bracer. As a glowing coil of rope appeared in her raised hand. She flung the rope with speed and precision. Wrapping them both up around the waists before they could evade. Then abruptly turned and broke into a full on sprint down the corridor, pulling the two clones behind her. As they argued and protested. Forced to either run

and keep pace with her or be dragged. She now had a rogue bot to deal with and possibly several fatally wounded farmers to save.

She found a soggy and disgruntled Spirit waiting for her just outside the main doors of the Spire. The horse knickered and shook his head at the two captured Clones she was dragging out into the night.

She took a moment to assess the burns on Spirit's hindquarters. They looked angry and pink. Still warm to the touch. His hide was slightly inflamed, but there was no blood or puss. At least not yet.

"Are you alright?" She asked, softly. Her voice trembled with concern, as she cupped his cheeks tenderly. Her blue eyes shimmering with regret.

Spirit huffed and butted his head against her shoulder. An action that spoke that he held no grudge. He was a War horse and accepted that his missions would sometimes be dangerous and getting hurt was inevitable.

Adora hummed in relief, pressing her forehead lovingly against his.

"We got a life or death situation, Spirit. Can you carry three people?" She asked softly as she pulled away. Staring determinedly at her steed, eyes turning a stormy gray hue. Spirit glanced back at the two clones and then at her, stamping his back legs to check out how limber they were and if there was any pain. He felt fine, at least for now and nodded.

"I need you to run fast!" Adora ordered, helping the two clones mount the horse and then slinging herself up onto his back.

Spirit never argued but nodded. As Swift Wind, Adora had commanded him into action with very little information during

emergencies. So he was accustomed to it. She would relay what he needed to know in route to their destination. He trusted her to do the same this time as well.

The clone seated just behind Adora, shouted directions over her shoulder. Pointing towards the gentle rolling hills behind the Spire. Spirit charged forward into the night. He carried them for miles, panting heavily at the extra weight and beginning to froth at the mouth as he started to tire.

"How much farther?" Adora called over her shoulder.

"To the bridge." The clone behind her pointed to an old, weathered, timber slat and post bridge. That spanned a narrow part of the Wailing River a few miles ahead. It cut along the border of Scorpania. Once she crossed she would be in the Kingdom of Thaymor. The bridge wasn't wide enough for a cart to cross, which meant it was just a foot bridge. Not meant to handle heavy weight. But Spirit never slowed as his hooves thundered across the bridge. Adora had explained enough, along the way. That he knew a crazed bot was currently on the loose and innocent people could be hurt or even fatally wounded.

He could not slow down…

He would not slow down…

Adora was counting on his speed to save lives.

She had to find and destroy that bot…

She had to protect….They had to protect…

They were a team…for now and always…

Spirit had long since lost himself within their sacred bond. Adora's emotions were so raw, so powerful and demanding. That he could not resist the compulsion to give his all to aid her. His heart was strong, pounding in the chest like a sledgehammer. His breath puffed from his open mouth, in clouds of hot mist. His legs lunged

forward covering ground at record speed. His hooves pounded against the earth. The power and speed of his gait, exploding clumps of soil into the air behind him.

The countryside on the other side of the Wailing River was hilly. Farmlands stretched around them as far as they could see. The fields were left to go to seed during the war. Where now choking on wild grass and weeds. Spirit sneezed, as his hooves churned up the pollen. Adora leaned over his wither's, tucking her face into his mane to avoid the pollen cloud. The clones were not as aware of their surroundings, left hacking and sneezing behind her.

The Greater Moon's and their satellites were beginning their descent towards the horizon when they finally came into view of the farmstead.

A rustic, wooden fence surrounded the large farmyard. Circling around the huge timber and gable barn. Animal pens surrounded the large wooden structure that thankfully looked unscathed. Except for the broken window, near the end. That signaled where the attack had happened inside.

A number of men were patrolling the outer grounds along the fenceline, armed with pitchforks, shovels and torches. They had set up two steel plows to block the path that led through a tall wooden gate at the entrance of the farm.

A large farmhouse, with a wrap around porch, sat in the middle of the yard. The box window's glowing faintly with lamp light.

Spirit finally slowed to a canter, heaving for breath. His body soaked with sweat and shivering in the cool night air. Adora patted his neck and thanked him. Sliding off his back as he stopped in front of the plows.
"Hold….!" An older man stood just behind the plows, pointing a Etherian Horde energy rifle at her. He was the oldest of the four guards. Standing sentry at the gates to the farmyard. His face was deeply wrinkled, weather worn like tough leather. With piercing steel blue eyes, that glowered threateningly towards her. Dressed

in tan leather breeches and a heavy, white cotton long sleeve shirt and black suspenders. With long, wild silver hair. That flared around his ears, like the hackles of a wolf. A dusty brown wide brimmed hat perched precariously atop his head. He had a strong, muscular frame, illustrating that he had spent his life working the land.

“I heard about your troubles, I’ve come to help.” Adora called, as she approached the plows. Raising her hands to show she meant no harm.

The old man’s eyes widened in both surprise and recollection. As he saw the runestone bracer’s upon her wrists.

“You are the Bright Moon, Champion…the She-Ra?” He called back, his voice rough and hoarse. No doubt from screaming order’s all night.

“Yes.” Adora answered, “I brought the clones who started this mess. They are going to find and shut down the Sentinel, while I heal anyone who has been hurt by it.”

“Jack!” A woman’s voice rang out from the porch of the farm house.

The older man turned around, as Adora observed over his shoulder. An older woman, most likely his wife. Standing on the corner of the wrap around porch, hand braced upon the thick post. That held up the eaves of the roof above. Wearing a simple soft blue cotton dress with a white apron tied around her waist. She had a kind round face, with light blonde hair, streaked with silver. Tied up loosely in a bun atop her head. Her warm green eyes were shimmering with unshed tears.

“We got things under control, Agatha. Go back inside now!” The older man shouted back.

“He’s leaving us, Jack! If you want to say your last goodbyes, I’d come inside!” She explained. Her voice strained and high pitched, as she sought to maintain control and not start to sob.

The old man spun back to face Adora. His eyes wide and pleading, then hardened into firm resolve. "Get those plows moved out of the way!" He commanded the two young men. The tales of She-Ra's healing magic was common knowledge and know doubt this old farmer expected her to work a miracle tonight.

The two young men jumped to work, pulling the heavy machinery aside. As soon as there was enough room to slip past the two plows. Adora dashed between them and raced up to the farm house, with the old man running close behind.

By the time Spirit made it up to the house, the porch was empty. Everyone was inside, leaving the Clones sitting nervously on the horses back unsure as to what to do.

"Should we…go inside." The second clone leaned against his brother's back, whispering near his slender, pointed ear.

"We should do as she commands, brother. We have to track down that bot and shut it down." The first clone awkwardly slid off Spirit, having just endured a very harrowing and frantic ride across the land. His legs had gone numb and he stumbled to his knees as soon as his feet touched the ground.

His brother did not fare any better, crumpling to all fours as soon as he hit the ground and crawling away from the horse. As his limbs slowly regained circulation.

Spirit watched them jog off towards the barn, debating if he should keep an eye on them. Or wait for Adora. In the end he huffed and trudged after the clones, Adora did not need them getting into any more trouble.

The inside of the farmhouse was very similar to the one she had stayed in. In Taymor, weeks ago. With thick wooden beams holding up a simple gable roof, the walls patched together with clay and sod. Consisting of one large main room with a stone fireplace, simple wooden furniture and a table and chairs. With

box windows and faded blue curtains that looked gray. Two small bedrooms sat at the far end of the room and Adora bleakly thought perhaps the wounded man was there. She followed Jack across the room towards the fireplace. She hadn't seen the young man at first, since he had been laid to rest on a hide rug, on the floor in front of the fireplace. His body was blocked by the two wooden rocking chairs sitting in front of the fire. It was very noticeable that the furniture had been built by hand. Carved from the wood of nearby forests and thatched with the hardier plants that grew around the farm. The cushion's on the chairs were sewn from scrap cloth from old blankets. There was an absolute lack of luxury inside the farm house. Everything was simple and homemade. Adora had lived rough in the rebellion for the last year, jumping from camp to camp. Having to hunt for their meals, when the rations ran out. Taking from the land what they needed to survive. While hiding and fighting Prime's forces. She understood and appreciated the hard work of living so close to nature. This farm never took for granted anything, they used everything they grew, everything they hunted to live. It was humbling and awe inspiring how resilient these people were.

Agatha had knelt at the young man's head, dipping her hands into a wooden bucket of cold water. Ringing out a cloth and then proceeded to dab it on the young man's face. The old woman's face was worn and white with worry. Her hair had come loose from the messy bun, hanging around her cheeks.

Adora quickly took stock of the wounded man's injuries. He was a big man, stout and had an ample waist. Much younger than she was perhaps just on the cusp of adulthood. With wild, thick black hair that hung low near his shoulders. A bare dusting of facial hair over his strong, square jawline. His expression was slack, his skin parlor was a sickly gray. All vitality had drained away over the course of the night.

He was wearing similar clothes of dark leather pants and a heavy beige button up shirt. Blood oozed from a stab wound in his side,

staining his shirt and pooling beneath him. A heavy compress of old towels pressed up against the wound and belted tight around the man's middle with rope. In a valiant attempt to keep his insides…inside.

He had another gash across his forehead, that bled in rivulets down his face. Agatha had tended to the head wound hours earlier. Wrapping his forehead in torn cloth. But it had soaked through almost immediately and now his black hair was encrusted with dried blood. The young man had bled out over the last few hours and was now hanging onto life by the flimsiest of threads. So Adora got straight to work. She knelt down at his side, igniting the rune upon her golden bracer. Drawing into her palm the healing magic she needed, before hovering her hand over his stomach. Her eyes flared a brilliant blue as she channeled the magic into his body.

The Simple Life

It was the excited whispers of several voices that finally roused Adora from her deep slumber. With a groan she rolled away from the irritating noise only to have her face bathed in a blinding ray of sunlight. With a jerk she snapped her eyes closed and sat up, now wide awake and disorientated. She blinked a couple times once she had evaded the sunbeam and found a bit of shade. Swinging her legs over the side of the cot she had been sleeping on. Squinting in a groggy, half aware state to greet a spartan bunk room, full of farm hands. That now surrounded her tiny bed, staring down at her, displaying varying degrees of curiosity and awe in their expressions.

“She’s awake!” A young boy's voice exploded from nearby.

“Go get Jack!” Another older male voice commanded.

Then the frantic sound of booted feet running off.

Adora felt completely depleted, her mind was sluggish and she barely had enough energy to move. The familiar bone deep ache of channeling Sheana's healing for far too long, throbbing throughout every muscle in her body.

“I might have over done it…again.” Adora moaned wearily. Pressing her face into her hands as she braced her elbows on her knees. The rest of that night was a blur. She remembered healing that young man, it had been as meticulous and time consuming as healing Kyle. She had spent the remainder of the night mending his body. His injuries had been so severe and it took a lot to heal the extensive damage inside his abdomen.To seal the long crack that ran along his skull. She had been moving on autopilot after, heading out into the gray pre-dawn with the old man….Jack. Needing to check on Spirit and find out what happened to the rogue Sentinel. Jack had taken her behind the barn where the busted up remains of the robot lay. The Sentinel had not gotten too far after it attacked Jack’s son in the barn. Jack had retrieved

his rifle and hunted it down, while his wife tended to their son. He was a crack shot with an energy rifle and had blasted the bots power core dead on. The sentinel lay sprawled against a wooden barrel, with his chest cavity blown wide open. The pale white armor was blackened and the insides were still sparking with residual electricity.

A couple farm hands had taken the two clones into custody and had them tied up in a small pen inside the barn. While another farmhand had taken Spirit and bedded him down in a stall, freshly covered in new hay. It was then, when she knew everything and everyone was taken care of. She allowed Jack to guide her back to the bunkhouse to sleep.

A dull pinging sound vibrated from deep inside her pack. That rested against a wooden leg of her cot. It took less than a second for Adora to comprehend that it was a voice message. Logged onto her communication pad…a sudden jolt of recognition snapped her awake in an instant. She had forgotten all about calling Catra…hopefully she had only slept through the night and not several days?

With a yelp she grabbed the pack, unlatched the buckle and dug out her small, thin pad. Tapping on the screen to play the message.

Catra's face appeared, her expression was tight in veiled panic. Eye's moist but stubbornly refusing to let the tears fall. Finn's little face was crowded in next to hers, his soft blue eyes were bright and hopeful.

"This is the seventh time I've tried to contact you! You better just be ignoring me and not dead, dummy! Call me back as soon as you get this!"

Adora glanced up, wanting to make sure she was somewhat alone. Finding to her surprise the bunkhouse was now totally empty. Taking in the modest sized shed the farmer had converted into a barracks for his farmhands. She had a small round, bedside

table tucked up against the front of the cot. Three walls were flanked by similar cots with thin mattresses, all identical to her's. Small box windows were cut into the walls, mostly above every other cot. A fireplace built of fieldstone sat against the back wall. With a round wooden table and several straight back chairs circling it. Spying a small box window tucked out of sight near the fireplace. She found that the world outside was bathed in a semi-twilight. The blinding ray of light that had cut through her window meant. It was either just after sunrise or early evening. Either way she needed to call Catra and calm her down.

She quickly tapped in the id for Catra's pad then waited anxiously for her to pick up. It took seconds for Catra to answer. Her eyes were glazed with sleep, hair wild from restless tossing and turning. Announcing that thankfully she hadn't slept for days like after using the Heart. It must just be the next morning.

"I'm sorry…I'm sorry…I'm sorry!" Adora began, pleading for her mercy.

Catra's stricken expression was quick to calm, as a huge grateful smile pulled on her lips.

"I'm just glad you're alright." She whispered, in a hoarse, croaky voice.

Adora quickly went into the crazy night she had. Watching her girlfriend fondly as Catra slowly woke up to her tale of a late night race across the prairie and a last minute save.

"How are you feeling?" Catra asked gently, after Adora finished her story.

"Tired…but good." Adora answered. "Wish I was there, holding you."

Catra cocked her a smug smile. "Well, unfortunately your spot in my bed's been filled."

"What?" Adora couldn't help but feel affronted and a little jealous.

Catra panned the camera towards Adora's side of the bed. Finding a little Thaymorian curled up under the blankets. Catra's baby blanket balled up under his head. His tuft of dusty blonde hair was just as wild, showing he had been just as restless as Catra. He was out cold now, mouth hanging open with a bit of drool beading in the corner.

"Sorry for worrying you both." Adora apologized again.

"I am starting to come to terms with the fact that She-ra will always be in high demand." Catra commented.

"I'm not She-Ra, right now." Adora corrected, her voice tight as if reprimanding herself.

Catra arched an eyebrow at how ridiculous she sounded. She could argue the point or just let it go. She decided to let Adora figure it out, this time. Perhaps if she figured it out on her own this time she would believe it. That she would always be She-Ra, in whatever form that magic took. Adora and those two incredible threads of power would always be intertwined. Into an indomitable, awe inspiring knot that never could be broken. Adora would understand all that one day.

Instead Catra sighed and went into her own tale of Scorpia's identity crisis and Sweet Bee's escape. Fighting Tung Lashor and then finally getting back to Mystacor. They talked until the sun rose over the horizon high up on the floating island and Catra had to go and sing her morning welcome to Adarion.

Adora quickly called up Entrapta and let her know what the two Clones were up to. Entrapta was quick to solve the problem of other's breaking into the spires. She didn't want anyone else to get any ideas about using the Spire's resources to manufacture bots or weapons. She encrypted the locking codes to the doors to make it more difficult and promised to send clones to guard every spire. To make sure no one that wasn't 'authorized' got entry.

Those security measures were good enough for Adora so she thanked her and let her go. She had just hung up on Entrapta when the old man from last night entered the bunkhouse, with at least five curious farmhands in tow. Including the young boy who had run off to fetch him. He was barely ten years old, wearing jean overalls and a yellow striped t-shirt. He was rail thin, with slender arms and legs. With pale blue skin and pointed ears. His face was finely boned, almost elfin. With a short nose and high cheekbones. The top of his head had wild, matt of black hair that hung near his shoulders. Instantly, Adora recognized his race as a Gar. She had known many from that race, growing up, as many had flocked to the Etherian Horde. Including Shadow Weaver, who's skin tone was more grayish than blue.

"Come, it's sunrise. We have breakfast on the table and would love for you to join us." Jack offered.

Adora smiled, following the old man out of the large shed. The farmhands hovered around them as they walked across the yard. No one spoke to her, keeping a polite distance just staring with star struck expressions. Adora took their spell bound awe in stride. Smiling gently at each one of the farm hands, as she spoke quietly with Jack. She had not handled herself with such humble grace long ago. The near constant flattery and praise that she received from the people of Etheria, when she first became She-Ra. It had given her quite a big ego and only emboldened her Hero complex. It took many seasons of fighting the Horde. Enduring the constant pressures of being She-Ra, the Savior of Etheria. Realizing that it would take more than brute strength and magic to protect the people she loved.

It would take Light Hope's betrayal and the truth of Mara's sacrifice. Then Shadow Weaver's ultimatum at the Fail Safe was the final truth for her to admit. That she wasn't a Hero…she was a sacrifice…just like Mara. Before she had no control, she was a tool of the First Ones. But then she shattered the sword…lost She-Ra. Then that magic was born anew and she was dealing with a whole new kind of Destiny…one she felt maybe she was in control of?

But now she was just Adora…a human woman. Who could wield the power of both Sheana and Despara. The Goddess's of Life and Death. She was no longer capable of becoming that mighty warrior. At least not right now, but she wasn't going to give up. She was going to uncover the truth of Mara's last days, learn about all the other vessels before her. Train with Razz, until she had earned the right to become She-Ra once more. She needed to be stronger, more in control of her magic then ever before! So she could protect everyone, be ready this time to defend Etheria. Against whatever threat was out there in the Universe. Make sure that if any other Galactic Tyrant, like this Skeletor or this Flogg guy. Ever tried to conquer her world, she would make them regret it!

After a quick breakfast of boiled oats sweetened with wild berries. Adora had quietly excused herself from the farmhouse. It had been a filling meal and the mixture of fresh berries accented the oats perfectly.

With the freedom she had found living in Bright Moon. Adora came to realize that she was happier outdoors than inside. She and Swift Wind had spent days exploring the orchards that surrounded the Castle. Running, walking or training with her sword in the open glens.

She found herself wandering aimlessly across the farmyard, heading for the pastureland behind the barn. She was completely drained from using her magic so much over the last couple days. She didn't have any reserves left to heal Spirit. But she needed to tend to Spirit's burns. So she needed to gather some plants to create a poultice. She had not known anything about natural remedies until going to Plumeria. During their aid mission to heal the land and push out the Horde, poisoning the forest.

Adora, Glimmer and Bow had traveled with Perfuma and her people for a time afterwards. As they migrated towards the coast for the hot season. The Plumerian's were transient people never

staying too long in one place. It seemed that they lived in certain parts of the Kingdom in certain seasons. Living along the coast of the Howling Sea for the hot season and deep in the shelter of the Whispering Woods during the cold season. The warm and cool seasons found them mostly in transit from one location to the next. Tending to the forest as they went, hunting and gathering what they needed to sustain themselves. Adora had found tranquility to her days then. The simple routines of rising with the day moons and helping them tear down the camp. Spending the day walking, getting to know both Glimmer and Bow. Making new friends among the Plumerian's. Tending to the animals when they stopped for meals or for the night to rest. Listening to wondrous tales each evening before the campfire, before retiring to her hammock. As guests to the pilgrimage, the Plumerian's had given them each a hammock to hang in the tree's each night. There was a familiar comfort in sleeping so close to Glimmer and Bow. Listening to the camp settling down around her in their own tents, covered wagons and yurts.

The Plumerian's never took too much and always sought to maintain a balance with nature. It was then that she had learned about natural medicines from an old herbalist, she swore might have been as ancient as Razz.

She had a large hide satchel that hung off one shoulder, bouncing half full on her hip. She would duck off the path and disappear into the forest only to reappear several minutes later further behind or in front of the caravan. Always foraging as they walked for herbs and plants. She had caught Adora staring one day and took her under her wing. Teaching her all that she knew, so now Adora had a rudimentary knowledge about natural medicines.

Now she was wandering the fields beyond the larger animal pens, searching for a bright orange flower called a marigold. She would combine it with an aloe cream, she had spied upon a shelf back in the kitchen of the farmhouse. Agatha, who was Jack's wife, had already given her permission to take some. She would only need a little bit, to soothe Spirits inflammation and allow the skin to heal naturally. She hoped to be back on the road in a few days.

It was mid-morning when she returned to the barn ointment prepared in a small tin bowl. Finding to her surprise. The burly young man, with thick dark hair. She had healed. Was already tending to Spirit in his pen. He was dressed in a fresh gray button down shirt, the long sleeves rolled up to his large biceps. Wearing a black pair of suspenders, clipped to a brown hide belt. His thick legs were in a pair of black slacks and heavy leather boots, with wide folded cuffs. Adorned his feet.

He had a kind face, with a square jaw hidden behind the scruff of partially grown facial hair. With warm green eyes that were staring at Spirit so tenderly. As he lightly spread an orange tinted cream over the Horse's hindquarters. He was whispering praise and assurances as he tended the burns.

Adora had come to know that he was Jack's only son. His large hands moved, with gentle grace. As he smeared, a mud like cream over the horses burns. She took note that it was the same cream she had made, so he also had a medicinal knowledge of plants.

Then he lay a heavy, hide blanket over the poultice he had smeared over Spirits rear end. Spirit seemed blissfully content, a dopey smile on his lips, as he whinnied and snorted happily. Standing patiently as the young man finished up.

Adora strangely felt like she was intruding upon a sweet, almost intimate moment between the two. So she stood quietly on the other side of the wooden half gate of Spirits stall. Smiling knowingly at her steed. When Spirit finally noticed her, he shook his wither's in mortification. Rolling his brown eyes and promptly shifting his bulk away from the man. Pressing his rear against the weathered wood at the side of his stall.

"Woah, there boy. We're almost done? What's got you all upset?" The man took a step back. Suddenly wary of the jumpy stallion, that had been so calm and complacent before.

“That would be me.” Adora responded, her voice light and teasing.

The man laughed, long and loud. Then slapped Spirit tenderly on the cheek, “Your mistress, has caught you cheating now?” He teased, before exiting the stall.

Spirit huffed and stomped the ground, promptly turning away from them and facing the narrow back window in his stall. Giving them both a good look at his ass. In protest to the teasing.

“Aww, Spirit…don’t be mad.” Adora valiantly tried not to laugh. Thinning her lips and clearing her throat to mask her amusement. Spirit had been blocking his side of the bond, since their reconnection. Now she could feel for the first time, just a trickle of emotional connection with her steed. It filled her with hope that she could repair things between them.

Spirit merely swished his tail dismissively.

Adora hummed softly as she followed the young man out of the barn.

The main aisle between pens was wide, farmhands were working in the newly cleaned stalls. Hauling in fresh hay by wheelbarrow. Each stall had a small window, open to the fresh air and a gentle breeze danced within the musty confines of the large wooden structure. A huge hayloft took up most of the back, where other farm hands were tossing loose hay onto the ground.

“I guess I don’t need this anymore.” She offered the man her bowl of ointment. As they crossed the threshold of the sliding doors. The warmth of the mid-morning sun struck them both. As they left the shadows within the barn.

Adora couldn’t help but shiver, now noticing the temperature difference from inside to outside.

“He will still need a few more treatments, the burns were not deep but widespread.” He took the bowl with a thankful nod. “If

you don’t mind, as thanks for saving my life. I would like to tend to your steed until he is healed.” He set the bowl down on a covered feed barrel just out front of the main doors.

“You seem to be all better.” Adora smiled softly. As they headed across the yard, politely ignoring the man's offer and redirecting the conversation. She was thankful for his help, but Spirit's wounds were her fault and it was her responsibility to heal him.

“Thanks to you, She-Ra.” He nodded back. Folding his arms behind his back, as they walked together with a casual stride.

“My names Adora, actually.” She offered.

“That’s very pretty….” His voice was soft, as he regarded her fondly. Then promptly hid the loving glow in his eyes, with a confident shine pointing to himself. “My names, Liam.”

Adora never noticed his brief look of affection. Taking his soft expression as just a friendly look, returning his smile with an honest one of her own.

“Don’t you worry. Ma, gave me a full check before letting me go out and tend to your horse. I’m fully healed, no holes, not even any scars! Your magic is very powerful.” He continued, as they walked towards the fence line at the front of the farmyard.

Adora took the compliment with a humble smile and nod.

“Pa, still won’t let me do my chores, though. “ Liam shrugged, “Got those clones of yours, doing them for me.” He laughed, his eyes shining with mirth.

Adora laughed lightly, “They are not my clones. But I agree with your father, they should repay the damages and pain they caused.”

“Oh, they are. “ Liam pointed to the pig pen attached to the back of the barn. Where two very muddy, very disgruntled clones were busy slopping out the pen with pitchforks. The half dozen pigs

were all crowded against the back corner watching their intruder's warily.

"My Pa,Intends to teach them an honest day's work." He offered, with a shrug.

"They're soldier's, born to fight Primes wars. " Adora sighed, "All they have known is duty and violence." Adora felt in many ways she was also talking about herself. " This simple life…might be beyond their understanding." She finished sadly.

"Or, exactly what they need to find Peace." Liam patted her on the shoulder, observant enough to catch the double meaning in her descriptions of the clones and herself.

Adora stared at him for a moment, her mind spinning with the possibilities. That this life could one day be her future. If she wanted it. Working the land, tending to the animals. With no responsibilities beyond her own daily chores. She would rise with the sun, put in a hard day's work and then retire to her own little farmhouse. To eat a good hardy supper and snuggle Catra beside a cozy fire until bedtime. They would have all the time they need to love and cherish each other. It was a beautiful dream that she was quickly getting lost in.

"The stories I've heard about She-Ra. Is that you were a Horde Soldier before joining the rebellion?" Liam, leaned his hardy front against the wooden fence. It groaned softly under his weight. Crossing his arms on top of the highest post, staring peacefully out at the wild, overgrown fields of weeds beyond.

"The Horde found me as a baby and raised me." Adora turned, surveying the fields in well practiced sweeps of her eyes.

Liam took note, that she wasn't just appreciating the nature beyond the fence but surveying it for potential threats that might be laying in wait.

"Stay with us for a while, at least until your horse is healed." Liam offered, his eyes full of a hopeful yearning. He wanted to spend

more time with her, show her what peace was like.

“I do not want to impose, I’ll do my share of the work.” Adora responded.

“You don’t have to, saving my life was more than enough to earn your keep.” Liam laughed.

“I can’t just sit idle, I need to keep busy. I want to work.” Adora is adamant that he allow her to do a few chores.
“Fine then, there is always more work than hours of daylight anyway.” Liam chuckled, moving off the fence and heading back towards the barn. Adora smiled eagerly and jogged after him. This was a perfect opportunity for her to learn how to work a farm.

Liam led her around the back of the barn. Where Jack was busy dismantling the Sentinel bot. He was kneeling down by the busted up chest cavity, having already taken off the bots arms and legs. He had a rusty metal tool box open near his hip and was busy digging into its contents for something. An angry, focused scowl on his face, as he muttered swears under his breath.

Liam was waiting silently, observing his father with a frown. As Jack reached up and rubbed the weathered scruff on his jaw pondering his next move.

“Adora wants to help out around here.” Liam finally spoke up.

“Nope.” Jack spat back with a grunt. Pulling out a blow torch of all things and igniting it.

Adora’s eyes flew wide in both shock at his answer and the lit blow torch he was now wielding towards this bot’s power core.

“Stop!” Adora shouted. She was no tech master like Bow, but had been around enough bots to know that fire and electricity do not mix! She lunged forward and grabbed the old man by the wrist. Her cheeks instantly burned with embarrassment. Hovering over

him, she was able to peer inside the chest cavity to see that he had already powered down the core. The wires and conduits were already dangling loose from the battery hub. As he was in the process of cutting the cores mounting brackets out of the cavity.

"My, you are a jumpy one." Jack chuckled, shaking his head. As Adora released his wrist and took a step back. Allowing him enough space to get back to work. He quickly melted the metal brackets away and turned off the blow torch.

"Liam, this girl does not need more work. She needs to learn to relax!" He grumbled. Thrusting his heavy leather gloved hand into the chest of the bot and yanking out a fist sized box. It was in the shape of an octagon, with clear glass sides that showed the crystal matrix of the core inside.

"Take this over to the machinery shop and tell Kronis to slap that core inside the cultivator. We'll get those weeds ground up and bailed before the cold season sets in." Jack commanded.

"Got it!" Liam grabbed the component and dashed off.

Adora was about to chase after him. When Jack thrust a blocking arm in her way.

"Nope, you stay! We need to have a talk." He stated, abruptly. His tone terse and the expectation of her to stay very clear.

Adora stood her ground, swallowing hard. She wasn't used to being commanded so gruffly, at least not since her time in the Horde.

Jack adjusted the brim on his hat as he stood up. Regarding Adora briefly, with a reserved half smile. That still resembled a frown, more perhaps a guilty grimace. Adora quickly fell in stride next to him, in the same, quiet, respectful manner she would for a Senior Officer. It was the same dutiful posture she would have shown to Queen Angella… or to Shadow Weaver. She kept her

head down, eyes focused on their path ahead. Marching in time to his pace. She never spoke, waiting to be addressed. Waiting for orders…

What she got was an Old man's raspy laugh instead.

"Stand down, soldier!" He sighed, grasping her shoulder and halting her steps.

Adora turned meekly, suddenly realizing she had gone into Horde Soldier mode.
"Sorry, force of habit. I guess." She rubbed the back of her neck, cheeks flushing once again with shame.

"You can take the girl out of the Horde, but ya, can't take the Horde out of the girl." He chuckled and shook his head ruefully. As he observed her rigid posture and clenched fists.

"I set off your military conditioning, didn't I" He nodded.

"I guess, I'm not used to being addressed like that anymore. It kinda caught me off guard." Adora huffed, attempting to relax her shoulders and calm down.

"I can be rather brisk, when I talk to people. I am the one in charge around here. So talking all commanding like that to someone younger than me is second nature. I am sorry, lass. You didn't deserve to be spoken to like that." Jack sighed, clapping her smartly on the shoulders. "Let's go back to the house, Agatha will get us a couple of cold tea's and we can talk."

Adora merely nodded, with a tight smile.

Adora found herself sitting in a large, wooden rocking chair that was carved from solid oak. Set at the back of the porch. Facing the backyard of the farm house and the rolling hills beyond. She was intrigued by the deep red varnish of the wood, which shined in various tones along the grains of the wood. The knots and

swirls flashed in the midday sun like fire. Everytime she rocked back and forth in the bright sunshine.

Jack sat in a similar rocker next to her and a small wooden table was between them with two tall glasses of tea. The cold liquid inside was beading upon the glass, in the heat.

“The beginning of the cool season is a strange time, the days are hot and the nights can be downright freezing.” Jack commented lightly.

They had been sitting in silence for a long time, this was his first attempt to start up a conversation. He had wanted to talk, yet had said nothing for at least an hour.

“Yeah.” Adora responded, tapping her index finger on the wide arm of her chair. Scanning the wild grass of the back yard, searching for more things to say. She wondered if the old man just wanted some small talk before he got into the meat of the matter. Or if getting to the point would be rude.

“I was a soldier in the Etherian Guard many years ago. I was a Scout, part of the Thaymorian Ranger Regiment. We patrolled the border’s here between Thaymor and what was once Scorpania.” Jack sighed, taking a long drink of his tea.

“I have a friend, whose father was a part of the Guard too.” Adora nodded.

Jack hummed with interest, wondering if perhaps he might know of him.

“Uhm…George…he’s a Historian now. He lives in the Whispering Woods near Bright Moon with his husband. They have spent their lives researching She-Ra and uncovering First Ones ruins in the area. They have this huge library, filled with relics, maps, books and treasure all the way back to the Forgotten Age, maybe even a few from Mara’s time during the Great Unrest.” Adora nodded, a slow thoughtful smile pulling on her lips. She had never thought of visiting the library to find her answers, but George and Lance

would definitely be able to direct her to some of the knowledge she sought. If they didn't have it, perhaps they might know where it might be hidden. Other libraries like theirs or in Mystacor?

Jack merely shook his head. "I must be far older than this George, I do not have any memories of a man with that name."

Adora honestly didn't know how old George or even Lance might be, she figured around the same age as King Micha.

"He fought during the First Princess Alliance." Adora answered.

"Ah, I was done serving by then. Had found this place and started making a home for me and my Agatha." Jack nodded, "Thankfully, I was already far too old and broken to get involved in that mess."

Adora glowered down at her lap where she was twisting her hands, swallowing her anger. The First Princess Alliance was the start of the War with Hordak. Queen Angella and King Micah were the only ones brave enough to take on the threat the Horde posed to Etheria. They had gotten the rest of the kingdoms to understand that war would be imminent if they didn't act. That if Hordak wasn't stopped he would invade and eventually conquer every other kingdom. Sadly, they had tried and failed to squash Hordak's military buildup.

"You were raised in the Horde, then." Jack asked pointedly.

"Yes." Adora nodded.

"I figured, with how tense you are all the time. Always alert, always looking for threats and strategizing your entries and exits to every room you're in." Jack chuckled. "I was like that for a very long time….being a soldier….it sticks with you for many, many years…." Jack sighed, heavily. His eyes were distant, staring out on the plains that stretched out behind the house. Searching for how he wanted this conversation to go. "War is an ugly thing. But being a soldier, fighting for the freedom of others who are too weak or two young to fight. That is noble and brave, worth

celebrating. But it leaves its marks, both physical and mental.” He tapped his head. “You struggle everyday to find balance, yes?” He cut his eyes to her briefly.

“Bad dreams, flashbacks…unwanted memories.” Jack began, as Adora ducked her head nervously. Her constant sleep fighting since childhood was a testament to that.

“You're angry and sometimes you're just nervous, helpless or fearful even if there is no reason to be.” He continued

Adora cleared her throat and didn’t respond, keeping her gaze firmly on the wild grass beyond the porch. Those feelings had been her constant companions for years. During and after the war, now with more threats looming those anxious feelings were getting worse.

“There’s the guilt and the self-blame, the shame, that you didn’t do things right back then in the heat of battle. That you could have made different choices, moved faster, fought harder and saved more people.” Jack was now tapping on his own arm rest. Refusing to look at her, while Adora was now staring at him. Eyes wide and mouth hanging open in awe, at how clearly he was describing her erratic emotions.

“You wake up and you're sad, you get irritated or annoyed at the slightest thing. Most days you're just numb and feel hopeless about the future. You don’t know how to live without the constant threat of war hovering around you. But you want to know peace, you want to feel safe and secure and have hope that whatever happiness you’ve found will not be ripped away from you if you don’t hold onto it tight enough.” Jack finished.

Adora could feel the hot tears now falling down her cheeks, she quickly ducked her head and brushed them away with the heel of her hands.

Jack chuckled, leaning over the side of his chair and retrieving a simple wooden box he had set there. When they had first

retreated to the rocking chairs.

“If you want to do a few chores around here in the mornings, to burn off some energy. I will not stop you.” He began, opening the box in his lap, “But after lunch, you will sit with me for the afternoon. I wish to teach you how to carve wood. I have always found it calming and it keeps my mind busy with happier thoughts.”

He started to pull out several tools and set them down on the little table between them.

“We can carve in silence, or we can talk about the little things, or the big. Soldier to Soldier.” He finished, still delving into the box intently.

Adora smiled and nodded. She remembered that Addie, who had also been a soldier, had shelves of wood carvings in her home. She had been fascinated by them and was eager to learn.

“I would like that…thank you, Jack.” Adora picked up a strange blade that looked like a long, narrow, arrow point, with a thick, slightly curved wooden handle.

A New Beginning

Catra had quickly gotten dressed and put on her leather jacket. The early mornings and evenings were starting to get rather cold. Then she grabbed her satchel, slinging it over her shoulder. With the comforting weight of Melog hanging on her hip, she peeked inside. To find the little golem curled up in a tight molten ball, the tips of their little paws. Poking out from the round mass of their body. Their pointy ears twitching and nose quivering in their sleep. Catra cast them a tender smile as she flipped the flap back down. Then she headed for the tall, box window. Kneeling on the soft cushions of the bench seat, she unlatched the simple hinged lock on the side of the wooden frame and pushed the glass open. Climbing out onto the flagstones and then jumping for the upper balcony above. Her assent towards the roof was effortless. As Melog squirmed, their tiny mewl echoed upon the misty dawn. Their feelings of comfort and contentment that passed through their link was soothing. As she climbed the thick wooden post along the edge of the upper balcony that held up the gable roof. The blinding glare of the sun was just cresting over the low hills along the side of Mystacor mountain when she reached the top of the dormitory. She made her way over the central ridge of the roof, so she faced the inner courtyard. The clay tiles that sealed the roof were warm upon her bare feet. Catra moaned with delight, the roof would be a perfect napping spot come this afternoon. Taking a deep breath she craned her head upward towards the glowing morning sky. The thin wisps of clouds spread above her, like gossamer threads. Spreading across the dawning sky.

Bracing her hands on her hips, Catra began to center herself, to prepare to sing. She had been unable to sleep last night, far too worried about Adora. So she had spent those hours writing a new song. Her thoughts fell wistfully upon Melog and all the bittersweet nostalgia she held toward the lyrics of the song. Taking a deep, cleansing breath she began to sing. All her honest

feelings for the ancient magical creature, rising to the surface and flooding outward into the universe through her voice.

"Created to be a fighter,

You were left in the Silence,

the lone survivor.

Because of your defiance,

Death surrounded you for so long…

All this time you've been waiting.

A thousand years, since you saw someone.

The last one remaining…

Since they left you all alone…

Death surrounded you for so long…

Forgotten in the Silence…

You were lonely for so long…

So, you reached out for my violence.

As kindred spirit, we belong…

A bond never to be broken…

Cause, all my life, I've been fighting.

I had never wanted comfort,

As my heart was always hiding.

My trust in others was hurt…

Since love left me all alone…

I’m not used to sharing.

My whole life, I’ve never mattered.

So I learned to stop caring…

I grew up hard, so my heart doesn’t shatter…

Since love left me all alone…

I think too much and I hate it.

You heal me in ways I’ve never known, I needed.

My heart and soul, my confidant.

I cherish you, my true self I’ve finally conceded.

A bond never to be broken…

But you found peace in my violence.

Comfort me and make me keep trying.

So, I will never leave you, in that silence.

I’ll heal you, so keep on fighting…

So I can look out for you and you can look out for me…

Now and forever… "

Her voice resounded over the open courtyard. The heart felt harmony floating upon the crisp morning air, soft and serene. A sacred communion with Adarion. All her devotion and love for the ancient Golem is given form in the soulful melody. Willing her source to heal and strengthen this magical being, who meant so much to her. Her mind wandered to Adora, near the end of the song. She had been gone only one day, but she already missed her like crazy. When her song ended she opened her eyes. She could feel the sun's heat beaming down upon her. Filling her with magic, with positive energy and hope.

With a satisfied smile she sauntered over to the edge of the roof. Finding Frosta had settled upon the flagstones just beyond the colonnade in the central courtyard below. Still in her night clothes. Her pale blue leggings and a long, simple white cotton night shirt. Hugging her legs, with her cheek resting on her raised knees, smiling sweetly with her eyes closed. Basking in the gentle harmony of her singing.

"Wow….your voice is beautiful." She praised in a whispered hush. Still coming down from the emotional rapture, Catra's voice could create.

Catra chuckled, blushing as she quickly climbed down. "Ok, ok… Snowflake."

She hopped onto the ground from the iron railing of the upper balcony, landing lightly upon her toes, just in front of Frosta. The young teen grinned, taking Catra's offered hand to allow the magicat to pull her up onto her feet.

“Let's go grab Finn, then we can go get some breakfast. I’m starving.” Catra was quick to change the subject, she was not too comfortable yet getting praised by others. Especially princesses.

Catra gingerly pushed open her front door and peeked in , now finding her bed empty.

Finn had already departed. With a shrug, she headed back to Frosta. Figuring the Thaymorian had already headed over to the kitchen.

Catra waited patiently outside Frosta’s room, while the young princess got dressed. Leaning against the doorframe. Tossing Glimmer a flippant salute, when the Queen of Bright Moon left her own room further down the corridor.

“Morning, Horde Scum.” Glimmer yawned, her hair was a wild pink mess. Scratching an itch at the back of her head as she ambled away. She was dressed in more athletic clothes. Prepared for a day of magic training. In a pair of dark lavender leggings and pale pink tunic that hung off one shoulder.

“Morning, Sparkles.” Catra called back. The sight of Glimmer’s training clothes igniting a ball of both anticipation and dread in her stomach. This was the start of a new journey for her, no longer a soldier for the Horde. But a Princess of Etheria…the Rune Bearer of Fire…she had a destiny of her own to fulfill. A slow eager grin grew upon her face as she contemplated the days ahead with a sense of pride and purpose. She promised to work hard, learn everything she could and become a force of good just like the rest of the Princesses…just like She-Ra. For the first time in her life, she had hope and a sense of pride in herself. She finally held onto true power and had solid, dependable friendships she could count on. For support and guidance. As she explored her magic and was able to move forward into the future without fear.

When they reached the kitchen, Glimmer was already at their regular table. Set in front of the large window by the front door. As always she had a large book open in her lap, focused on her reading she was absently forking up bits of scrambled egg. Finn was not seated at the table. Catra quickly loaded up her plate with pancakes, cream and strawberries. From the buffet counter set up at the back of the dinning area, near the double doors to the back kitchen. She asked the tall dark skinned man if Finn was in the back. When he breezed through the double doors with two large pitcher's of orange juice. He smiled politely, shaking his head no. Catra was curious where the boy went off to each day.

Frosta had taken note of what Glimmer was eating and filled her plate with all the same foods. It was more than obvious that the young queen of Snows idolized the Queen of Bright Moon. Catra gave the young princess a knowing smirk, Frosta merely scoffed and headed to the table.

"Where's Mermista?" Catra inquired several minutes later when they were finishing up.

"She left with Sea Hawk a couple days back, I guess her Dad's lost his mind or something?" Frosta shrugged, nibbling at the last bit of toast.

"Was that why. Sea Hawk suddenly appeared here at Mystacor?" Glimmer closed her book and set it aside on the back bench. Now fully attentive to Frosta's story, which never really went beyond that first statement.

"I guess." Frosta shrugged, again.

"Well, Entrapta stayed on Beast Island so she can work with Holo-Hordak to get Etheria's old First Ones planetary defenses up and running." Catra began, Glimmer merely nodded that she knew all that.

"Perfuma's gone to Meadow Lands with Scorpia on a diplomatic mission for Scorpania." Catra relayed, pushing her empty plate

aside and taking a long drink of her orange juice.

“So that just leaves us five to train?” Glimmer groaned, “Aunt Casta’s gonna be thrilled.”

“It is, what it is.” Came Aunt Casta’s easy going response. As she breezed into the dinning room. “ Adaptations have been made, so I believe your lessons will proceed without a hitch.” She grinned eagerly. “Shall we be off then, students.” She finished, turning on her heel and leading them out of the kitchen.

Aunt Casta led them back to the large open courtyard that dominated the middle of the Adepts Dormitories. Netossa and Sprinerella were already in the yard. Along with several giant standing stones, that had once been out in the tranquil gardens. But to their surprise, Scorpia and Perfuma were there as well. Talking softly to each other just in front of a couple basic assault bots. One was Emily and the other was similar, but a dark pearl blue.

“Scorpia?” Catra darted for the tall Scorpioni, clearly confused as to her sudden appearance.

“Oh, hey…hi..Wildcat….yeah…change of plans.” Scorpia chuckled and rubbed the back of her neck with a pincer. She was jittery and nervous, refusing to look at Catra and keeping her eyes firmly on the ground.

Perfuma sighed and shook her head. Scorpia still had a very hard time asserting herself around Catra. She had gotten better over the last year, claiming some personal power and confidence while in the Rebellion. But ever since she had gone with Catra to interrogate Sweet Bee. She had been acting off balance and anxious. Now she was acting nervous. As if afraid she might be disappointing the hybrid and going to get verbally dressed down for not doing what she had been told. Even though she was now in charge of her own kingdom and was capable of doing as she

pleased. She had reverted to that anxious, worried, submissive mess again.

Catra smirked. Self consciously, crossing her arms over her chest. She didn't like that Scorpia was suddenly so uptight around her. So she was going to ignore how weird she was acting for now.

"Did you chicken out at the last moment?" She taunted.

"Yes…. " Scorpia groaned miserably, kicking the toe of her boot at some loose stones.

"Catra." Perfuma warned, taking a protective step forward. Directing a dark frown of displeasure at the feline.

Catra was only trying to ease Scorpia's nerves, seeking the familiar slightly antagonizing teasing they had shared in the Horde.

"Don't sweat it. Scorp. That coward can wait until you're ready to face him. You have lots of more important things to do first." She encouraged, then cleared her throat. " I'm glad you're here." Catra admitted, with a warm smile.

"Really…you're not mad…? " Scorpia breathed a sigh of relief.

"Why would I…be." Catra groaned and bowed her head. She had believed that her and Scorpia were on equal ground now. But it seemed that Scorpioni had reverted. To her old, self conscious prattling. Expecting Catra to yell at her, acting like a subordinate instead of a Queen. What the hell?

Scorpia merely nodded. A relieved smile gracing her face before turning to the bots behind her.

"So Entrapta has set up…." Scorpia looked to Perfuma for confirmation.

Perfuma merely nodded, offering her a confident smile to continue. Scorpia had been battling self doubt and anxiety ever

since Catra and Glimmer left yesterday.

“Remote learning…bots… so her and Mermista can join in our training.” Scorpia waved an arm towards the two bots. Who immediately activated, their central cores coming to life as they rose up on their three legs.

A flickering light glowed before each of the bots, slowly forming into two figures. As before. Emily emitted a hologram of Entrapta. Who was sitting on her hair, typing furiously in a pad. The white pillar of Beast Island’s central data bank dominates the background behind her. Vague silhouettes of clones, moved about the periphery of the room. It seemed Entrapta had been busy calling in reinforcements to help her with the research and implementation of activating the Ancient defense systems.

“Hi, everyone!” Entrapta waved, clicking her recorder on and setting it on the ground in front of her. As several clones bustled in and out of their line of sight behind her, along with a couple bots carrying lab equipment. From the looks of things, she had once again made herself at home on Beast Island.

The second bot projected an image of Mermista. Who was standing with her hands on her hips, glaring sideways at someone. Clearly annoyed with whatever they were doing.

“No…put it there!” She pointed to her left then rolled her eyes and sighed dramatically.

“Seriously…Hawk…how do you see all my stuff fitting in here?” She complained, as a cozy brightly lit island cabana flickered into view behind her. The walls were thin, slates of weathered wood. Turned grayish white from age and the constant assault of salt water. A simple wooden dresser adorned the wall by the window, with various nick nacks and trinkets littering the top. Books and maps were crowded upon a single shelf hanging above the dresser. Whatever room she was in, it was no doubt a bedroom. As she moved around they caught sight of a large hammock

hanging from two posts, in front of a larger window the overlooked the sea.

"Mermista, Dearest…I need you to be more open minded." Came Sea Hawk's roguish reply.

"I would be more open minded, if this hovel you found me was like eighty percent bigger!" Mermista growled, crossing her arms over her chest with a huff.

Mermista's new residence in Salineas slowly came into view as the Water Princess paced. A small window, with shutters woven in thatch lay behind her. Then she moved towards the camera, picking it up. Which they figured out was built into her new communication pad, then the area around her was full of sunlight. She must have moved out of the room and back outdoors.

"Let's just get this over with." She muttered, her tone bored and exasperated. Whatever she was dealing with in Salineas it was a lot and she was feeling rather overwhelmed.

"Well this is going to be interesting." Frosta leaned towards Glimmer, commenting with an amused chuckle.

Catra turned from the bots. Returning to Glimmer's side, casting the Queen an incredulous look of disbelief. Shaking her head, the crazy situations she found herself involved in since joining the Princesses was just too much sometimes. Scorpia and Perfuma followed after her with the bots stomping behind. They all unconcsiously lined up in front of Casta. As several older sorcerers filed down the colonnade behind them. Each one wearing different coloured robes. With Master Elys in the lead in his purple gray robes. His long gray hair was looking more wild than ever, standing up at odd angles around his ears. He had dark bruises under his tired eyes, illustrating many long nights of research and perhaps worry.

"I know that old guy in the lead, but who are the rest of them?" Catra leaned closer to Glimmer.

Who glanced over her shoulder. “The Magic High Council.” She responded.

Frosta glanced over her shoulder then. “They wanted us to demonstrate our elemental magic right?” She groaned… “I hate tests.”

Scorpia overheard and was now trembling…”I’m going to fail for sure…I don’t really have my magic back yet?” She whimpered to Perfuma. As red lightning began to crackle along her exoskeleton.

Perfuma’s eyes widened in alarm and she took a step sideways, a little further away from Scorpia. Even passively the level of threat Perfuma sensed from Scorpia was unbelievable. The pressure of the magic she was holding inside was like a powder keg, ready to explode.

Scorpia was so lost in her own anxieties she never noticed her magic igniting over her body or Perfuma stepping away nervously.

“Scorpia…take a deep breath…you look ready to explode…literally” Catra growled, as she leaned towards the taller woman. Keeping a close eye on the council as they made their way around the colonnade towards the front of the courtyard. Hovering in the shadow’s behind the pillars that held up the upper balcony.

Scorpia closed her eyes and took a long, calming breath as instructed. Focusing on following her order’s and not her toxic inner monologue. That was shouting at her that she was going to screw this all up like she always did when under pressure.

“I can do this…I can do this…” Scorpia muttered, seeking to manifest the best outcome through her affirming words.

“Alright, Glimmer. Why don’t you go first.” Casta beckoned Glimmer forward.

“Ok…” Glimmer nodded, taking a decisive step forward.

“Your element.” Casta inquired, typing on a data pad in front of her.

“Light.” Glimmer responded, igniting her palms with sparkling motes of light.

“Alright, let’s see some of the magic you have obtained.” Casta smiled softly.

“Well, I haven’t tried to conjure more than the abilities I used to have when I recharged with the Moon Stone.” Glimmer shrugged. Teleporting to the other side of the courtyard, startling the Magic High Council when she reappeared in front of them. Thrusting her hands upward over her head and sending two blinding pillars of light into the sky. Then a huge ball of light floated down to illuminate the courtyard in blinding white light before she dispelled it. Casta merely nodded proudly, when Glimmer teleported back into line with the rest of the princesses.

Casta called for both Mermista and Entrapta to come forward. The bots clanked into position in front of the line up of princesses. The holographic emitter's expanded in a sudden flash, showing a panoramic view of both Mermista and Entrapta location. Entrapta was holed up in a massive cargo hold, deep in the Beacon on Beast Island. Large industrial spot lights had been set up along the walls, with clones holding the poles in position. Casting Entrapta in a column of brilliant white light, as she handed her data pad and recorder to another clone who silently moved to her side. Then just as swiftly departed from view, as Entrapta took several deep breaths.

"My magic is magnetism." She nodded, before beginning a well rehearsed routine of her magical powers. Tearing the sheets of metal off the walls and bending and twisting them with just the flick of her wrists. Pushing and pulling giant pieces of machinery around the hold, as she swung her arms in a wide arc. Her movements were not graceful or elegant like Spinnerlla's but direct and efficient. Then two clones pushed a large screen into view, that held an array of schematics and mathematical

equations. As Entrapta snapped her hair towards the screen, diving into the more theoretical uses of her magic she had yet to figure out. Explaining the basic laws of magnetism and then digging deeper into the magnetic fields that governed the wider universe. By the time she was done the council stood stunned and slightly shell shocked by her genius. Not knowing if they should be thrilled or scared at the raw, destructive power she could one day possess.

Mermista cleared her throat, taking away Entrapta's audience. "My magic is water." She shrugged, standing upon a glassy, white beach that reseeded behind her to a rugged cliffside. The glowing blue green coastal water's lapped and frothed around her ankles, as she too began to manipulate the sea beyond. The movements of her and arms and legs was like she was dancing upon the sand. Directing the waves in large dramatic sweeps of her arms, or merely twisting her wrists and stretching her finger's for more precise strikes. As the sea rose up and moved obediently to her commands. When her magic show ended, both Emily and Mermista's bot retreated back in line.

Casta than nodded to Netossa.

“My magic is the element of Binding.” Netossa stated proudly. As she walked forward with a confident grin. Igniting her nets of light and putting on quite a show for the old sorceress. Weaving amazingly intricate barricades and traps, that grew and transmogrified in size and shape. Exploding into sparks of light only to reform in seconds in different parts of the courtyard.

Casta called on Spinerella next. Spinerella was not to be out done by her wife. So she gave Netossa a smug grin and nod as she passed her. Moving gracefully out into the open, as far away from the other princesses as she could get and not getting too close to the High council.

“My element is air.” She called out her element in her sweet, soft voice. She rose up into the air, high over the dormitories in a howling vortex of wind.

“You all better hang onto something.” Netossa shouted as she spun on her heel, charging for the far side of the courtyard. Catra’s ear’s pinned back, as she grabbed her satchel in a panic. Clutching Melog’s pouch protectively against her chest as she spun and ran. Spinerella had been a whirlwind of mass destruction back in Erelandia, when she had been chipped. Her unleashing her full power again, had Catra’s heart beating hard in her chest with fear. She dashed for the shelter of the colonnade on the other side of the courtyard. Her natural agility, carrying her far ahead of the other princesses as they all sought shelter as far away from the Wind Warrior as they could.

They all hid behind the heavy wooden columns, watching in both awe and terror at the sheer unbridled power of Sprinerella’s elemental magic. As she demonstrated her abilities by levitating the giant standing stones and juggling them as if they were toys. Directing the massive objects with her gusts of wind, by a flick of wrist or causing them to swoop and spin with grand gestures of her arms. She looked like a conductor, directing an orchestra of mass destruction high overhead. When Spinerella’s demonstration was done she hovered effortlessly down from the sky. Her toes tapping onto the flagstones, as light and graceful as a dancer. The standing stones floated down from the sky as if they weighed nothing. As she replaced them back into a perfect circle around the outer rim of the courtyard.

Catra’s ears were humming from the constant howl of the wind and she cringed in pain. Shaking her head vigorously to try and clear the irritating noise. Then flipped the flap of her pouch to check on Melog. The cat shaped blob, mewled softly. But seemed pretty unaffected by Spinerella’s wind storm. He was glowing a pale yellow, reflecting Catra’s anxious feelings. Catra smiled softly down at Melog, giving him a loving pat on top of his head. His tiny pointy ear’s flatten upon her hands’ contact, as she stroked him lovingly. Then his tiny ears sprang back up, when she withdrew her hand from the pouch. Tossing the flap closed, as she followed the rest of the princesses out of hiding.

“That was quite a show.” Netossa smirked, nodding towards the now terrified, huddled sorcerers. Still cowering behind the pillars on the other side of the courtyard. Their faces pale and eyes staring at Spinerella in fearful awe.

“You think I overdid it?” Spinerella moaned, pressing her hands over her mouth in dread. Feigning modesty, even though her blue eyes were shining with pride.

“Naw, better they know what you're capable of.” Netossa patted her affectionately on the back and gave her a gentle kiss on her cheek. Instantly soothing her worry and affirming her choice to show off. Spinerella sighed happily and nodded, reaching for Netossa’s hand.

It took Casta a few extra moments to put herself back together. Needing to comb down her wind blown hair and adjust her golden circlet back in place upon her forehead. Taking a few extra deep breaths to settle her pounding heart, as she brushed her hands down her robes.Clearing her throat to dispel the tremor in her voice before she spoke.

“Frosta, state your element and proceed.” Casta nodded to the young teen.
“Kay…Uhm…Ice!” Frosta shouted, jogging in front of the council.

Then it was Frosta’s turn, who hadn’t gone much further than her power’s before the loss of the Fractal Flake. Creating weapons of ice over her hands, then forming ice walls and slides. Erecting various other objects upon the flagstones, such as a throne and a statue of herself sitting upon it.

Casta nodded to Perfuma.

“Earth!” Perfuma nodded towards the council before beginning her own display of power. Perfuma was the same. Possessing the same level of magic power as before. Calling nature to her, to create an armor of vines around herself. A blanket of blooming flowers grew beneath the council’s feet briefly.

The council stood motionless, their hands curled before them politely. Their wrinkled faces were expressionless. Taking in the limited magic on display with a scholarly stoicism, exuding only patience and resignation towards their students. Though, Catra could see the silent disappointment in their eyes. She had endured years of that from Shadow Weaver, so she was highly attuned to catching sight of the subtle scrutiny.

As Casta had done for both Frosta and Perfuma. She asked what element Catra was the Rune Bearer of.

"Fire." Catra responded in a clipped shout, as if responding to orders.

Catra had no idea what they expected as a demonstration of her magic. Merely ignited her body in flames as she walked towards them. The magic she had conjured thus far had been through acts of desperation and emotional overloads. So she had no magic she could control on demand. So she wasn't going to play by their rules, she refused to be some dancing dog for their entertainment. If they were going to be disappointed with them then let them! She didn't give a crap what they thought of her or her friends.

The council stood, features impassive to the less than impressive display of power she provided. As she tossed a small fireball from hand to hand, her well practiced insolent smirk firmly in place as she regarded the old council taking her measure. Master Elys was the only elder to show emotion, narrowing his eyes in confusion and pursing his lips. As Catra spun on her heel as if completing a marching drill and returned to the line up. Snuffing her fire out as she turned, crossing her arms behind her back in an at ease pose.

Scorpia swallowed hard when it was her turn.

"Uhm…well…I don't know what my element is or if I have my magic back or not…" She chuckled, rubbing the back of her neck. As red lightning snapped and sparked across her body.

“Uhm…my Rune Stone was the Black Garnet…” She began to prattle, striding across the courtyard as the lightning intensified. Responding to her turbulent emotions. As she closed in on the Magic High Council the lightning surged. Exploding from her chest in a concussive blast, that took out a huge chunk of the dormitory over the old sorcerers heads.

The council screamed, some ducked for cover while others scattered out onto the open courtyard. When the dust settled, a huge hole had been blasted through the living quarters on that side.

“Oh…my gosh…I am so sorry…I didn't mean to do that!” Scorpia shouted in alarm, her face red with humiliation. Unable to control the tears now streaming down her face, she ran full speed out of the courtyard.

“Scorpia!” Perfuma called after her, rushing across the courtyard with Catra racing to catch up.

Just as they entered the garden’s beyond the Dormitory. Catra caught sight of Scorpia’s tail stinger, slipping inside the slowly closing door of the Basilica’s western porticle.

She pointed towards the cathedral and immediately changed course. Perfuma noticed her change of direction and was now racing after her up the wide stone steps.

They charged inside, finding no trace of the large Scorpioni.

“Where did she go?” Perfuma inquired, standing in the main aisle of the Crossing. Glancing up towards the Ambulatory and then back towards the Nave.

“Adora and I investigated the front of the Basilica, but we didn’t get a chance to look at the back.” Catra offered, raising her face upward as she took a few deep sniffs. Then darted down towards the Nave. “She’s this way. “ Catra called, as she disappeared into the shadows of the long, cavernous corridor. Perfuma merely

nodded, accepting Catra's hybrid talents without comment and followed.

The arcade within the Nave was huge, with a vaulted ceiling carved from the purest marble. Gloriously detailed mural's were carved into the vaulted roof that covered the wide aisle. These images were not of war, but swirling patterns of runes. Each twisting and circling each other, moving in organic patterns that weaved into each other in a seamless round that seemed to have no beginning and no end. The ornate upper balcony was lined with tall, arching stained glass. Each pane of glass contained a mural of one of the Rune Bearers of the ancient past. The mid morning sun was behind the eastern colonnade of mural's causing the colorful portraits to glow as if powered by their own magic. Catra and Perfuma were in awe of the majesty of the stained glass.

"There is a huge dome made of crystal at the front of the Cathedral, it's just as amazing." Catra commented as her gaze swung from right to left. Lingering on her mother for a long time, as Aoi stood in her leather armor, hands raised over her head. As the sun beat down upon her. Her wild, long mane looked like fire as the morning sun illuminated her countenance in stained glass.

Perfuma was moving slowly towards a carved statue of a Scorpioni in an elaborate robe. Nestled into one of the four large ornate bays. That flanked the main floor on either side of the arcade, below the upper balconies. Inside stood regal representations of the Ancient Rune Bearer's much like in the apts. A lizard-kin in simple cloth pants and flowing long sleeve shirt. A net was draped over his chest, tied at the hip with floating waiter's used for fishing. He had a kind face with a scarf tied around his head, that held his long, wild tuft of hair against his back. He held an incredibly long fishing rod in his hands, that bowed several feet over his head. The Rune of Binding was etched upon the rod between his gripping hands. Next to his bay was a female goat hybrid. Dressed in full metal armor, the simple knotted hilt of a broad sword could be seen over one shoulder. Various scientific items, tools and pieces of ancient tech were

scattered around her feet. She had a hard, determined expression on her face. Scowling down at the Rune engraved upon the head of the heavy sledge hammer in her hands. Which was the Rune of Magnetism. On the other side of the arcade are more flanking bays. One was a Moth Hybrid in leather armor, with a long woolen cloak that nearly dusted the ground. He had his hood pulled up, casting his face in shadow. He had a crossbow strapped to his back, along with a wide belt with many large pouches full to bursting. He held a simple orb in the palm of one hand, with the Rune of Farsight etched upon it. He had stern pointed features and wise deep set eyes. That seemed to see far beyond the veil of reality staring straight ahead. His expression was fearless, determined and very intimidating.

Catra was drawn to him, as she instantly recognized him as the Seer of Fate. Below his hands, resting at his feet. Was an unfurled scroll, etched upon the stone was the Prophecy of Fate that she had only heard once during a dream. It was in an ancient script written during the Forgotten Age. But Catra could read it as easily as she could read runes. Unable to stop herself, compelled as if by magic she began to read the Prophecy aloud.

"The two shall come,

One sleeping, lost to time.

One stolen, lost to space.

Child of Time, Child of Space.

(Images of herself as a baby filled her mind. Nestled in the warmth of her baby blanket, laying swaddled upon a hide rug on the floor. The flickering light of a fire played across her soft round face. The image shifted to an alien world far beyond Etheria. A pudge hand reaching from a simple woven basket up towards a round window filled with strange stars and two very different moons.)

Each born of magic, given form through blood and bone.

One shall walk Etheria, upon the dawn.

(An image of herself as a small child, scared and confused. All bundled up in a heavy cloth sling, over her mother's shoulder. Her wide mismatched eyes, staring in horror as they made their escape into the barren, blackened savannah. In the dead of night. Running and hiding in the farming villages of Thaymor. Then living in the safety and security of Whispering Woods. Finally following the Seer of Fate into the opulence of the crown city of Scorpania, Then the damp, in-hospitable environment of the Stinger mountains. During the last days of Mara's Rebellion, the Great Unrest.)

The other shall greet the twilight.

Both reaching for and sheltered by each other.

(An alien starscape, the cries of an infant. Angella's face… but younger. Swathed in the cowl of a predatory bird. Her lavender eyes looked sad, but determined. Then an image of little Adora reaching into her stasis pod, freeing her from her eternal slumber. Her cerulean eyes shining with joy, a huge, goofy smile gracing her sweet, round face.)

They shall ascend upon the final day,

Becoming part of the stars.

To usher in a new beginning.

(An image of Darla breaking the atmosphere of Etheria, ascending into the limitless expanse of the cosmos beyond. The star's behind the ship began to flash one by one, their light growing in power. Until the whole universe was consumed by light and then faded away into a void of eternal darkness. Leaving only the thirteen ribbons of magic to weave and knot. Forming an incredibly complex and glorious tapestry. That was so complicated and grand she could not comprehend it. As it seemed to no longer have a beginning or an end.)

Each gives sustenance to the other.

Space offers dreams of life-Eternity in Death.

(Am image of Adora many years older, standing before a waterfall. Her tender smile was warm, peaceful. The silent joy in her eyes spoke of finding true happiness. It was an expression of contentment, with herself and the world around her that the current Adora had yet to reach. She was dressed in a fine white gown that flowed like silk down the subtle curves of her body all the way to the floor. The toes of pearl white slippers peeked from beneath the hem. The gown was low cut, with golden accents upon the bodese. That flared like golden wings over the tops of her bare breasts. Her blonde hair was longer and trailed down her back, free and flowing like the majestic waterfall behind her. A thin, elegant golden tiara graced her forehead with a red rune stone set in the center.)

Time offers the soul salvation-Strength in the weft, elegance in the weave.

A tapestry made whole, so shall be one to the other."

***(She saw herself, standing before two regal thrones that looked like shields. In a grand room carved of crystal. She was also many years older. Her* long dark mane was pulled back into a ponytail, high atop her head. Her silver tufts were delicately braided and hung low along her neck. Beaded with orange sunstone shards. That glinted like sparks from a smoldering campfire amid the ash gray strands. A silver, magicat mask adorned her forehead. It was more elegant, finely crafted then her previous mask. The points flaring majestically upward in the same manner as She-Ra's crown. Etched with runic knots down the sides, that hooked into sharp points along her striking cheekbones. With a brilliant orange sunstone gem, that glowed with magic power in the center of the mask. She was dressed in dark black leather pants, with a gold stripe up the sides. Long knee high black hide boots with wide gold buckles were on her once bare feet. She wore a dark red leather armored vest over her chest, with a gold winged pin above her right breast. Her arms were bare except for the matching leather bracers on her wrists. Black fingerless gloves adorned her hands While a long white cape with gold accents hung off her left shoulder.**

"Wild cat?" Scorpia's soft spoken voice penetrated the haze of prophecy clouding her mind. She was instantly drawn back to reality with a gasp. Snapping her eyes up to find Scorpia leaning over the marble carved railing of the balcony above.

"That was weird and I never want it to happen again." Catra mumbled with irritation, pressing her finger tips to her temples as a headache began to pound behind her eyes.

"Scorpia…come down here…" Perfuma called, never leaving the bay she was investigating.

Scorpia merely nodded and ducked out of sight. The sound of her boots, clicking sharply against stone stairs soon followed.

Catra walked briskly to Perfuma's side. Taking in the tall, imposing figure of a Scorpioni in grand flowing robes of state. Her expression was stern, with exoticly shaped eyes and high prominent cheekbones. Incredibly long hair was elaborately braided down her back in thousands of smaller braids.She held an aura of grace and royal impunity. As she surveyed the arcade beyond by peering down the curve of her nose. Holding a massive tome in her pinchers, that bore the Rune of Dreams. The Rune carvings here were all different from all the others. Each one was engraved upon an object, while the rest had just been simple slates held in the hands of the Rune Bearer's. This Rune was elaborate and looked heavy, in her pincher's. Her long, segmented tail was curved around her feet. Rising up towards the thick book, her stinger poised just below the Rune on the cover of the book as if pointing to it.

Catra stood silently taking in every detail of the Scorpioni wondering if she had ever met her as a small child. When she and her parents had hid in the capital city of Scorpania a thousand years ago? During their trek across the kingdoms to her eventual entombment deep in the caverns of the Stinger's.

"Catra?" Perfuma's soft voice penetrated her concentration.

"I remember the Rune Bearer of Fate…but this woman…I don't know?" Catra muttered, as Scorpia left the winding staircase back in the crossing. Jogging into the nave and crossing the arcade to stand just behind them.

"I wonder who she was?" Scorpia sighed heavily. Her voice was barely a whisper, despondent.

"Well, I can read the Rune she is holding." Catra shrugged. "Your elemental magic is not lightning, Scorp." Catra chuckled, crossing her arms over her chest.

“What is it?” Scorpia was suddenly very intrigued.

“It’s dream.” Catra stated bluntly. Finally having that last piece of the puzzle, as to why Angella stated she only was able to help her through her dreams because she was connected to that magic. Her friendship with Scorpia, who it seemed had been unconsciously evoking the magic of dreams since Primes fall or before? Had allowed the Queen, who was trapped between dimensions, a magical thread back into this reality. If only to help her heal and reclaim a life she had lost a thousand years ago. Scorpia had never lost her magic, it had finally been set free just like hers when Adora released the Heart. It was working just like it was supposed to, no longer shackled to the Black Garnet or tainted and siphoned by Shadow Weaver’s dark magic.

Scorpia and Perfuma looked at one another in confusion and surprise.

Threading the Loom

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“What does that even mean?” Scorpia shook her head, shrugging her shoulders. Hanging her head with a dismal frown, as she walked away. Knowing what kind of magical element she channeled only made her more confused, now. She stood beneath the domed mural of Runic knots, craning her head back and tracing the intricate patterns with her eyes…finding no meaning to any of it.

Perfuma rushed to her side, placing her small hands into her pincher, seeking to ground her and offer comfort. Wanting to keep her thinking positively, not wanting her to spiral back into the toxic pit of self doubt and worthlessness. It wasn’t her fault that she knew so little about her own magic, it was Hordak’s. He was paying his penance for all the wrong he had done, for that she was content.

“We’ll figure it out…I’ll help you anyway I can.” Perfuma offered with a positive, self assured smile. Seeking to bestow confidence upon Scorpia, who looked lost and confused as she traced the patterns above with her eyes.

Catra stood frozen by the statue, searching her memory for information from the ancient past she could offer to shed any light on Scorpia’s magic. When an amazing story Glimmer had told her, during the celebration of Primes defeat came to mind. It was honestly the first appearance of Scorpia's magic. Illustrating just how powerful she cared about her friends.

“It’s one of the lesser elements…Oroboro’s explained a little to me during a dream.” Catra began, when suddenly it all fell into place. “Scorpia…you have been accessing your true magic since the Heart…maybe even before? ” Catra spun towards the now startled

Scorpioni. “Queen Angella would never have been able to cross over to our dimension without that thread as a bridge….she appeared to Glimmer…during the final battle. Glimmer had been losing to her father…she would have never found the strength to defeat him if it wasn’t for her mother’s spirit coming to her. “ Catra was pacing, folding and unfolding her arms as she worked it all out. “ Angella was able to use my dreams to aid me. All the knowledge I’ve gained about my magic, my history, your history… would not have been possible without your magic.” Catra exclaimed, rushing towards Scorpia excitedly. “I would have never been able to see my parents again…and have those sweet moments of being their kit. Even if it was just during a dream…it was real, those memories mean so much to me!” Catra clasped Scorpia, around the bicep. Bearing her heart and her eternal gratitude to the tall, muscular woman in a single breath. She was near tears, her mismatched eyes shining with overwhelming emotion. Scorpia sniffled, her cheeks burning with pride. As a hopeful smile pulled upon her lips as she stared down at Catra.

“I have no idea how I did any of that.” She mumbled.

“What?” Perfuma gasped, she had not heard anything about this until now.

Catra groaned, she had been so desperate to prove to Scorpia that she had never lost her powers. That she had been helpful from the very start. That she had just blurted out her secret about Angella. She understood bitterly that the more people who knew the less secure that secret would become. Harsh memories of losing Shadow Weaver, confiding in Scorpia and then being punished by Hordak, burned in the back of her mind. She had to be more careful! She had vowed never to hurt Glimmer again. She was not willing to endure the Queen's disappointment in her ever again. She needed to approach the eventual reveal of Angella's ethereal presence here on Etheria. With more tact then how Glimmer found out about the Eternian’s.

“Don’t tell…at least not yet…WildCat has Entrapta working on a way to get Angella back.” Scorpia spun on Perfuma, gripping her

hands. Her dark blue eyes pleading with the shorter blonde to keep silent.

"I spoke to Angella again during my time with the Squad. She had to leave her physical body in that twisted dimension the portal created. Becoming whatever magical manifestation she is now…" Catra slumped to the pristine marble floor in a heap. Curling her tail despondently around her ankles as she hugged her knees.

"I don't know if she's a ghost, a memory or something else entirely. I have no idea what Immortal's are or their powers. But she seems to be existing in the Eternal realm now?. " Catra huffed, flopping backward onto the cold floor with her arms outstretched to her sides. "She doesn't have a body anymore. So it's looking to be even more difficult now to get her back." She whined up at the roof, miserably.

Perfuma and Scorpia laid down as well, unconsciously forming a triangle pattern with their heads close together.

"It's a whole new beginning…for Etheria…for all of us." Perfuma observed, her eyes tracing the Runic patterns on the roof.

"It's kinda exciting…but also terrifying….its excifying!" Scorpia joked with a weak chuckle.

"You're such a dork." Catra smirked, raising up on an elbow and punched the Scorpion lightly in the arm. Which only made Scorpia's smile broaden.

"There you guys are!" Frosta's voice exclaimed, echoing through the arcade.

"We have been looking everywhere for you." Glimmer scolded a second later.

Followed by the mechanical clacking of the two sets of bot's legs, stomping down the arcade towards them.

A moment later, Catra heard two bodies shuffling onto the floor on either side of her. She glanced sideways, finding Glimmer laying on her right and then Frosta laying on her left. The shimmering of two hologram's that were Entrapta and Mermista were also now laid out on the floor amid their circle. Emily and her robot sister were crouched nearby at the edge of the arcade. Their three, long slender legs splayed out like a strange metal spider. While Netossa and Spinerella, found spots on either side of Scorpia.

All of the princesses unconsciously formed a nine pointed star below the arching roof. They lay like that for a long time in companionable silence. Each one of them staring upward at the runic mural as if star gazing. In time Glimmer began to fill the other princesses in on what happened on Beast Island. About the genetic experiments, the threat of Omega Prime and the Mutants. The impromptu Alliance meeting soon became a debate as to how to handle these new invader's and the new threat. Since Beast Island was out beyond Salineas's borders on the Growling Sea. Mermista offered to get the word out, to all the merchant vessels traveling between islands. To be on the lookout for any dark vines on any of the islands they visited. They would spot Omega Prime eventually, hopefully before more casualties happened. If they had to engage with the monster in the next few days, they would just have to wing it! It wasn't ideal, but Entrapta was working on gathering more information from the First Ones genetics lab and 'Galius' data banks. Entrapta related to them that she was also working on a tracker program…she had enough Horde DNA to get a good sample. But she also needed some Wrym DNA as well. She wondered if she could get some from one of the other princesses Guardian Beasts?

"Mine, flattened what was left of the Palace and then disappeared back into the depths." Merimista shrugged.

"Juliet reported to me that mine flew off back under Sky Dancer mountain. The Bright Moon guards couldn't find a trace of it in the tunnels beneath the Waterfall." Glimmer sighed.

“We left the remains of the Heart Blossom, I can not bear to go back there. Your free to go check it out. Maybe my Guardian is still there.” Perfuma offered with a resigned sigh.

“I have no idea either, my guards reported that after my Guardian ate the Fractal Flake it just shimmered out of existence.” Frosta grumbled.

“Ok, then I guess Plumeria’s my best lead then. Thanks, Perfuma.” Entrapta offered, the sharp clicks of her keyboard soon resounded off the marble walls of the arcade.

“So Frosta told us, your dad’s gone nuts?” Glimmer turned and smirked at the hologram of Mermista laying on the other side of Frosta.

Who on cue groaned long and loud. Before answering.

“It’s a long and annoying story, that I do not want to rehash yet again to another person. The cliff notes version is, after the Sea Gate fell. My dad was pissed! He came out of retirement just to disown me and take over the throne.” Mermista declared, her voice high pitched and wavering with unshed tears.

Catra cringed and hugged herself, the guilt at her past action’s striking her like a hammer in the gut.

“Sooo…I was packing up my things and loading them on, Sea Hawks ‘new’ boat. When the Guardian attacked and finished off the palace then ate the Pearl. We had already sailed off, so I never looked back. That rampaging beast was my father’s problem. If he wanted the throne, he gets to deal with all the bullshit that goes with it!” Her voice trembled, but she quickly cleared her throat.

Glimmer glanced over, leaning up on an elbow and reaching over Catra and Frosta. Wanting to reach out and hold Mermista’s hand. But was thwarted by the fact she was a hologram and her hand went right through. Mermista noticed, her watery brown eyes

sliding down to Glimmer's hand that had attempted to hold hers and smiled softly.

"I went to Mystacor when my magic disappeared. I was planning on settling down here for now, learn some magic, become stronger. If I could no longer be the ruler of Salineas, I could at least be it's strongest defender. But then Sea Hawk showed up and ruined it!" She snarled, then sighed heavily. Thumping the back of her head against the ground. "No, he didn't…he's just….Ugh…" She groaned and thumped her head a few more times. Building up her courage. "My dad attacked the supply convoy of ships you sent, Scorpia…your people are dead." She moaned, turning her head towards the Scorpion. Her expression was full of guilt and remorse.

Scorpia gasped, blinking rapidly to clear the sudden shock and grief.

"He's armed every island on the southern archipelago with weapons and they are patrolling the waters. The coastline past Sea Worthy is now full of landmines and he's rebuilding our navy, setting up armaments along the northern coast to keep out invaders…he's pushing an xenophobic agenda on my people that they have no say in. He wants to separate from the rest of Etheria…" Mermista spat out in a rush.

"He wants to cut off all ties to the mainland, like Meadow Lands did?" Netossa offered, solemnly.

"I've gone back to Salineas to try and reason with him, because he's gone absolutely crazy! So now, I've set up a new home… sorta…in Sea Hawks old village in Broland. While I figure this all out." She finished, scrubbing her hands down her face and releasing a painful sounding moan.

"We are here if you need us." Spinnerella offered, sweetly.

"I will eventually, for sure." Mermista sighed. "If I can't get my father to stop, my people are definitely headed towards a civil

war.”

Glimmer’s eyes flew wide in horror.

Catra whimpered softly, squeezing her biceps hard with her fingers digging her claws into the skin. Overwhelmed by her emotions.

Scorpia huffed, still reeling from the news that the people she sent to help rebuild Salineas were now all dead. Perfuma was holding her pincher tight, leaning over her and keeping a close watch on the pain and frustration that was now washing over Scorpia’s face.

It was mid-day before they emerged from the Basilica. The sun had disappeared and now the sky was overcast and gray. Thick clouds hung heavy over Mystacor, threatening snow. The day had never really warmed up much and Catra shivered as she moved briskly down the stone steps. Frosta grinned up at the sky, this was her weather. Her cheeks were rosey from the chill as she huddled in her fur lined parka.

“If it snow’s want to build a fort? We could have a snowball fight?” She offered with an eager grin.

“Sounds good to me.” Netossa clapped Frosta on the back. “But this time I am not going to let you win.” She taunted.

Frosta glowered up at her.

“Don’t listen to her, Frosta. You won fair and square last time. Netty’s pride is just bruised.” Spinnerella advised, giving her competitive wife a hard look.

“That wasn't all that was bruised.” Netossa pouted, rubbing her arms and then her ass. Shuddering ruefully at how aggressive Frosta had been during their last snowball fight.

Emily was walking just behind Scorpia, who was taking up the rear of the group. Lost in her own thoughts.

“Well, I’ve got an itinerary to keep too.” Entrapta stated, her hologram flickered into nothingness and Emily stomped away to investigate the garden. Then Mermista’s sudden cry of alarm. Drew everyone's gaze away from Emily to the other bot, that had been keeping pace with Scorpia as well.

Mermista’s hologram glitched and froze, with the Salineas Princess in some strange ducking pose with her arms crossed over the back of her head.
“What the Hell, Hawk…I came out here to get away from you and your band of bro’s and your endless buffoonery!.” All they could hear was her voice now and not anyone else that might be nearby. It was comical and confusing, to listen to her exasperated tirade towards Sea Hawk. Then the hologram abruptly flickered away as she cut the connection. Mermista’s bot turned and stomped after Emily. Now free to roam and explore the grounds as well.

Casta and the High Council had taken their leave by that point. Leaving the Princesses to return to a now abandoned and slightly collapsed Dormitory.
Scorpia cringed and tapped her pincers together in shame. As she surveyed the massive damage to the upper floor on the far side of the courtyard. Her deep blue eyes shimmering with remorseful tears.

“I’ll make a couple calls today, get some of the construction crews over here from the Merchants Quarter to rebuild that side of the Dorms.” She promised.

“It’s not that high of a priority, Scorp.” Catra observed the blasted out hole in the top of the building with her hands on her hips.

“We don’t have rooms on that side anyway.” Frosta shrugged.

“It will need to be sealed off at least before the Cold Season’s sets in.” Glimmer nodded. As she stared at the crumbling clay roof. Scorpia had exploded a good portion of the upper rooms on the far side of the courtyard. Almost through the middle of the building, so half of the damaged rooms would be left open to the elements. So they would have to seal off that side still connected to the usable portion of the dorms. It wasn’t a big job, but still a job.

“Get a hold of some of your builder’s, Scorpia. There isn’t a huge rush, but if they could fit in the repair within the next few weeks. We should still beat the first snow.” Glimmer advised.

“It snows up here…” Catra groaned. “Of course it snows up here.” She shook her head and groaned more loudly in disappointment.

Aww…Wild Cat. I know you hate the cold. I’ll get you some warm clothes, maybe your jacket is still in your force captain’s quarters.” Scorpia offered.

Catra smirked, “Entrapta packed up everything I owned in my pack when we left on the skiff, Scorp. I am sure I tossed it somewhere in my room.” She chucked a thumb back at her room.

Scorpia nodded and then heaved a great sigh. She was going to have to report the casualties in Salineas to Lonnie. Send out orders for the rest of the convoy’s currently headed towards the coast to turn around and come back to Scorpania. Get in contact with the supply staff at the Warehouse in Sea Worthy to find out if they had gotten attacked? She had a whole day of logistics to figure out and a lot of calls to make.

A streak of brilliant light shot across the sky just above the wreckage of the dorms. Swooping in a large arc and then

descending at a sharp angle towards the open fields beyond the citadel.

"Darla's back!" Glimmer exclaimed, hopping lightly on her toes before disappearing in a shower of sparkles.

Netossa and Spinerella cast each other knowing looks, as the Queen of Bright Moon made her hasty exit.

"Where did Casta and the Council go?" Perfuma asked.

"Casta gave us the rest of the day off. I think Scorpia kinda scared the crap out of those old farts.They needed to get back to the Citadel and change their underwear." Frosta exclaimed with a giggle.

"Jeez…That was not my intention…" Scorpia cringed again and sighed heavily.

Catra threw her head back and laughed, long and loud. At Frosta's crass joke. Easing the tension and calming Scorpia's guilt, who was now blushing and smiling fondly down at the Magicat.

It was supper time, when Glimmer returned. Teleporting into the dining area in a shower of sparkles. With Bow, Brojee, Caz, Litha and Drissi. Just as the rest of the princesses were sitting down to eat. They all looked up taking in the new people with a mixture of curiosity and confusion. Frosta was not amused by the sudden appearance of strangers and she stopped eating, to glare with distrust towards them.

The two boys eagerly darted for the buffet table, loading up their plates. While Litha rolled her eyes and giggled, approaching the counter in a far more dignified manner. Taking her time to figure out what she wanted to eat, while the boys tossed a bit of everything onto their quickly overflowing mounds of food.

Brojee was deep in conversation with Bow and Glimmer and had not noticed in time. To reign in his overzealous glutton's. Gapping in bewilderment, as the two boys shuffled past him with towers of food. Drissi had a whole turkey leg shoved into his mouth, crewing merrily as he walked behind Caz towards a long table near the princesses.

Caz slid his plate at the end of the table just behind the oval table nestled in the bay window with the princesses. Sliding onto the end of the bench and tucking in, completely focused on his food. He never noticed the strange, slightly appalled look he was receiving from Frosta. Who sat at the end of the table with the princesses. The Queen of Snows shuddered and quickly averted her gaze. As Drissi joined him with his own disturbingly large portion of food.

"Who are those guys?" Frosta growled as she leaned sideways closer to Catra, who was sitting next to her.

Catra looked up from her plate, setting aside the buttered roll she had been devouring. Chewing quickly and swallowing, she nodded towards the new group of people currently sitting with Bow and Glimmer at the table behind them.

"The oldest boy..there." She nodded towards the tallest young man, with scruffy looking dark hair. Currently shaking his head in dismay at his younger cohorts. His dark blue eyes watched in disbelief as they attacked the food on their plates with all the gusto and savagery of two starving young men.

"He's called Brojee, he's the leader of that little group." Catra picked up her roll and took a small bite, using the bread as a shield to mask her pointing finger. "The little girl sitting next to him is his sister. Litha, the bigger boy is Drissi and the red haired one is Caz." Catra turned to regard Frosta with a smirk. " They are Scraper's. Entrapta sorta killed their starship and marooned them here on Etheria."

Frosta’s eyes widened in surprise, Glimmer had not mentioned them. Then she shrugged, accepting Catra’s account as valid. She had witnessed Entrapta’s demonstration of magical power earlier today. As she ripped paneling off the walls of the beacon back on Beast Island. Twisting and warping them into different shapes then flattening them again. It wasn’t too far -fetched to think she could take down an entire metal starship.

“Ok…but why are they here?” Frosta remarked, her voice high pitched with indignant ire.

“Bow brought them…cause….I have no idea. They were supposed to be scavenging parts back in the scrapyard in Scorpania. So they could fix their spaceship back on Beast Island.” Catra shrugged.

Frosta’s frown deepened into a scowl. Then she promptly shoved away from the table and stomped up to the young men.

“Why are you here?” She questioned boldly.

Drissi paused, just finishing shoving an epic sized spoonful of mashed potatoes into his mouth. Making his cheek’s puff out as he stared dumbfounded up at her. While Caz merely scoffed and stood up to confront her on her own terms. Hot headed and indignant at Frosta's rude interruption to his meal. He was not going to just sit and take her aggression without a relation of some kind.

“Cause we want to be!” He quipped back sharply, shaking the remains of his turkey bone at her as if he was brandishing a weapon.

“Frosta, these guys are our guests.” Glimmer was quick to respond. Standing up to confront Frosta as well, her hard, disapproving look forcing the Ice Princess to back down somewhat.

“Seriously! Have you guys learned nothing! After everything that’s happened with these Eternian’s. Their intruder’s…outsider’s…it’s

stupid for us to just nievely welcome them in our midst.” Frosta put her hands on her hips in agitation.

“They are my friends, Frosta. I trust them.” Bow defended them calmly. Not even pausing his meal.

Frosta's scowl deepened, as she glared pointedly at each one of the intruder’s.

“I'm watching you!” Frosta declared, pointing two fingers at her eyes and then at them. Before storming out of the kitchen in a huff.

“Well that was friendly.” Brojee commented lightly, as he watched the young queen of Snows stomp out of the front door.

“Aunt Casta has set you guys up in two rooms here at the Basilica. I can show them to you after supper.” Glimmer offered, paying Frosta a concerned glance but unwilling to go after her just yet. Seeing her tirade as nothing more than teenage angst, she had been very much the same at that age. Not taking well to change, her poor mother had dealt with her moods in a similar fashion. Letting her cool off and then approaching her later to discuss her concerns. So she would deal with Frosta in the same manner.

“Entrapta has taken apart that Doom Seeker Drone and decrypted its energy signature. I downloaded her tracking program just before we left Scorpania. So I want to climb up to the summit of Mount Mystacor tomorrow morning and try it out.” Bow had his tracker pad out, tapping on the screen with a stern, focused expression. Completely ignoring his half eaten plate of food, that was now growing cold.

Glimmer huffed, forking a piece of roast turkey and shoving it into his mouth. Bow mumbled a thanks as he chewed.

Brojee chuckled as he leaned over the table, snatching the pad out of Bow’s hands. He had only known the man for a couple

days, but knew the Etherian Maker could become completely engrossed in his tech and forget everything else.

"Eat, before your wife loses her patience with you. We have plenty of time to deal with these drones." He commented, teasingly.

Bow chewed more vigorously, his eyes bright with joy and cheeks burning. While Glimmer ducked her head and blushed.

Catra's ears flicked as she smiled fondly down at her empty plate. She had heard the whole, tender, light hearted teasing between Brojee and Bow. The thought of her two friends being married one day. Warmed her heart and made her feel very content and happy. It was the perfect future she had been silently yearning for, for herself. Since her first kiss with Adora.

Her smile slowly dissolved into a contemplative frown. The archer had such a kind, honest personality he befriended others so easily. It was a talent she wished she possessed. Sadly, her upbringing had made her jaded and distrustful of others. She found a more kindred spirit in Frosta than Bow. With that she stood from the table and bid everyone good night. Taking her leave swiftly, to go track down the disgruntled Queen of Snows. She had a debt to repay to the young queen, perhaps she needed a friend right now. Someone who could understand her fears and relate to her anger and distrust.

It didn't take Catra long to track down the Queen of Snows. She hadn't gone too far, brooding upon the steps of the Basilica's eastern porticle. Leaning against a grand serpent carved pillar, that held up the elaborate fresco above the heavy wooden doors. With her knees drawn up to her chest, her head cast upward to the glowing evening sky. Catra noted that beyond the orchard of apple trees. Adarion was sinking just behind the dark silhouette of the slender towers of the Sorcerers Citadel. Soon she would have to sing her evening vesper's.

Catra approached her slowly, offering her a small, gentle smile. When Frosta turned and acknowledged her with a grunt. The fur lining of her parka's collar had fluffed up as she huddled over her knees. Obscuring the sides of her face somewhat, but Catra's keen eyesight still caught the shimmering wet trails of tears as they fell down her face.

"Hey, Snowflake." Catra greeted her with a warm smile, settling down beside her on the wide landing beside the stone carved pillar.

"Why do you call me that all of a sudden?" Frosta muttered, sniffing and wiping her nose with the cuff of her parka.

Catra merely shrugged, "It's just a nickname."

"Like 'Sparkles'." Frosta sighed, refusing to look at her. "Is it a friendly nickname or mean name calling? Cause Snowflake sounds kind of wimpy and I am not weak!"

Catra chuckled and shook her head. "Sparkles…ah well. It was a mean nickname at first….but now…it shows her how much I care about her."

"Like when she calls you Horde Scum…now? It's not in a mean way, like it was during the war." Frosta nods.

"Yeah, Glimmer and I have come a long way as friends in the last few seasons." Catra nodded.

"I care about her too….but she still doesn't take me seriously." Frosta pouted. "Even after everything we've been through, she still treats me like a kid!"

"But you are a kid?" Catra commented dryly, bumping her shoulder against Frosta's playfully.

Frosta released a long drawn out groan, shoving Catra away angrily.

“I know and I hate it!” She snarled. “I’ve been ruling a Kingdom a lot longer than she has!” Frosta began, her voice high pitched a tight. “I know stuff….But she never comes to me for advice…she does whatever she wants…and she doesn’t make the best decisions…especially when she’s stressed…and I do not want to go through another…Heart of Etheria…crisis again! ” Frosta moaned.

Catra was quiet for a long time, absorbing Frosta’s worries.

“That can't happen…again?” Catra whispered softly. The slight waiver of uncertainty in her tone.

“I know…but we need to be cautious with people beyond our solar system. Those four I am sure have their own problems, they might not be bad people. But I do not want to get wrapped up in any of their drama, or have it show up on our doorstep. Ya, know! Etheria needs time to rebuild, grow stronger so when we do start to go out there into the universe. We are on equal ground with the rest of the planets. I just wish Glimmer and Bow were not such bleeding hearts. I just know that they are going to drag us all into something huge and scary and that we are not prepared for…just like last time.” Frosta moaned, ducking her face away into her crossed arms.

Catra knew nothing about the fear and anxiety Frosta had gone through during the war. But her tears now were a glimpse to how upset she had been during those turbulent years. But Catra agreed with her, whole heartedly. The universe beyond Etheria, it was scary and overwhelming. They needed to tread forward cautiously. Needed to be ready, they had to remain focused on making Etheria strong and able to defend itself from universal threats.

“We have enough problems to deal with right now!” Frosta bemoaned miserably, as she hid her face in her arms.

Catra sighed heavily, struggling to figure out how to comfort the obviously frightened teen.

“We got this…Frosta…no matter what…we’ll tackle whatever the universe throws our way together!” She offered with a warm smile, her voice was the most positive and uplifting she had ever heard. It was honestly so out of character for her, but also the fact that she could talk this way now. It gave her hope that she was becoming that better person that she had been striving towards for the last couple seasons.

Frosta started to laugh. “You sure are starting to sound like one of us, now.”

Catra’s grin broadened. “Well I am a Princess now.”

“Yep, having to deal with the crazy that comes with having magic and the universe ending bullshit that comes with it!” Frosta quipped.

Which caused Catra to nod and laugh even louder.

Chapter End Notes

My summer is going to be crazy busy, so I will not be able to update as often. But I should be back more consistently come Sept. Have a great Summer!

Moving Towards Tormorrow

Chapter Notes

> My Summer's been Busy!!!! But I managed to sneak in this update so. Enjoy! KaTaai and Bitzy Bee thanks for your comments on the last chapter. I love reading comments. Who knows what is in store for our hero's..lol. Only time will tell, so stay tuned.

Adora woke long before dawn. Got dressed and left the bunk house before any of the other hands had even begun to stir. The two clones had not been welcome in the large shed that the farm hands shared. So accommodations had been set up in the hayloft of the barn. They were very much like Wrong Hordak had been at the beginning. Naive, blunt and overly literal. Which led to miscommunication and frustration among the farmhands. Adora had experience acclimating a freed clone to the wonders of the world. So she had become an interpreter and buffer. For the two Clones who just wanted to earn their place here on the farm. That yearning to be a part of and accepted within a larger group structure still drove them. But they didn’t understand yet how to navigate the complicated realm of social interaction with other free willed individuals. Being part of a military hive mind, they were never allowed to show emotion or express their thoughts, if they even had any. So they never had much use for speaking to each other besides confirming orders and acknowledging them. Understanding when someone was joking or annoyed with them was confusing. Instructing them about the proper facial expressions to use, to help them communicate could be frustrating. Emotion was so foreign to them, it was like having to teach them a whole new language. So they needed practice and lots of it. The farm hands were coming to understand their difficulties and some were more patient with them than others. But Adora was certain they would figure out ways to fit into Etherian society, they just needed time.

Adora took a deep breath as she walked across the yard, arching her back and turning and twisting her shoulders. Working out all the kinks from sleeping in that low cot. The hay mattress wasn't very firm, it shifted and crunch every time she tried to get comfortable. She was honestly about ready to toss her bedroll down in the barn, right in the aisle in front of Spirit's stall. But she didn't want to be rude at the kind gesture of giving her a bed to sleep in. So she had endured another restless sleep in the bunkhouse. The sky overhead was majestic, the blanket of stars twinkling high above seemed endless. Adora loved the stars and had been enraptured by them since Etheria had left Despondos. She stood in the open yard for a few minutes just gazing up at them in awe. Hands braced on her hips, marveling at the infinite starscape. Her people had maped the whole universe, based their language upon the stars. She wanted to understand them better… the First Ones…the Eternian's…their civilization had expanded far beyond just Etheria and Eternia… and countless other planets before the War with Prime began. Was it just the fact they were losing the war that drove them to exploit Etheria…Krytis and obviously many other planets for their magic. The First Ones knew that Magic was Prime's weakness that was why they were weaponizing it in so many other forms. They had created Omega Prime, the Mutants, Portable Runestones and the complicated weapon of this planet's artificial Heart. Hopefully all of those questions would be answered as soon as she got back to the Crystal Castle. Spirit had only been healing for a day, but she needed to speed things along. They needed to get back on the road quickly, she glanced down a Sheana's bracer. The blue runestone glowed softly, acknowledging her yearning to use the magic. Adora smiled softly and strode forwards with more purpose.

"Good morning." Adora unlatched the metal pin with a creak and clack. Pulling the gate open with a low groan. Spirit turned from staring out of the window, to find Adora standing in his pen. The warm glow of a lantern in one hand, illuminating the tender smile of greeting upon her face. Her other hand held a bowl of

ointment. He had expected Liam to come first thing this morning, but was content to see Adora as well.

She set the lantern down on a wooden barrel that was used as a make shift table or as a seat whatever was needed, while tending to grooming or hooves in the horse stalls. Then she moved gingerly through the hay, avoiding the waste dampening a few spots near the gate.

Spirit swishes his tail and huffs, turning his rump towards Adora so she doesn't have to move too far into his space. Standing obediently, as she pulls off the weighted blanket and folds it over the metal bars on the side of his pen.

"Thank you." Adora acknowledges his kind gesture, before starting to rub his hind quarter's down with salve. Her hand was glowing the whole time, infusing the ointment with healing magic. It was cathartic, working in the silence of the early morning. Speaking softly to him about everything that happened yesterday, with the clones and with Liam. Confiding in him once more. Basking in the smoother emotional flow across their link. He was content here on the farm, the grain was good but he yearned for a treat.

"I will see if I can find you some apples for breakfast." Adora offered, tucking the heavy blanket into place upon his back and giving him a tender patt on his cheek.

Spirit bunted her with his forehead, excited by her promise. Adora giggled and then turned towards the gate to his pen. Spirit reached out and nipped her shoulder gently. A silent inquiry about where she was going, as he wasn't ready to let her leave.

"Not too far, I was hoping to practice a bit with my sword and shield…I will just be outside the barn if you wanted to watch?" She offered, with a warm smile.

Spirit nodded as he turned towards his windows to illustrate where she would be in view for him.

Adora smiled softly and left Spirits stall. Heading down the earthen aisle, relishing in the quiet morning. The barn had a heady scent of horses and cattle, which she found comforting. Acknowledging a small group of young farm hands with a nod as they entered through the massive doors to attend to the livestock both inside the barn and outside in the various pens. That surrounded this large structure.

She moved off from the barn, just past the outer pig pens. Squinting towards the prairie beyond the farm's border fence, as the glare of dawn burned upon the horizon. She closed her eyes, as the gentle warmth of day spread over her face. Knowing that beyond Thaymor, deep within the lush embrace of the Whispering Woods. Hovering high above the mountain range that sat just north of Bright Moon. Upon the floating Island of Mystacor, Catra would be singing her morning greeting to the sun.

"I miss you…" She whispered softly.

Then took a deep, cleansing breath as she summoned both Despara's sword and Sheana's shield. They appeared in her hands in a flash of light. As she moved smoothly into her first set of attack forms. That Light Hope had taught her years ago. Holding the shield close to her chest, she thrust out with her sword. Then swung downward in a high arc, adjusting her grip to slash as she moved forward again. It had been a long time since she was practicing with both sword and shield. But Light Hope had been thorough with her training back then and it was coming back to her as easily as breathing.

"She's amazing, ain't she Pa?" Liam commented in a breathless whisper. As he leaned against the railing of the wrap-around porch of the farm house. He stared in awe, his eyes focused and unblinking. As he watched Adora training. She was both graceful and strong, as she slashed and thrusted with the blade. Moving her shield close to her body or swinging it outward as she blocked and attacked imaginary foes.

Jack stood stoically beside his son, leaning against a thick wooden post that held up the awning. Arms crossed over his chest as he slowly shook his head.

“Don’t be getting any crazy ideas, son.” He grumbled.

“What do you mean?” Liam mumbled back, bowing his head to pick nervously at the flaking paint upon the railing. Avoiding his father’s disapproving gaze.

Jack had caught his son admiring the young woman many times yesterday. He couldn’t fault him for it. Life on the ranch was dull, the day’s tended to blend together into predictable routines. Adora’s appearance was new and exciting. She was sparking his son’s thirst for adventure. It didn’t help that she was also very pretty, and had such a sweet and kind personality.

“She is She-Ra, the Princess of Power?” Jack arched an incredulous eyebrow. As if that fact alone was enough to put Liam in his place. It should have been pretty obvious that Adora was out of his league.

“So?” Liam spat back boldly. Yet, his eyes shone with self doubt, nervously picking at the peeling paint.

Jack growled and rolled his eyes. His son’s fixation on the She-ra would not end well.

“Do not get your hopes up, boy. Adora is going to leave us in a few days and you will never see her again. “ Jack shrugged.

“Or maybe, I could go with her?” Liam offered in a soft whisper. A wish spoken aloud, that was as much a plain statement of fact, or perhaps a passive ultimatum.

Jack made a loud, harumph sound, shaking his head.
“Stop pinning after the girl and go do your chores!” He commanded harshly, pushing off the post and heading down the steps and out into the yard.

Liam sighed and followed obediently after his father. His admiring gaze never leaves Adora. As he headed towards the large equipment sheds behind the barn.

The equipment shed was a mammoth building of riveted metal sheeting, bent over an iron girder frame. Creating a long, rounded shape that allowed the rain to run along the seams between the metal sheets that formed the roof.

Two massive door's rolled away to either side, that took up the whole of the front of the shed. Allowing for the larger harvesters and other equipment to enter and exit for field prep and repairs.

The dawning light was gleaming off the large silver ribs that ran the length of the shed. Forcing Jack to adjust his hat to shield his eyes, while Liam merely squinted. Soon they had crossed the cavernous threshold and into the cool shade inside. The shed had a damp, musky smell that hung heavy in the air. Small chirping birds echoed from the rafter's high above. Their booted feet crunched softly on the earthen floor. As they moved between the hulking machinery, currently clogging the front of the shed. Moving swiftly behind to the open backend of the shed. That was filled with small walls of crates along the sides. A set of large metal working tables filled the center of the building, with various other fabricating machines sitting on top. Various tools and machinery scraps were scattered over the other tables. All repurposed Horde tech, scavenged from the war torn fields. All in various states of assembly. A large, well muscled man was hunched over a back table. He was bald, with tiny nubs on the side of his head were ears might have been? Wearing the typical commoner's clothes, beige cloth pants and a well worn pale blue long sleeve shirt. Stained with oil and various other lubricants. He had rolled up the sleeves above his elbows. He was wearing a dark padded leather apron of a blacksmith draped over his front. With bulky, heavy gloves that came up to his elbows. A bulky utility belt was tied around his thick waist, the pockets filled to

bursting with wires, small tools, bolts, nuts and other tiny parts used to fix machines.

“Kronis.” Jack called as they got closer. “How is the installation of that Bots, energy core I gave you yesterday?”

Liam hung back as his father went to speak with the old Maker. Picking up strange, half assembled objects from the table and attempting to figure out what they did.

As Kronis turned from the work table. His green skinned face was weathered and deeply pock marked from either disease or long days in front of a forge. Jack never inquired, he didn’t care what a person looked like, just what they could contribute to the farm. Kronis lower jaw had been replaced with a jagged piece of metal. It wasn’t pretty, but functional. Kronis’s yellow eyes glowed in the half light of the shed. Jack figured he might have some lizard-kin, or perhaps Gar in his heritage to make his skin such an odd, mottled green color.

Jack could see his monitor’s, one had a harvester’s schematics. The other had, Entrapta’s scowling face, tapping her chin as she reviewed information upon her own monitor’s back in her lab. He had never really paid any attention to the politics of the Maker community, but he knew she had been cast out when she joined the Horde. It was common knowledge that the Princess of Dryl was still very much a piraria in the Maker Community and still shunned by most. But since the war ended, she had been working to regain their trust. Sharing her breakthroughs and every bit of knowledge she had uncovered about the First Ones, the Horde and the Universe beyond. Seeking only to strengthen and better the lives of every Etherian.. He trusted Kronis, he had been their Tech Master for over a year now. If the Old man was willing to work with Entrapta, then he must see her council of value in his work.

“This is genius.” Entrapta praised, tapping on her pad that was just out of view.

“Thank you, Princess. As a part of the Maker community, I seek to contribute how I can to get Etheria self-sufficient again. I agree with your assessments, it is about time we wean ourselves off the Ancient First Ones tech.” He turned back to the monitor. With his jaw he was incapable of smiling, but his eyes shone with pride.

“Is it alright if I refine your repurposed power core schematics? Perhaps with this research. I might be able to diversify the installations into more kinds of tech? Alwyn and the Kingdom of Snows will most definitely need this! ” She exclaimed, typing furiously on her keypad.

“By all means, I know you will put it to good use.” Kronis nodded, cutting the feed so he wasn’t keeping Jack waiting.

Entrapta never even said goodbye, cutting her end of the feed first. As she also judged that their communication had reached a beneficial end.

It was midmorning, by the time Jack and Liam left the shed. Kronis had meticulously walked them through the retrofit and the new control board he installed in the harvester. Kronis bid them farewell with a curt wave, watching them until they had moved beyond the huge rolling doors. Before he turned back to his work table, tapping on the far corner. Releasing a tiny drawer that was hidden underneath. With a resigned sigh, he pulled out a small earpiece and pressed it into his ear.

[This better be important Lock Jaw!] A deep, sultry voice snapped sharply from the ear piece as soon it was activated.

[I’ve sighted the bounty Prime offered.] He growled into the ear piece.

The woman on the other end laughed harshly for a moment before responding snidely.

[I guess you have been under deep cover in the Maker Community and haven’t heard. That bounty is meaningless now, Primes dead.]

Lock Jaw clamped his mouth shut, seeking to control his temper. He was not so out of touch that he hadn’t heard of Primes death.

[I may have been assigned to the ass-crack of Etheria, Lynn. But I am not that out of touch. I just dealt with a couple of his stringless puppets last night.]

[Whatever. Do not engage, she is under surveillance. Tri-clops wants to gather as much intel as possible before we take her into custody. She is far more powerful and deadly than Prime gave her credit for.] Lynn responded, with amusement.

[She’s just a woman with the magic to conjure weapons...She's no more deadly than a basic sorcerer. What are you talking about ?] Lock Jaw grumbled, tapping on his keyboard to activate his clearance to the Seeker Drone hovering out in the farm yard. With a flicker the schematic of his current creation disappeared. Replaced by an image of an athletically built young woman in a white long sleeve shirt and gray pants. With a long blonde ponytail, swaying back and forth as she moved in sharp jerking motions. The image pulled back, giving Lock Jaw more of a tableau picture of what was going on. She was currently stacking square bales in the hayloft with two freed clones.

[Your mission was not to apprehend the Etherian Rebel. But to infiltrate the Maker Guild. Stay on mission, Lord Skeletor wants to know how technologically advanced Etheria has become in the last thousand years. I suggest you leave her alone, Tri-clops is pretty messed up right now. So if you get yourself into trouble I can’t send him out to repair your cybernetics.] She snarled back.

[Noted] He grumbled back, pulling down the cuff of the thick glove on his left arm. Revealing a black, cybernetic arm, that he had been hiding for close to a year now.

[Lynn…out] She cut the feed with a loud buzz.

Lock Jaw yanked the earpiece out and tossed it angrily into the hidden drawer. He was tired of being undercover, bored with working with such ancient, simple tech. He had grown fond of the Etherian's though, but his fear of Lord Skeletor outweighed any compassion he might have for the people of this planet. So he would stay on mission. Their tech was still mostly powered by ancient First Ones crystals. As they were now, they would pose little threat to Skeletor's plans. Princess Entrapta ,though, had a brilliant mind. Her virus that freed the chipped Etherian's and the clones was startlingly inventive and highly adaptive for infiltrating and corrupting other computer systems across the universe.

Trap Jaw was quick to make himself known here on the Mainland. As a capable Tech Maker and just as brillant of an inventor. Moving from farm to village over the last year. Claiming to have invented a way to repurpose Horde Primes bots. Using their power cores in Etherian farm equipment and village power stations. Making the ancient first one power crystal obsolete. It was exactly what Entrapta had asked for weeks ago, after the First Ones systems began to go offline. Then the Rune Stones died and Mystacor almost fell out of the sky.

He had used some basic Eternian engineering tricks he had learned in his youth. While he had been banished to wastes of the Dark hemisphere of Eternia. After his failed coup to usurp the Council Elders from Eternos. He had joined a brigand gang and learned how to scavenge and repurpose old Horde tech from the time of the Great Unrest. That had been left rot after the Uprising, the great civil war that had sundered the people of Eternia forever into two hemispheres. Not content to be just a waste thug, he had quickly risen in rank and brought all the brigand gangs under one banner. Leading a raid upon Snake Mountain. But Lord Skeletor proved to be far more powerful than his army of mercenaries and thugs. Leaving him the lone survivor and hideously maimed.

Skeletor had seen something in him, something worth saving. So he had Tri-clops rebuild his right arm and lower jaw with mechanical parts. He was mostly a weapon's expert now, his skills were in repurposing tech. Which he had used to join the Maker community here on Etheria and over the last year become one of the most renowned new tech inventor's on the Mainland. Creating a trusted name for himself as Tech Master Kronis.

Adora returned to Spirit's stall after lunch with a tin bucket of freshly picked apples. Enticing him to leave his stall, by brandishing an apple under his nose and leading him out into the aisle. The Stallion was more than eager to leave his pen, following Adora back out into the warmth of the mid-day sun. Munching happily on his treat, as she led the way through the farmyard, tossing him an apple from time to time.

Spirit shook his wither's, trotting around Adora as they passed the weather worn, wooden front gate to the farm. Charging ahead into a canter, as they wandered into the wild, open fields beyond. Adora set the now empty bucket by a fence post, before following Spirit into the rolling prairie.

"May I join you?" Liam shouted, jogging to catch up to her.

Adora turned and offered him a warm smile of greeting and a curt nod, silently inviting the young man to walk beside her.

"Spirit needed to stretch his legs. He has been cooped up for too long in that barn." Adora nodded towards the horse, currently prancing and kicking jovially in the distance.

"Is it true Spirit was once your Alicorn? Swift Wind." Liam inquired, his tone soft and wistful.

"Yes." Adora sighed, the guilt still heavy in her voice.

"Amazing…The farm hands have been talking about your adventures all day. I overhead a bit, while doing my morning

chores. ” Liam shrugged, unsure if he was making her uncomfortable by asking about Swift Wind.

Adora had been swarmed by the younger farm hands last night, when she was relaxing in a chair by the fire in the bunkhouse. They had sat around her on the floor and bombarded her with endless questions and begged for stories. She had reluctantly began to tell them tales about her time in Bright Moon fighting the Etherian Horde and finding the Sword of Protection. She never saw herself as a storyteller, but she had soon gathered some of the adult farmhands as well. She felt pride in how enthralled they all were with her adventures. The companionable air in the bunkhouse reminded her of her time in the rebellion, while they were hiding from the Galactic Horde. Sitting around a fire glyph, listening to Bow pluck his lute. Perfuma would share folktales from Plumeria, or they would listen to Sea Hawk sing shanties. He would teach Catra the more raunchy ones, after Frosta had gone to bed. Because out of all of them, she found them the most entertaining. Then they would enjoy tormenting each other and everyone else. By changing the lyrics and making them even more dirty and crass. An unspoken competition between them, of sorts to see how flustered they could make everyone and each other. It was all in good fun, more or less and Adora would always intercede and get Catra under control before it got really disgusting. It helped keep Sea Hawks' spirits up and allowed Catra to unleash her snarky wit in a more friendly manner.

Adora could feel her cheeks warm at the thought of Catra, singing those dirty songs. With a wistful sigh and fond smile, she finally responded to Liam.

Liam's nervous expression turned into a confident grin, at her warm regard.

“We still have our bond and he is still very intelligent. His body has changed because my magic is currently restrained into these gauntlets.” She raised her gauntlets for emphasis.

“May I see them?” Liam inquired, suddenly very fascinated by her armor.

Adora thought about it for a moment before shrugging and offering Liam her wrists, so he could inspect the metal gauntlets.

“Before Primes Invasion, we had an Artisan from Mysticor staying with us for a time. Studying the local river stones. We mostly have Granite, limestone and shale. He did find a few agates and clear quartz though.” Liam offered her a small, grateful smile as he clasped her wrists in his hands. His grip was firm but gentle.

“He made leather armor and jewelry, using local stones to store magical aura’s.I followed that old Leathersmith for season’s and he taught me everything he knew about magic gems, healing crystals and simple stones. I have been fascinated by stones ever since.” He continued, his dreamy reverie into his past falling silent as the Gemstones glinted in the sunlight.

“The Gem Stones…” Liam squinted, slowly turning her wrists in and out of the sunlight.
“There are many layers….” He muttered, drawing his hands down her wrist to hold her fingers more firmly. As he continued to inspect both Rune Stones, his gaze unblinking and totally focused.

Adora swallowed, suddenly nervous about how animated he had become and how penetrating his gaze was upon her magical bracer’s. His eyes were far too close and intimate, like a lover's stare.

“A quartz….so many layers…Amethyst…Sodalite…Clear Calcite and some I can not even identify. ” He whispered in awe, turning to the Red Gemstone. “A Sardonyx…Carnelian…Obsidian…Garnet… again, more I can not name.” He slowly shook his head in disbelief.

“These are truly amazing…” He heaved a breath, overwhelmed by the power he glimpsed. Taking a resolute step back from her.

Noticing the crimson blush now accenting her face, he chuckled and bowed his head. Relishing that his close proximity had unintentionally had such an obvious impact on her.

Clearing his throat he turned towards Spirit, giving her time to calm down.

“Different Gem Stones and Crystals are capable of holding different types of magical charges. The facets of your Rune Stones hold a fathomless amount of magical energy.” He advised, clasping his hands behind his back and not looking back at her.

Adora stared down at her bracer’s and nodded.
“The First Ones used Gemstones and Crystals to store magic and information.” She commented lightly.

Liam nodded, “Mystacor has the very same practices. No doubt passed down from the First Ones who survived the Great Unrest.”

“What kind of magic do my RuneStones possess?” Adora asked, honestly quite intrigued.

“The Blue stone…is a Quartz. A very strong and resilient crystal.” Liam finally turned and pointed to the Golden gauntlet. “From what I could tell…holds the magic of Love, Healing, Insight and the Divine and much more.”

“Sheana…” Adora whispered, staring in awe at the blue stone.

“The Red Gem…” Liamm pointed to the silver gauntlet. “Is a Sardonyx, a type of Agate. It is a stone of strength, courage and protection. A very powerful stone.”

He reached out and tapped the Runestone, with a smirk. Snatching his hand back and clutching it protectively against his chest, when it flared and began to hum menacingly.

Adora cringed, as Despara’s disapproval burned red hot inside of her. She laughed nervously and clamped her own hand over the stone to calm it down.

Liam cleared his throat, seeking to settle his sudden fear. Feeling rather humiliated that he had reacted so fearfully when the stone flashed.

“Despara…can be rather volatile..I suggest you don’t tap her again.” Adora advised with a weak smile.

“Yes, of course.” Liam sighed, rubbing the back of his head nervously before continuing. “The magical properties I could see were Strength, Passion, Decisive action and Determination.” He began to walk back towards the front gate of the farmyard, glancing over his shoulder to see if she was following.

Adora whistled to Spirit, before jogging to Liam’s side. The stallion fell into step with them as they crossed under the wooden gate once again.

“I heard you call your Runes by their names?” He asked quietly.

“Yes, Sheana, The Light Bearer and Despara the Harbinger of Darkness.” Adora nodded.

“Ah, your title…She-Ra makes much more sense now.” Liam chuckled. Adora frowned in confusion not understanding where he was going with this train of thought.

“The Artisan spoke of many kinds of magic that could be held within the facets of different Stones. Light and Dark are the Source of all magic in the universe. The Alpha and the Omega. The beginning and the end of all things.” Liam explained.

Adora held her breath as grim clairity took hold over her. She had never thought too deeply about the title the First one had given to Etheria’s Greatest Warrior. But it made so much more sense now. Liam, if unintentionally had given her yet one more piece to the puzzle that was her magic. When she got to the Crystal Castle she knew she would finally find all the answer’s she needed and begin her journey to becoming She-Ra once again.

“I’ve been working on a saddle and barding for my horse for a couple of years now, I would love to show you.” He offered an eager smile pulling upon his lips.

Adora was genuinely interested and wanted to agree to go with him. His gentle nature and keen intelligence made him easy to be around. She felt calm in his presence and wanted to learn more about Gemstones. But she caught sight of Jack leaning against a post upon the porch waiting for her. Remembering her promise, she shook her head sadly.

“Perhaps another time, your father is waiting for me.” She chucked a thumb back to the farm house before turning on her heel and jogging towards the porch. Spirit followed, nibbling on the grass as he ambled over to the porch.

Leaving Liam watching her leave with veiled disappointment, shimmering in his eyes.

“Yeah, next time.” He growled, kicking a clump of earth before heading towards the barn. The horse armor wasn’t quite finished yet, perhaps this might be a good thing. He would have time to put on the final touches before showing it to her. Perhaps he could fit it upon Spirit? That would be a great gift to offer, in return for saving his life. With that thought in mind, Liam had a spring in his step as he jogged to his workshop. Tucked away in the back of the barn in a spare stall.

Shadows of Eternia

Huntara groaned, squinting her eyes open just a crack. Her mind was foggy, her memories muddled. Finding herself laying face down on a cold metal floor. Within a small, barren room. It had barely been a day or perhaps two? Since she had been defeated in battle on the heath high up on Scorpion Hills and then taken prisoner by that Cyborg…Tri-Clops.

Her cell was barely lit, the small lights embedded high on the wall flickered. The faint hum of electricity is a soft white noise in the background. There were no windows, just three smooth flat metal walls. With the glowing green barrier of an energy shield, at the front of the tiny cell. By her spartan accommodations, she surmised that she was locked away in a military compound. She could taste a coppery musk in her mouth…blood. She sighed and rolled over onto her back, flopping a powerful arm over her eyes. As a sharp pain ignited in her side, as she shifted position. Making her suck in a startled breath, then she grunted and tried to take in air more gently. Her ribs were cracked or broken? Her whole body hurt, her muscles throbbing. It felt as if she had been beaten with a club? Perhaps the Eternian soldier's here had worked her over, while unconscious. She didn't remember anything beyond being tied up at the back of that bastards hover sled then waking up in here. The memory of her futile battle with Tri-clops flashed in her mind. Her anger surged, along with a good dose of humility. Followed by a wave of exhaustion and pain. Huntara adjusted her position once more, if a bit more gingerly. Sitting up and slumping against the back wall of the cell. Stretching her legs out straight, allowing a low, growl of discomfort to rumble out from deep in her throat.

She had to escape? Had to think of a way out of this? No one knew where she was, or that she had been captured? She was all on her own here. Unless she could figure out a way to get a message back to the Alliance? There might still be hope, she could save herself?

Carefully, trying not to move too much. She took stock of herself and her surroundings. The earpiece she was using to spy on the Eternian's was gone, also her bladed, retractable staff was absent from her belt. Either lost on the heath or taken from her before being thrown into this cell. Her boot knife was gone and she had two new pieces of jewelry on her wrists. Two thin metal bracelets, she could also feel a metal collar around her neck. She had a good sized cut running along her hairline near her left ear. Dried blood was caked over her temple and smeared across her cheek. They must have clubbed her unconscious when Tri-Clops got to this place in his War Sled. Explained why she didn't remember much as to how she got in this cell. Her head was pounding, which was even more proof of receiving a blow to the head.

Turning her head slightly, she caught sight of someone sitting cross legged in the deep shadows at the far corner of her cell. Her eyes flared in alarm, as she realized it was a person. A female, with long silver hair that cascaded over her hunched shoulders and down her back. The woman was covered so heavily in thick shadow. All Huntara could make out was what she could see in that sliver of pale light coming from the weak lights on the front corners of the cell. The woman was wearing pale blue leggings, with a dark navy blue leather armored skirt that hung low near her knees and long heavy black boots that rose up her calf to just under her knees. Huntara could not make out her features, since her head was bowed. In meditation or contemplation? Huntara could not determine. Was she a fellow prisoner? From the style of her armor, perhaps she was a magic user…from Mystacor? A sorceress?

"Hello?" Huntara called tentatively.

The woman slowly raised her head offering her a small, warm smile. Huntara swallowed hard, she was startlingly gorgeous. Yet a subtle warning of threat pulsed behind the numbing fog deep in the farthest recesses of her mind. That was quick to fade, replaced by tempered curiosity. The woman had very pale skin as if made of alabaster. With high, prominent cheekbones and deep, ocean blue eyes that seemed to draw her attention and hold it

firm. The alluringly fierce woman slowly rose to her feet and crossed to the front of the cell. The energy barrier finally illuminates her features more fully. Giving Huntara the first real good look at her cell mate. She wore a tight, dark blue leather armored bodice that matched her skirt. Hugging her large breasts and slender, toned stomach. With the same alien runic metal swirls that adorned her long skirt. A heavy black hide cloak hung off her shoulders, with a thick white furred collar around the hood. Her upper arms were bare, except for two silver gauntlets adorning her wrists all the way up to her elbows. Each armored piece had a dark crimson stone embedded upon the wrist. She wore dark black leather gloves, with silver armored inlay on the top of her hands, that looked like the scales of a serpent. That she was currently pulling off as she smiled tolerantly down at her. A superior air in her casual demeanor. As she tucked the armored gloves into the thin leather, braided belt that adorned her curved waist.

“Stand before me, Rebel.” Her voice was sultry, regal and smooth.

Huntara recognized it, but she couldn’t remember where? It was a struggle to form coherent thoughts, in the concussed haze she was in. Huntara merely stared up at her, with a blank expression.

The calm, commanding woman watched Huntara without emotion for a moment, waiting for her to obey. Huntara didn’t move towards her, but she did stand up though. Her added height allowed her to stare down at the woman with silent defiance. The shorter woman turned her back on Huntara with a resolute nod, pulling the long black gloves away from her belt and methodically putting them back on. Making sure the gloves were nice and tight on her fingers. Then lunged forward clearing the distance between them at blinding speed. Raising her arm and slapping Huntara across the cheek. Her hand connected like a thunderclap, snapping Huntara’s head sideways with the force of the blow. When Huntara still did not do as she was instructed. Standing frozen at attention, her Horde conditioning taking over. At the sudden, brutal assault of corporal punishment. It was how her staff sergeant had kept the cadet’s under his command under

control. Growing up in the Horde, she understood and responded to this kind of violence on a very visceral level. All emotion flooded from her, she did not react to the attack. Her expression stern, eye's hardened like granite. Staring at some distant point just past the shorter woman's shoulder.

The woman smiled, an arrogant self satisfaction in the subtle curl of her lips. Abruptly she backhanded Huntara across the other cheek. Snapping the taller woman's head to the opposite side. The sharp edges of the armor plates on the back of her glove split Huntara's lower lip.

"Even after your first lesson, are you still unbroken? I am going to enjoy breaking you…my pet."" She chuckled ruefully. Pacing away to the left, carding her fingers together to tighten the gloves once more. Huntara licked away the blood from the corner of her mouth. She had no memory of the beating she had taken last. But no doubt this woman had been the one to administer it.

"I guess another lesson is in order, I do enjoy training my new pets." She turned crisply on her heels. Her boots tapped a crescendo back towards Huntara.

"You are lucky, to have me as your master. I am far kinder and more lenient than the blood thirsty War Monger's my lord employs on other worlds to maintain order. They would have used the control collar without hesitation at the first sign of disobedience." She stood before Huntara and tapped the thin, smooth circlet that now hugged her throat.

Huntara growled, quickly clasped the collar with both hands and attempted to rip it off. Instantly, it crackled in retaliation. Red lightning surged forth, as the metal glowed a blood red. The agony was instant, electricity tearing across her body in blinding arc's. That felt as if her flesh was being flayed, sending her writhing to the floor.

"I have a soft spot for strong, beautiful women. I must admit, it is a weakness. So I am loath to punish you in any way that might

scar that wonderful body of yours. I have no desire to ruin my pet's ability to please me in the future." She admitted, watching with fake pity.

As Huntara grunted and moaned in pain. Curling herself up into a tight ball to protect the more vulnerable parts of her body. In case this crazy, sadistic woman wanted to punish her in a more intimate way.

"I favor the glove more for how tactile the punishment is. I understand it is less effective than the collar but I do enjoy feeling my pet's body." She shrugged, snapping her hand towards Huntara's cheek. Smiling coyly as the taller woman fought not to flinch. When all she received was a tender pat upon the cheek. Huntara blinked rapidly and took a deep breath, seeking to calm herself. She would not retaliate at least not yet. For right now this woman had all of the control. That collar when activated would render her prone and vulnerable upon the floor in seconds. She would not be able to defend herself when all that electricity was short circuiting her muscles. Leaving her mind and body temporarily numb from the intensity of the pain. She needed to be patient and gather info before planning her escape. She would find this woman's weakness and exploit it! She was a trained Horde Soldier, she could endure…and she would prevail…when the time was right she would strike this woman down and reclaim her freedom.

"That was a warning." The smaller woman's voice grew cold and hard. "You will address me as Master Lynn and you will eagerly obey my every command."

Huntara squeezed her eyes shut tight, grinding her teeth in both humiliation and frustration at the predicament she was in. Vowing that for now, she would obey, she would call this horrible woman, Master. But the title would be curse, a snide and disrespectful word, she would spit at her.

"You are an Eternian…" Huntara growled, slowly rising back onto her feet. Refusing to call her Master just yet, she still held onto a

good amount of defiance.

“Yes.” Lynn responded in a clipped tone, sounding bored. Huntara took a deep breath to steady her voice.

“You work for this Skeletor fella?” Huntara pushed on.

The woman rolled her eyes and crouched before her. Fear and resentment burning in her icy blue eyes at the mention of Skeletor. The emotion was quickly hidden behind an air of superiority and an arrogant smirk.

“I believe you need further training, my pet.” Lynn cooed. “You are not allowed to talk, unless I order you too.” She lunged out again, grabbing Huntara by her pony tail and yanking her forward onto her knees. The sudden burst of impossible strength was uncanny…almost magical in nature.

Then the wall behind Huntara surged to life in a blinding flare of light. Her whole body went ramrod straight, as an invisible force pulled her towards the wall. She cried out in alarm as her body slammed into the wall and was held in place. The bracelets and collar seemed to be magnetic. Stuck in place with her arms linked over her head and forced to stand slightly off balance, on her tiptoes. She glared down at the malevolent silver haired woman now, smiling eagerly at her. Knowing she held all the power and could do whatever she wished to her without retaliation of any kind.

“As I have said, I enjoy a more tactical approach to breaking my pets.” Lynn spoke softly, sliding her index finger seductively down Huntara’s cheek and under her chin. Huntara could only flinch and squeeze her eyes shut at the unwanted touch. Watching in fear as Lynn unlatched a slender, highly polished, dark wooden baton from her belt. That had been out of view before since it was at her back. It had a smooth bulbous head on one end, looking strangly erotic. Upon further inspection, Huntara realized that it was a polished, onyx, skull of some vile, strange alien. With large, elongated hollow eyes and the sharp teeth of a predator. Clamped

shut in a deathly, rigamortis smile. Huntara swallowed her revulsion as she watched the woman caress the skull, in a highly suggestive manner. As if trying to arouse a lover. The carved skull began to glow a fiery red, like molten steel.

"This is an ancient weapon..a family heirloom, I guess. A Horde Ula…dating back to the time of the First Ones. I find it is a very versatile 'tool' for training. It was 'gifted' to me by an old mentor of mine, when he passed away." She grinned coyly, showing off her perfect teeth. Huntara was quick to catch the dark satire in her tone. This tool of torture had not been gifted but taken by force, when Lynn had killed the previous owner. The sight of the club like weapon, sent shivers of pure terror through Huntara. As her sluggish mind began to clear. She started to remember the agony she already endured at the hands of this vile woman. As flashes of her previous day of torture flared in her mind. Her heart ramped up and her breath stuttered into shallow pants as the woman stalked towards her. Preparing herself for the unbearable pain ahead.

Huntara was barely able to clench her abdominal muscles before the woman rammed the glowing skull into her stomach. Huntara stubbornly clenched her jaw tight, refusing to give the woman what she wanted. Knowing that she had relished her cries of agony the last time. With all her strength, Huntara refused to show weakness. She would become stone, hard, impassive and resilient. Her core self would be sealed away behind impenetrable walls of her iron will. Her mind and body may break in time, but it would be a slow, wearing like water upon the river stones. It was strange that these memories of torture were coming back now… the fog lifting from her mind. As the unbearable pain intensified and tore through her body, webbing outward from the point of contact. Until every muscle, every nerve was on fire. The previous days of misery were so vivid and unfiltered, as Huntara writhed against the wall. The woman ground the glowing bulb, between her breasts, her underarms, her groin. Attacking all the most vulnerable parts of her body. Until the last of Huntara's restraint crumbled away and she threw her head back and screamed. Her voice echoing like the howls of the damned, through the empty

corridors of the dungeon. As the woman shuddered, eyes half closed in rapture at the blissful sounds of Huntara's misery. She was truly enjoying breaking this one and was looking forward to the days ahead. Finally after almost a year of endlessly boring reconnaissance for her Lord's lost artifacts. She could claim a brief, carnal pleasure for herself. This mission was finally becoming worthwhile.

"I have no idea what it is?" Adora mumbled in disappointment. She had only been carving wood for little more than a day. Yet she had expected more progress towards making the chunks of wood she whittled… resemble something.

Once again she was left with some strange, angular shape with four pointy bits at the bottom and a triangle on one side.

"It takes time and patience to carve things out of wood." Jack chuckled, as Adora handed him the odd half formed chunk of wood with a disgruntled huff.

"Both things I am lacking as of the moment." She responded, bracing her chin with a fist. As she frowned and rocked back and forth with growing agitation in her wooden armchair. She had been idle for only a couple days, yet it was eating away at her. She couldn't help but feel that she was wasting time, time she didn't have. She needed to get to the Crystal Castle…

"What was it supposed to be?" Jack asked, turning the angular hunk of wood back and forth trying to figure it out.

"A horse…" Adora sighed, watching Liam, chopping wood from a huge pile. Then stacking the cut pieces into a large, open storage shed built behind the back porch of the farm house. There were at least three or more sheds, all lined up near the farmhouse back porch that would need to be filled before the first snow.

The young man had disappeared for a bit in the early afternoon. But returned to the farmhouse closer to supper. It hadn't taken

Liam long to over heat from the strenuous work, needing to take his shirt off to cool down. Sweat beaded and glistened upon his barrel chest. Rolling in streams down the inclines of his large arms and between his well defined pectoral muscles. His dark hair was soaked, from the few hours of long exertion of chopping and stacking wood. Adora had been so engrossed in her carving. She had been completely oblivious to the yearning looks, Liam would cast her. Silently, hopeful to catch her watching him with approving eyes again.

Jack cast her a sympathetic smile and nod, setting her poor attempt at a horse down on the table between them. Then turned his weathered face towards the setting sun glowing upon the horizon. Setting fire to the sky and turning the low flying clouds to brilliant flame.

“She should be singing her farewell to the sun right now.” Adora smiled softly as she took in the sunset, that will now always remind her of Catra. Suddenly overwhelmed by longing to hold her again. She sighed heavily and cast her longing gaze downward. Her blue eyes were wet, but determined. Missing Catra, was not an uncommon feeling for her. She had spent three years dealing with it. It had been her constant companion, along with the guilt and yearning to fix things between them.

“Who?” Jack questioned softly, already dreading the answer.

“Catra…I miss her so much already.” Adora answered, warmth and devotion clear in her yearning tone.

Jack scowled at her, tapping a finger against the armrest of his chair. He was wise enough with love. To hear how deeply Adora's affection ran towards this Catra. What he didn’t know was if it was platonic or romantic love? His gaze swept towards his son, who had taken a break from chopping and was leaning against the hilt of the axe. Currently embedded into the chopping block. Just staring at Adora, while the blonde stared wistfully towards the setting sun. Jack sighed heavily, either way, he couldn’t stop his son's infatuation with her. Or his misguided attempts to woo her,

striving ardently for Adora's attention…his hope fueled by any scrap of affection she may offer him. He was young once and had fallen madly in love as well. Only time would tell if Liam's heart would be accepted or rejected. If the boy even had the courage to offer it. He hoped that Adora left before his son gained such bravery. He saw no future for him with Adora. She had a destiny far greater than being a farmer's wife. She was Etheria's greatest hero, its savior. She wielded the most powerful magic upon Etheria. She would always be needed to defend the planet. Shouldering the burden of protecting countless lives. Her future was far greater than he could comprehend. She would hold witness to unbelievable wonders and endure unmentionable horrors. That would be far more traumatizing and deadly than anything he had survived as a Soldier. He did not feel that kind of price was worth the physical and mental scars. His son would one day carry if he ran away to join She-Ra on her journeys. Jack just knew, She-Ra would never regard Liam in the ways he wished…he was just a simple, farmer's son. He needed to understand that and be content with his lot in life. This dream to follow her, to become a hero…to somehow have her fall in love with him…it was only going to lead him to heartbreak or death. Jack groaned in dread and bowed his head, refusing to look at his son. Who had so ardently spent the entire afternoon, seeking to gain a single look of approval from Adora. Who seemed completely oblivious to his son's attraction to her.

The evening found Adora back in the bunkhouse. Sitting around the single wooden table with several farm hands, the farm's engineer and the two clones. Playing a game, she had learned was called 'poker'. It was a serious game, somewhat fast paced. It was a game of chance, of strategy and devious bets. One had to be cunning and have a good..'poker face.' Temper's flared since money was on the line. Each hand could bring a flood of gold or one could lose everything. So far she had been playing it safe. Betting moderate amounts of her coin and only upping the wager when she knew her hand was good. She could not bluff to save her life so never tried.

Other farmhands at the table were not faring as well. She sat stiffly in her chair, holding her cards close to her body. Scrutinizing each one and flicking her eyes up from her deck. To gauge the expressions of the other players sitting around the table. Trying to figure out her next move or her next wager. Then staring at the small pile of gold, silver and copper coins she had piled up in front of her. So far she had lost as much as she gained, she was breaking even.

A middle aged Thaymorian sat next to her. He had a gentle, round face and laughing hazel eyes. With short curly brown hair, that tufted out around his curved horns. His long ears flicked, as he glowered down at his hand.

“That’s it, I want Syrn and Riley back!” He shouted in disgust, slamming his cards down on the table. An older, broader man sat beside the lean deer hybrid. His worn and weathered, pale green skin was shiny with sweat. From sitting too close to the heat of the fire nearby. He had no ears, only tiny holes surrounded by bumpy, scar tissue. A dented, jagged metal plate adorned his chin, where his lower jaw once was. He wore a simple pale blue long sleeve shirt tucked into thick, leather gloves and tan cloth pants. Heavy black boots adorned his feet and the smell of oil lingered upon his clothes. His yellowed eyes regarded the Thaymorian with sympathy. As he placed a restraining hand on the hybrid's forearm.

“Calm down, Garrin. You are not doing that badly.” He sighed as he sought to halt the smile that now spread across his upper lip.

“Kronis, I’ve lost several hands in a row!” Garrin stabbed an accusing finger towards the two clones. Who were sitting across the table from him, blinking innocently as they held their cards next to their chests. Both had tall piles of Gold, silver and copper coins neatly stacked beside them.

“We all have bad days.” Kronis soothed.

“I have never lost that many hands in a row, in my life!” Garrin snarled, glaring down at his greatly diminished stack of coins.

Adora chewed on her bottom lip, not liking where Garrin's anger was directed. If things turned violent she would have to intercede.

“Their cheating…I have no idea how…but their cheating!” Garrin slammed his palm down on the table. The vibration causes the Clones coin tower’s to tumble.

Adora was shocked and a bit angry at his accusation. “They would not know how.” She began to defend the clones, “We both just learned to play this game tonight.”

Garrin snapped his heated glare towards her. “How would you know they haven’t played this game before?”

“I wouldn’t….I just….” Adora stuttered, as the ice blue gem on her silver bracer started to tremble.

“How can you defend them? You are the ‘Mighty She-Ra’. Who protects the weak and vanquishes all evil. Those two are evil.” Garrin spat, his eye’s glossy with frustration and rage.

“They are not evil!” Adora stood up abruptly, cheeks heating with rage and indignation.

“Look, Garrin. “ Kronis stood up and put a bracing hand on the Thaymorian’s shoulder. “You need to calm down.”

“Calm down…Calm down…Kronis. I’m broke! Those two con-artists took me for everything I had!” Garrin shouted.

“We are not cheating,” Came the quiet reply from both clones at once.

Garrin sagged in his chair, as he tossed his cards on the table in disgust then crossed his arms over his chest. Arching an eyebrow incredulously.

“We have been taught the rules and have figured out how to play the game very well.” The first clone boasted, in a bland emotionless tone.

“We have found it is a simple game of skill and mathematics.” The second clone added.

“We memorized the symbols on the cards and calculated the odds. We recognize the betting patterns and merely count the cards. To know when to bluff, how much or little to bet, or when to fold.” The first clone added.

Kronis’s jaw dropped and Garrin groaned.

“You can’t count cards! That’s cheating!” Garrin whined, pinching his nose in frustration.

“Oh…” Both clones, confident air deflated into somber contemplation. As they hung their heads behind their massive piles of coins.

“I shoulda know better than to play cards with clones.” Garrin moaned, shoving off from the table and gathering up the remainder of his coins. The rest of the farm hands were quick to throw down their cards and gather their coins as well. Everyone casts the clones' scathing looks of distrust and betrayal. Adora watched them go, as Garrin stormed out of the bunkhouse. Disappearing into the darkness of the farmyard beyond. Her attention focused on the open door until she heard the scraping of chair legs and turned back to the table.

Finding both clones, filling their coin pouches with their pilfered ‘winnings’. Their pale faces showed no emotion at all. Then they promptly left the bunkhouse through the front door, headed to their own cots in the barn loft. Since the farmhands refused to bunk with them. Adora frowned, the clones seemed indifferent now, to what they did. Intentionally or not.

“They are an odd couple.” Kronis grumbled, softly.

Adora slowly brought her gaze back to him. He was now lounging back in his chair with his arms crossed behind his head. The flickering light of the fire in the bunkhouse's stone fireplace, glowing over his stern face. Making him look more fearsome than he actually was.

"You are going to have your hands full with those two, for sure." Kronis nodded.

"What do you mean?" Adora sighed, thumping the back of her head against her chair.

"You have become responsible for them now. I've watched them, they follow you around the farm like two lost little ducklings. Always lingering nearby to help you with your chores. They act like lost wolf cubs who have imprinted on you. So for whatever reason, they will never willingly leave your side." Kronis observed with a smirk.

"They are not my pets, they do not belong to me." Adora advised, her tone crisp and stern.

"No, but they are not individuals yet either." Kronis nodded, "They don't even have names."

"They are like Wrong Hordak…" Adora bowed her head in contemplation. Realizing that these two clones were not ready for the real world. They were just like Wrong Hordak had been so long ago. Innocent, lost and confused as to how to navigate without the hive mind to guide them. With that she gathered up her meager coins into her own pouch and headed after the clones. Resolute to be what they needed…a Guardian, a teacher, a friend… until they were ready to set forth on their own.

She was slowly crossing the farmyard, admiring the night sky once more. Headed towards the barn to say goodnight to Spirit, when a great noise erupted from inside. She rushed through the partly open doors, to find both clones nervously dancing around a highly

agitated Spirit in the aisle. The horse had kicked down his stall door. The busted wooden gate was hanging limply off to the side on one hinge. Spirit was tossing his head from side to side, eyes rolling and searching the air high above. Spirit had gotten upset like this earlier, just before lunch. She stopped stacking bales in the loft to go down and calm him in his stall. He had been ready to kick it open then too. But as soon as his freak out had happened he had instantly calmed down, but remained stoic and vigilant.

The fear and anger that had burned through their bond then was ignited into an inferno right now. Adora cringed in pain for a moment, before taking action. Charging towards the wild stallion without fear. It took a moment to realize that Spirit was now adorned in thick leather armor. The Croupiere that protected his hind quarters was layered leather of the darkest brown, with fine silver chain mail links inlaid over top. He wore a well worn saddle that didn't quite fit with the new leather adorning his well muscled frame. The boiled leather of the saddle was cracked and chipped upon the pommel and the floral etching along the seams was nearly worn smooth. The leather stirrups were weathered and the metal boot straps slightly rusted. An elegant leather Petral that was draped over his chest, with metal plates flaring up along his flanks like the mighty wings of a Pegasis. The leather Chanfron upon his brow was shaped like a triangle, simple and elegant. With a long, slender horn of brilliant white gemstone that thrusted upward proudly. His riding tackle was firmly in place around his ears, angrily biting upon the bit in his mouth. As his reins dangled and swayed around his feet. Adora was quick to lunge for the reins, snatching them from the ground before Spirit tripped.

"Whoah, there…" She breathed, wrapping the leather binding around her wrist and forearm as she moved to confront the highly agitated Stallion.

Spirit snorted, his nostrils flaring as she pulled his head down. Placing a hand tenderly upon his brow. The silver bracer trembled, as both Sheana's and Despara's gems glowed softly. Adora gasped in fright, as the light bearer's and harbinger of darkness's power

was drawn out of the gemstones and absorbed by the horn adorning Spirits forehead. The horn flashed then began to glow, humming as a charge built inside the facets. Spirits nickered and yanked his head free from Adora's restraining grip. Pulling the reins free once more, as he galloped towards the partially open barn doors. Exploding out through the crack and into the night.

"Spirit!" Adora screamed in fear, ready to run after him. When a low moan and whimper of pain floated out of the Spirits stall. She rushed into the pen, to find Liam laid out upon the straw. Clutching his head and coughing as he regained air to his lungs. He must have been attaching the Armored Barding. Just before Spirit was startled and broke out of the stall. Unintentionally slamming the young man against the iron fencing along the side of the pen. When he had kicked down the stall's gate.

"We got him, sister. Go tend to your out of control steed…" The first clone knelt before Liam while the Second clone grasped her shoulder's, spun her around and ushered back out of the pen. Adora nodded, racing back out of the barn.

Terror… Rage…and an urgent sense of duty pierced like a blade across their sacred bond. As Adora sprinted into the night, across the moonlit farm yard. Flinching at how powerful the emotions were. As she charged up the wooden steps and circled around the farmhouse porch, panting heavily and out of breath. Catching sight of Spirit's pure white shape far in the distance. That seemed to be glowing with a ghostly, ethereal light within the darkness of the fields beyond the farm. He was galloping away at full speed, tossing his head upward as if tracking something? His fiery mane snapping like wildfire, as he raced away out of sight.

"Spirit!" Adora shouted in terrified desperation. Just as a blinding flash of light shot up into the sky just behind a hillside. Then faded away, replaced once more by the dim half light of the Greater Moon's, that were partially hidden amid the dark clouds above.

“Let's go find your horse, She-Ra!” Liam’s commanding voice drew Adora out of her sudden panic and refocused her. She looked down, finding him mounted on a dusty brown roan mare. That strangely had already been fitted into a saddle and tack. He was staring up at her with firm determination. She nodded and climbed behind him, wrapping an arm around his middle to stay on the horse's back. As Liam kicked the mare into a full gallop. The horse charged forward into the night, trusting Liam’s guidance fully.

The Scars we leave behind

Chapter Notes

Thank you to all who have left comments and Kudo's.

The last of Etheria's lunar court was on the wane. The smallest moon hung low in the sky. Falling silently into the mountain range that sprawled below the floating island of Mystacor.

Catra was the lone observer to the final moon's departure below the horizon. Sitting in somber reflection upon the clay tile roof of the Adept's Dorm's. Huddled in her leather coat, her ripped black leggings looked far more weathered and torn. From months of travel and enduring one battle after another.

Drawing her knees up tight to her chest and wrapping her arms around her legs. Tucking her tail tight around her ankles. Unconsciously making herself look smaller, the invisible weight of guilt and worry pressing down upon her, forcing her shoulders to bend.

Resting her chin upon her knees. Her dark ears falling in melancholy and exhaustion. Her mind had refused to give into sleep last night. Wound up far to tight, with constant intrusive thoughts. Nagging at her. That she was failing at being better, being a good friend…that she was once again hurting the people she cared about. Then the pendulum of her thoughts would swing and she would be worrying about Adora…catastrophizing about the future.

What was Eternia's agenda on Etheria….

The Nameless One…The Crystal of Kaydak?

Who was the little kitten…who stole the Crystal and Peekablue's involvement?

Where did those strange mutants….on Beast Island…disappear to?

Omega Prime…

All of these unknowns…all of these threats, they were like ticking time bombs that could go off at any moment.

Catra felt like she was suffocating…it was all too much to handle.

So she had left her bed hours ago and retreated up to the roof to think. To work out the turmoil of her thoughts and unknot all the stress and anxiety keeping her awake. To hatch strategies and ploy's that would keep her and all of her friends safe. Desperate to make herself feel more prepared, more in control…

Catra smiled weakly, this retreat to the rooftops to work out her plans. Had once been a very selfish endeavor, to save only herself. This was perhaps the first time she had sought solitude to think about protecting others.

It gave her hope that she was improving…becoming a better person.

This last year being a part of the Rebellion. She had grown and changed so much. Like a snake shedding its skin as it outgrew its old body. Catra had slowly sloughed her rage, her poisonous resentments and distrust of others. That she had once wrapped around her heart like armor.

Most of the toxic layer's she had grown from being raised in the Horde, being mistreated by Shadow Weaver, by Hordak…by so many others in authority over her. Had been shed, yet she knew she still had a layer yet to scrape off.

She was not coping well with all this stress. Falling back into her old ways of dealing, her old ways of thinking.

She had done something to Scorpia? Hurt her somehow? Why was she acting so scared and twitchy around her? So nervous and submissive? Catra hated it! Things were weird between them. The tension and anxiousness, Scorpia felt in her presence was thick, palpable. Like a dark malaise was tainting their friendship again. She wanted to grab the muscle bound dolt and shake her, scream at her. Act normal! She did not want to rekindle the old dynamic between them!

Yesterday had been strange, her interactions with Scorpia had been a mixed bag. Things had seemed back to normal, at least briefly. While they were in the Basilica. The scorpion had been at ease around her, they had even bantered…but then as soon as the rest of the princesses turned up. Scorpia became a nervous wreck and their interactions became annoyingly stilted and awkward. The scorpion eventually just disappeared with Perfuma for the rest of the day.

That evening Catra had been wandering the grounds. Absently lost in her thoughts after leaving Frosta on the steps of the Basilica. Finding herself headed towards the roof of the dorms. When she walked past Scorpia's room on the upper balcony. The door was open and the tall woman was hunched over her communication pad at a small iron tea table next to her fireplace. A pad of partly shredded paper under a quickly tapping claw. With several bent and snapped pens and pencils scattered around the table top. It was obvious that Scorpia was struggling and overwhelmed. Catra had seen her in this floundering, hopeless state countless times back during their Horde days. As the Scorpioni sought to help her with the day to day bureaucracy of the Horde. The woman tried hard, always giving each task her best effort. But Catra had no patience for her bumbling attempts to be helpful back then.

The administration tasks were tedious, mindless and practically non-stop. For the first couple years, Catra had taken full responsibility for the paperwork. Before she became utterly fed up

with it. Catra was quick to delegate the work to a small team of underlings. After she had dominated Hordak and became his partner in the war campaign. She needed to focus on more important matters…such as conquering Etheria.

Catra quietly stood at the threshold of Scorpia's room, collecting her thoughts. This was her chance to show her that she could be a good friend. Perhaps find out why Scorpia was acting so odd.

"Hey, there big gal!" Catra offered the platinum blonde woman a warm, disarming smile. As she closed the front door. Intentionally caging the taller woman in the room with her. Unconsciously afraid that Scorpia would run away if given the chance and needing some kind of barrier to keep Scorpia in the room.

Scorpia snapped her head up so violently, at the sound of Catra's voice. Catra was worried she might have strained her neck.

Then immediately Scorpia began to stutter nervously.

"Uh….hey, there Wild Cat." Rubbing a huge claw behind her neck and casting her eyes to the side, avoiding eye contact with Catra.

Catra's smile deflated as she sighed and rolled her eyes, unable to hide her frustration. She promptly sat down in a chair opposite the Scorpioni. Desperate to replace the authority of her standing posture, to one that was more companionable in nature.

"Need some help?" Catra offered gently, taping a sharp claw against the screen of Scorpia's communication pad.

"NO! " Scorpia nearly screamed.

Catra's eye flew wide and her ears pinned back at the sudden burst of sound. Her hackles had fluffed and her tail lashed for a moment. She quickly calmed down her natural instincts. As Scorpia blushed and hung her head in defeat as she pushed the pad towards her.

"Yes…" She muttered weakly.

Catra chuckled fondly.
"Relax, We got this, Scorpia…I will always be here if you ever need me." Catra offered, scanning through the many supply documents and personal files of the recently deceased soldiers. That Scorpania had lost in transit along the Salineas coast.

It was slow, tedious work but something she was used to. Her time being Hordak's second in command was not glamorous or exciting. Most of her days were spent administering the day to day operations of the fortress. She never got out much to lead missions. Which was alright with her at the time. She was pretty messed up after the Portal…so she kinda became a bit of a shut in herself.

Catra had held herself back all day yesterday. While she was helping Scorpia devise retrieval missions for the lost personnel. Biting her tongue and wrangling her temper. Every time Scorpia would meekly bow her head and concede to whatever Catra advised, instead of talking it out like equals.

The supplies and equipment along the southern coast of Salineas were long gone, stolen by pirates, or merchants or civilians. So she had to redirect the rest of Scorpania's aid convoy that was already in route. Towards other villages and towns along the southern border of Scorpaina. Not willing to pull them all the way back to the fortress just yet. The supply depot in Sea Worthy was already set up and fully stocked, so pulling out so deep in Salineas territory would be impossible right now. So a contingent of guards and replacement personnel would be sent to uphold Scorpiania's presence in the city. To help where they could and be prepared to send aid to any island in the Archipelago at a moment's notice.

As soon as Mermista gave the word it was safe to do so.

Catra sat upon the roof of the dorm, her gaze was unfocused and lost to her tortured thoughts. Her relationship with Scorpia was strained and she needed to figure out what went wrong. Before the tender roots of trust and friendship she had managed to cultivate in the last few months, shriveled and died. She couldn't lose her again! The mere thought sent her heart pounding and her breath coming in short, shallow bursts of panic. Squeezing her eyes shut tight, a few tears fell unchecked down her cheeks. She brushed them away by grinding the heel of her hand into her eyes angrily. Before picking up her communication pad from where it rested against her hip. She had once again, purged all her painful emotions into a song.

Willing to open her heart to the magic of Adarion, to her source. Confessing her truth to the Universe. It had helped her deal with the heartbreak of nearly losing Adora back on Beast Island. Hoping that perhaps it would work again. That Scorpia would hear her heartfelt apology and want to talk.

A meager warmth slowly replaced the chill in the air. As dawn began to glow upon the edge of the island. The heavy clouds hovering above, were set alight into glorious morning hues. As the stars faded and the last moon relinquished its reign to Adarion.

" *My world was crumbling, my heart was shattered inside.*

No one could save me…but you tried.

I never dreamed that I would meet somebody as selfless as you.

I was a fool, trapped in my own lies, until I lost you."

Scorpia was just closing her door to her room. Dressed in her red and black leather armor. With a heavy woolen blanket draped over

her arm. When she heard Catra's mournful voice echoing from above.

"I wanna say, I'm sorry.

I wanna say, I care.

I need you to forgive me…

I need you to stay…"

The Scorpioni had been on her way to meet Perfuma in the apple orchard. For their morning meditation that has become a part of her cherished routine. Yet she was unable to leave the balcony. Transfixed upon the sad, repentant melody filling the air. Her mouth hung open in shock at finding herself within the lyrics of Catra's song.

"What a wicked game I played with you.

Kind, one moment, cruel, the next…it's true.

But when I was hurting, you would always care for me…

I'd hiss and spit to leave me be. "

Scorpia sniffled softly, as she felt a hot tear trail down her cheek from the corner of her eye. So many painful memories clashed with the fragments of good she had shared with Catra over those painful years.

"I never deserved your loyalty.

I never earned your friendship.

But you offered it freely, with no strings attached."

Scorpia sighed heavily, bowing her head.

"Oh, Wildcat…" She moaned, the air was heavy with regret, confusion and frustration.

"I wanna say, I'm sorry.

I wanna say, I care.

I need you to forgive me…"

"I need you to stay…"

Catra's voice faded away, cracking with remorse.

Scorpia knew they had to talk, that she had to find the courage to confront Catra about what she had done. To bear all her hurt, her grievances and anger about how betrayed she felt. Catra needed to know she had crossed a line and that she would not…could not allow her to do it again.

As quickly as those bold idea's crossed her mind, Scorpia was filled with dread and fear. It clamped over her chest like a vice and she was struggling to breath.

Far to many years of ingrained, self doubt about her worthiness, her lack of personal power. Created a cruel, reciminating inner

monologue that assaulted her. Every time she felt she was not living up to her potential. Once again those harsh accusations needled her. She had been a failure as a princess, a failure as a Force Captain and now she was failing at being a Queen…she had no right to feel indignant about how Catra had taken over their interrogation of Sweet Bee. Trying to bribe the Antrineed with offering her military aid. Then glared at Scorpia when she sought to intercede. Easily intimidating her, with that fierce, uncompromising stare. That in the past always led to violence. Forcing her to back down, making her feel less then, making her cower. Catra had completely disregarded Scorpia's personal power, her title as Queen. Treated her like a worthless subordinate….again.

Catra was a take charge kind or person, she was smart and resourceful. Scorpia should just give the title of Queen to her, she would lead her people much better…

As quickly as those idea's struck, she shook her head vehemently. Catra had been a tyrant…honestly. She would never give that Magicat power like that any time soon. With a resolute sigh, she squared her shoulders and strode purposefully down the balcony to the stairs. She needed to keep moving forward, she could not deal with having that talk right now. So until she had regained her power and confidence, she would keep her distance as much as possible.

Catra watched with growing disappointment. As Scorpia made a hasty retreat out of the courtyard. The claw of her index finger, fully unsheathed and idly scratching a groove into the clay tile at her hip.

Scorpia was avoiding her…wanting to get as far away from her as she could.

It hurt…so bad…

Catra rubbed her chest with her other hand to ease the burning ache she felt.

As she watched despondently as Scorpia disappeared into the treeline of the outer gardens.

A soft puff, like the snuffing out of a tiny flame whispered beside her. Catra's right ear twitched at the subtle sound, as she cast her gaze sideways. Finding Melog sitting beside her. She had left the Krytian sleeping atop Adora's pillow back in her bed long before dawn. Finn had taken to sleeping back in his own cot last night, hiding his book away as he always did against the wall. So no one could take it in the night without waking him. He had disappeared all day yesterday, reappearing only at bedtime. Their friendly conversation before the fire, about their day, had been… stilted. She tried to pry gently about what he was doing, while his answers had been frustratingly brief. He was definitely hiding something?

Catra smirked proudly down at Melog. They had used her magic before to teleport up to the healing grotto atop Mystacor Mountain weeks ago. It had been much more powerful, appearing in a flare of white flame. This was their first use of her magic in their new form. Which meant they were getting stronger. She noted that Melog was looking more cat-like and less blobby. Their legs are more defined, but still very tiny. Their face was more angular and their ear's had grown in size, taking up most of the top of their head now. The kittenesque features were more pronounced and they were becoming very adorable.

"Mew." Melog inquired, cocking their cute, round head to the side. Causing their large ears' to flop charmingly. Calming waves of comfort and hope passed over their link. As Catra smiled weakly, cupping the small alien cat in her palms and setting them on her lap. Petting down the back of their head and scratching their ears absently as she withdrew back into her thoughts.

Casta had the princess scheduled to meet up in the Apprentice library in the lower bastion's of the Citadel. Later this morning. To

research their elemental magic in the old guild tomes from the Forgotten Age. Which would have been just after Mara stranded Etheria in Despondos. Catra was less than impressed with Casta and the Magic High Council's effort so far to teach them magic. Yesterday had been a complete waste of time and today was no different. Being stuck in a musty library was going to be rather boring, so she was going to skip it. She had her own research to delve into anyway.

Casting her gaze out towards the gleaming white carved stone of the upper bastions of the Sorcerers Citadel. She narrowed her eyes, as she scrutinized the many keeps, tower's, spires and domes of the vast sprawling castle. Somewhere in the upper halls was Light Spinner's old quarter's perhaps her study? Hopefully still untouched.

"You need to get higher!" Bow demanded while staring determinedly down at his tracker pad. Tapping on the screen as he sought to boost the signal.

Brojee was standing atop a tall boulder on the very peak of Mount Mystacor. In a barren glen filled with scrub grass and standing stones. Drizzi was sitting atop Brojee's shoulder's, with Caz standing upon his own broad shoulders. The red head was stretching his arm up as high as it could go. With a long, slender metal pole clutched in his hand. That had a transceiver and a router box attached just underneath a high tech looking antennae at the top. The very tip of the antennae was blinking merrily.

When Bow demanded higher, Caz squeaked in fright. As Drizzi boldly stood up on Brojee's shoulder's. Brojee, gritted his teeth and broadened his stance to maintain the younger boy's balance.

"Any luck…cause my back is about to break here?" Brojee complained in a strained voice.

“This is not working….” Bow growled, as his screen refused to show anything besides the blank landscape of Etheria below them.

Caz huffed then leaped off Drizzi’s shoulder, landing on the ground in a crouch with the antennae still held high over his head.

Drizzi yelped and Brojee yelled in fright. As Caz’s unthinking maneuver knocked them both off balance. They tumbled backward off the boulder striking the ground hard on their backs. Drizzi groaned, clutching his head and rolled from side to side in pain. As Brojee scrambled to his feet, glaring heatedly back at the reckless youth. Currently cringing in regret as he stared down at poor Drizzi. Writhing and moaning in pain.

“Sorry…sorry….” Caz apologized.

Drizzi growled, lunging to his feet and charging for Caz.

“Let me show you what it felt like!” he declared.

Caz squealed, tossing the antennae to Brojee. Who caught it with a gasp. Before Caz tore away down the hill with Drizzi on his heels. The heavy set teen ready to box the red head’s ears with his fists.

Brojee watched the two boy’s chase each other around the cliffs below, arms crossed in contemplation. Tapping the end of the pole against his hip.

“How much higher, we got to go?” He asked.

“Several more feet at least if not more.” Bow sighed, “I really thought this would be high enough.”

“Well, we could always head up in Darla. One of us can go on a wing with this little device…” Brojee offered bravely.

Bow blinked, that seemed like a rather reckless plan.

"Or…I could just download Entrapta's program into the Ships data banks. Do a sensor sweep…as we fly over Etheria? " Bow began to mutter, as he marched away down the hill towards the two boys. Who were currently wrestling upon the ground, grunting and yelling crude obscenities at each other.

"Let's let Litha take a look at Entrapta's program before you go shoving it into Darla's computer core." Brojee offered, "It might not mesh well, if at all with ancient First Ones tech."

"Fine with me…I'll let Entrapta know it was a bust and what our plans are now." Bow nodded, he was disappointed but still remained optimistic that there was a chance to track the drones. Increasing his pace and totally ignoring the two boy's brawling on the ground. Quickly disappearing down the narrow footpath they had used to get up here.

Brojee could hear the Tech Master's frustrated voice, echoing in the distance as he spoke with Entrapta. It seemed Entrapta was not too keen on uploading her tracking program into Darla's sensor array, either.

Several hours later, Litha was lounging in the Captain's chair on Darla's command deck. In a pair of pink overalls and a cornflower yellow t-shirt. Kicking her bare feet over the arm of the chair, bracing Bow's tracker pad on her stomach.

"Won't work." She stated, while Entrapta's holographic image merely nodded her agreement nearby. Emily twittered, her power core blinking from maroon to indigo as Entrapta's image was replaced by Hordaks.

"The program is built upon modern three demenisonal Horde code. There is no way Darla's, First Ones, AI could even read it. They speak two completely different languages."

“I would have to delete Darla’s current AI. Then rebuild her in a three dimensional configuration which would be…quite an undertaking. Or rewrite the program in First Ones glyphs...using a vast amount of data crystals to hold the code… ” Entrapta reasoned, her voice floating from somewhere behind Hordak. Followed by rapid clicking, on the keyboard of her portable computer.

“Which would also take a considerable amount of time…” She mumbled…”Cause I have no idea how to read First Ones writing, let alone write code in it… and Adora can’t help, cause she has no idea how she can read it either…so she can’t teach me…” Entrapta kept rambling until Bow cut her off. “Perhaps…your fathers’ could teach me? They have a library full of First Ones research..and they know how to read First Ones glyphs? ”

“Ok..ok..ok.” Bow conceded with a growl, his constant pacing back and forth across the front consoles of the command deck never slowing. He was not going to send his fathers to Beast Island, that wasn’t even an option and Entrapta was not going to leave either. She had set up a lab and workshops, it seemed like she was planning on staying there for the foreseeable future.

“So what’s the plan now?” Brojee inquired, leaning over the tall back of the command chair. Attempting to read the Horde code spider webbing across the screen as if he could understand it.

“Horde surveillance Drones.” Caz quipped, as the command door slid aside with a hiss. He strode into the bridge, with a smug smile plastered on his face. Holding a sharply angled, arrow head shaped surveillance drone.

“Where did you get that!” Brojee snapped in horror.

“Picked up a few crates of them back in Scorpania’s junk yard?” Drizzi shrugged, “Figured we could retro-fit their power cores as spare thulite batteries for our pistols.”

Hordak's image wavered and blinked away to be replaced by Entrapta's once more. She looked perplexed and agitated, her lavender's pig tails intertwining nervously in front of her stomach.

"Scorpania should not have any of those…I closed off the spires." Her expression was confused, her voice soft. Struggling to figure out if perhaps Scorpia had betrayed her trust and stolen weapons from the nearby spires for their military build up?

"Naw…this one's pretty banged up." Caz offered, walking up to Entrapta and showing her the busted, burnt out drone.

"It's just a piece of scrap left over from your war with Prime, I figure." Drizzi nodded, slapping Caz on the back. The shorter boy stumbled forward a couple steps, before shooting Drizzi a heated glare over his shoulder. The violent back and forth teasing they had started earlier had still not fully run its course.

Entrapta heaved a long breath of relief, her smile returning. Scorpia had not betrayed her trust. Yet the unsettled feelings remained. She never regretted becoming a part of the world beyond her lab. Making friends and learning how to be a friend in return. Yet the complexities of engaging in social relationships and the many strong feelings that came as a result. Was hard for her to deal with at times.

Catra had skipped breakfast, her stomach was twisted up into far too many unpleasant knots to be able to hold down food. She wasn't in the best of moods either. So it would be prudent of her to avoid other's. Lest she lose her temper, and lash out or say something she would regret. Catra peeked into her satchel, finding Melog glowing a somber blue accenting her melancholy mood. She needed solitude, so she refocused herself on more personal pursuits.

She found herself once more in the burnt remains of the park, she had found Mermista hiding in during the fall of Mystacor. No

longer lost in the smoke and devastation of the inferno, frantically searching for She-Ra. She was able to calmly place exactly where she was at the fringe of the Merchant Quarter.

The broken and twisted iron gate she had crossed before, was the entrance to a vast outer Bailey. A part of the sprawling front garden's that lay before the Sorcerer's Citadel. She turned and walked along the edge of the garden. Brushing her hand across the whitewashed stone of the border wall that separated the Citadel from the Merchant Quarter. As she slowly made her way deeper into the burnt remains of the enclosure. The ancient stone wall was still smeared with soot from the fire. The many years of growth of moss and lichen clinging to the lower stones tinting them an odd green- gray near the yellow dead grass.

She took to a narrow flagstone pathway, lined by stacked, half walls of field stone. She soon came across the cobblestone courtyard with the elegant water fountain. Where she had her fateful encounter with Mermista during the fall of Mystacor. She crossed the courtyard, once again following the path unerringly onward towards the looming granite ramparts of the lower bastion.

Garden boxes paraded along the wall on the other side of the courtyard. The once vibrant flower's long turned to ash. Leaving the many small planters barren and black.

Moving under the shadow of trees clustered in a large grove further along the path. Catra watched the long white limbs of birch trees that reached upward towards the gray, overcast sky. Their branches swayed in the cool breeze. Scratching at each other, making soft creaking noises. Their once lush green leaves are scorched and dead. Laying upon the ground around their base in large heavy piles. Casting her gaze upward once more, searching beyond the trees. She was confronted by the massive outer parapets of the ancient Citadel, carved into the base of

Mount Mystacor. Built during the Forgotten Age, by the Hybrids who survived Mara's war.

The citadel rose high above the city below, giant walls of stone, smoothed to a polished gray by time and the ever present wind. The lower towers, walkways and ramparts were camouflaged to blend into the rock of the mountain. The architecture was modest and far more conservative. The battlement walls were thick, robust and strong. Built to protect those who lived within and hide them away from the world.

While the upper citadel that was built to stand out, like a beacon. Constructed closer to their modern time. It was carved from ivory marble, gleaming in the dim sunlight like the purest crystal. The grand, elaborate spires, massive wrap around balconies and glorious crystal domes. Were opulent and flamboyant compared to the lower halls. The citadel was a mammoth undertaking to take in, as its size was so massive it was incomprehensible to see it all from the ground.

The sprawling city below was utterly dwarfed by the sheer majesty of the Sorcerer’s Citadel.

Jitsu had tossed her prized whip over one of the many balconies high above. Catra had never tried to find where it might have landed. It may have fallen somewhere in the Upper Bastion below the balcony she had fought on. Or even the lower bastion or perhaps out here in the garden’s. She felt finding it was an impossible feat, so had given up before she even tried.

With a bitter grumble, Catra headed down a softly declining hill towards a tranquil pond, flanked by flat stones. This would be the perfect place to mediate, Catra thought. As she walked along the perimeter of the pond. Glancing into the clear water, as it rippled under the cool breeze blowing down from the mountain. The ripples make her pause and reflect once more upon the past. She had done something…or said something… to make Scorpia feel insecure around her. Blind apologies were not going to be enough. She needed to do more…to fix them…she just didn’t know what?

But she wasn’t going to give up, her friendship was too important.

On the other side of the water she was greeted by a massive stone archway. The underside of the arch was etched in various runic knots. She noticed the trinity knot first, as it was the most dominant of the symbols. But there were thirteen more different knots. Spirals, in a set of three, in a set of four. A larger, more intricate knot she found familiar that she knew stood for strength. A circular knot she understood as a shield. Some that looked like flower’s, or clover leafs. One that looked like two hearts interwoven. All the knots were framed in another knot that wove endlessly on either side of the arch. Catra quickly pulled out her pad from her satchel and began to take pictures, cataloging the runic knots.

She passed under the arch to enter another huge inner Bailey. The enclosure was empty, with long spiraling pathways of flagstone cutting through the grass. The looming stone ramparts still lay in the distance. With a determined scowl, she chose a pathway and headed forward across the grassy field.

She hadn’t paid that close attention to the detail of the architecture the first time Casta had led them through the Citadel. So overwhelmed by the majesty and magic that surround her. She merely followed along with the rest of the Princesses to the Atrium high above.

Now she was approaching the Citadel with far less wonder. Beginning her journey to uncover the forgotten past of Etheria’s Hybrid’s. That had begun early that morning in the Elemental Basilica. She had taken numerous pictures with her communication pad, storing them for later appraisal. Finding the statues of the Runebearers of the Deep magic’s strangely absent.

Now she planned on taking her time to explore the Sorcerers Citadel as well. She would map the labyrinth of halls and cloisters as she made her way up to the Master’s quarter’s and studies. Filing away any mural or glyph or rune she came across. She was

going to start to gather as much information as she could about the hybrid's of Mystacor and the First Ones who took their place. The last thousand years lay before her in the tiny details of the architecture that surrounded Mystacor. She would piece it all together and hopefully begin to unravel how to use not only her magic, but those of the other Rune Bearers.

She had very little trust that Casta's way of invoking the magic would work for her or any of the other's. Catra was convinced when she released the Heart, Adora had reset the magic, to how it was before the First Ones meddling. She just needed proof to support her hypothesis, as Entrapta would say. She honestly believed her answers did not lay in the dusty old tomes of the Sorcerers Libraries but in the old ways…that perhaps were still marked down on the ancient walls of the lower bastion and hidden rooms beneath the Citadel itself.

Scanning the rough, granite carved ramparts, as she closed in on the fortress. That blended into the natural rock of the mountain, as she reached the edge of the bailey. No doubts there were sentries upon the more fortified inner curtain wall. Beyond lay the higher parapets on either side of the looming gatehouse. Where she would be stopped by the Citadel Guards. Casta would have no doubt instructed them to guide any of the Rune Bearer's up to the Apprentice Library.

She wanted to avoid all of that!

So walking up to the front doors was out of the question. With a mischievous giggle, Catra ducked out of view behind a set of boulders several meters away from the massive entrance gateway. She scanned the patrol's walking the walls high above, tracking their routes. A childish excitement bubbled inside of her. This stealthy infiltration was like her childhood explorations back in the Fright Zone. When she would skulk unnoticed in the rafters or

creep along the ducts of the fortress. Investigating every nook and cranny for adventure and excitement. Taking risks and seeking thrills as she navigated through the mechanical guts of the Fright Zone. Leaping from one metal rafter to the next, as the Horde Patrol's moved far below in the very bowels of the Foundry. Or swinging across bottomless shafts on cables and wires as she traversed the inner labyrinth of the huge tower complexes near the Forge. Or climbing up the side of a rusted out silo deep in the Refinery.

The day may have started off on a sour note, but the rest of it was going to be fun!

What was lost...

Chapter Notes

> Bitzy Bee: Thank you for the comment, I do have a back story for Shadow Weaver/Light Spinner worked out. But I do not go into all of that until later in the story. Right now I am focusing only on her time in Mystacor. Which I will start to delve into in a few more chapter's.
>
> Also thankyou to all who left Kudo's.

“So, how’d the Parade of Princess’s go?” Double Trouble lounged, across a plush armchair before the roaring fire in Master Elys’s study. Scrutinizing his well manicured fingernails with a self satisfied smile. They felt they had done some exceptionally good work and were just waiting for the applause. When Master Elys remained stoically silent, they glanced briefly towards the old man.

Master Elys sat at his desk, with DT’s leather bound spell book open in front of him. A boney, wrinkled thumb rubbing absently over the five stones embedded into the back of the lotus amulet sitting on the desktop. His ancient countenance was focused intently on DT’s research notes. Bushy white eyebrows shielding dull brown eyes.That were tired but determined, as he tapped a spindly thin finger on the sketches upon the paper.

Humming and grunting in acknowledgment as he slowly went over the research notes and spell work.

“That is none of your concern.” Master Elys grumbled a minute or two later, never taking his eyes off the research before him.

“You are no fun.” Double Trouble groused, spinning elegantly upon their butt in the armchair. As they steepled their finger’s between their knees. Rocking nervously upon the cushion, it had been a very long time since their spell work was critiqued.

“DT….where did you get this information…” Master Elys, flicked his eyes up to pierce the shape shifter with a very disgusted frown.

“It’s better you don’t know…” Double Trouble rolled their eyes and stood up. Flipping their long blonde hair over a shoulder as they crossed over to Master Elys’s desk in a few long strides. The tall, light green chameleon hovered over the old man’s shoulder.

“I came to you to check my work, because you are a Master StoneMason. If anyone can decipher those gem’s in the amulet it would be you. So am I on the right track or not…” Double Trouble demanded with impatience.

“These are not naturally occurring crystals.” Master Elys leaned back in his chair for a moment before leaning forward again. As if pulled back towards the amulet by some unseen string. He pulled out the small drawer at the side of his desk, digging his hand in briefly. Then pulling out a small lilac dyed, suede pouch. He set it on the desk and flipped up the top flap. It held a set of metal beading picks for jewelry crafting. Then he pulled out a leather band that had many magnifying lenses stacked on a hinge on one side. Pulling it over his head, he began to flick the glass lenses down one by one over his right eye until he had the right magnification. His eye began to grow larger behind each glass lens and more owlish. While his wild white hair was flaring around the band. He truly became the sight of a mad scientist.

“I figured that out…” DT sounded bored. “What I don’t understand is the design…” Tapping on the back of the amulet.

“The stones are set in a constellation pattern…one I have not seen in the skies over Etheria.” He turned the amulet, right and left seeking to catch the light of the fire. The silver gleamed and the crystals sparkled with an infinite clarity.

“Well, Etherian magic is sourced from the moons…not the stars!” DT offered, with a frustrated groan.

“Well, at least the kind of magic we were capable of conjuring while trapped in Despondos…yes..” Elys agreed.

“What are you saying, old man?” DT moved to stand in front of the table, leaning over the amulet with new found curiosity.

“This amulet may be from another planet…who’s magic is governed by the stars. You had said it was from the future…now that Etheria is no longer trapped in that Shadow Dimension. We may discover stellar magic of some sort? ” Elys confronted DT’s concerned stare with one of his own. They stared at each other in silence for a bit, each of them absorbing this new revelation. Before Master Elys got back on topic.

“Each shard is a different shape…” Master Elys began to tap on each shard with the point of a metal pick. “The pyramid…which invokes manifestation…the cluster…harmony..the sphere..projection of energy from all sides…the point…focus..the wand..”

“I know all of this old man…” DT was growing frustrated with the mages tendency to fall into long drawn out lectures about Gemstones.

Master Elys ignored him and continued.

“Each gem contains more than just one type of crystal…” Master Elys began, using a pick to tap gently on a lavender stone. “This one, for example, holds both Moonstone and Tiger’s eye…those crystals are tied to both water and earth…body and emotion… Stability and Intuition…it is as if the stones are not minerals but organic in nature…” he continued to ramble his hypothesis.

Double Trouble groaned and threw up their hands, returning to their armchair. Flopping down in defeat, resigned to the fact that they needed to get comfortable cause the old man was not going to merely answer their question with a simple yes or no. He was going to ramble out his observations aloud like verbal diarrhea.

As the old mage continued to explain all the different stones in great detail. Basically reiterating all the research DT already had written down in his book.

"An immense amount of magic is self contained inside each shard…as if each gem is an individually specific spell." He muttered, "completely independent of the amulet's transmogrify spell." Master Elys took a moment to take a few breaths before continuing.

"The spatial arrangement of the facets within each shard. Is far too numerous and far beyond three-demensional space…It is as if they are connected to not just space but time as well…they break all the laws of magic…that I know of." Master Elys voice was trembling with fear.

"Far beyond anything I could conjure…even decades from now." DT groused, crossing his arms over his chest.

Master Elys shot his eyes up and pierced Double Trouble with a look of accusation.

"Are you telling me you created this amulet in the future!" He nearly shouted.."I have seen the droplets of blood encased in each crystal…this is Blood-casting..the most loathsome of the forbidden deep magic."

"I know…I've been researching all the Great Mages and a few of the rather reckless and insane sorcerer's from the Master's library…Orko, Geldor,…Ramlin…" Double Trouble swallowed, refusing to admit that they had even tried to find tomes written by Gorta, but had found no trace of the famous Dark Mage in Mystacor. "Trust me that amulet is far more complex than anything those hacks have come up with…I'm talented but I am not that amazing." Double Trouble admitted.

"Which means…" Master Elys took a deep breath.

"Means I lied to the kid….I never made this…. " Double Trouble huffed in disgust, standing up abruptly and snatching the amulet

off the desk. Breezing out of the study before Master Elys could say anything more or condemn them for sneaking into the Forbidden section of the Master's Library.

Catra had found her own way into the lower bastion, scaling the ramparts close to the furthest tower. There were little to no guards walking the curtain walls of the citadel. It seemed most of their guards and defenses were positioned upon the outer walls of the city itself. So sneaking into the lower bastion was easy. She kept low, moving in a crouch so not to be seen above the wall. As she made her way across to a corner watchtower. Opening the heavy wooden door. She paused for a moment as she caught sight of a circular knot, etched high up in the corner of the door near the heavy iron hinges. It was a rune…a shield knot… protection…she quickly took out her pad to record it.

Then slipping inside. She was quickly enveloped in the comfort of silence and shadow. Moving up the staircase to the sprawling main keep, that ascended towards the upper bastion and descended down to the inner ward below. That she assumed held the cellar and guard barracks.

The lower citadel halls had a robust earthy smell of mold, the air thick with the scent of oil and ash. The halls were rough and natural. Carved from the mountain itself. The narrow, earthen halls she navigated were empty, yet she could hear the faint clips of footsteps either before and behind. The crisp sound of conversation, echoing like taunting whispers that she could only make out a few words of.

A moment later a door swung open just ahead of her. Catra's hackles rose and she was quick to leap into concealment into a small alcove. Ducking behind a large wooden chest that dominated the tiny nook. Her ears twitch as two men, dressed in the heavy leather aprons and long gloves of iron workers or perhaps smelter's from the Forge. Ambled past her hiding spot, laughing and discussing their daily tasks and the shipments of

various metals they had just just delivered to the Maker's guild. It seemed the bottom floors of the lower bastion did not have a Guards Barracks. But held the maker guilds and their various workshops. Each door held the same shield warding glyph etched in the wood, tucked out of sight in the upper right corner near the hinges.

As she moved up to the floors above, the halls widened as she left the workshops. She found the halls above were better lit. The narrow slat windows are replaced by broader, casement windows that allow in more natural light. The walls held touches of artistry here and there in tiny alcoves. Tall vases with abstract designs in various colors. Simple tapestries hung along the stone walls, depicting scenes filled with hybrid's and human's from long ago.

The corridor's became more crowded, as she entered the dormitories. Filled with all manner of hybrid and human. Some dressed in the fine silks of sorcerer apprentice robes, carrying heavy books and satchels, as they scurried anxiously towards the Great Hall. Other's wore the more robust leather aprons and heavy cotton pants of Maker's assistants. Headed downward to the workshops, at the back of the Great Hall.

Catra had no way to blend in, so she was quick to leap up into the wooden rafters of the now vaulted corridors. Watching them all bustle back and forth up and down the Great Hall. The magic students moved swiftly to use the grand central staircase in the echoing foyer at the head of the hall. While the Maker's assistants, took to the narrow winding staircase at the back of the hall.

A bell tolled, long and loud. Vibrating off the stone walls. Catra cringed, cowering slightly as she crouched upon a thick wooden beam high above. As the hall and massive foyer was quickly emptied of all students.

"Wow…" Catra breathed, the hustle to get from point A to point B made a hell of a lot more sense. The students were ruled by the toll of the bells. If they were late, no doubt punishments of some sort would be given. The strict authoritarian regime these kids

obeyed was eerily similar to her youth as a cadet training in the Horde.

The higher up she went the more refined and opulent the halls became. Until she was once more wandering the massive corridor's of white marble with red velvet drapes in the deep alcoves and the tall arching stained glass windows. That overlooked the sprawling city below. Each one of the oak doors she passed held a Master's study. She just needed to investigate each one until she found Light Spinner's. How many Master's of Magic could there be?

It didn't take her long to realize that perhaps she should have approached the hunt for Light Spinner's study better. It was well after lunch and she was wandering the upper levels of the Bastion utterly and completely lost.

She had managed to find the open atrium that Casta had taken them to on their first night in Mystacor. Then she found a huge observatory at the top of a very tall turret tower, several open gardens, and at least five or more huge, circular rooms. The walls are covered in crystals with an open skylight.

She had gone down hall after hall after hall, sneaking into one study after another. None of them held any hint that they might be Light Spinner's. She was losing faith that her study even existed anymore. It had been over a decade since she was on the island, they might have cleaned her study out and given it to another mage by now? She may not even have her old quarter's anymore? There may be no trace she even existed in Mystacor… her disfigured statue in the Hall of Sorcerer's spoke volumes about how scorned and despised she was.

That realization struck her hard, making her steps falter as an icy cold lump formed in her stomach. Light Spinner was her only lead to find out about the Deep Magic that was linked to the Nameless One.

With a moan of despair, Catra slumped against the wall and slid downward.

She sat disponently on the floor and slowly turned her head to the side, staring out the bottom of a large arching window. Finding that the view overlooked the northern enclosure. The outer curtain wall on this side of the city was the least damaged by the fire. The white stone looked almost untouched, Catra figured it must not have gone much farther than the outer Bailey. Before Mermista snuffed it out with the water from Mount Mystacor's waterfall.

She watched the smoke billowing up from the stout chimney on top of a massive domed roof of a huge stone and mortar building in the center of the enclosure. Which was without a doubt the Forge. Surrounding it were large warehouses and several tall silo's and what looked like a grain mill. As it had a fat wooden windmill spinning at the top of a tall tower. Several barns and livestock pen's were scattered throughout the rest of the enclosure. The city that spread out before the Citadel was set up in a massive circle. Divided into four, smaller, circular shaped enclosures by dividing walls and watchtowers. The city resembled a gigantic magic glyph? Whether on purpose of not, it was fascinating. Just to the west was another enclosure, Catra could just make out the green canopy of trees stretching above the dividing wall. She would have to explore the rest of the enclosures in the coming days. She figured there may be runes etched along the walls as well as in some of the more ancient buildings.

Catra traced her gaze back from the furthest point on the horizon to the vast garden that sat before the Citadel. The northern enclosure butted against the outermost bailey wall that had the huge green space before the citadel. From this high up the mammoth garden that stretched around the Citadel was in full view.

Catra gasped and scrambled to her knees and pressed herself against the glass. The cobblestone paths she had used to get to the citadel were spider webbed throughout the garden.

Separating the garden into thirteen smaller sections, each one held a different elemental mosaic in the center. She was quick to note that each mosaic varied in tone and color, holding very familiar runes in the center. The five greater elements, the lesser elements and the deep magic's. All in their respective garden's.

Catra was quick to pull out her pad and begin to take pictures. Walking the length of the hall and then back again, taking as many images as she could get, from every angle.

"So this is where you've been." Glimmer's irritated voice rang out behind her, as the chime of her teleport faded.

Catra yelped in fright and spun around clutching her pad to her chest, oddly startled by Glimmer's sudden appearance. Catra's sudden fear had snapped Melog out of their nap. The golem puffed into being atop Catra's head, hissing and spitting. Glowing like a flaming ember. Catra had been so focused on the garden's below she had not been attuned to her own surroundings like usual.

"Seriously, Sparkles…You are going to give me a heart attack!" Catra groused, tucking the pad away in her satchel and pulling Melog gently off her head. Her hair was now tussled, from their tiny claws. Sticking up at strange angles as if she had rolled out of bed.

Cradling the orb shaped kitten against her chest and soothing them with soft, gentle strokes. Melog was quick to start to purr and change color to a somber violet. A flowing mane of soft pink formed around their neck and a matching tail, unfurled. To swing lazily behind them, as Catra smiled fondly down at them.

They were getting stronger every day and it was amazing to see the small changes take shape.

"You know you can't hide from me, I can use my magic to find you anytime. I wish." Glimmer crossed her arms and smirked.

Catra huffed, then turned to face the windows. Tucking Melog securely back into their pouch at her hip.

“Unfortunately, I’m the Queen and I can’t be a slacker like you.” Glimmer taunted with a joking grin.

Catra rolled her eyes and crossed her arms over her chest, in mock indignation.

“I have not just been wandering around sight seeing all day.” She defended, because technically she was. But it had a purpose….she was doing her own research.

“Did you know that the outer bailey was sectioned off into smaller garden’s for each magic element on Etheria. “ Catra offered.

“No, I never noticed that!” Glimmer darted for the window beside the magicat,eager to see. “I’ve been coming here and exploring Mystacor since I was child and I still haven’t seen all its secrets.”

“I’ve been taking pictures and got lots of runes and ancient tapestries to show you. From down in the lower bastion, but not many from up here.” Catra patted her satchel, not really surprised at all.

“Built in two totally different era’s…” Glimmer nodded.

“If you could have found me at any time, why didn’t you?” Catra asked, quietly.

“Well, I saw no need for both of us to suffer today.” Glimmer chuckled, slowly edging closer to Catra. Who was standing a couple window’s over. Catra saw her less than subtle attempt to grab her and quickly back stepped out of her arms reach.

“Well, see ya!” Catra turned abruptly and attempted to make her exit. Hiding from Glimmer may be futile but it was worth the challenge.

“Not so fast, Horde Scum. I covered for you for most of today, but Aunt Casta has been pestering me non-stop to find you. So I’ve found you, so come on!” Glimmer lunged and clutched Catra’s shoulder before she could bolt.

Catra took a deep breath when she felt solid ground again, stubbornly refusing to show how off balance she felt. She focused on taking in their new location instead. Glimmer blinked them into a stately dining hall that held a table long enough to accommodate a whole Horde siege battalion. Massive banks of windows sat behind the table made up of tiny rectangular panes. That overlooked a lush hanging garden, of crawling vines woven into pure white trellises and boxed flower beds still in full bloom despite the colder weather. All sheltered within a large balcony just beyond the windows. On the far wall held an ornate hearth that gleamed with black onyx stone and a deep mahogany mantle. Catra was instantly drawn to the oil portrait that sat just above the mantle in a gilded gold frame. Of a raven haired woman and two children, a boy and an infant girl. The woman was slender, with rich, gentle brown eyes and a shy smile. The boy looked barely seven years old, with thick, dark hair and deep brown eyes that twinkled with mischief. The babe in the woman’s arms, had a crown of soft raven hair like her mother. Her large hazel eyes stared out with a keen intelligence that spoke that she understood far more than she could articulate.

“This is Aunt Casta's private quarter’s.” Glimmer leaned in and whispered.

Catra had known that Glimmer’s Aunt was the Head Sorceress here at Mystacor.

The sheer size and royal opulence of her dining hall put into perspective how high ranking and important Castaspella was to the Magic community.

The Princess were all seated for the noon day meal, with Casta sitting at the head of the table. The meal consisted of a large platter of assorted dried fruit, nuts and cheeses. Fresh bread steamed in the center of the table, with a dish of churned butter. Another platter sat near the bread of cured meats. The last dish was a large white porcelain Tureen of soup.

The sweet and salty smells assaulting her nose was making her mouth water. Her tail began to swish in wide lazy arc's as she eagerly scanned the banquet laid out upon the table. It had been a little over a year since she had been introduced to the luxury of having a variety of foods to enjoy. The smell and sight of real food still excited her. Even though she fought hard to tamp down any sort of expression on her face. Her stupid tail always gave her true emotions away. With a humiliated groan she was quick to grab her tail and hold it firmly against her chest.

"So happy you could finally join us." Casta stood and waved Glimmer and Catra to a set of chairs beside her. Her tone was polite but held an edge to it. She was not pleased with Catra's lack of devotion to her studies today.

Catra stood rigid, quickly taking in Casta's level of threat. She was no stranger to hearing that condescending tone of disappointment from authority figures. She really was not up for being around people today. Quick to swallow the growl, she felt rumbling deep down in her throat. As Glimmer grabbed her hand, holding it gently yet firmly as she pulled her towards the table. Refusing to allow her to retreat.

Glimmer sat down adjacent to her Aunt, with Catra following to sit beside the Queen. As soon as her butt hit the cushion. The rest of the Princess's finally began to fill their plates. Tucking into the breads and meats with vigor. As Perfuma laddled up bowls of soup and passed them down the table.

It was then Catra realized that they had all been waiting on her to arrive. She suddenly felt ashamed to have made them wait.

“So Catra, Glimmer had told me you were unable to join us this morning because you were pursuing your own investigation of the lower Bastion’s runes?” Casta inquired with a genuinely interested smile.

Finding out the Queen had been spying on her all morning. Catra arched an eyebrow at Glimmer. She had not been as studious of a student this morning either. Glimmer merely shoved a spoonful of soup into her mouth, refusing to look at her.

“Yes, I have cataloged all the runes, tapestries and mosaic’s I’ve found on my Communication Pad.” Catra nodded, as she nibbled on a cracker.

“I would love for you to join me for tea later today to discuss your research. The whole point of today was to find out more about your elemental magic.” Casta popped a few nuts in her mouth and hummed in delight.

“Certainly.” Catra nodded, her stomach churning anxiously. Her ear’s twitching at the sound of Scorpia’s hushed conversation with Perfuma further down the table. Trying to catch any stray words or phrases to see if they were talking about her?

Scorpia had offered her a small smile in greeting when she sat down, but it had looked forced. Now the scorpion was avidly focusing upon her meal or Perfuma.

The sick unsettled feelings squirming in her gut that had made her skip breakfast. Quickly ignited into frustration and irritation.

What the hell was her problem? She had so much to worry about right now…she couldn’t deal with Scorpia’s issues right now. She hated how awkward and off balance she felt in her presence and she didn’t know how to fix it, let alone what she did to make things so weird!

Coming here was a mistake!

Catra growled low in her throat, scowling down at her bowl of soup. As she spun her spoon in agitated circles. She could feel eyes upon her, sneaking her eyes up for a second to find the source. The rest of the princesses were busy in their conversations with each other. Her quick scan of the table fell on Casta, finding the sorceress was watching her. Her dark hazel eyes, full of quiet concern.

Suddenly feeling like she was on display. Further humiliated by her obvious show of emotions. She knew being around people today would be a bad idea. Glimmer really hadn't given her much of a chance to escape. But still…she just didn't want to be here!

So she promptly stood up, pushed her chair away from the table and walked out with her head held high. Feigning as much dignity and calm as she could. Until the heavy oak door closed behind her. Then and only then did she let the tears fall.

Spinning and Weaving

Chapter Notes

> Thanks for the comment, Bitzy Bee. The Nameless One's pronouns...never thought about that. The Nameless One is a Dark God, they had infected Shadow Weaver, during the spell of obtainment and Catra in the portal and Horde Prime. I envisioned them as the dark thing that She-Ra exercised from Hordak. You will have to make your own judgement if they are evil or not as the story unfolds.
> Thanks also to everyone who left kudo's.
> Alright, here's the next chapter. Enjoy!
> Leave comments and kudo's. I love to read what you all think of the story so far!

Catra retreated to one of the circular rooms filled with crystal encrusted walls and a skylight. It was an hour or so later and she was sprawled out in the center of the mosaic tile glyph, that lay beneath the skylight. Staring dismally up at the six crystal lenses that circled the skylight above.

Wondering what these rooms were for. She had found twelve of them in the upper Bastion, each one was slightly different, with a unique mosaic on the floor. The crystals in the walls were a different hue and had a different amount of lens mounted in the roof. One room had a scrying pool like what Shadow Weaver used to cast spells and watch her shadow spies. Another had tall mirror’s,this one had rose pink, crystal pillars circling the glyph.

The chime of Glimmer’s blink echoed softly in the far corner of the room. Catra groaned and pulled her arms in, folding her hands over her stomach. Refusing to acknowledge the Queen, she remained staring up at the gray, misty, overcast sky hovering beyond the skylight.

Glimmer took her aloofness in stride, having gotten used to Catra’s moodiness over the last year. She merely settled down on

the floor beside her, enjoying the silence. Catra was stressed, she knew that. She was stressed too, but they each handled it differently.

“I don’t want to talk about it.” Catra broke first, a snarl in the undertone of her voice.

“I didn’t say anything.” Glimmer commented back.

They lay in silence for a long time.

“What’s this room for?” Catra asked softly.

“It’s one of the monthly magic collection room’s used to channel and store magic from the moons.” Glimmer responded.

“Which moon is this?” Catra spoke again, her curiosity peaked.

“Moons…” Glimmer clarified. “Certain moons align at certain times of the year..each month is different.” Glimmer shrugged. “The Master Astrologist keeps track of what moons are lining up from the observatory.”

“There are Five larger moon’s. Elidor being the largest and what we used to call our day moon, during our time in Despondos. Then there are four smaller moon’s and three tiny moon’s. All of Etheria’s magic is governed by those moons.” Glimmer began to explain.

“Adarion is the source of Fire Magic.” Catra advised, Glimmer merely nodded her agreement.

“Which makes thirteen magical elements.” Glimmer added.

“Is there one of these rooms for the Great Conjunction?” Catra rolled onto her side, suddenly very excited. The Lunari, a pride of Magicats she had just learned about from Sweet Bee, would return to Etheria on that day.

Glimmer laughed. “Of course…did you want to see it?”

“Yes!” Catra leaped to her feet, thankful for the distraction from her troubled thoughts.

“Alright.” Glimmer climbed to her feet and took Catra’s hand, leading her out of the room.

Catra was confused, but followed for a time.

“Why are you not just teleporting us?” She finally broke, after Glimmer had led her down several long winding corridors.

“Because you don’t like it, it makes you sick.” Glimmer responded, she had noticed how uncomfortable Catra looked after she blinked them into the state room for lunch. Even if the Magicat had tried her hardest to mask it.

“Anyway, a walk will do me some good. I need to clear my head.” Glimmer added.

Catra was taken aback by the Queen’s empathy.

“Thank you…” She muttered quietly. Having good people in her life that treated her with care and consideration was still very foreign to her. Voicing her gratitude was kinda awkward and she sometimes stumbled over her words.

“I know it’s hard to believe, but I do care about you.” Glimmer squeezed her hand.

“I know you do.” Catra squeezed back. “Thanks for trying to include me in lunch…but I’m just having an off day and needed to be alone.” She explained, her voice soft and remorseful.

“I understand…are you hungry?” Glimmer asked, never looking back at her. Merely leading her ardently by the hand down the wide, opulent corridors. This moment of comfort and connection was so familiar…Catra felt safe being led by Glimmer. A soft, nostalgic reminder of Adora…

“Sorta…but I’m not ready to eat yet.” Catra offered.

It took a good half hour to traverse the Citadel to the uppermost keep. Heading towards a huge open courtyard set apart from the rest of the sprawling Citadel. On a massive outlook that jutted out of the mountain. That overlooked the northern side of the island. In which they had to cross a covered bridge to get to.

The tile and stone design embedded into the ground was the most intricate Catra had ever seen. With twelve mosaic's circling what looked like a sun…Adarion. There were thirteen lenses, hovering by magic alone over a set of standing stones and archways. That circled the intricate magical glyphs. It was the most simple and also the most mysterious of all the magic collection rooms.

The sunlight was fading, staining the thick blanket of clouds that covered the sky to cobalt and indigo. Creating a grim, melancholy atmosphere that hung like a shroud over both of them. An ancient timelessness hovered around the standing stones. The howl of the wind echoing through the arches, whispered to Catra of her long, lost ancestors. Persecuted and hunted down by the Eternian's. The Sunna, culled or stolen from their homeland. The Lunari, forced to abandon Etheria in order to protect their people from a similar fate.

The intensity of the grief and loss she felt, drew Catra away from Glimmer. An instinctual need to lick her wounds, even emotional ones on her own.

It was time to sing her farewell anyway. So Catra wandered to the very edge of the circle of standing stones. So she could watch the sun fall behind the mountain's below the island.

She didn't have the will to sing, her heart was so burdened. So she began to hum. The sound of her voice was soft, the melody haunting. As she leaned tiredly against a stone pillar, arms crossed, gripping her biceps tightly. In a learned attempt to self soothe. She couldn't help but feel lost and alone, adrift among people who loved her but could never truly understand her. The kinship she had experienced during her dreams of the past, when

she walked among her people. The memories of that time that had once brought her solace now made her feel lonely.

Glimmer was instantly transfixed on the hauntingly beautiful melody. Quickly intoxicated by the sound, she was compelled like never before to add her own voice to the slow, wavering cadence. As the sun disappeared below the horizon and Elidor rose to take its place. Glimmer's gentle voice began to harmonize with Catra's.

Catra turned in surprise, to find Glimmer standing in the center of the open courtyard. Her face upturned to the rising moon, her whole body bathed in a brillant, incancident glow. Catra shifted her gaze to the first moonrise, finding that Elidor, the largest of Etheria's moons, was also glowing with the same serene purity as Glimmer. Hovering just above the peak of the highest mountain below the floating island. Catra was quick to put it together…as the Sun was her source…Elidor…their once day moon was Glimmer's source of magic.

"Wow…" Catra breathed, as Glimmer's sweet voice faded away. She had the most satisfied grin on her face as she slowly opened her eyes. That was now sparkling with the magic she had absorbed from Elidor.

"That felt just like recharging at the Moonstone." Glimmer giggled. Her lavender eyes full of wonder, the beaming smile upon her face was infectious.

"Well…that proves it. Adora did reset the magic to how it was a thousand years ago." Catra proclaimed with a smug grin of her own.

"Which means?" Glimmer responded.

"Which means…I have no idea what it means. I know nothing about magic!" Catra ranted, storming out of the courtyard.

Glimmer ran after her. "Then let's change that!" She declared, grasping Catra's hand as they reached the bridge. "Have supper

with my Aunt Casta and I, ask her all your questions…get your answers.” Glimmer pleaded.

Catra huffed, she had trouble trusting that Casta had anything worthwhile to share but she would give her a chance.

“Alright…let's go eat. Sparkles.” Catra finally conceded.

A broad, hopeful smile spread over Glimmer’s face as she blinked them away to Casta’s private quarter’s once more.

A much smaller, much more cozy looking room appeared before her. When the blinding light of Glimmer’s blink began to fade. Catra’s stomach as always heaved at the sudden change of location. Glimmer rubbed her back in soothing circles. As Catra quickly took in the room, needing to find a place to sit down. Finding that she was in a study, very similar to Master Elys’s. It had a hearth that took up an entire wall, with a small fire burning quietly. She grimaced and rubbed her belly, heading towards the white marble hearth. The flames danced in greeting as she drew near. Sitting down on one of the three dark blue velvet armchairs that sat before the fire. Noticing another portrait of the same beautiful woman with two much older children above the mantle. She sat in regal grace in a large, high polished wooden chair with a dark, red velvet cushion. Dressed in fine silk robes of a Mystacor Mage. Her once gentle brown eyes were hardened, a tight smile on her face. A boy at least fourteen stood behind her, wearing the typical apprentice robes of Mystacor. There was an uncomfortable stiffness to how rigid he held himself upright. His brown eyes no longer sparkled with mischief. They were distant, haunted. A young girl barely into her teens was standing just to the side of the chair also in apprentice robes. Her pose beside the woman was also very forced and awkward. Her dark hair hung low over her eyes and cascaded over each shoulder. Framing her slightly bowed face as if she was trying to hide. Her hazel eyes were still alert but wary.

Catra was keen enough to see the subtle details between the portrait in the dining room to Casta's study. The years had not been kind to these three.

They had all suffered in some way since the earlier portrait, the hardship and pain they now carried was weighing on each of them.

Catra quickly scanned away from the painting, the mirror of pain she saw hitting far too close for comfort. The room was filled with bookshelves, full of old, dusty tomes. A squat, high polished wooden table sat between the three comfy chairs by the fire. With a single white pillar candle in a simple bronze holder. Wide, arching windows took up the back wall. The darker hues of twilight now accenting the many panes of glass. The fire flickering and crackling, casting a warm incandescence over the walls. A sense of peace and contentment fell over Catra as she lounged in the chair, slowly closing her eyes and humming softly.

She heard the stiff fabric of the cushion shift as Glimmer settled down in the chair across from her. The Queen once again did not say a word, just sought to enjoy the silence.

It seemed it had been a long day for both of them…

"Good you're here." Casta's gentle greeting, roused them both from their rest.

Catra felt numb and empty, as she opened her eyes to find the Head Sorceress of Mystacor. Striding across the study from a set of huge double doors, carrying a tray of sandwiches and an array of cut fruit. A fat silver teapot and three delicate porcelain cups sat upon the tray as well. She set the tray down on the short table between them and sat down on the last remaining chair.

"My, The evenings are becoming cold quickly this year." She commented, rubbing her hands down her legs.

Catra and Glimmer paid each other a meaningful look. Etheria's weather might be returning to its natural state, whatever that might have been. Since some of the Eternian's planetary systems went off-line permanently. When Hordak rerouted the super computer into the Sky Tree's, Hive mind. Entrapta and Hordak were working together to prioritize what First Ones beacon's, outposts and transmitter's needed to stay online to keep Etheria running. While they worked on slowly weaning the planet off its dependency on First Ones tech.

"I may need to change into the heavier robes soon." Casta shivered.

Glimmer smiled softly at her aunt, as she leaned forward taking a half of a sandwich off the platter.

"Go ahead, eat, eat." Casta offered the platter to Catra with a swish of her hand.

Her stomach growled in response. The magicat grimaced and acquiesced, taking a full sandwich off the plate. She quickly took a bite to avoid having to engage in the polite small talk now passing between the mage and her niece.

"Will Bow be joining us?" Casta inquired, as she nibbled on a slice of apple.

"Bow has been a bit preoccupied with his new projects. " Glimmer offered cryptically. There was a sourness to her tone that didn't go unnoticed by Catra.

Bow tended to become rather single minded when it came to his 'projects'. Much like Entrapta, he would hole up in his workshop until he perfected what he was building.

"Finding the Drones? Or the retrofit of his bow?" Catra offered. Bow had been enthralled with Brojee's thulite energy bolts and wanted to adapt his bow strings to shoot them fast enough not to blow himself up.

“Both.” Glimmer huffed, knowing she would be waiting till long after midnight again for Bow to come back to their room for rest, if he even came back at all.

“How were your research endeavors today?” Casta was quick to change the topic, as Glimmer’s frustration with Bow or perhaps everything in general began to shimmer in her eyes.

“Sorry for not giving the library a chance.” Catra offered, pulling her pad out of her satchel and setting it down on the table. She gave Melog a quick scratch under the chin, when they blinked awake and raised their head. To acknowledge the intrusion into their space.

“There is plenty of time for that, we all seek knowledge in our own ways.” Casta nodded towards Glimmer. As her niece had offered her some much needed insight into Catra’s character. Earlier in the day, she had been less than forgiving of the Magicats blatant disregard of her endeavor to educate her. Catra had very little faith that anyone in authority would ever truly help her. Since everyone who ever had any power of her either manipulated or abused her. Catra had trust issues and had learned to depend on only herself. Casta offered Catra a soft smile of understanding, as she reached down for Catra’s pad. Beginning to thumb through her many photos.

“You are more interested in the history of this place than the knowledge it contains.”

“I need to understand how to use my magic, how to use it in the ancient ways before the First Ones tampered with it.” Catra, began “I don’t think your magic books can tell me that.”

“That is true.” Casta nodded. “But the rules of magic remain the same, cast either in the modern ways or in the ancient ways.”

“Magic is fueled by emotion and driven by intention.” Catra recited.

“Yes…that is the first tenant of magic…where did you learn that?” Casta was pleasantly surprised.

“I…read it somewhere.” Catra lied, masking her unease by focusing on grabbing another sandwich. She couldn’t tell Glimmer about her mom, not yet…it would only break her heart. To know she had visited Catra many times in the last few weeks but had never reached out to her own daughter. She was using the threads of dream that Catra was connected to somehow…through Scorpia’s magic. Intentional or not, Scorpia was the catalyst to Catra's journey to uncover who she truly was, where she came from and finally giving her purpose now that the war was over.

“I recharged tonight.” Glimmer blurted out.

Casta’s eyes widened in surprise and she gave her full attention to Glimmer.

“Catra was singing her farewell to the Sun and I got so caught up in it. I started to sing too, just as the Largest of the Greater Moons rose in the sky. It felt just like recharging at the Moonstone.” Glimmer explained, the excitement of the moment bleeding into her tone. Making her voice louder and more eager, like the wonder of a child.

Casta was in motion in seconds, moving swiftly to a giant bookcase at the back of her study. She ran her finger down the spines of several books, before pulling one off the shelf.

“Have you been recharging when you sing to the Sun, Catra?” Casta inquired, as she carried the large tome to her desk. That had been hidden in the far corner of the room beyond the firelight. She waved her hand towards a teardrop shaped crystal chandelier that hovered above her desk. It bloomed to life, casting the far side of the study in brilliant magical light.

“I don’t know what that feels like.” Catra shrugged, taking the last of her sandwich with her. As she followed Glimmer across the room to survey the now open book.

“But I feel more connected to Adarion everyday that I sing….it’s like I have a daily conversations with the Sun. I talk about myself, about my friends, and what I’m feeling.” Catra shrugged, as she spoke around a mouthful of bread, meat and cheese. She had been coming to understand the Sacred creed of the Sunna more intimately. Because in essence she had been walking towards the sun and allowing her shadows to fall behind her. During her twice daily conversations with her source. That forced her to confront the darkest parts of herself and cast that pain into the radiance of the sun as she sang.

Casta had flipped the pages until she came across a map of the sky. Every one of Etheria’s moons were illustrated in fine detail, upon a circular rotation with Etheria in the middle of the two pages.

“These are the Greater and Lesser moon’s.” Casta began, “We have always channeled their magic upon their monthly patterns into crystals. Using the Lunar lenses…during our ceremonies. We then can use the crystals for our own magical conjuring and spell work…also our defenses. “ Casta commented, dryly.

A harsh fact that Mystacor had to create a shield to hide themselves, so that Horde could not target them. Catra merely gave her a noncommittal shrug, Casta’s casual reminder of her role in the war. Only spurned her resolve to prove herself, as a powerful, capable protector…just like the Princesses…just like She-Ra.

“It makes complete sense that the Rune bearer’s would be connected to them…just like your RuneS Stones used to be.” Casta was verbally working it all out. “ I will have to test this theory…” She tapped her chin.

Catra began to slowly read the details written about every moon's magical properties and their names and monthly cycles. It was fascinating.

“So which set of moons is aligning this month?” Glimmer asked.

“Elidor of course, but it is transitioning from the back of the eclipse to the front…the Greater Moon Vesi…known as the Coral Moon…will be first in line and then the Greater Moon Heliwir…the hunter’s moon will be in the middle.” Casta explained. “I could get into greater detail about which Moons are in the waxing phase and which ones are in the waning phase and how that affects the flux of magic…” Casta mumbled, still tapping her chin as she mused.

“Are there any books on Adarion?” Catra asked, moving towards Casta’s bookshelves to investigate.

“The sun did not exist in the sky when my people were discovering magic.” Casta shrugged.

Catra nodded, she honestly already knew that was the answer. Mara had stranded them in Despondos for a thousand years. With only Elidor’s light to provide them any semblance of a day and night cycle.

“But my people…the Sunna...our fire magic comes from Adarion. In my time a thousand years ago, Etheria still had the Sun and the stars. The magic back then was not governed by the Moon’s alone. I found Runes all over the lower bastion and elemental mosaic’s out in the garden’s. Tons of tapestries down in the lower level near the maker’s workshops, carvings up at the Steam grotto…Mystacor is full of ancient knowledge…I just need to rediscover the old ways…” Catra was musing to herself as she absently read the spines of the books upon the shelf.

“Then you will need a spell book to write down all your research and hypotheses, perhaps with guidance you can begin your own spell work.” Casta declared, pulling out the largest drawer at the bottom of her desk.

Presenting Catra with a thick, crimson leather bound book. Catra took it, bracing it in one hand and flipped through the thick, blank pages within. This book was exactly like what Finn was carrying

around…it made no sense. Finn was a simple villager from Thaymor…what did he know about magic?

"All spell caster's have spell books…creating new ways to thread the magic of Etheria. Spell work is always being tested and discovered. I understand that the Rune Bearer's need to learn to use their magic through trial and error. I shall give each one of you a spell book and allow you more freedom to research and discover your magic." Casta pulled out another leather volume, bound in deep indigo and offered it to Glimmer.
"The High Council wants to help you. They are the most knowledgeable in their fields of study. Please go to them if you have questions." Casta advised, as she once again crossed the room to another bookshelf. Pulling out a couple thick leather books and proceeding back to her armchair with them.

"The princesses were studying the magical textbooks on their elements in the Apprentice library today. Gaining an introduction to channeling and threading magic…glyph work may not work for all of you. But tomorrow we are going up to the Master's Library to research in more detail from the spell books of the previous High Mages. If you want to join us." Casta once again gave Catra that same warm, patient smile.

"Can you take me to Light Spinner's study…or her old quarter's tomorrow?" Catra asked, bluntly. As she turned from the bookshelf she had been studying.

Casta was taken aback by the sudden request.

"She needs to know what Shadow Weaver told you, Catra." Glimmer clutched her spellbook to her chest as she returned to her seat. Her eyes downcast, lost to her own bleak thoughts. The threat of the Nameless One, hung like a dark shroud between them.

Until Catra nodded, taking a deep breath before she began to retell the omen of the Nameless One, Shadow Weaver had foretold to her in her dream.

The whole time Casta's face became more pale and her eyes grew dark and fearful.

"That is not good…that is not good at all." She breathed at the end of Catra's grim tale.

"The Dark Mage Gorta…created the spell of Obtainment. He sought to enhance his own magic by calling upon the Nameless One…who is the embodiment of the void itself….the conjuring is parasitic…devouring the magic of other's to empower the vessel….the caster…" Casta scrubbed her hand down her face, seeking to purge the stress and anxiety now building inside of her.

"Do you know about the Shard of Kaydak?" Catra pressed, desperate for answers. Talking about Light Spinner and the spell of Obtainment, sent Catra's own anxiety that she might still be tainted by the Nameless One into overdrive. She had allowed that demon to devour her in the portal, giving birth to a dark, twisted version of herself. That monster still haunted her memories and she still had nightmares about it from time to time.

"It is a fragment of the Crystal Prison that Gorta had been sealed inside of. When his body had been taken over by the Nameless One." Casta began to tap her fingers rapidly against her knee's as her anxiety built.

"It was shattered over five thousand years ago, the shards were then cast to the galactic winds. To make sure that Dark God could never be reborn." Her voice grew soft and reflective.

"Adora told me Jitsu…was here to steal the Shard of Kaydak for this Lord Skeletor. That shard was then stolen by Peekablue, along with a kitt…" Catra never got to finish as Casta jumped to her feet.

"I know that Catra…I was there…I cast the truth spell on him that forced him to talk." Casta groaned and began to pace before the

fire. The firelight flickering over her pensively bowed countenance was ominous.

"I was just a child…when the Horde began amassing in the Fright Zone…The High Council back then wanted no part of the coming war. Norwyn was the Head Sorcerer at that time, he butted heads with Light Spinner constantly. She wanted the High Council to invoke the Spell of Obtainment. To use dark magic to give them the power boost they would need to wipe the Horde off the planet. Her research was not sound or even sane! The spell work was controversial and full of forbidden glyphs." Casta rubbed the back of her neck, grimacing with second hand shame. Mystacor could have ended the Horde back then and stopped the war from ever happening. So many people could have been saved…Micha could have been saved…But Norwyn refused to allow them to get involved.

"When Norwyn and the High Council refused to help her. Light Spinner used my brother's magic instead. He was just a teenager at the time, but his raw talent for magic was impressive. Which had caught Light Spinner's attention. He had been her prized pupil for many years. He was the most powerful sorcerer Mystacor had ever seen. She manipulated and used him, dragging him into her schemes and nearly killed him…then later out of spite! When he dared to fight against her. She banished him to Beast Island!" Casta's voice rose in both rage and despair.

"I need to understand…" Catra began to explain, knowing by asking about Light Spinner she had uncorked years of pain and anger.

"No, you don't!" Casta spun on her, cutting an arm violently across the air in front of her. She was livid, her face was red and eyes burning with both fear and rage.

"Her study has been sealed, her research and spell work has been locked away!" She snarled. "She was cruel and selfish….and she deserves to be forgotten!"

“She was scared!” Catra shouted back.

“Why are you defending her?” Casta was appalled. “Of all people, she treated you the worst…” She had heard the horrible stories from Adora how Shadow Weaver had mistreated Catra growing up in the Horde. Never from Catra herself, the magicat was far too proud. To divulge the abuse she had suffered at that woman’s hand. During the last days of the rebellion. Casta had witnessed Shadow Weaver’s toxic attitude towards Catra first hand, that was like a subtle poison. That affected not only Catra but weakened the bonds she was trying to cultivate to those around her. Heard the snide, verbal barbs she flung at Catra like sharp daggers. That arrogant, condescending way that woman constantly cut her down in front of the other’s, trying to make her feel less than, inadequate or a burden. How Catra would eventually retreat, no longer able to endure the woman’s bitter criticism. Holding herself, seeking to self soothe in the same ways she had noticed with Adora over the years. How Catra would flinch when the woman got to close, how her hackles would rise and her claws would extend. Becoming hyper alert of her surroundings. It was all a silent tell to the neglect and cruelty she had endured as a child.

Light Spinner had been a manipulative, self serving witch and the Monster she turned into. Was self inflicted and well deserved. But what she did to Catra, to Adora and countless other innocent children in the Horde. That was unforgiveable.

Catra’s ear’s folded back, as she bowed her head in contemplation. Her heart, already beating fast in rising anxiety over this confrontation, began to pound. The static white noise of a looming panic attack began to buzz in her head. As the terrible memories of her childhood began to threaten her resolve. Because what Casta said about Shadow Weaver was all true… yet…

Catra clamped down hard on her lower lip, drawing blood with her canine. Using the pain to shake herself free of being emotionally overwhelmed. She needed to stay focused, she needed to get through to Casta. Her mind was spinning, grasping for anything

that she could say to make her understand…When suddenly Finn's words, uttered with such conviction back in that barn in Thaymor rose in her mind.

"I…don't know…but…I know that forgiveness is not always earned…but it's needed." Catra finally declared with conviction, meeting Casta's burning gaze with one just as impassioned.

Glimmer had remained in stricken silence through the whole exchange. She understood that Shadow Weaver had been a horrible mother to both of them. But neither Adora nor Catra had ever truly opened up to her about how brutal their upbringing had been in the barracks. She crossed the room and stood in solidarity next to Catra. Reaching out for her Aunt who looked ready to shatter any moment. Tears of both fury and misery, clouding her hazel eyes as she seethed.
"Auntie…Norwyn was not the pillar of goodness you believe he was. He was also meddling with Deep Magic. When Light Spinner absorbed him, she also absorbed a fragment of Time magic." Glimmer sought to explain, drawing Casta's seething wrath away from Catra. The magicat was trembling, holding herself and clearly near tears.

Casta's frantic pacing came to a sudden stop.
"What…" She breathed in disbelief, her eyes wide in shock.

Catra grasped desperately onto that fragment of hope that only a full disclosure could bring. Summoning her courage she spoke up again.

"Light Spinner was corrupted by the Obtainment spell…by a fragment of this Nameless One. She fought against this evil for years…she needed to feed off the Black Garnet to stay alive…as her body was in a constant state of decay. After she devoured Norwyn she was given a vision…an omen. She witnessed the Nameless One destroy our universe…she found Adora and saw her as a means to an end to save us. Then Adora found me in that stasis pod from a thousand years ago. Shadow Weaver raised me and Adora to fight this evil…there is a prophecy given by the Rune

Bearer of Fate. It's inscribed upon his statue in the Basilica." Catra tried to convince her, but once again was interrupted.

"The two shall come,

One sleeping, lost to time.

One stolen, lost to space.

Child of Time, Child of Space.

Each born of magic, given form through blood and bone.

One shall walk Etheria, upon the dawn.

The other shall greet the twilight.

Both reaching for and sheltered by each other.

They shall ascend upon the final day,

Becoming part of the stars.

To usher in a new beginning.

Each gives sustenance to the other.

Space offers dreams of life-Eternity in Death.

Time offers the soul salvation-Strength in the weft, elegance in the weave.

A tapestry made whole, so shall be one to the other. " Casta spoke the words long memorized in her youth.

Catra merely nodded, while Glimmer blinked several times absorbing the power within those words.

"Fine…tomorrow. I shall unseal her study…and retrieve her spell books from the vault. You will only read her research in my presence. Her spell books will never leave my private rooms. Got it!" Casta declared.

Both Glimmer and Catra nodded in agreement.

As soon as the gemstone horn mounted upon his brow, absorbed the magic's from Adora's bracer's. His entire being was filled to overflowing with power. The miserable silence he had been enduring since Swift Winds demise was lifted. Spirit could hear that glorious song of Etheria's Magic once more. Throbbing like a heartbeat within the facets of the gleaming white stone. The thrill of laying claim to that incredible power, urged him to bolt from the barn. He finally had the means to protect Adora. Just as he did before and he was not going to squander it.

The steady, well balanced weight of the armor did not hinder him at all. As he galloped at full speed out of the farmyard and into the dark fields beyond. The five greater moon's were floating high overhead. Their gentle light peeked out from the swiftly moving clouds above.

His nostrils flared, as the spicy, musky scents of wild grass assaulted his nose. The tell tale perfume of decay that dominated the cool season was thick in the air. As his hooves churned up the

ground, sending clumps of dirt and damp moss into the air. His ears were perked straight up, listening to the whispered hum of the drones engines hidden within the evening serenade of night time creatures. It had flown out of the barn and rocketed across the farmyard and out into the fields beyond. But Spirit would not let it get away, these drones would no longer lurk and spy upon Adora. He could not see them…but he could sense them. Just like before, the invisible spy was hovering just out of reach.

Spirit raced after it into the night. He was charged with a sacred duty to protect She-Ra and he would not fail. Tossing his head upward, shifting the weight of the Rune Stone horn he now wore upon his brow. Wielding it as he did as Swift Wind…like a sword. He pointed it upward towards the moonlit sky.

A bolt of golden energy exploded from the tip of his horn. Rocketing up into the sky. Followed by the satisfying scream of rending metal. Spirit tracked the Seeker Drone as it phased into view, smoking and sparking high above the field ahead.

With a knicker and a whinny of triumph, Spirit galloped forward as the drone plummeted towards the ground. He spun around and then he donkey kicked the smoking drone with all his strength, out of the sky. Promptly stomping it into the ground with all four hooves. Until it was a dented, flattened hunk of metal buried into the ground.

“Spirit!” Adora's frantic voice called out to him from the base of the hill.

Spirit reared with exhilaration and galloped back down to the field below. Prancing around the brown roan, tossing his head back and forth with pride.

“What has gotten into you?” Adora chuckled, her sudden anxiety finally easing since there was no immediate threat lurking around.

“Perhaps he was just excited about his new armor?” Liam passed her a proud grin over his shoulder. The subtle push for adoration from her, very clear.

“Did you make this?” Adora breathed in awe, climbing down off Liam’s horse and gently approaching Spirit.

“Yes…I’ve been working on it for many years.” Liam nodded. Watching her approvingly as she admired the armor. Brushing her fingertips down the ornate silver metal wings of the peytral. That flared out from Spirit’s chest and over his flanks. As she slowly made her way towards Spirit’s head. She had hoped when the magic flashed into the sky earlier that she would feel it returning to her bracer’s like when Kyle had stolen a fragment of Sheana. But the power had not returned, she did not feel lesser by its absence but she knew part of her magic was missing.

“As I have said. I spent my childhood under the tutelage of an Artisan from Mystacor. He taught me all about Stone Craft, leather and metal working. This armor is my finest work to date.” He explained with pride.

“It’s beautiful…truly.” Adora nodded, cupping Spirits cheeks with her hands and guiding his head downward. Her movements were slow and gentle, not wanting to spook the steed. Needing to draw his forehead downward so she could caress the base of the pearl white horn. In the hopes of reclaiming the magic this stone had stolen.

As her hands reached towards the leather shaffron, Spirit huffed and yanked his head away. Backing up and glaring down at her with distrust and betrayal yet again.

“Spirit…I’m sorry…but the magic is not yours to keep. Despara got real mad when Kyle took Sheana’s magic..I don’t want…” Adora stuttered out in panic. Her blue eyes moist with unshed tears, features twisting into anguished knots of far too many conflicting feelings. Not knowing what to do, not wanting to hurt Spirit’s feelings but also wanting to protect him.

(***Be at peace...)*** Sheana's voice echoed soothingly in her mind.

(The Goddess stone is a worthy conduit for our powers. We have merely granted this honorable steed the magic he has earned once more. But you will have to recharge the 'portable runestone' from time to time. Whenever he discharges our magic, as Etheria will simply reabsorb it.) Despara advised with a small chuckle. Having seen the fearful vision Adora had of her exacting divine retribution upon poor Spirit if she didn't get their magic back.

"Oh…Thank the stars…" Adora breathed, clutching her aching chest. As relief and joy washed over her. So very happy for him to reclaim the magic he had lost. It had been killing her to have to take it away by force.

"What?" Liam frowned down at her in confusion.

Adora giggled nervously, it was weird having the two Goddesses speaking to her in her mind she had to learn to stop responding verbally. Not wanting to get into a long explanation of her current link to the Goddesses of Life and Death. She quickly sought to deflect Liam's coming questions.

"What kind of Gemstone did you use for the horn?" She asked, sending a warm apology over her bond with Spirit. Holding her hands behind her back as she approached the Stallion again. Telling him through non verbal means that she would not touch his horn again without permission.

"The magic is yours…" She whispered as she got closer. Offering Spirit a bright, gleeful smile.

Spirit nodded vigorously, pawing his front hooves into the dirt aggressively.

Stating 'Damn right this is mine', with a firm jolt across their link of possession and confidence. That she could trust him with this power, that he would be responsible with it. As he had been before and that he felt more prepared to protect her.

Adora pressed her forehead to his in apology, as Spirit finally allowed her to reach out and take the dangling leather leads.

"I used a Gemstone called Selenite. It is a crystalline Gypsum." Liam shrugged.

"The Goddess Stone." Adora tossed her recent knowledge back at him over her shoulder with a smug look.

"Yes, it is a sacred stone. It can harmonize more than one kind of magic. It offers protection and healing. But it is soft and malleable in nature, so I do not believe Spirit should use it as a thrusting weapon or it might break. Honestly, it's just for ornamentation." Liam advised, guiding the roan alongside Spirit. As Adora walked back towards the farm.

"Thank you, for this amazing gift." Adora offered him a warm, grateful smile.

That was so alluring and pure that Liam's face flushed at her praise. He ducked his head in humility, chuckling nervously. As he rubbed the back of his neck, unable to meet her gaze as he had been overwhelmed by her beauty yet again. Adora could reduce him to a nattering fool with a smile. The unbearable yearning to always be at her side, to make her smile again, make her laugh….touch her…kiss her.. He had never felt this way before for anyone. It was the most intense feeling he had ever experienced.

When they returned to the front gate to the farmyard. Kronis was waiting for them. Leaning casually against the thick wooden post to the entry gate with his arms crossed over his chest. His yellow eyes narrowed, as he scrutinized the crystal horn adorning Spirits forehead. As Adora led Spirit under the gate, headed over the yard towards the barn. The pearl white horn was still glowing softly as not all of the stored magic had been released.

Kronis fell into step with Liam's roan, as the young man crossed under the gate a few moments later. He had seen the magic beam

released into the sky and slowly put the pieces together.

“Adora’s horse is wearing your barding?” Kronis asked, as he had watched the young man work on the leather armor over the last year. In the back stall at the end of the barn he had claimed it as his workshop. He never suspected the young man knew about crystals.

“Yes, it was a gift…I owe her for saving my life.” Liam responded, dismounting his horse.

“Was that a portable Rune Stone attached to the shaffron?” Kronis inquired, trying to act nonchalant but his surprise was obvious.

“I have no idea what that is. I was an apprentice of Master Elys of Mystacor as a child. I merely applied my knowledge of crystals to the armor…It was purely aesthetic.” Liam shrugged. “The fact that the Goddess Stone resonated with She-Ra’s magic was unexpected.” He finished with a smug smile. Striding off towards the barn with his head held high.

Kronis rolled his eyes at the boy’s unearned confidence. He had no idea what primal forces he was playing around with. The Gar groaned, scrubbing a gloved hand down his face. He had a dilemma on his hands now. The knowledge to create portable Rune Stones had been lost over a thousand years ago. The only remaining artifact was the Sword of Power that He-Man wielded. The Sword of Protection that had been wielded by She-Ra. That the current incarnation no longer possessed was either lost or destroyed. She had been able to summon a sword…but it wasn’t the one created by the First Ones. The rest of the portable Rune Stone weapons that were used during the Great Unrest, when the First Ones had been at war with the Galactic Horde. Had been lost to myth and legend if any still existed at all. Should he report this to Lynn? Or perhaps he should just keep a closer eye on Liam? He could gather more information before proposing to Lord Skeletor that the Ancient Magic of Etheria was once again free.

Njorun

Chapter Notes

> Thank you! Pink Storm for all of your comments, I really enjoyed reading each one. Thanks to all who left Kudo's as well.
> Here's another update.

Night had fallen over Mystacor, the moon’s hidden behind thick clouds. A cold rain fell upon the island. The Adept’s dorms huddled within the downpour, a stalwart shelter against the storm. The soft whispering of water against the window panes. A soothing lullaby for the occupants within, as night drew onward well past midnight. Several of the windows lay in somber shadow as many of the princesses were already fast asleep.

Yet firelight flickered within a lone room on the second floor. A soft glow illuminating the damp window. That light danced upon the walls inside, a comforting warmth filling the dark room. Scorpia had fallen asleep at her table, her head rested sideways upon the time stained pages of an open magic tome. One red claw gripped a large serpent’s tooth, attached to her neck by a leather cord. Her other claw lay over a small assortment of Plumerian meditation stones upon the table. The stones looked like glowing pebbles beneath the Scorpioni’s mighty claw.

She cringed and cried out weakly. She rarely dreamed, her sleep was usually just a restful void she retreated to everynight. But for the last month since the magic of the Heart had been released. Her dreams had been gaining in frequency. Becoming more vivid and far more intense. Now that she knew her magic was that of dreams. It was making a hell of a lot more sense.

She had fallen asleep reading an ancient spell book, written by a mage from the Forgotten Age. Who had been researching Dream magic. So her mind was churning over the text she had been reading. Her troubled unconscious still sifting through her faded

memories of her mother, her grandmother…the only other family she had known who had a connection to the Black Garnet.

It was a familiar dream, one she had been plagued with often as a small child but had faded as she grew older. Since the Heart's release. She has been tormented by these bleak phantasm's of her past, almost every night.

Scorpia was once more trapped in the smaller, weaker body of her childhood self. She stood frozen within the archway to the Black Garnet chamber, up in Horror Hall. Her large pincers clutched the crumbling stone on the rim of the archway. Her eyes transfixed upon the darkness within. Deep blue pools shimmering with unshed tears. Dressed in a junior Cadet's uniform. Of an indigo sleeveless shirt that allowed the red exoskeleton on her shoulders and upper arms to be free. The red symbol of the Horde emblazoned on the back. Loose black pants adorned her short legs and heavy gray boots were on her feet. Her platinum blonde hair was short, hanging just below her chin. Her bangs held away from her face with simple black barretts at her temples.

The shadows within the ancient Black Garnet Chamber held the bitter, iron scent of fresh death and sour stench of decay. The stillness in the air was noxious, if she breathed too deeply she may succumb to its poisonous embrace. An overwhelming sense of loss fell heavily upon her. As the darkness whispered her family's requiem. The wind howled through the chamber, an echo of the final screams of her family. Her two mother's final breath hung within the chamber. The vengeful wrath of their guardian, her grandmother's blood mingling with that of the others upon the flagstones.

Scorpia could not find the courage to leave the faint torch light in the hall she cowered in. Knowing that their corpses still lay within the darkness. Left to rot like spoiled meat. She could not face them. Could not honor them with the funeral rites down in the

Catacombs, in the ways of her people. Not as she was now. A child, weak and worthless.

It was the sharpness of claws made of dark magic upon her shoulder, pressing subtly against the base of her throat. That made her flinch. The first movement she had made in the last hour.

"What are you doing here, Princess?" The dark presence demanded, in Shadow Weaver's voice. Its solitary red eye glowing menacingly in the half light as it elongated and swung into view around her shoulders.

"Nothing.." Scorpia yelped, swallowing hard as the pressure of the claw at the end of the shadows thumb grew heavier against her throat. Drawing a thin ribbon of blood that now trickled down the back of her neck.

"You have been told numerous times that Horror Hall is off limits to you now." Shadow Weaver reminded, her voice was sweet, motherly. Yet also commanding and thick with disapproval.

The Black Garnet had not wanted to bond with her and the sorceress had lost interest in her usefulness. So the Rune Stone had been taken out of its original chamber and brought down to the fortress. So that Shadow Weaver could run tests and try and unlock its magic for herself.

Scorpia cringed, her mother's death…her grandmother's death… Mr. Pointy's death…it was all her fault. If she had been worthy of the magic, if it had bonded to her as it was supposed to. If she had been able to be the weapon Shadow Weaver had wanted….her family would still be alive…

"Return to the Barracks, child. Stop with this pointless rebellion. I have shadow spies everywhere. There is nothing that I do not see, nothing I do not hear…you belong to the Horde. It's about time you accept that." Shadow Weaver chastised, the shadow spy dissipating along with its blade like claws.

Scorpia hung her head in defeat. A few months ago, she might have screamed and cried. Attempt to fight the shadow that had followed her out of the fortress to her family's tomb. But now, her whole being had become numb. She slowly turned and walked solemnly back down the Great Hall. Staring at her plodding feet, refusing to look up at the crumbling portraits. Of her once proud and powerful royalline. Retreating back to the only life she had ever known. She knew her place and had accepted her fate.

She no longer had a family, no longer had a Rune Stone or a kingdom. She was a princess in title only. She had no powers and no way to fight against the Horde. She could never avenge her family or her people.

She was nothing…but clay for the Horde to mold.

The dream shifted, as a timeless mist curled around her. Scorpia found herself once more in her adult body. Standing in an eternal plane set apart from the waking world. Glowing motes floated in the air around her, that reminded her of the magic snow that had fallen for days after the Heart's magic had been released. An ethereal silence reigned supreme, as she now found herself in a realm of pure magic.

The true Heart of Etheria…

Scorpia could feel a gentle vibration tingling against the tip of her tail stinger. A long dormant lore that had laid hidden deep inside her own subconscious mind.

Her tail began to sway high over her head. In wide, languid movements that were both elegant and hypnotic. Her stinger trembled with anticipation. The lore was ancient and it seemed to hang in the air of this eternal plane. She was filled with a sudden wonder, as the vibration began to caress her claws like the soft touch of a lover. Her heart sped up with excitement, as her arms

began to move slowly through the air as if she was drawing some huge mural out of nothing. Then the endless colored threads of magic began to float within the mist rolling around her. Hanging in the air like millions of glowing ribbons of light, weaving within the magic that surrounded her. The deep maroon that was the same color as her lightning were the only threads to approach her. They began to twist around her stinger and then weave themselves around her claw tips. She moved the ever increasing threads, with a precision and grace with her claws she never could possess in the waking world. Gathering threads with her stinger and then weaving them before sending them forth into the ether once more from her claw tips.

Creating, bringing life to the vision she willed into existence. While the other threads retreated, weaving together to form an endless knot that formed the border of her creation. With her tail held high, waving in rhythm with her long arms, drawing the threads from the strobing aura of lights, shimmering in the sky above. She looked as if she was dancing through the now fading mists. Her movements were graceful and breathtaking, as her whole body began to glow with the magic of dream. As a world more vivid and wondrous than anything living in the waking world came alive around her.

It took no time at all for her to weave a world of her own within the dreamscape. Her heart and soul, manifesting before her. Given form by the strength of her will, sustained by her pure emotions and slowly coming alive as she bonded once more with the magic of her ancestors.

Scorpia stood proudly upon the crest of a hill, as the morning light broke through the clouds, falling over the wide fields of flower's below. The many blooms rose to greet the light, unfurling gloriously beautiful petals. The sky glowed, refracting the light as if made of crystal. With long, wisps of clouds stretched out over the endless horizon. A warm fragrant spring wind caressed her, tossing her longer platinum hair playfully. She closed her eyes, smiling with pride at her creation.

" ***This is a fine beginning, Precious."*** *A gentle, refined voice floated upon the wind.*

Scorpia's smile of wonder faltered as she spun around. Greeted by the ghostly countenance of a mythical creature she had not seen in decades.

"Mr. Pointy!" She exclaimed, dashing up to the crimson serpent and embracing their mammoth scaly snout. As her arms drew close the spirit of the Black Garnet's Guardian became solid once more. Infused briefly by her proximity. With the energies of manifestation. The raw essence of dream magic giving them a physical body for Scorpia to embrace.

The great serpent raised their powerful neck and laughed, when Scorpia released her hold. Their timeless voice boomed overhead, a joyous explosion of sound.

" ***My nickname...yes. Since I had given you one, you felt it was only right to give me one as wellI I have not heard that name spoken in far too long.*** *" They stared fondly down at Scorpia, who stood blushing and grinning up at them.*

Their ruby eyes shone with the radiance of twin star's. Shimmering with unshed tears of long held affection for the now fully grown Scorpioni.

"Let me look at you, my precious." They grinned, as Scorpia stood tall before them.

"**You bear the striking beauty of your mother, Vivyane. The height and strength of your other mother. Celeste."** The serpent swept their piercing gaze over her.. The intensity of their admiring stare, leaving Scorpia trembling and blushing. " **They would have been so proud of you, my precious one."** They advised, with a brilliant, toothy smile.

"I hope so…" Scorpia breathed, wiping away tears that had started to stream down her face. As she t*ook in the immensity of the Guardian of the Black Garnet in her own sweeping gaze. They*

were once again translucent, a spirit of the creature she had known as a baby. Transfixed upon the majesty of their form, she was in awe of their muscles coiling and uncoiling before her. As they would have in life. Their mighty being hovering just above the grass of the hill. A giant crimson snake with a regal crown of spikes circling their brow. Longer, thicker spikes formed a fin that ran the length of the serpent. Their tail ended in a huge bulb of spikes that resembled a club that looked very much like a morning star.

*" **But, my true name is Njorun, I am the Guardian of Dream** . " They offered. Curling low around Scorpia, so their enormous face could gaze more closely upon her. Their expression was pensive, Scorpia was the king's namesake and the last royal born. They regarded their long lost Rune bearer, with gentle curiosity. Scorpia looked so much like her mother, Vivyane. She had been training with her. To take on the magic held within the facets of the Black Garnet. She would have shared the magic with her mother and her grandmother. If she had been given the time to unlock her potential. But the power hungry sorceress from Mystacor did not give Scorpia a chance to mature into her magic. She had cast her aside as a failure, when she was a small child, before her magic could even manifest. Shadow Weaver had been the slow poison that tainted Hordak's relationship with the King. Swayed his hand to murder Scorpia's mother's, her Grandmother… So she could steal the Black Garnet and its magic for herself. Now that magic was free of the Rune Stone shell and was flowing naturally, as it once did before the First Ones meddling. Scorpia was absorbing fragments of the magic everytime she dreamed, but she had yet to commune with her source.*

That would be her first lesson…

Double Trouble was huddled under the heavier wool blankets he had been given for the coming cold season. Laying on their stomach, facing the bed that Catra was currently thrashing in, trapped in the throes of a nightmare. They had wrapped Catra's

old baby blanket around their head, not liking how scratchy the wool was against their sensitive scales. The outer membrane that protected their eyes in lizard form flicked over their eye lids.

They were hesitant to intervene too quickly, people were quite vulnerable in their sleep. Their unconscious mind always divulged secrets and hidden intentions.

Especially during a nightmare, when their emotions were the most exposed. They hadn't had much to report to Blue, besides Catra's return and Adora's mission to the Crystal Castle. It didn't help that the Seer wasn't picking up their calls either. But this was an opportunity for information, they couldn't pass up. They figured the Prince was just hiding again, he was good at that. When it was safe the Seer would answer again and then they could give them new info.

The world around her was as black as pitch. The ground beneath her rumbled, her ear's twitched. As Catra strained to hear over the howling of the night wind.

She swore she could hear the roar of tanks and the heavy beat of thousands of soldier's boots pounding the earth. It was the sound she knew well, the Hordes War Machine was on the move.

Distant screams echoed, followed by explosions and the rapid, piercing whine of cannon fire. Catra wanted to move, desperate to go to the aid of the villager's she heard being slaughtered. But she was frozen, laying prone upon the hard, trembling ground. She felt as if her body was being strapped down in the same, unyielding restraints that Prime had used. To hold her against the surgery platform, as his clones cut her mane and inserted the control chip. She started to panic, as the trauma of what happened next washed over her. Prime would come, inflict unimaginable pain and suffering upon her. He would rip into the very core of her inner self. Tear her apart piece by piece, until

there was nothing left of her but an empty husk for him to control.

Her heart leaped in her chest, beating wildly like the wings of a desperate bird unable to escape their cage. Tortured by the sounds of battle as thousands of innocent Etherian's were slaughtered. She cried out in misery and frustration into the void.

The nightmare shifted…

Catra glanced around anxiously, finding a small nightstand with a photo of two Scorpioni women with a smiling baby Scorpia in their arms. A small stuffed scorpion sat in front of the framed photo. The harsh light of the hallway, cascaded through the open door behind her. She swallowed hard as she noted the dark sleeve adorning her left arm and the sudden weight of her long mane.

She was in Scorpia's force captain quarters….just after the Horde conquered Salineas.

It was one of her most cruel memories…twisted and given form within this ever unfolding nightmare.

She was staring forlorn down at a piece of paper in her hands. Catra knew she was a miserable sight to behold at this point in the war. Her long brunette hair was knotted and unkept, oily and unwashed. She had been so wrapped up in the war effort, as her plans to finally conquer Etheria came to fruition. That her daily grooming had gone by the wayside. She had been incredibly driven for the last few months, to dominate everyone and everything that tried to get in her way. She would rule over Etheria and then…then she would be the strongest, no one could hurt her or threaten her ever again. She would finally be in control of her own life. She had been enduring long days of planning and

overseeing countless troop deployments. She had been under extreme stress for far too long. It had taken its toll on her health and her sanity…

She had just gotten back from Salenias, the assault on the Sea Gate had been a huge success. She had wanted to celebrate with Scorpia on the beach front but the woman never showed up. Which had led her here, to Scorpia's quarter's. The dread that she might have left too had already started to torture her. She had been short tempered with the Scorpion for weeks, since Entrapta 'left'. When the woman had failed her, she had lashed out as she commonly did when Scorpia screwed up. Which honestly was quite often. Screaming some very mean, very familiar words…

*(**You broke the recordings…one simple thing and you completely ruined it! Of course you ruined it, yeah…your Scorpia. I mean how could you possibly be this useless!)***

The fear that she might lose the war because Hordak did not have Entrapta's notes had gotten the better of her. She knew she had hurt Scorpia's feelings, but it wasn't like she hadn't treated her any worse than before?

Finding Scorpia's room empty and a note waiting for her. Her anxiety that had been compounding inside of her for months… ever since the portal. Grew beyond her control to contain. What was left of her heart finally shattered like so much glass.

She was alone….

The main lights in the room were turned off. Leaving the rather spartan living quarters in a muted darkness.Only a fragment of light was invading the room, through the open door. In a faint narrow beam from the overhead light in the hall.

Their low humm is the only sound, beyond Catra's slow, shuddering breaths as complete panic sets in as she reads the note.

…everyone had abandoned her…

She could feel the hot trails of tears falling down her face, striking the paper in her hands. The words started to blur, as she wept softly.

(Sorry, WildCat.

I tried to be the person you needed most. But you don't need me…you never have.)

Her emotions burned inside of her, black and burdensome.

Guilt……regret…resentment and finally rage…

Her arms fell in defeat and the note fluttered to the floor.

"Fine…I don't need you either!" She growled, storming out the room. Needing to find somewhere to release all her pain. A place to unleash all her fury, a place to destroy.

Catra whimpered in her sleep, rolling onto her side and blindly fumbling for Adora's pillow. Clutching it tight to her chest as she curled around it. Seeking the only comfort she had left. Taking deep breaths as she sought to envelop all of her senses in Adora's lingering scent. That always calmed her, always made her feel safe…made her feel wanted…loved…

The world around her was as black as pitch. The ground beneath her rumbled, her ears twitched. As she strained to hear over the howling of the night wind.

She swore she could hear the roar of tanks and the heavy beat of a thousand soldier's boots pounding the earth.

Distant screams echoed, followed by explosions and the rapid, piercing whine of laser fire. Catra wanted to move, desperate to go to the aid of the villager's she heard being swept up in the

attack. But she was frozen, laying prone upon the hard, trembling ground. She felt as if her body was being strapped down in the same, unyielding restraints that Prime had used. To hold her against the surgery platform, as his clones cut her mane and inserted the control chip.

Panic…fear…suffocating her…

The repulsive smell of decay, musky and putrid…the stench of the grave… a scent she recognized…that had clung to Shadow Weaver…tainted the air around Horde Prime…and…

Her heart leaped in her chest, beating wildly like the wings of a terrified bird unable to escape their cage. Tortured by the sounds of battle as thousands of innocent Etherian's were slaughtered. She whimpered and cringed, attempting to hide from the void surrounding her.

Guilt…regret…crushing her…

A bitter taste invading her mouth, more sour than bile…like acid burning her throat…

A being of pure darkness hovered over her, given life by an oath to the Nameless One. Catra held her breath, frozen with fear. Unwilling to open her eyes, until she felt the pressure of a clawed finger poking her in the center of the forehead. Sending all her survival instincts into overdrive. Her whole body lurched and buzzed with an electric charge.

Wrath…loathing…devouring her…

A fierce, biting cold enveloped her…an ache penetrating deep into her bones…

The being hovering above her was pure evil…

She knew who the demon was before she opened her eyes. Her heart sank back into that pit of unending misery. That she had

endured during those tragic years, when she was filled with nothing but rage and pain.

Void Catra crouched over her stomach, grinning down at her. Her smile was so wide and feral, it showed her fangs. Her golden eye gleamed with an amused sort of malevolence. This was her at her most vile, having offered herself to the Nameless One. She had become a vessel of darkness, of hate and vengeance.

" ***Heeeey, Caaaatra…"*** The demon sang tauntingly.

Catra couldn't speak, stunned and frightened she could only stare up at her dark-self. Her soul trapped, frozen under the demon's predatory glare. The demon's dark whispers. Promising her an unending punishment within the bowels of its hellscape if she ever disobeyed again. She belonged to them, a part of the darkness that preyed upon the weak. A harbinger of the new order, born from the abyss to exact divine retribution upon the universe that had unjustly imprisoned them.

Then the desolate abyss she was trapped in shifted, like the turning of a page in a book.

She was once again bound and forced to kneel before a throne, made of bones. The apex of the throne had the skull of a four horned beast. The backrest was the spine and hips, the ribs splayed outward. The seat was covered in a fur hide.

High pitched, manic laughter echoed from the empty void behind the throne.

As Void Catra sat smugly upon the throne, her legs crossed. Her eyes slowly take in Catra's, forced subjection with a pleased expression. The superior arrogance in her disapproving scowl, reminded her of Prime. As she was forced to kneel before his throne on the Velvet Glove.

" ***Awww, poor thing…you're all alone again."*** *Void Catra cooed, leaning down smugly, as the tip of her clawed toe poked Catra under the chin. Forcing her to crane her head upward at a*

sharp angle to prevent the toe claw from piercing the tender part of her throat.

Then the world shifted again…Void Catra had Catra pinned on her knees. Her arms twisted at such a sharp angle behind her back, the tendon's were screaming, her bones on the verge of snapping. Held firm in a grasp so strong it could rival She-Ra's.

All of the attacks she had led as a Force captain as a Commander flashed around her. The death and destruction she caused across Etheria, began to escalate. Leaving nothing but desolation and mass graves in the wake of the hundreds of Horde assaults, as her armies began to take more territory. Creeping ever closer to Bright Moon.

*" **Let's be honest…this is all your fault."** Void Catra, whispered mockingly in her ear. Catra could feel the hot tears falling down her cheeks, as her dark self forced her to watch every one of her sins. Which unfolded one after another in clear, agonizing clarity. Her brutality against Adora…her betrayal of Entrapta…her cruelty to Scorpia…The guilt and remorse was choking her. She couldn't breath, couldn't look away. It was tearing her apart, her heart ached and her soul screamed for mercy.*

*" **None of this would have happened, if you had not been so weak…"** Void Catra sighed in resignation, lifting her up by her pinned arms to her feet.*

Catra cried out in agony as her arms nearly snapped under the strain of her full weight. Then Void Catra spun Catra around and tossed her across the dark abyss that lay behind. The scenery shifted yet again, as Catra collided with a cold, iron railing. She had only a second to catch her bearings, glancing over the side to the bottomless pit. The snow falling around her and the frozen tundra that lay all around the metal bridge that spanned the gap of the massive hole.

Unearthly howls were echoing from the pit, the hole as black as pitch like the abyss itself.

She was back in the Horde compound up in the Northern Reach. Her shoulders were on fire, arms aching, fingers tingling. Her arms might be dislocated? Nerves were definitely pinched….

Then Void Catra was upon her again, pulling her off the railing by the shoulder's and flinging her across the expanse of the bridge. Catra screamed as she flew, her body striking the unyielding surface of the metal bridge, then rolling to an abrupt stop into a snowbank at the very edge of the chasm. Ice and snow bit into the exposed flesh of her bare arms, her hands instantly going numb. As she sluggishly picked herself up off the ground. Her arms trembling under the strain of her own weight. As she struggled to remain on her hands and knees, she groaned and squeezed her eyes shut. As she suddenly felt woozy and disorientated. At this point she felt herself beaten in every way a person could be.

Her body was exhausted, her mind shredded, her heart shattered.

"If you hadn't given into your resentments, your jealousy for your best friend. " *Void Catra, taunted as she stalked down the bridge towards Catra. Her eyes gleaming with amusement. As all the times Catra had been mean or violent to Adora flashed in her mind, again.*

" Allow your fear or your rage to control you."

Catra couldn't breath, she struggled to take in air but her throat was tight and her chest rattled.

"Admit it! The world would have been a better place, if you had never woken up…if you had never been born!" *Void Catra grabbed her by the hair on top of her head and forced her to look up. Confronting her with all her worst memories, her abuse, her trauma. All the agony of believing she was a monster,*

being unworthy of love. That still festered inside of her heart. The desolation and misery that followed when it had been proven true. When everyone that had once cared about her…was pushed away by her own toxicity.

It all turned the world black once more.

"You willingly offered yourself up to me! You allowed me to destroy you, to recreate you in my image…to seed myself inside of your soul…you belonged to me!" *Void Catra screamed in fury inches from Catra's face.*

As the darkness was enveloped in a blinding divine light. The swirling vortex of the portal sucked Catra away. But this time she did not fight it, did not claw and struggled against the current. She willingly turned onto her back and closed her eyes, as the familiar healing powers of She-Ra flowed over her.

Catra cried out and bolted upright in bed.

"Wow…I thought only Momma Adora got into fights with the bed." Finn chuckled, his voice soft. Floating to her from the side of the bed.

Catra cut her eyes sideways, clutching her chest and forcing air into her lungs. Seeking to calm down her racing heart, hammering against her ribs from the nightmare.
"Want to talk about it?" Finn inquired, his tone full of concern.

"NO." Catra blurted out, much too loudly. As the impact of what she had endured began to subside. She was left reviewing the nightmare and the hidden truths it held. She had been worrying about a fragment of the Nameless One still being inside of her. But the dream had illustrated, with much relief that She-Ra had pulled the darkness out of her. When the connection to that chaos dimension had been severed by destroying the portal. In the very same way she had with Shadow Weaver, when she had healed her

back in Bright Moon. Destroying the fragment of the Nameless One as she cleansed the body with her divine magic.

“Thank you….Scorpia…” Catra bowed her head, humbled by her friends' ceaseless efforts to care for her. Pulling her knees up to her chest and resting her forehead on her crossed arms. The Scorpioni was mad at her and still her magic sought only to comfort and protect her.

Just like always…

That realization only spurned her anew to make things right between them.

“If you ever want to tell me about it, I’m here…ok.” Finn offered again, rising from the bed and retreating back to his bed roll.

“Sure…kid.” Catra muttered, never raising her head from the security of her arms. Needing time to absorb the revelation, that she was not tainted by the Nameless One. She felt lighter, as one worry lifted from her mind.

She listened to the soft rustle of Finn, snuggling down in his blankets. The faint crackle of the dying fire. The whispered hush of the rain, falling upon the glass of the window. Debated calling Adora, she really needed to talk to someone. The horrifying images, enduring the torment of her Dark Self and the cruelty that spewed from her mouth. Was haunting her…she could write a song about it. Perhaps Adarion could soothe the ache of guilt and regret that was burdening her heart. But sunrise was hours from now and Adora needed her sleep. They had spoken before bed, like they had been since separating. She knew Spirit had been acting weird today and ran off into the night. Adora was itching to get back on the road to Crystal Castle. But the armor this Liam guy had put on his back tonight and his flight across the fields had rubbed his back haunches raw. Adora was recovering slowly from healing Kyle and then Liam, she had given Spirit what she could of her healing magic every morning. So she was stuck at least for one more day.

Catra turned onto her side, curling around Adora's pillow. Hoping her lingering scent would be enough to lull her back into sleep. The minutes crept by, agonizingly slowly and she never relaxed, or felt drowsy. Her comfort, that had always worked in the past, was failing her. She was fully alert and unable to settle down and she was growing more and more frustrated.

Catra groaned and rubbed her face with her hands giving up. The soft snores of Finn, let her know the little boy was fast asleep. She slipped out of bed, only to receive a faintly concerned mew from Melog. She turned to find the tiny kitten, crawling out of the mound of pillows in the corner of the room. They had not tried to intervene during the nightmare. Melog always let her bad dreams run their course and never tried to wake her up. But she had sensed their attempts to comfort her over their link when she first woke up. As they were now, in their newly developing form. Their emotional connection was like a gentle caress.

"Hey, Melog." Catra was quick to squat beside the powder blue kitten. Their body had changed yet again. They now looked more like a plump kitten, with large paws and an incredibly long pink tail. That floated and swirled like an ethereal cloud at sunset. Their face was still very round but the muzzle was more pronounced…but their ears were still huge. Flopping endearingly within the glowing pink mist of their mane. As they scampered into Catra's welcoming arms. Their color tone instantly warmed into a fiery orange as her magic enveloped them. Their mane and tail, flaring into a flickering flame of brilliant yellow. They snuggled for a moment before crawling up onto her shoulders and curling around her neck, purring softly.

Catra chuckled, at Melog's obvious cat-like behavior. They loved to perch on her shoulders, wanting to stay close, but not hinder her. As she moved to the hearth and began to stack new logs into the fire box. With a flick of her wrist and a snap of her fingers. A tiny spark, jumped from a claw and onto the dry wood, instantly blossoming into a roaring fire.

She smiled with satisfaction, intent on spending the rest of the night curled up in a chair by the fire. She was heading back to the bed to fetch a blanket, when her ears swiveled towards the window. Catching the subtle sound of Scorpia, moving above, in her room then moving outside onto the upper balcony.

Catra began to pace, her thoughts fighting each other in a dual battle of opposing ideas. She was desperate to fix things, and wanted Scorpia to talk to her. This was an opportunity to get the Scorpioni alone and confront her about the weirdness between them. Yet she didn't want to be rejected again, like this morning.

She felt like such a coward, pacing back and forth in front of the fire chewing absently on a claw. Working up the courage to go out there in the rain, as the fire leaped and swayed from one side of the firebox to the other. Becoming more violent and agitated, absorbing its Rune Bearer's frantic emotions.

(...go…) Melog's voice whispered in her mind. It had been many days since she had heard from them. Their voice was gentle, childlike.

Catra's eyes widened in shock, then a slow, confident smile spread upon her face.

"Ok…" She was instantly in action, pulling Melog off her shoulder and setting them gently on the cushion of the chair by the hearth. She was not going to force them into the rain. Uncaring that she was wearing just her white training shirt and pair of Adora's black shorts as sleepwear. She dashed out of the door into the torrential rain and leaped upward to the railing above.

Finding the taller woman, hunched over the railing in a sleeveless tank top and loose green sleep pants.

"Hey, Scorpia.." Catra greeted her timidly. Crouching on the railing a few feet away, scratching the back of her neck nervously where Primes chip once was.

“Biscuits and Gravy!” Scorpia shouted in alarm at Catra’s sudden and rather meek intrusion to her thoughts.

“Hungry, big gal?” Catra chuckled softly, offering Scorpia her signature taunting smirk.

“Yeah…maybe…” Scorpia chuckled back, nervously rubbing the back of her neck as well.

“Still hurts?” Catra nodded towards her neck, it was pointless small talk but she needed to keep the conversation going. Otherwise her courage might falter and then she would surrender to her insecurities and run away.

“Nah…I just…”Scorpia took a big breath, working out her words. “We all still do it, don’t we…” She finished lamely.

“Everyone who got chipped…yeah, I noticed that we all rub our scars…when we’re upset…” Catra finished for her, she was drenched. Her hair hung heavily around her large ears. Water dripped from the ends and created tiny river’s that fell down her cheeks like tear tracks and dripped off the tip of her nose.

“Yeah…I’m sorry Wildcat.” Scorpia moaned, still refusing to look at her.

“Why are you apologizing…I’m the one who screwed up again.” Catra nearly shouted, her voice high pitched and exasperated. Her fur was soaked now, clinging to her bare arms and legs like a wet blanket.

Scorpia cut her eyes towards her for the first time, waiting. Finding the cat-hybrid crouched on the railing in the rain. She was completely soaked, her short dark hair was plaster to her head. Bangs hanging low over her eyes dripping upon her face. Her expression was the most miserable Scorpia had ever seen. Her white t-shirt was hanging low, nearly see through from the rain.

Scorpia was quick to note that seeing hints of Catra’s bare breasts, didn’t affect her like it might have a month ago. Instead

she was more concerned about her well being.

Catra hated water! The fact that she would endure being cold and wet…just to talk to her…it spoke volumes about her commitment to their friendship.

"I just…don't know what I did…" Catra muttered bitterly, climbing down off the railing. Crossing her arms on top of the railing and mimicking Scorpia's hunched pose.

Scorpia sighed, the breath leaving her lungs was drawn out and sad.

"I liked your song this morning." Scorpia slid in closer to her, pulling her into a consolatory side hug.

"I am sorry, for whatever I did or said…I know I hurt you again.." Catra sniffed, wrapping her arm stiffly around Scorpia's hips. It was an awkward attempt to hug her back. Her insecurities and feelings of unworthiness holding her true affections in check.

"It's a start, Wild Cat…" Scorpia smiled tenderly down at her, leaning the side of her head against the top of Catra's thick dark hair.

"It's a start…" Scorpia stated again, after her long talks with Perfuma today. She understood a bit more about being patient with Catra's obliviousness when it came to her more predatory nature.

She may not have meant to glare at her so threateningly, this misunderstanding may be more Scorpia's fault then Catra's. But Scorpia still needed time to deal with her own issues of inferiority…when it came to Catra.

What was found...

Chapter Summary

> Thank you Pink Storm for your comment and everyone who left Kudo's. I hope you all enjoy this latest chapter, things are going to get more exciting soon.

The following morning, found; Scorpia and Catra cuddled up under a heavy wool blanket on the outer balcony. Both sitting up against the Scorpioni's front door, trying to keep each other warm, in a very similar manner. When they were returning to the Fright Zone after their mission to the Northern Reach.

Scorpia had her arm wrapped around the feline's shoulder, tucking the smaller woman against her side securely. Catra had been soaked and shivering, when Scorpia had wrapped them both in the blanket. So keeping her warm was paramount in the Scorpion's mind.

They had spent the remainder of the night, watching the rain fall upon the central courtyard. A silent solidarity passed between them as Scorpia leaned her head atop Catra's as they huddled together for warmth.

Catra had slowly, stubbornly fallen asleep against Scorpia's chest. Mumbling a thankyou as sleep claimed her. But Scorpia couldn't sleep, far too many thoughts churning inside her mind. She didn't know what the gratitude was for, but it still warmed her heart to hear it. She gave the top of Catra's head a short, friendly kiss. Catra wasn't the same person she had been a year ago. Scorpia knew this, and had witnessed how hard she was trying to overcome the toxicity of her past. She was good and her heart was kind. The more she dwelled upon what happened with Sweet Bee. The more she talked about it with Perfuma. Whose perspective she respected, as it was very insightful. The more she came to understand that Catra was not entirely at fault. That she was going to stumble from time to time as everyone did. She was

coming to understand that yes, Catra had over stepped, she had disrespected her. That she would need to in the future have a good long talk about her mistreatment in the past. But she needed to work on herself first, she needed to deal with her inferiority issues, her insecurities and doubts. Perfuma had spent time counseling Catra and then Adora, seeking to quiet the negative voices that each of them were cursed with thanks to being raised in the Horde. She was coming to understand Horde Orphans in a way the rest of the princesses could not.

She kept a vigil, watching Etheria's many moons travel across the night sky, alone with her thoughts.

As the night dragged on Scorpia thoughts shifted…towards a more positive outlook.

She was beginning her own journey once more to claim her birthright. Djouron has taught her so much already. She was excited to return to her own elemental realm tomorrow night and learn more. She was also eager for morning to come, so she could share her exciting news with Perfuma during their meditation session.

"Morning…" Perfuma's gentle greeting penetrated the fog of exhaustion Scorpia had been wading in.

She blinked and turned her face upward, to find the Plumerian Princess standing in front of her. Hands clasped gently in front of herself, a tight, polite smile gracing her normally sweet features.

"Morin'in…" Scorpia responded, her voice husky from lack of use. Then she felt the slight weight of Catra. She instantly looked down, finding the cat-girl's face slumped against her breasts. Drool soaking the front of her sleep shirt.

"Oh…this is not what you think it is…" Scorpia stumbled, seeking to shift herself out from under Catra. Many months ago, she might have still fantasized about finding herself in this exact situation

with the Cat Hybrid. But definitely not now!
Scorpia cringed, chuckled awkwardly, looked hopelessly about. Trying to figure out what she could do to gently extract herself.

All while Perfuma's eyes glittered with amusement at how flustered she was.

The Plumerian crouched before her, pulling her long green cloak shut. The morning air was crisp. She had noticed that ice crystals had formed upon the grass making them glisten and the trees had nearly shed all their leaves. The flagstones of the courtyard had a thin sheet of ice from the frozen rain. This was the end of her time meditating outdoors for the year. She would have to go on a little adventure this morning to find a peaceful, warmer place someplace indoors. As the cold season sets in.

"It's o.k Scorpia…calm down….I understand. " Perfuma giggled and sighed, smiling reassuringly. Perfuma's eyes were tender as she reached out, pushing a stray strand of platinum blonde hair back behind her ear.

Scorpia sighed with relief. Perfuma said that a-lot. Her voice was always reassuring, always supportive and full of hope. She had become her rock to draw strength from, her soft place to land when her world crumbled back in Scorpania. Perfuma had become her best friend, the person she thought about most and always yearned to be near everyday.

She was falling in love…

"You're the best, Perfuma…you know that." Scorpia praised her, finally thinking straight and no longer panicking. She tapped a claw tip tenderly against Catra's arm and shook her gently.

"Time to get up, Wildcat." She called, gently.

Catra snorted and blinked rapidly, coming around far too quickly. By becoming aware of the unfamiliar scent and the strange fleshy pillow she had been sleeping against. She flung herself off Scorpia with a startled cry, when she became fully aware of the situation.

“Nope….sorry…ugh…” Catra swayed on her feet, disorientated by her sudden violent movement away from Scorpia. She felt light headed and her vision of a concerned Scorpia and an amused Perfuma swam briefly.

“Did you talk?” Perfuma asked hopefully.

Scorpia averted her gaze. “I’m not ready…” She muttered.

Perfuma nodded, folding her arms over her chest.

“Are you two better?” Perfuma pressed, warmly

Catra turned to Scorpia, her expression was reserved but hope shone in her mismatched eyes.

“Yes…” Scorpia smiled up at Catra.

(*Forgiveness is not always earned, but it is always needed.)*

“Good.” Perfuma nodded, before turning and opening Scorpia’s door. “I need you to start a fire, Scorpia…I am freezing my ‘petals’ off!” She moaned, disappearing inside.

Scorpia gave Catra a small apologetic smile, before scrambling to her feet and following after Perfuma. Closing her door softly. Leaving Catra standing alone once more on the balcony.

But this departure was on good terms, Catra no longer felt that gnawing anxiousness and brooding desolation from yesterday.

Today was off to a much better start.

Adora packed up her bag and headed for the barn well before dawn. She was going to pour every once of healing magic into Spirit’s burns and then get back on the road. After Spirits freak out yesterday. She just couldn’t shake the feeling that Etheria was running out of time. The pressure of impending doom was a

constant weight upon her conscience. She needed to get going, needed to figure out what really happened to Mara and regain control of everything!

When she entered the barn she was stopped in her tracks, being confronted by the two clones. One was tying up a mule to the front of a small, covered cart. While the other was at the back, loading the cart with supplies and provisions.

"Are you guys headed out on a journey?" Adora laughed, as she walked past the wagon.

"Yes…Sister." The first clone responded, his voice slightly muffled as he was crouched under the side of the Mule. Buckling up the stomach harness to the pulling bar.

"We shall be ready to depart…soon." The second clone advised, as he stepped up into the cart to properly stack the provisions. He had set haphazardly at the back of the cart.

As Adora drew near Spirit's pen, she found Liam already inside applying a layer of ointment. He wore a pensive expression of remorse, as the burns on Spirit's rump looked red and puffy.

"I'm sorry, I put the barding on you last night." He apologized. "I wanted to show it off and it was selfish." he muttered, patting Spirit on the neck. As he stared ruefully at the armor currently draped over the fence of Spirit's stall.

Spirit tossed his head, nibbling absently on an apple. Liam had brought him as a treat and an apology gift. He was still wearing the saffron with the horn, refusing to allow him or Adora to take it off last night.

"Morning." Adora hung her pack on the hook by the gate, then tossed Liam a curt wave as she entered the pen.

"Morning…" Liam grinned, his dower mood lifting instantly upon Adora's appearance.

“Owww…” Adora moaning in empathy. “I got you.” She reassured Spirit. As she noticed how inflamed the burns were and cupped Spirits cheek lovingly. Then went right to work, calling the healing magic into her hand from her golden bracer and applying it directly to the wounds. Liam watched the blue gem come alive, as she drew the magic into her left palm and applied it directly to the irritated skin. In time both hands were a-light with that soothing white energy, her eyes glowing an electric blue with magic.

Liam’s breath stalled, as he stared in awe and wonder. Becoming enraptured by her beauty as she was imbued by divine light. How her features became even more angelic, more gorgeous under the influx of magic. Her blonde hair was infused with a golden radiance as her whole body seemed to glow with power.

She was amazing…she was breathtaking…she truly was a Goddess…

He wanted to kiss her….or bow…or breath…he needed to breathe!

Liam took a deep, rather loud breath, suddenly feeling light headed and dizzy.

Taking tentative steps away from the horse, worried he was going to faint. Heading cautiously towards the gate to lean against it. As he regained his bearings and his senses once more.

“How is he looking?” Kronis’s gravelly voice interrupted Adora’s concentration.

The healing aura faded instantly, as Adora raised her head to regard Kronis with a stern look.

“This is why I do this without an audience.” She huffed, shaking her head in irritation. Before scrutinizing Spirit’s burns which now looked much better. The skin had nearly healed and his pearl white hide was starting to grow back in.

Kronis smirked and grabbed the heavy, winged peytral from the edge of the gate.

“Grayskull…brat.” He muttered as he walked away. He had overlooked Tri-clops feeds last night. Watched Jitsu’s interrogation back at Mystacor and came to realize that this Adora, was the long lost Princess of Eternia. Which only gave him more incentive to leave his current mission. That was to infiltrate the Tech Master’s guild and report back to Lynn how much of a threat Etheria might pose to Lord Skeletor’s future plans for the planet. The only threat he had managed to find was Entrapta. But Adora turned out to be a much bigger prize. To lay before Lord Skeletor then Entrapta. So he would be sticking with her for the time being. Liam’s portable Runestone was highly compelling to analyze as well. So since the boy was planning on leaving with Adora then so would he.

“You're departing today, then.” Liam motioned to the pack, Adora had hung from the tackle hook along the side of the pen.

“Yes.” Adora nodded, unsure how to say goodbye. In the brief time she had been on the farm she had grown quite close to Liam and his father. She never spent much time with Agatha, Liam’s mother. She had to admit she was kinda avoiding her. Honestly she had mother issues…thanks to being raised by a narcissistic, power hungry manipulator and then watching the only woman who had been a good mother figure. Sacrifice herself for her and all of Etheria. Well, it didn’t make her too eager to bond to another mother.

“I’ll go get packed then.” Liam chucked a thumb over his shoulder.

“Wait…what? No…is that why the clones are packing that cart up there?” Adora was finally putting the pieces together.

“Of course, a couple of the farm boys saw you packing this morning and word got around. So Pa got the clones right to work to provision us for our journey. ” Liam nodded.

“Us…” Adora blinked completely off balance now. She was ok with the clones tagging along, they didn’t fit in here and they needed her. But Liam? She didn’t want to take him away from the farm, what if Jack needed him? He was also not trained at all to fight. Her life right now was a complicated mess. With deadly conflicts threatening everyday. He didn’t need to get caught up in all that… she couldn’t put him in harms way! She wouldn’t…

Liam saw her frown deepen and the forehead wrinkle with worry. He could sense she was going to tell him not to come. That she saw him as a hindrance and not a help.

“You are going to need me. I am the only one who knows how to repair Spirit’s barding if it gets broken during battle… I don’t want to be a farmer, Adora. I want to be an Artisan of Mystacor, I want to mold Crystals and carve gemstones, create armor like what I gifted you. Please take me with you.” Liam knew he sounded desperate. He was done being complacent with his lot in life. He wanted more…he wanted to be someone worthy of her love. She just needed to give him a chance to prove it. He couldn’t let her leave without him!

Adora was reluctant to agree. Ever since finding the sword, ever since she became She-Ra. Danger and life threatening situations were her day to day normal. She didn’t think he was ready to deal with that level of risk. He had lived a life sheltered and free of such hardships. She was honestly rather confused as to why he would willingly choose to leave such a beautifully peaceful life.

“If I said, no…would it stop you?” Adora countered. “Would you stay…”

Liam was quiet for a bit, his expression crestfallen and introspective. Finally he slowly raised his eyes to confront hers.

“No…I would just go to Mystacor on my own then.” Liam admitted, his eyes firm.

Adora sighed, her smile small, resigned. As she conceded with a nod.

“Fine, as long as you're with me. I can keep you safe. I will be headed back to Mystacor eventually.” She advised with a sigh.

Liam nodded, snatching up a piece of barding.

“I will be riding Spirit bareback for the time being.” Adora stated, petting Spirit’s back tenderly. “So you can pack the saddle too.”

Kronis placed the barding into the cart and headed back for another piece. There was no way Adora would be putting that horse in full armor until he was fully healed. Liam was already heading down the aisle with Spirit’s saddle when Kronis started to head back to the pen.

“She’s riding him bareback, then?” He inquired.

“Guess so.” Liam shrugged as he passed.

Kronis chuckled, that was a very ballsy move for a princess. She must really trust that horse.

Catra let out a long, miserable groan. As she rolled her shoulders and stretched her neck. She had been sitting at Casta’s desk in the study all morning, several tall stacks of leather bound books perched along the front were blocking her from view. She had been scanning the pages of several spell books, none of them seemed to reference dark magic or anything about the Nameless One.

Glimmer was lounging on an plush armchair by the hearth, her legs kicking absently as she flipped through another spell book in her lap.

“Stars…Light Spinner was prolific in her research…she goes on and on and on…just get to the point already!” Glimmer complained. “There is more writing than glyph work in here…” She huffed, “that I can barely read…by the way.” She finished with a growl. Turning the book sideways with a smirk.

Catra laughed mirthlessly. “You were never on the receiving end of one of her long drawn out lectures or one of her wonderful pep talks.”

Glimmer arched an eyebrow at Catra. As the cat girl stood up from the desk and strode pompously towards the Queen. With head cocked and chin jutting upward, staring down her nose at Glimmer.

“I creature as unmotivated and insolent as you, could never hope to achieve anything in this life. Let alone understand the complexities of magic.” She spouted in a flippant, condescending manner.

“She really talked to you like that?” Glimmer swung her legs around to sit up straight in the chair. As Catra flopped down in the companion chair beside her.

“All the time.” Catra shrugged. “She was hard on everyone, but she was the most cruel to me.”

“That’s terrible.” Glimmer moaned, slamming the spell book shut.

“Light Spinner was a condescending bitch…even before she was tainted by Dark Magic.” Casta’s snarl echoed from the door to the study. As she walked into view with yet another stack of books. “A pompous blowhard, who thought she was some kind of savant when it came to spell casting. She treated me terribly too, Catra. Well, my brother Micha. Since he was more powerful and eager to please. She treated him like her protege, pumping him full of

praise and ideals that he could do great things as long as he learned spell work only from her. Than introduced him to dark magic and knowingly put his life at risk. For her own benefit." Casta finished, slamming the books down on her desk.

"She wasn't a good person…I get that better than most." Catra agreed, "But she gave her life. So that Adora and I could get to the heart. That should count for something…" Catra's voice trailed off nervously. She wasn't exactly a good person either. She had a chance to redeem herself to Etheria, to do good things, to protect her friends…to protect Adora…all because that woman sacrificed herself.

Casta nodded, agreeing reluctantly. Her mouth set in a thin lipped frown of disdain, eyes drawn inward in reflective condemnation. She would not argue, but she would also not forgive. Her hatred of that woman ran far too deep.

Catra's smirked, she never thought that she would ever be the one to defend and advocate for Shadow Weaver's better self. But it had been there in the end…when it had mattered most.

"Will you be able to take me down to Light Spinner's Study, now?" Catra asked, tamping down the hope she felt. Castaspella had reluctantly agreed to allow her and Glimmer to read Light Spinner's spell books. Which so far had been proven pointless. But unsealing the dishonored Sorcerers Study was a whole nother battle to fight.

"Retrieving Spinner's research from the vault was one thing, dismantling the seals on her study will take more time I am afraid." Casta apologized.

Catra nodded and sat back down, leaning over to the low coffee table to pick up another leather bound book. She set it on her lap and began to thumb through the pages.

"This one is different…" Catra spun the book in her lap to face Casta. Who walked over to scrutinize the pages, full of Spinner's

tiny, hastily scrawled handwriting.

"It's not a spell book…it's her journal." Casta tapped the pages, then knelt down on the coffee table to sort through the stacks of books. Searching for more journals.

"Do…sorceresses keep journals?" Glimmer questioned, setting her spell book aside. Far more interested in reading about Light Spinner herself than her research. She had not known the woman for very long. Shadow Weaver had been her first teacher in magic. She had found the old woman compelling in 'a don't stand too close to the fire' sort of way. She was highly intelligent and a cunning wordsmith which made her very dangerous. She was the ultimate survivor. Able to manipulate any situation to her advantage, driven by her own set of morals and personal ambitions. That rarely meshed with the people who surrounded her.

Glimmer loathes to admit it, but Shadow Weaver had become her advisor, her confidant…As a young queen confronted with the bleak reality that the Horde was going to win the war, that she had failed. She had felt alone, scared and desperate for power. Shadow Weaver had been the only one on her side and had become the person she listened to most.

That in itself should have rang some really loud sirens of warning. But she had deluded herself to believe that activating the Heart had been the only way to win.

It had turned out to be the biggest mistake of her life, one that the people of Etheria had paid the price for.

The guilt had been eating at her ever since Prime had kidnapped her. She had been working tirelessly ever since to make amends.

"Elidor has begun to wane as I write this. As my source of magic has begun to fade in intensity, as the moon grows thinner and thinner each night."

Catra's emphatic voice drew Glimmer out of her thoughts. She turned her gaze upward, finding the Magicat standing before the hearth. Light Spinner's journal flipped open to a random page. That she was now reading aloud. Glimmer cut her eyes towards Melog, who was lounging on the polished wooden mantle above the fireplace. They were still a powder blue, their mane fluttering between a soft rose to a deep magenta hue.

Casta had sat down in her chair and was avidly listening to the cat girl as she read.

"I shall no longer be able to show Norwyn my spell work, until Elidor is once more at full strength…which will not be soon enough…I need to gain the High Council's approval for my research. Into Light Craft's more arcane uses, from the time of the First Ones. When they bonded the threads of Etheria's magic to weapons…portable Rune Stones…amulets…that it is possible for us to recreate these tools and use Etheria's magic more efficiently. So that the spellcaster can store their magic for use, when their source..such as now is weakened and so to their magic." Catra's voice faded, as she contemplated the text.

"Shadow Weaver was a Light Caster?" Glimmer regarded Castaspella with incredulity.

Casta arched an eyebrow in disbelief. "Her Sorcerer name while on Mystacor was Light Spinner.."

Glimmer groaned and rolled her eyes feeling rather foolish at being so oblivious.

"She was obsessed with the First Ones even then?" Catra tapped the book.

"She explored all of Mystacor…Catra. The investigation you have started for yourself…she went deeper, she went down into the forbidden catacombs beneath the citadel in search of the deep magic. She explored Arxia before we even knew it existed!" Casta explained, reaching for a leather journal for herself to read.

“All your questions…about the ancient ways to cast magic. Perhaps Light Spinner had uncovered more than just the mysteries of the First Ones. Perhaps she uncovered the secrets of Hybrid magic as well?” She finished with an eager, almost hopeful smile.

Catra was quick to sit down and start to read through the journal. Glimmer also picked up a journal and began to read.

It was well after the noon time meal, before Adora was ready to depart.

She stood upon the top step of the porch, holding a simple wooden box full of carving tools. A parting gift, she had taken with a humble thankyou to Jack. While the grizzled old man stood nearby, scowling down at his son as he tossed his overstuffed pack into the covered cart. Agatha was sniffling and valiantly holding back her tears. Hugging Liam tight, pulling away nodding and then pulling him back in for another hug. The young man was chuckling, embracing his mother warmly. Understanding how difficult it was for her to let him go.

“I’ll be back one day, Ma. Please don’t worry…it is time for me to go out there and find my own place in this world.” Liam offered, thumbing away her tears. “I need to do this…Ma.” Liam pleads.

“I know…I know…” She sighed, turning and trudging up the steps. She stopped before Adora, holding her gaze with a firmness that only a caring mother entrusting her only son to another could have.

Adora swallowed, “I’ll take care of him…I promise.”

Agatha’s stern, teary eyed expression softened instantly.

“Thank you She-Ra, I will hold you to it.” She advised, before heading into the farmhouse to deal with her anxiety and sadness

in the seclusion of her home.

“You are going to have your hands full with that delusional fool.” Jack growled, folding his arms stubbornly over his chest.

Adora was taken aback by the brutal remark. Jack had been her mentor for the last few days. He had been gruff but never cruel with his words.

“There is nothing wrong with wanting more, he wants to go to Mystacor and become a Stone Mason.” She advocated.

Jack made a sharp, huffing sound. Turning on his heel and walking away down the side of the porch refusing to say goodbye to his son.

Adora turned and walked back down the stairs, finding Liam standing stiffly by the cart staring after his father. His expression was hard, glaring at the old man’s back. His eyes held an unyielding determination to prove him wrong. With a stiff, resolute nod towards his father. Liam mounted his roan colored horse and guided the animal in front of the cart. Waiting patiently for Adora and Kronis to join him on their own mounts.

No one looked back as they crossed the open fields, heading stalwartly over the plains of Thaymor towards the dark silhouette of the Ancient Forest far in the distance.

Cutting the threads

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A week ago…

Max watched Levi, pacing. She resembled a caged predator, prowling along the bank of the river. Growling and muttering to herself, her hands fluttering up around her ears. As she worked through her tangled emotions that had been tying her up into knots all day. He was not going to intrude upon her brooding. It had already been a rather tense day being in her company and he needed a break. So he busied himself with other tasks. He had set up their tent, started a fire with the leftover firewood from their previous camp. Then went for a walk in the forest further up the embankment. Enjoying the tranquility of the narrow, overgrown foot trails as he slowly gathered more firewood. Returning to camp briefly to drop it off and then disappearing back into the trees to gather more. He finished the chore late in the afternoon. Casting Levi a worried look, as she was still walking along the rocky shore. Tapping her chin and muttering to herself. Wanting to have a more leisurely hike, along the trails so he could be alone with his own thoughts. Max disappeared in the forest once more, ascending a tall rise in a hidden glade as evening descended. He observed the sunset falling behind the edge of the valley, when he reached the summit of the hill. He welcomed the evening, basking in the glorious colors of the dying sunlight upon the low hanging clouds in the distance. Smiled fondly as he remembered Catra's beautiful voice echoing in the twilight during their journey to Scorpion Hills. He wished things could be simple again, like they were when they were kids. But that time was gone, now things were complicated and with so much hurt and heartache between them. He didn't think Levi would ever forgive Adora for leaving. He refused to dwell on what if's or what could have been. He would appreciate the small things that made him happy and perhaps in time Levi would learn to find happiness again. So

instead he listened to the nocturnal serenade of frogs and the soft rustle of small rodents in the underbrush of the forest. Allowing his thoughts to wander along more pleasant paths.

He had never been a very good soldier, but he had not known any other life than that. So he never questioned what he wanted out of this life, or wished for more. Until the war ended and he was free to make his own choices. He and Levi had fled after that last battle near Bright Moon. When most of the Horde battalion's had been wiped out by the rebel forces. When Primes ships had shown up, they were already hiding deep in the Whispering Woods and headed north, towards the highlands.

They never looked back, never wanted to fight ever again. Eventually finding a home, a purpose in their village, in the upper highlands of BrightMoon. They had cast off everything that would link them with the Horde as they traveled north. Leaving their past behind them as they sought out a new life, a new future. Max was eager to return to that simple life. Of knowing exactly what to expect out of each day. The stability of the routine of going to work and coming home. To return to the regular, domestic life he had been enjoying with Levi for the last year. It gave him a security he never knew he needed to be happy.

When he returned to camp, the Greater Moon's were ascending into the night sky, the first sparkle of starlight shimmering high above. He found Levi hunched over her knees on a flat stone before the fire. Brushing a hand through her short dark hair. A grim introspection clouded her eyes, as she frowned deeply into the flames. She seemed to have got the ranting and raving out of her system. So Max approached the fire with a warm smile of greeting.

"Ready to eat?" He inquired, clamping his mouth shut as he noticed a small ear piece in the palm of her hand.

"Remember all that stuff Lonnie was telling us about before Adora and Catra showed up?" Levi hedged.

“Yeah, about the Eternian invading and Prince Peekablue showing up at Mystacor and spiriting away some kitten and a universe destroying crystal.” Max added, his blood running cold and his heart speeding up. As her expression hardened into firm determination.

“Yep, I found this earpiece up on the heath when I went with Catra to find her alien pet.” Levi tossed the ear piece to Max.

Who snatched it from the air with a swipe of his hand.

“What of it?” Max grumbled, as anxiety roiled in his stomach.

“Well, looks like those Eternian’s managed to find Peekablue and the kitten out in the Crimson Waste and they are closing in.” Levi nodded towards the ear piece.

“This communication device belong to the Eternian’s?” Max groaned, already knowing what Levi was going to propose.

“I’ve been listening to their communication’s all day, Max. They are everywhere…they have had agents hiding and spying on us for over a year…Shits, about to get real, so sit down.” Levi pointed to the stone on the other side of the fire.

Max could feel all his expectations of a simple, peaceful life now dissolving. With a heavy heart, he sat down to listen to what Levi had to say.

Present day...

It had been a harrowing few days. Finn moved on light feet, down the back streets of ‘The Valley of the Lost’. The deep shadows cast over the cobblestones, from the tarps, the inhabitants used to provide shade spanning the winding street overhead. Was a cool comfort for the magicat’s overheated furred body and aching bare feet. Finn slipped into the sprawling city at dawn, before the scorching sun could bake them for another day.

Having swiped a tan hooded cloak from a clothes line, strung across two Horde Cannon turrets. The burnt out metal hulls had been converted to a makeshift domicile by some bandits a few miles away from the city.

They moved, with the hood pulled up, unnoticed through the early morning crowds. Gripping the strap of Peekablue's pack, that hung heavily against their small back. Ducking past domestic squabbles out on cracked and crumbling porches of mortar and sandstone buildings. The doors, windows and other accents to the buildings. Little more than a patchwork of tarps and scrap pieces from Horde war machines, wood from Salineas merchant vessels and the gigantic bones of long dead monster's. All scavenged from the debris that still lay scattered all over the northern savannah and southern desert.

They navigated deeper into the city with ease. Remembering the layout, long memorized from their youth. As the valley was only a few days' travel from Solaris and had been a regular stopping point whenever the royal family was in transit between kingdoms. They quickly left the crude patchwork of homes for the wider streets near the heart of the city. The occupants of the city were quick to take to the streets before the sun rose too high. Wanting to tend to their errands or chores before the heat got unbearable and they had to retreat into the shade for the afternoon.

Finn was quickly surrounded by the rough and rugged inhabitants of the Crimson Waste. A crushing mob of thieves, bandits and mercenaries, who would kill you for a gold piece if given the opportunity. Keeping their head down as they pass bickering merchants, fighting over prime locations for their carts in the main thoroughfare. As they moved through a huge, sprawling market that dominated the core of the city. The Valley of the Lost was the hub of the Crimson Waste, where all the supply routes from Salineas and the surrounding northern kingdoms conducted trade. At least that's how it was in their time…many years in the future. But even now, the Valley was still the heart of the Crimson Waste, where most of the inhabitants lived and were able to scrape out a living in this unforgiving desert.

Eek chirped and slipped their tiny scaly head out along the side of Finn’s hood. Tasting the air with their incredibly long forked tongue. Then chirped softly, nuzzling the underside of Finn’s chin before slipping back into hiding.

Finn smiled tenderly, but never took his eyes off their surroundings. Their soft blue eyes were sharp and alert. As they picked their way down a deserted alley, avoiding the refuse and drunken inhabitants they came across. Currently sleeping off last night's festivities.The drunkards were curled up against the side of the alleyway. Belching and muttering in their inebriated stupor at the ground beneath their faces. Some wore the leather armor of bandits, other’s the light cotton pants and hooded cloaks of locals. Small, carved tiles from bones and wood lay discarded around them along with tinted bottles of whisky. Finn was quick to assess that the group had been gambling and drinking in this alley.

Finn grimaced in revulsion as they moved deeper, as the thick stench of vomit, feces and rotten food wafted into their sensitive nose. They skipped and dodged the garbage littering the narrow walkway, stepping over more drunkards along the way. They needed to find a good place to hide, something small that they could curl up in. Fully concealed and tucked far away from the noise of the market so they could get some sleep.

Skeletor’s men had tracked them and Peekblue down a couple days ago. It had been strange, the night before the attack. Peekablue had given Finn his pack that held his journal that he always wrote in before bed, his communication pad, provisions and a mission. He had to take the Crystal of Kaydak, back to the Sunna Stones. That they had to reach the secluded grotto behind the stones before the Hunter’s moon turned red. It was cryptic and kinda scary.

But Finn nodded, then ran off alone into the Savannah. He was miles away before the Eternian hunting party caught up to Peekablue. Who had led them away in a different direction. Finn’s keen hearing had picked up the low whine of the war sled’s that ran Peekablue down. Then the battle cries in the distance as they

engage Peekablue. Finn envisioned Peekablue giving those villains a good thrashing with their twin rapier's. As they ascended out of a dried up ravine miles away. They knew it had been a short but brutal fight, that inevitablly Peekablue had gotten captured. But had managed to hold the henchmen back long enough for Finn to slip away into the night.

They had been running ever since, managing to use every tactical trick they had learned from their mother's. About surviving in the wilderness, covering your tracks and hiding your scent. Until their frantic journey across the desert had led them here, down into the southern canyon's and onwards towards the Valley of the Lost.

Finn took to a set of carved stone stairs, headed upward. The Valley of the Lost was built up along the canyon walls. As well as stretching out across the canyon's floor. With some areas of the city, overhanging lower streets or even hidden inside the labyrinth of sandstone caves within those walls.

Finn stopped at the top of the stairs, glancing warily up the street. Before ducking into another alley on the street above. The alley was empty, it would led them to a feeder street to the outer avenues that run south and west above the Market's core. If he followed that street it would wind around and lead them into the depths of the canyon wall. They did not want to be pinned down inside some cave so they never intended to go too far from the stairway they had used to get up here. Needing to be able to circle back and head back down to the Market. When Finn reached the end of the alley, they stopped. Scanning the street for any sign of their pursuers. There were less people up here, milling about without purpose, gawking at stalls, like down in the market.

The rough looking inhabitants were headed in and out of makeshift buildings that jutted out of the sides of the canyon. The varying sandstone carved buildings seemed to be pubs or tiny eateries.The fresh smell of baked bread and roasted, spiced meat, made Finn's mouth water. The many savory scents was almost enough to draw the kitten out hiding in the shadows of the alley.

Finn was used to going without so it wasn't hard for them to scamper away on all fours. Ducking behind a line of barrels and crates in front of a tavern further down the street.

It was there in the relative safety of the nook between the barrels and the tavern's simple clay front wall. That they found a bit of respite from the gnawing fear and anxiety they had been living with for days. Quickly tucking their knees up to their chest and curling their fluffy blonde tail around their ankles they fell into a very light sleep.

Eek crawled out of hiding from beneath Finn's hood. Slinking down their shoulder and crawling swiftly up the rough, oily wood of the barrel. To crouch upon the top, crystal blue eyes alert, tracking every stranger who passed by.

Always vigilant and courageous despite their diminutive size. To protect the one they shared a sacred bond with.

A few hours passed in relative tranquility. Eek watched the sun rise until it was nearly overhead. Fluffed out his multicolored wings and proceeded to preen himself, cleaning his feather's of the clinging dampness of afternoon. As the sun's piercing rays were blasting the valley in waves of intense heat. The air was saturated with a wet humidity, which clung to every breath. The citizens started to retreat indoors to wait out the hottest part of the day.

Eek's hearing, along with all of their senses. Was so much more powerful since She-Ra had changed them with her magic. They heard the soft tones of inquest a few blocks back from where Finn was sleeping.

The tiny lizard looked on anxiously. As an overly tall and broad shouldered, green scaled...Ogre? Was stopping random people and inquiring about a Magicat kitten. He was strange looking, kinda deformed. He didn't resemble any of the various lizard-kin, or Snakemen. Eek had seen wandering the Waste for the last few years. He had beady black eyes hooded by a large protruding

forehead. A short, pushed in snout and a very large square jaw. With what looked like two tusks on either side of thin lips. Sharp, pointed ears on either side of a bald head, with dark spikes running like a mohawk down the top and back of his head and down his long, powerful tail. He towered over the folks he was stopping, easily intimidating them. With a huge, round gut and large clawed hands and feet. He wore no armor, except for black leather bracers on his wrists and a wide bronze metal belt around his ample waist. With a tattered, leather tasset to protect his groin. A rather nasty looking polearm was lashed over his powerful shoulders, upon the Ogre's large back. With a heavy two handed pommel and a large, flared spear point.

After having no luck with the townsfolk, he lumbered down the street heading for the tavern Finn was sleeping in front of. Eek shot a warning through their link to Finn. The kitten stirred instantly, never raising themselves out of concealment. Merely reaching up with a furry, clawed hand and gently snatched Eek off the top of the barrel. Then crawled towards the side of the building, glancing back as they retreated.

"Whiplash…" Finn growled, he would recognize Skeletor's henchmen anywhere. He had been one of their jailers in the previous timeline. The hatred and loathing they had for the lizard ran deep. Having survived long years of abuse, being treated like a worthless slave every day. Tending to the lizards every whim, as the vile, self serving lout pretended to be the king of Crystal Castle.

Slinking into the shadow's of the narrow alleyway, created by the outer walls of two buildings. Finn followed the twisting corridor to the back of the tavern and darted across a side street, heading back towards the stairwell that would lead them down to the Market. Where it would be easier to blend in and disappear into the crowds.

Eek had perched themselves atop Finn's hood, wings fluttering in panic. As the thunderous footfalls of a much larger, much more muscle bound monster echoed behind them.

Finn never glanced back but picked up their pace, scampering down the stairs and darting into another alleyway. Which was much more narrow then the ones above. Finn ducked around the corner, their heart hammering in their chest. Hurried across another side street and made for an alley at random, trying to lose Skeletor’s lackey.

Weaving into another narrow corridor between a squat shed with a thatched roof and a two story, mud brick building. Finn was quick to notice that the shed had a crude root cellar, dug along the side. Steps were cut into the sandstone that led downward into the damp earth. They quickly danced down the steps, and shouldered the makeshift door of dented metal open. Slipping inside, they huddled in the dark. Ears twitching as they gauge Whiplashes approach. As the heavy footfalls of the Ogre grew louder as he approached outside. Finn panicked, darting into the deeper shadows of the cellar. Their night vision locked onto a catch of barrels and wooden crates stacked along the back wall. Quick to leap into a used barrel that no longer had a lid. Curling up tight inside, ear’s twitching at every sound. Muscles still full of adrenaline, their arms and legs were twitching. Prepared to leap free and run for it if their hiding spot was revealed.

When the crunch of heavy feet whispered away down the alley, Finn felt their heart skip with joy, settling down instantly along with their breath. As they began to truly relax for the first time in days. Their breathing evened out as exhaustion claimed them. Nodding off into a deep slumber, as they finally felt they were safe and concealed.

The rest of the hunting party were breaking camp, when Whiplash returned from his mission. The Seeker Drones scanning the Crimson Waste had found the two wayward traveler's a few days back. Lynn had sent a hunting party out immediately, to retrieve the shard. When she saw the surveillance feed. That had been

transmitted back to their primary operations base beneath the icy tundra of the Northern Reach.

They had managed to catch up to them out in the northern savannah a couple days ago. Hunting down and capturing the older man escorting the kitten. But the hybrid had been quicker and far more cunning. They had managed to stay ahead of them by masking their tracks and disappearing into this massive sandstone canyon. Whiplash had tracked the kitten to a large Bandit settlement called, The Valley of the Lost.

Beastman had sent Whiplash ahead as a scout. As he looked the most lizard like, he could blend in with some of the locals and survey the area. Find the best approach to sneak into the settlement quietly. He was to track the kitten and find out where the child was hiding and capture them.

As one of Lord Skeletor's higher ranking warriors, Beastman had taken on the mission personally. Be it for praise and promotion, or just to get out of the base and away from Lynn and her constant fawning over her new pet. Beastman had been leading the hunting party for the last week, deeper and deeper into the Crimson Waste.

The small hunting party had set up camp on the northwestern edge of the sandstone canyon, just a few miles outside of the bandit settlement. Whiplash gnashed his large tusk like canines, nervously as he watched Beastman prowl back and forth like a caged animal. The ogre was keen enough to notice the fresh blood, staining the front of Beastman's furry chest and the dried blood still adorning the claws of his huge hands. It looked like the interrogation was proceeding as usual for the savage brute.

Beastman was a mercenary from the Berserker Islands back on Eternia. Much like the rest of his race. He was at least seven feet tall, covered in a thick mat of dark brown fur that hid a massive body of tightly packed muscle. Wearing very little in the way of armor. Just a simple leather pauldron on his right shoulder, strapped in place with a thin belt that ran across his huge chest.

His groin is protected only by a leather and chainmail loincloth. The only piece of adornment he wore was a necklace made of tiger teeth. A coveted trophy he had earned by killing three Alpha Tiger’s from the Tiger Tribe. Ripping out their canines from their barely cooled corpses. It was a battle story he told often around the fire.

His face was broad, with a large protruding jaw and long tusks, jutting out of the sides of his mouth. His eyes were cowled under a thick forehead. Glaring at his henchmen with a predatory gleam, as they set to tear down camp. A set of dark horn’s ran down the center of his shorn head, with a thick dark ponytail at the back. That whipped back and forth as he moved, like a war banner. His large wolf-like ears twitched, as he heard Whiplash's cowering approach.

Whiplash could tell by Beastman’s barking growls and low snarls. That it was not safe to deliver his news. Their leader’s wrath had been on a hairpin trigger, ever since Lynn got her new pet. His only hope was that Beastman’s attention would remain upon barking orders at the fearful henchmen, racing around him as they tore down camp. Allowing him to slink past and remain anonymous for a little while longer.

“Where is the kitten?” Beastman demanded, kicking the snakeman lackey who had been folding up a tarp in his way. As he strode towards Whiplash, folding his powerful arms over his barrel chest.

“I tracked them into the bandit settlement.” Whiplash admitted he was tall but still he only came up to Beastman’s chest. The berserker hovered over him, threat clear in his looming presence. Whiplash couldn’t help but cower more.

As he saw the battle for self-control raging in the beast's dark glare.

“I do not wish to play this game, Whiplash. Pulling information from you is like slow torture.” Beastman growled, his dark eyes growing calm again.

“It took me most of the morning to map the village..it is not set up in a very organized way. Its streets and alleys are narrow and winding, going deep inside the walls of the canyon. The outer buildings are thrown together with scraps…it’s cluttered and confusing…” Whiplash began to ramble.

Beastman turned to watch his men packing the warsleds, front compartments with tents and packs. Latching spears to the metal hooks on the side of the war machines.

“Did you find the filthy creature or not?” Beastman sighed, as the choking smoke from the dowsed fires nearby billowed towards them.

Whiplash could deny it, that they had lost the kitten. But he felt silence was the best choice to avoid Beastman’s wrath.
“Then go back there and bring the little thief back. By the God of Chaos. They are just a child, barely reaching your waist. Go back there and drag them back here by their tail if you have too. I don’t care how to do it, just get it done.” Beastman’s voice was cold, emotionless.

Which was not a good sign, Whiplash knew this trap. Beastman’s rage was like a volcano, always calm and misleading, drawing you in close, then he would explode. The malicious violence he was capable of could be devastating in close quarters.

So Whiplash merely nodded, backing away.

“We shall meet you at the rendezvous point…you have three days..” Beastman ordered. “Do not show up again in my presence empty handed.”

It was the growl of their stomach and the insistent pangs of hunger that finally roused Finn from their slumber. They had barely eaten anything in the last few days, not having the time to stop to even take a breath. Fleeing day and night to stay ahead of

their pursuers. They could not ignore their hunger any longer and with a long, drawn out groan and a stretch of their arms. They crawled out of hiding and slunk back to the cellar door. Pressing their ear against the rusty metal, listening. Finding no footfalls or even the sound of breathing in the alley beyond. They pushed the door open with a dull creak and slipped back outside, pulling their hood up once again.

Evening was falling over the Valley of the Lost, deep shadows creeping and falling over the narrow alley they were slinking down. Moving on light feet, they quickly made their way back to the wide thoroughfare that held the market.

As soon as Finn ducked out of an alley, they had to dodge out of the way of a huge cart filled with scavenged scrap. The street was clogged with carts, people swept around them like water moving through a river. A humming rumble of voices and loud shouts of hawker's and Merchants promoting their wares assaulted their tender ears.

Which folded back against their head, seeking to muffle some of the discordant sounds hurting their ears. Finn sniffed the air, skipping to the side of the street so they could blend into the traffic pressed close to the stalls. There was excitement in the air, tense and edgy with a hint of danger. From being surrounded by the cutthroat mercenaries, bandits and other less than moral inhabitants of the Waste. Finn stayed vigilant, moving at a brisk pace down the crowded Market, hunting for the scent of food. Two story buildings loomed behind the stalls, with simple metal plaques hanging beside narrow open doorways. Finn passed a supply store that was crowded with people inside. A smithy, with racks of weapon's hanging on the back wall and scavenged pieces of horde armor. The hybrid's nose crinkled as they passed the doorway, sneezing as soot from the forge inside tickled their nose.

Eek, croaked softly near their fuzzy ear. The lizard's tongue lashing near their cheek. The feelings of caution, stalling them in their tracks. Finn slipped across the street and into an alley

nearby, hovering near the opening. Scanning the crowds. A group of three snake men came into view a few stalls down the street. Where Finn had just been. Dressed in the worn, mismatched leather armor of mercenaries. Hands hovering over thick belts that had horde stun batons and whips latched on their hips. Kicking over broken crates, as they scanned the crowds. A rowdy, uncouth band of brother's making just enough of a ruckus to draw the attention of the crowds.

Finn cursed, they were bounty hunters. It looked like Whiplash may have hired some local thugs to help hunt them down…Finn wouldn't put it past Skeletor to have put a bounty on them either. Further loathing for the fat lizard and that vile bag of bones burned in their chest. They spent their previous life being hunted and had to spend their childhood in hiding. Now in this timeline too, they were being hunted. They hated being on the defensive and having to continuously run away and not fight. But keeping the shard out of Skeletor's hands was more important than their pride.

They could hold their own in most cases but not three against one…that was bad odds. With a frustrated growl, Finn watched the merc's as they slowly made their way down the street. Swallowing nervously, their heart beating hard in their chest. As they were closing in on their pathetic concealment in the mouth of an alley.

Then as if some invisible being was watching out for them. One of the tin barrels of coal and ash near the edge of the upper balcony of the Smithy down the street. Came clattering to the ground right beside the Snakemen, as they passed the doorway of the Smithy. The Mercenaries cried out in alarm as a cloud of dark soot billowed over them. A large goat hybrid in a leather apron ran onto the street through the front door of the building. Cursing and hollering up at the upper balcony, shaking their fist at the quickly fading cloud of sparkles.

Finn took the distraction, slipping out of hiding and dashed back across the street.

Rounding a corner to a side street that would lead them out of the market.

It was more narrow, with shops already closed for the day. They were almost to the end of the street when a cry echoed behind them. There was no chance to take shelter inside the buildings since the doors were locked. There was no way to circle back and hide in the crowds back at the market.

They were trapped…

Finn broke into a run, darting into another alley. Dashing down the empty corridor and then a few blocks deeper into the back streets. As the merc's chased after them, shouting as they pursued them.

Two merc's appeared at the head of a street, Finn had just ran onto. Snapping their head back, finding another Merc rounding the corner behind them.

They were trapped in the middle. Finn scanned the street on either side in a desperate attempt to find an exit. Raw terror of once again being captured and imprisoned roared in their ears.

They couldn't…wouldn't ever be locked up again!

Finn ran for a side alley, as the Merc's booted feet thundered behind them. They barely made it inside, before being brought to the ground. One of the snakemen had managed to clear the distance and tackle them. The merc snarled and rolled Finn over onto their back, slapping them across the face in an attempt to stun them. Seeking to intimidate them to submit. Finn returned the violent favor by kicking them right in the testicles.

The snakeman's eye's rolled back as they groaned and clutched their tender balls between their legs. As he hunched over in pain, Finn scrambled to their feet and took off at full speed. Only to be grabbed by the second merc, who clutched their shoulder and swung them, slamming them against the rough wall of the alley.

Finn instantly had the air knocked out of them, giving the Merc an opening to yank them off the wall and twist their arm behind their back.
“Stop struggling, you wretched brat!” He snarled into their ear. As Finn kicked and struggled in their grasp. Writhing and screaming like a wild thing.

With great effort, Finn twisted their free hand behind their head and slashed the Merc across the face with their claws. Clamping their canines into their lower lip as fiery pain exploded from their pinned arm, from their shoulder all the way down to their fingers.

The Merc howled in agony, as their face was ripped apart. The speed in which the Merc released their hold on their arm. Proved they had slashed deep. Fighting to hold back the nausea that followed the pain, as their shoulder was dislocated. Finn took off again, running on all fours, ignoring the agony exploding through their right arm. As they disappeared at breakneck speed into the darker streets beyond. As the remaining two Merc’s gave chase once again.

Finn entered an alley, the bright sounds of laughter and warm lights of fire pits illuminated the street ahead. They glanced behind as two dark familiar shapes entered the end of the street they had just left. With a groan of fear, they darted for the firelight.

Slamming into the chest of a huge, dark furred Tauran. Just as they emerged from the alley. They bounced off the gigantic hybrid and landed on their ass with a startled grunt. Finn took him in, blinking in stunned awe at the sheer size and girth of the living tank now standing before them.

The Tauran was dressed in loose amber pantaloons, with a wide utility belt around his waist. A matching sleeveless amber vest that hung open, showing off his huge, well muscled chest and large washboard abs. Heavy, black, knee length leather greaves adorned his calves. His hoove tips were sheathed in metal, blunting the sharp ends. A red headband wrapped over his

forehead. Tucked and tied under his large curving horns. That pointed outward from his temples like twin battering rams, the tips also blunted by metal caps. He looked every bit a swashbuckling pirate from the Salineas coast.

The bull's soulful brown eyes caught Finn's and held firm. The sudden threat diminished with how warm and concerned the hybrid was for their well being.

"Atila…I found the tavern, Cap't wanted us to meet that Rebel Captain in. A few blo…" The tauran's companion's soft voice faded away. As they caught sight of the kitten sprawled at Atila's feet.

Finn snapped their eyes away from the indomitable figure of the Tauran to a light blue squid hybrid. He wore similar amber pantaloons and a long sleeveless vest that was closed with large black wooden toggle buttons and leather hooks. He had a white silk sash, wrapped several times around his more modest hips. His feet adorned in black combat boots. The squid had stern, sharp features with hawkish yellow eyes that never missed the smallest of details. His head was crowned in wild, white hair that he kept rather short. Looking more like a sea urchin had attached to his head than hair. All four of his tentacles were amputated at different lengths, capped with silver bulbs.

Finn shot a look behind them at the sound of quick footfalls coming up the alley behind them.
"Help…" Finn whimpered to the two pirates. Heaving for air as they sought to catch their breath.

The two pirates looked at each other briefly, as the bull's nostrils flared as he became aware of a very familiar scent. His eyes widened in shock as he crouched down, hovering over Finn for a moment taking another deeper sniff. Then promptly stood up, turning to his shorter companion with a look of bewildered disbelief. A beat passed between them as they spoke without words. The Tauran gripped the hilt of the saber he had sheathed to his hip. The Squid's eyes narrowed, cutting to Finn and then back to Atila before nodding mutely.

The two sets of footfalls came to an abrupt halt, as the Tauran merely side stepped Finn's prone form and stood in front of the kitten. Guarding the child without any further prompting. The Squid hybrid passed Finn an easy smile before helping the kitten to their feet.

"We got you, little one." Otis promised, guiding Finn behind them. As they pulled twin short swords from crossed sheaths across their lower back.

The two snake men stood at the mouth of the alley, staring cautiously up at the hulking Tauran wielding a curved sword and his Squid companion with twin swords. Standing in defensive poses before the stunned kitten behind them.

"Stand aside, stranger's. We have no quarrel with you." One snake man offered, his hand hovering over the hilt of his whip.

"Just give us the kid and we will leave." The other snake man nodded towards Finn.

"What did the kid do? Atila questioned.

"The kids got a nice price on their head." The first snake man answered, receiving a cuff upside the back of his head from his partner.

"Don't tell them that!" The other snake man hissed.

"Good to know." Atila nodded, sheathing his sword and spinning around towards Finn.

Finn swallowed hard back stepping in sudden panic, resulting in him tripping backwards onto his butt. Then crab crawling back further in fright. Shaking their head in disbelief, betrayal burning in their now tearful blue eyes. As their once allies turned on them.

It all happened so fast…

Atila stormed over to them and swept them up off the ground with one powerful arm, swinging them up onto their broad shoulders like a sack. Then striding off into the milling crowds warming themselves around the fire pits of this backstreet. All while the squid hybrid moved like fast flowing water, slicing with his swords in wide arc's both high and low. Backing the two shocked and flustered Merc's back into the alley, before they could draw their weapons. Pinning one snake man against a wall with a sword to his throat the other with a sword pointed square at his chest.

"The kids our bounty now, so I suggest if you want to live….leave!" Otis commanded.

The two snake men slipped away from the blades, when Otis pulled the swords away just enough to give them clearance to move and then they turned tail and ran.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you Pink Storm and Bitzy Bee for your comments, I so enjoy reading what people think of the story. Also thanks to all who left Kudos. This is the last chapter of this arc, I am currently working on the next one. Titled "Kingdom of Light and Shadow" I hope to start updating soon so hang tight.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!